The Fraternization of the Fiend and the Flibbertigibbet

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33259051.

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Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra)

Character:
Hordak (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Octavia (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

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Marriage of Convenience, Alternate Universe, Slow Burn, Mutual Pining, Hordak and Shadow Weaver hate each other a lot, Religious Conflict, POV Alternating, Fluff and Smut, Attempt at Humor

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by Gargantuan_Dumpsterfire

Summary

At his very core, Hordak is a conqueror. He will do whatever is needed in order to win, whether that entails building an empire out of a broken ship, attempting to clone his failing body, or even marrying an Etherian princess to secure advanced weaponry.

In an act of desperation, he reluctantly partners with the Princess of Dryl in technological collaboration. However, he soon finds himself outsmarted, outclassed, and slowly going out of his mind as he realizes how much he doesn't hate it.

Notes

Ah, nothing like a self-indulgent journey into an overused romance trope! Won't you join me as I flounder my way through a multi-chapter fic that I haven't outlined at all?

This chapter is totally SFW and most of them will be, but rated for eventual sexual content, language, and maybe some good ole fashioned violence. Rating may change to E for eventual smut (if I can write it without dying), but smut will be in isolated chapters so that the fic can function without it.

Thank you to Toebee and Em for beta reading!

Setting the Stage

Pop!

The cork was tossed into the wastebasket beneath the desk; she wouldn't need to reseal the bottle. Shadow Weaver eyed the wineglass in her hand for a moment, but really, why bother? Setting the glass aside, she removed her mask, and took a long drink straight from the bottle. She reached into the desk drawer and pulled out a newspaper she'd taken from the commissary: *The Etherian Daily News*. To relax, she often liked to read up on the royals and pass judgement on their life choices.

As she flipped absently through the paper, she reflected on the past few days. What a shitty week this had been, and it was only Wednesday. Shadow Weaver had raised Adora as if she were her own daughter, had poured *everything* into that girl, and the traitor had thanked her by running off to play dress-up with their sworn enemies: the princesses.

She took another long drink from the bottle. This was Catra's fault. How it was Catra's fault, Shadow Weaver had not yet determined, but clearly the little bitch had driven Adora away. Her eyes skimmed the paper, and she let out a pleased hum when she read that a pirate had accidentally set the Salinean princess's newest fleet of boats on fire. Good for him.

She knew she was procrastinating. She was going to have to talk to Hordak at some point regarding the failed battle of Thaymor. He'd messaged her earlier demanding she give a status report in the sanctum the moment she was able to do so, but with everything else going on, the last thing she needed was to listen to him go on another tirade of mostly empty threats directed at her.

She turned the page, further contemplating the issue of Adora. All those years of planning… How was she going to overthrow Hordak now? She could easily kill him in any number of ways, and she

reveled in the elaborate fantasies daily. Sometimes, she liked to imagine she was holding him by his ludicrously large ears as she drowned him in one of the vitrines he had scattered about his sanctum. Other times, she considered putting an elaborate curse on him and watching him slowly descend into madness. No matter the scenario, it was always slow and painful, and she always had a front row seat to the show. Ah yes, sometimes such daydreams were the only thing that got her through the day.

Unfortunately, due to Adora's unplanned absence, she would have to wait a while longer to get rid of the bastard. Without a suitable replacement lined up, the Horde would crumble and split into chaos. Obviously, Shadow Weaver herself would be the *true* ruler of the Fright Zone when the time came, but people neither trusted nor admired her; she needed a puppet to play the part of the sovereign while she pulled the strings from behind the curtain. She mused how Hordak had stumbled into such a position himself, seeing as the current Lord had the charisma of a moldy ration bar, with the leadership skills to match. He'd simply been in the right place at the right time when King Scorpio died, and the kingdom's inhabitants had remained loyal.

Adora, however, was well-liked among her peers, kind, strong, brave, pliable… Shadow Weaver had been molding her into the perfect leader and now it was all going to shit. She took another drink. She had always known the girl was destined for greatness, and it was with both pride and fury she'd learned that Adora was the legendary She-Ra. This *could* work in her favor, though. It would have to. She'd get Adora back, one way or another... and she wanted that sword, too. What better person to take down the princesses than their very own hero?

Eyes skimming down at the page, she spotted a headline from the Etherian Science Guild: *'Wormholes, Portals, Alternate Dimensions: Are they real? Renowned scientist from Dryl shares her theories, turn to page 12 to learn more!'* Shadow Weaver quirked a brow. How ironic. She certainly had no desire to learn more on page 12, and she tossed the paper aside. Taking one

last, long swig of the bottle's contents, she slowly rose to her feet and reached for her mask. She might as well get this over with.

Hordak pulled the lever and watched the green orb of light expand with energy, and he tried not to hope. *Please hold the charge*. He grit his teeth, not daring to blink, not daring to breathe, as though he could stare the machine into submission. It had been nearly two decades since he had last successfully opened a portal, and no matter how many times he tried to recreate that exact moment, he had been met with nothing but miserable failure. As the green glow remained steady, Hordak's sneer melted into cautious wonderment. Against every instinct, Hordak hoped.

He felt a sudden weight on his shoulder as his little winged spy landed upon him and chittered excitedly. Hordak absentmindedly reached up a hand to stroke the boy's head, the two of them watching and hoping. *Please, please hold.* This maddening green ball of energy was both the lock and the key to everything in his exhausting life. It was the reason he was stranded here, wasting away in a broken ship. It was his way home, back to his family. It was the only way to regain everything he'd lost, and so much more.

The charge was holding. Had he finally done something right? The sphere answered his question by beginning to falter, informing him that no, of course not, he was a failure through and through. The crackle of static from the device echoed through the sanctum, as though it were laughing at him, *mocking* him for thinking he could accomplish anything. The light flickered out to nothing, matching Hordak's insides.

Hordak's breathing increased as he tried to hold in his anger, causing Imp, who sensed danger, to fly from his shoulder to the rafters above. The growl in Hordak's chest built to an enraged roar, and his armored fist grasped the machine's lever, violently

ripping it from its place and throwing it overhead, sending it clattering into the distance.

His temper not fully sated, Hordak dropped to his knees, bestowing mindless punches to the metal floor while rage-fueled grunts tore from his throat. Was he destined to be stuck here forever? It was surely what he deserved. He was a speck of impure dirt, trapped in the decaying body of a failed conqueror, forever abandoned in this hellhole kingdom, a dark mark of imperfection on this exasperatingly primitive planet. So lost was he in self-pity and fury, he failed to hear the door to the sanctum open with a hiss.

“Lord Hordak.”

Hordak’s ears perked up at the low voice behind him, and he immediately ceased his assault of the floor. Somewhere in the darkness above him, he heard Imp screech at the unwelcome visitor. *Good boy,* Hordak thought; he’d taught the little creature well. Hordak rose fluidly with his back to the voice and lifted his now bruised fingers to comb his messy hair back into place.

As he tried to pull himself together, the voice continued, "You wanted to see me, my Lord?"

Definitely not the phrasing Hordak had used. He was certain he had never *wanted* to see the loathsome sorceress, but necessity overrode comfort. As he tried to get his trembling body to still, he wondered how she always managed to have the most poorly timed entrances; he was convinced she somehow did it on purpose. “Shadow Weaver.” He cursed himself as he heard his voice waver, unsteady from the physical exertion. "I believe I called for you *hours* ago."

The woman bowed low to him, although he had yet to face her. “My apologies, my Lord. I was reviewing time-sensitive reports from the force captains and the day just slipped away from me.”

Hordak turned toward her, quickly folding his arms behind his back so she couldn't see how his hands trembled. His defective body would pay dearly for this outburst later. "What is the status on yesterday's attack on Thaymor?" His face took on a bored look as he spoke. Most underlings earned a glare or a scowl from him, but with Shadow Weaver… The wretched woman just made him *so tired*, he couldn't even muster up a full frown unless she did something to make him exceptionally angry.

"Certainly, my Lord." She was not using her typical bootlicker tone of voice, Hordak noted. That could only mean… "Unfortunately, I must inform you that the attempted siege was thwarted by the princesses."

This made Hordak exceptionally angry.

His impassive expression turned into a look of outrage, and he felt his talons dig painfully into his palms as his hands inadvertently balled into fists. "Is that so?" While he managed to make his voice come out smooth and level, it held a dangerous edge that cut sharply through the newfound tension. "By all means, enlighten me on how you failed to overtake a *noncombatant town."* His metal sabatons echoed as he slowly stepped closer to stare down at his pathetic second-in-command.

"If we'd had Adora leading the mission as planned—"

"*Enough!*" Hordak's shout was accompanied by the sound of flesh on metal as he slammed a fist into the support beam of the portal, needing an outlet for his fury. Shadow Weaver flinched, taking a step back, but Hordak pursued her. "The training division falls under *your* supervision. If our troops are unsuccessful in seizing land occupied by civilians, I will be placing that blame *entirely* on you."

Shadow Weaver's eyes were wide, and she stammered out her reply, "Lord Hordak, you must understand, the princesses intervened on Thaymor's behalf! Without Adora, the squad only had a few days to recalculate—"

"I said *enough*," Hordak growled, his gaze narrowing. "This is the last time I intend to hear about your rogue force captain. You will elect another force captain, you will see that they receive sufficient training to perform adequately in battle, and that *will* be the end of this. Do I make myself clear?"

"Of course, my Lord. Perfectly clear," Shadow Weaver murmured with a bow. Hordak noted with annoyance that Shadow Weaver's voice had regained the overly polite, velvety timbre that he hated. "I will take my leave now."

Hordak held up a hand as his scowl deepened. "I did *not* say you were dismissed." As much as he desired to get rid of her, a longer meeting now meant the less he'd have to see her later. His body now aching considerably, he strode past her towards his throne and she wisely followed behind him.

As they made the short walk in silence, Hordak pondered briefly on what to do about the botched mission. Thaymor was a small scrap of land with next to no useful resources; the mission had been, in part, a trial run for the newly promoted cadets. However, meager as the village was, there was still no reason to accept failure, especially with those blasted princesses watching. The Horde did *not* lose. They would simply have to strike again in the coming weeks. As Hordak ascended the stairs to his throne, he had already decided to send out the order for a second attack within the next few days. However, that was not why he needed to keep Shadow Weaver here a while longer.

Hordak settled on the large metal throne, and was joined shortly by Imp, who flew from his hiding place above and landed on Hordak's lap. The two of them glowered at the bottom of the stairs where Shadow Weaver stood. "What do you know about the sudden emergence of a princess called She-Ra?" Hordak asked candidly, scratching underneath Imp's chin. "My companion tells me the Thaymor soldiers were oddly intrigued by her appearance. I want to know why."

Shadow Weaver's breath hitched, but from her place below the throne, it was inaudible to Hordak. While she was not surprised he had heard about She-Ra's appearance, she had been hoping in vain it would not be a topic of conversation. If she expected to stick to her own plans of retrieving Adora against Hordak's direct orders, she could not reveal to him that She-Ra and Adora were one and the same. After a moment's hesitation, deciding that part of the truth was safe, she replied, "She is a legendary warrior princess wielding powerful magic embodied in her sword. A figure from ancient Etherian legends. We do not know where she came from."

Hordak's nose wrinkled in disgust. It appeared the dark witchcraft on this planet could conjure up new princesses on a whim. How delightful. "See to it our logs are up to date so we can monitor any encounters for weaknesses."

Every princess was the same to Hordak, and Shadow Weaver was pleased that he was placated by her response. "Of course Lord Hordak, I will make it my utmost priority." Right after her *real* utmost priority of silencing anyone who knew the truth. She glanced subtly at Imp. If that flying little hellion recorded anything about She-Ra's true identity, she'd feel the wrath of Hordak for withholding the information.

She just needed to ensure he remained disinterested in the topic for a few days, so she could cover her tracks and work on getting Adora back, then all would fall into place. She glanced at the damaged portal machine, and was reminded of the article she was reading earlier. *Ah, a perfect distraction.*

"My Lord, there is one last thing, if I may speak freely..." she began, as if she didn't do so often. "I have watched you struggle with this portal machine for years." A deep growl from Hordak warned her that she needed to get to the point, and she began talking faster. "What I mean to say is, while there is none with a mind as brilliant as yours, perhaps more information on the subject exists outside of these walls."

Hordak was aware she was being purposefully vague, trying to reel him in. His barely calmed temper was rapidly rising again, both at her gall and at the fact she'd successfully piqued his interest. His fangs instinctively bared, his scowl turning into a look of pure rage. "Are you implying that I do not know what I am doing with my own invention, Shadow Weaver?" he snarled, gripping the armrests of his throne while glaring down at her irksome form. "You dare to stand before me and remind me that you have *watched me fail* for *years?* Tell me, do you find I am lacking sufficient knowledge?"

"No, Lord Hordak, not at all!" Her body eased to the ground and she knelt before him in repentance. "I merely thought you should know that I discovered a resource who has done extensive research on the topic. I thought perhaps this information could be of use to you."

Hordak scoffed, having had more than enough of this ridiculous conversation. "Let me ensure I am understanding you correctly," Hordak growled. Imp climbed back to Hordak's shoulder as the warlord rose from his seat and approached the top of the stairs, towering over Shadow Weaver's kneeling form. "You are suggesting I discuss classified information about our most advanced technology with an outsider, simply because they conducted research?"

Her eyes widened. "No, my Lord, not all. I just thought—"

"No, you clearly did not. You are dismissed."

Shadow Weaver rose frigidly and turned to go after a curt bow, but she wasn't done. Hordak didn't work well with others and it was no great surprise that he wasn't intrigued by a prospective resource; that was perfectly fine. She had been trying to play nice, but there was always another angle. "I do hope you will forgive my boldness, my Lord. I just would hate for the rebellion to have any chance at getting their hands on an operational portal before we do."

Hordak had been descending the stairs to go in search of the discarded portal lever, but stopped dead in his tracks at that, eyes widening. Beneath her mask, Shadow Weaver smirked. *She had him.*

Hordak felt his blood run cold, the aches of his body disappearing and being replaced with a much worse feeling. *Do not give in*, Hordak told himself. *Do not let her win. Do not be desperate.* Hordak was desperate. "And just what sort of being born on this pitiful planet could possibly have any concept of the inner workings of portal machines?"

Shadow Weaver let out a short huff, nearly a laugh, and Hordak's ears flicked with frustration. As she walked out of the sanctum door, he heard her reply: "Your wife."

I Thought You Said Weast

Chapter Summary

> As Hordak grumpily journeys to Dryl, Princess Entrapta reflects on her kingdom's new inhabitants, the pointlessness of royal formalities, and the importance of pockets.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In the early morning light, Hordak gazed over the ship's hull at the dazzling pink glow of the moonrise. The waves lapped rhythmically against the vessel while a chorus of bird songs were carried along in the Summer air. A warm breeze invited Hordak and his crew to embark on a smooth journey across the horizon. How Hordak despised it.

Following the encounter with Shadow Weaver, Hordak had spent half a day hemming and hawing while getting nowhere with his portal machine before he finally swallowed his pride and demanded the sorceress arrange a meeting with the Princess of Dryl. The conniving witch had smugly asked him *"Whatever for?"* although she knew damn well why. Nevertheless, he had grumbled something about needing to discuss details of the weapons manufacturing. It was a poor excuse he didn't have to tell, but he told it all the same. Deep down he knew it was more for his own benefit than for Shadow Weaver's.

It was under Hordak's guise of discussing weapons logistics that Shadow Weaver delegated the task to Commander Cobalt. She'd mentioned something about having an urgent need to speak with the troops from the failed Thaymor battle, and Hordak hadn't questioned the matter; he was just pleased that he didn't have to deal with her throughout the scheduling process. He didn't know if he could bear the triumph in her voice over the situation without having to punch a hole in something.

There were other challenges to face, however, and Hordak grew exceedingly impatient when it took Cobalt the rest of the already half-wasted day to get everything in place. There had been excessive back-and-forth with the Princess over the details, as if Shadow Weaver had requested the other woman make things as difficult as possible for Hordak. He wouldn't have been surprised if this were the case.

He had at first ordered the commander to set up a video call, but the princess replied with a message saying such a meeting was unnecessary, as everything about her facilities was already documented. Shortly after, an endless stream of data files began pouring in. They received video footage of the robotics labs, research papers, progress notes and statistics… All admittedly things Hordak was interested in perusing at a later date, but right now he needed to find a way to prod her for knowledge without showing his hand.

By the thirty-first file, which was a recording of some odd mechanical rodents firing tiny missiles at one another, Cobalt was getting exasperated, and Hordak was livid. As much as he loathed face-to-face meetings, he instructed Cobalt to invite the damn princess to the Fright Zone and be done with it. But resolution never came easily in his miserable life, and no sooner had the commander sent the communication than the vexing creature had replied that she needed to remain in Dryl for her work, refusing to make the journey to Hordak's domain for interrogation (although Hordak was certain Cobalt had not phrased it as such to the princess). She had added that if he were truly interested, she would be more than happy to host Hordak in Dryl and show him her full operations.

Hordak had been outraged at the suggestion. "If she does not wish to come by choice, you will drag her here kicking and screaming!" he'd bellowed at the nervous Commander. The other man stood his ground, however, and informed Hordak that Shadow Weaver had warned that an act of violence towards Dryl's monarch could disrupt their alliance. So Hordak had taken out his frustrations by punching a hole in something.

In the end, Hordak begrudgingly acquiesced; he knew it was better for him to see the labs of Dryl for himself to get the answers he sought. Being on site might even allow him to determine if the princess had any pertinent supplies to aid in his portal creation without broaching the subject with her directly. While the machinery Dryl had supplied him *was* quite impressive, comprehension of the multiverse was an entirely different matter; he was positive that a lowly Etherian's knowledge on the subject would be limited to the ridiculous science fiction books he'd seen floating around the Fright Zone.

Be that as it may, it was still important he investigate Shadow Weaver's claim about the princess's possible understanding of the topic. Although she was technically an ally, she was still a princess and therefore could not be trusted to roam around freely with such knowledge, should she truly possess it.

With the plans made and all parties in reluctant agreement, Hordak and a small team set out the very next morning. He hated to travel and had for the most part managed to avoid it. He also hated to leave his empire in the hands of Shadow Weaver, yet he was still grateful he got to leave Shadow Weaver. Silver linings, the Etherians called it.

Imp flew to him from the bow of the ship and as Hordak reached up for him, he winced as he heard a groan from the wiring of the extensive plates surrounding his shoulder. The small, robotic limbs that helped dress him in his life-supporting armor were too cumbersome to pack, so he would have to rely on his own hands to do the job. He'd brought his most trusted tools, but expected Dryl to be more than equipped if the shoulder needed mending.

As he gazed out at the peaceful sea, he allowed himself to stew in annoyance over the princess for making him come to her without repercussions. To have to feign respect for a *princess* was completely inane, allies or not. Then again…Despite how absurd he'd found the proposal initially, Hordak discovered the alliance between their kingdoms *had* been very agreeable thus far. The Horde would send fleets of their weaponized bots to Dryl, and

they would be returned a week or so later more powerful than ever.

While their strategic union had occurred quite some months ago, Hordak had never met the princess; there'd been no need to. They'd simply signed a few agreements via digital messaging, sent the documents away for official seals, and that was that. He knew Etherian tradition generally depicted some sort of elaborate event with both parties present as standard, but had that been a requirement, Hordak would have refused to make the deal. If all the princesses of Etheria lay slaughtered before him, he would not be able to pick Princess Entrapta of Dryl out of the lot. Hordak chuckled at the very thought; what a lovely sight that would be!

However, now that the introduction between them was inevitable, Hordak *did* find himself mildly curious about the one responsible for the Horde's impressive new weapons. It was only a fleeting feeling however, and he knew she would inevitably fade back to irrelevance, lost somewhere in the confines of his subconscious with her fellow princesses.

"First Ones tech: log 3,568! Also, mine log 872. First Ones tech is becoming harder to find in the mines of Dryl. This is not necessarily due to a lack of their existence. Although that *could* be the case, it is more likely due to the increasingly frequent disappearance of the mining bots."

A sudden buzz pulled Entrapta out of her thoughts as she cast an annoyed glance at the intercom in her main lab.

"End of log," she muttered as her prehensile hair carried her quickly to the intercom. Pressing the button to speak, she let out a huff. "What is it?"

"Did you read the file?" The voice of Commander Octavia answered, slightly distorted by static.

“Oh, shoot. Not yet, but I will!” It had completely slipped her mind. Political files were just SO disinteresting.

Another crackle of static trickled through the speaker. “...You said that last night. Princess Entrapta, please read the file. That tells you everything you need to know about Lord Hordak’s visit.”

Entrapta sighed. “Yes, I’ll read it as soon as I’m done filing these logs!” she called through the intercom. She thought for a moment before pressing the button to speak again. “What’s the rush, anyway? It’s not until tomorrow.”

“...Are you kidding me?” Octavia muttered quietly, before continuing in a louder tone, “Princess Entrapta, it’s *today.* Like, in a few hours.”

Entrapta’s face scrunched up. No, she distinctly remembered having the conversation yesterday. She'd been going back and forth with some guy about how she wasn’t in the mood to travel, and he didn’t seem to appreciate her robo-rodent fighting footage. That *was* yesterday, right?

“...Princess Entrapta, did you lose another day again?”

Oh dear. There *had* been a minor explosion, hadn’t there? She spoke quickly into the intercom, “Uh, just one sec, okay?” Holding the device in a strand of hair, she rewound her recorder until she was certain she made it to the day prior and hit play. "*Autobio log, year 31, month 6: The octopus woman keeps pestering me about the file for that guy from the Horde who is coming for a tour of Dryl tomorrow,"* Entrapta’s recorded voice said. "*His name slips my mind, I’ll have to check a previous log. Horton or Harmonica maybe. Oh y’know actually, it’s probably in that file…"* Present day Entrapta covered her ears with her hands as a loud explosion was heard on the recorder, making the tiny speaker clip aggressively.

Entrapta stopped the recording and pressed the com button. “Octavia?” she began.

“Yeah?”

“I think the meeting is today.”

A sigh came through the speaker. “Yes ma'am, I think you’re right. You need to get ready, I’ll be on comms with Cobalt so we know when they’re getting in. And *please,* read the damn file.”

Entrapta looked longingly at her workstation of First Ones tech fragments before her hair pulled her up into a vent. As she skittered along towards her room, she glanced down through the grilles and saw Horde-uniformed figures running frantically about, trying to adapt to the labyrinth-like layout of the castle. The newcomers usually didn’t like to venture inside her domicile; she’d heard quite a few complaints about all the traps. Entrapta didn’t mind, she liked her space, and she liked her traps.

She had been referred to as a “hermit” more than once, and she couldn’t deny that it was true. Dryl had a low population of natives and they all stuck to themselves, as did Entrapta. After her alliance with the Fright Zone was official, the Horde had sent a large number of troops and other personnel to reside in her modest kingdom. Some managed outposts, some had been stationed further out in the mountains to patrol the perimeter, and several higher ranking officers like Octavia were in charge of making sure the weapons were successfully delivered to the Fright Zone. None of them had opted to reside directly in the Crypto Castle, and she had to admit she was grateful for it.

Still, it was rather nice to not be in total isolation any longer, and Entrapta had hoped that she might make a friend or two among the faction. It wasn’t going well so far. She’d managed to ease into a fairly friendly working relationship with Octavia, but the one-eyed woman had so far kept their interactions brief and mostly professional. As for the rest of them…Despite her connection to the Fright Zone, many of the troops didn’t like her based solely on the fact she was a princess— something they made so apparent that even she could comprehend it. Oh well, can’t win ‘em all.

When Octavia had announced the Horde Lord's sudden and fast-approaching arrival, the newest inhabitants of Dryl flew into a panic. Upon learning Entrapta had no on-premises royal advisor, which Entrapta thought was a terribly pointless thing to have, Octavia had appointed herself the position for the duration of the visit. "*Just so Lord Hordak doesn't absolutely murder you,"* she'd said*. "No offense, princess, I'm not saying you need someone to tell you what to do, but he's just been known to… Well, he's got a temper, I'll leave it at that. I'll be your buffer, if you'd like."*

Entrapta had accepted the offer, but she really didn't see what the big deal was about. She'd show the guy her labs and the craftsmanship she put into the weaponry that she was certain he wouldn't comprehend, then she'd go about her day as usual. Nevertheless, it was always nice when someone showed interest in her work, and she was excited to show off all that Dryl had to offer, even if no one truly understood it.

When she reached her room, she dropped out of the vent gracelessly and cocked an eyebrow when she saw her royal wear laid out on her bed. She approached the ensemble with a scowl, plucking the note from the top of it. *'Let's make a deal. Wear this and we'll revisit letting you build me a robotic eye. -O'* it read. Ooohhhh, finally! She supposed she could suffer through for the sake of scientific discovery.

Senseless as it was to wear such a thing in her own castle, she showered and quickly changed into the outfit anyway, already brainstorming for the prosthetic eye. Aside from the opportunity of new experimentation, she did like Octavia and was hopeful they could become friends. Octavia had said she wanted to help Entrapta make a good impression; if only the poor aquatic woman knew that such a feat for Entrapta was impossible, and that a nice pair of clothes would do very little to salvage her chances of success.

The garments weren't *that* bad, truth be told. Fitted plum pants with a matching underbust vest and a flowy white blouse. At least it was comfortable. It was one of the outfits she wore if she had

to go to something particularly royal-ish, but most occasions simply got her trademark overalls. Why put in the effort when she'd just leave the event after an hour anyway? Plus, the overalls had plenty of pockets so she could load up on snacks before heading out.

Octavia had thankfully not spotted all the matching accessories that went with the clothes (or the oil stain on the top), so Entrapta finished the look off by donning her oversized boots, work gloves and welding mask. She looked in the mirror and frowned. This *really* wasn't practical, how was she supposed to show off her lab in something without *any* pockets or a flame retardant coating??

Changing a second time after the meeting would eat up precious time, but she could compromise. She grabbed a pair of her full-body coveralls from a pile of clothes on the floor. Perfect! She'd say her hello's in these fancy pants, then throw the coveralls directly on top of them so they could get right to it. Satisfied with her plan, she slung the coveralls around her shoulders and sat down on the bed.

She began swiping absently through her data pad, feeling a bit like a prisoner in her own castle. She would've preferred to go back to her lab, but she didn't want to exit through the door; she didn't feel like interacting with all the chaos in the hallways. Having everyone in the castle was less exciting than she thought it might be initially; it was a little *too* weird, even by her standards.

She'd take the vents, but she wasn't sure the tightly fitted pants would survive the journey. Meeting the feared overlord with her underwear peeking out of ripped trousers would certainly make an impression, she thought with amusement. Octavia might keel over. Oh well, she'd just have to play host for a day or so and then all would return to its normal levels of weirdness. Besides, she'd never hosted anything before, maybe it'd be fun. At the very least, it would make for some good data.

Something was nagging in the back of her mind as she paused her mindless scrolling. Wasn't she supposed to review something in particular? She tapped her chin. It was something very, *very* important. Oh yes! How could she forget *again?* She was going to analyze the mining bot location logs to see why they kept going offline. She flopped back on the bed and got to work.

Entrapta was pulled out of her work yet again some time later by a rather aggressive knock on her door. Upon opening it, she was met with the frazzled face of Octavia.

"Lord Hordak has arrived!" She announced, stepping out of the doorway and inclining her head toward the hallway. "You need to go greet him at the West entrance."

Entrapta cocked her head. "Don't you mean the East entrance?"

Octavia's eyes narrowed. "The *West* entrance. We need to go," she replied insistently.

"Yes. We need to go to the East entrance, where all guests should arrive," Entrapta said, staring at Octavia with a look the other woman couldn't understand.

"I'm...confused?" Octavia said slowly, raising an eyebrow.

"I am confused." Entrapta blinked.

As they stared at each other, Octavia was getting frustrated. Hordak surely would've arrived at the entrance by now, why was the princess being so difficult? Opening the castle doors was a huge pain due to all the codes and puzzles Entrapta had installed; if they kept him waiting, Octavia wouldn't be surprised if they arrived to find that the warlord had opted to knock the door down instead of waiting further. "Look princess, we don't have time for this. Let's *move.*"

Octavia breathed a sigh of relief as Entrapta followed her into the hallway, but it quickly turned into a groan as the little scientist

started to head in the opposite direction.

“Princess Entrapta! To the *West!”* Octavia snapped.

Entrapta turned her head, brows furrowed. “But the West entrance is the one that leads to the dungeon.”

Octavia stared back at her, panic beginning to set in. “No…” Octavia’s voice came out oddly hoarse. “The *East* entrance leads to the dungeon.” She licked her suddenly very dry lips. “I should know, I’ve gotten dumped down there twice in the last week.”

“Yes, exactly,” Entrapta replied, nodding her head enthusiastically. “The East entrance is being used more frequently than the West, so I rerouted the trapdoor! You’re welcome!”

Octavia’s pupil was but a tiny blip in her widening eye. Her whole life flashed before her and she braced herself against the wall to keep from falling to her knees. “Oh no…” she whispered. “Oh no, oh no.”

Somewhere far below their feet, the raging growl of a wild beast could be heard.

Chapter End Notes

A dull but necessary introduction. Stick with me and maybe I'll let them meet up in chapter 3!

Thank you Cas for beta reading!

Day Damn One

Chapter Summary

> Hordak gets out of prison and admires the peaks and valleys of Dryl's mountains.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Entrapta had taken off towards the dungeon without hesitation, but Octavia trailed sluggishly behind her. The commander had still not fully regained her faculty of speech, outside of repeated groans of "oh no, oh no". It took them quite a long time to navigate to the bowels of the castle, as Entrapta had to pause frequently to disable or evade more traps. The closer they got, the louder the echoes of snarling and aggressive phrases could be heard echoing through the halls. By the time they finally made it to the outer door of the dungen, Octavia put a shaky arm up, blocking Entrapta from opening it.

"Princess Entrapta, listen to me," Octavia said gravely. "When we get in there, you need to open the gate, bow, and apologize." She wanted to add 'beg for mercy', but opted not to. While she'd personally never seen Lord Hordak lay a hand on a member of the Horde, she'd heard enough tales in the Fright Zone and attended several of his fear-inducing assemblies to know he was not a forgiving person. She hoped he would be understanding since this was purely an accident.

Entrapta gave an affirmative nod before keying in the code to the door. "You got it!" the princess chirped, far too cheerily in Octavia's opinion. As the locks began shifting to grant them access, the sounds behind the door quieted. With a deep breath from one and a nonchalant hum from the other, the two women entered the door and descended the stairway to the Crypto Castle's dungeon.

Once at the bottom, the two paused, unable to see their surroundings. The large room was dark, the only light coming from two glowing red slits that turned slowly towards them from the center of the room. Octavia ducked as a screeching, flying object came within inches of her face. With a clap of her hands, Entrapta's dungeon lit up by sound-triggered lighting along the walls.

"Lord Hordak!" Octavia dropped into a kneeling position immediately as Entrapta scurried over to the gate of the dark purple cage in the middle of the room. "My sincerest apologies, sir, there was a, uh...a misunderstanding."

None of the group locked in the dungeon replied as they blinked, adjusting to the sudden light. It gave Entrapta an opportunity to survey the guests as she hurriedly unlocked the cage. There were three figures: some sort of beast-man covered in brown fur, a solid teal fellow with feathers, and a remarkably tall specimen with large ears, a flamboyant cape, and a generous portion of thighs on display. Out of her peripheral, she spotted a fourth figure: A blue, winged baby flying about the room. Fascinating. She opened the gate and stepped back.

"Hello!" Entrapta greeted, but the three immediately exited and walked past her without sparing even a glance. *A bit rude,* Entrapta thought with a slight frown.

"How could you let this happen?" The teal feathery man mumbled to Octavia. Entrapta cocked her head as she studied the three men. The one speaking to Octavia didn't have any avian qualities other than the feathers. Maybe she could ask him what species he was later. She'd like to ask all four of them, actually, she mused as the winged baby landed on the thigh-guy's shoulder.

"There will be consequences that will be dealt with at a later time," Thigh-Guy said in a low, growly voice. Ah, so he must have been the one doing all that yelling. "I need to be shown to my quarters." He had tucked his right arm well within his cape.

Entrapta hoped the fall hadn't injured him; that would probably be another mark against her in the bad impression category.

Octavia had risen by this point, and now gestured towards Entrapta. "Of course, right away. But first, may I formally introduce you to Princess Entrapta."

The three large men and bat-baby turned toward her, and while she wasn't always successful at reading expressions, they certainly didn't look friendly. "Hi there!" She said again, waving a hand.

She noticed Octavia staring at her behind the group, making intense eye contact and bowing her head. Oh, right, *right!* Octavia had told her to bow and apologize to Lord Hordak. Entrapta quickly bent at the waist, bowing to the group. Now, she knew there was a proper duration for holding a bow, what was it… Three seconds? Ten seconds? She should know this, it was Princess Basics 101. Of course, princess etiquette was terribly dull… Maybe she should brush up on the latest handbook that they sent the royalty every year. She wasn't sure where'd placed it, or if she even kept it at all. Oh well, a bow is a bow, it's not like she was committing a war crime by holding it for the wrong length of time. At least, she didn't *think* that was the case—

Octavia cleared her throat loudly, pulling Entrapta back to the present. Whoops, she'd been bowing for far too long, hadn't she? She rose from her position immediately, ready to move on to the apology. Her gaze bounced between the three figures. Ah shit, which one of these was Lord Hordak?? She really should've read that file. If she had to guess, she'd go with the guy in the cape, people with capes always seemed important. But how would she know for *sure*? Should she just ask? Octavia had said not to insult the warlord, and not being able to recognize him seemed rather impolite. Her darting eyes landed on Octavia again, who was still staring at her and jerking her head aggressively. Entrapta didn't know how to interpret the gesture and she was getting uncomfortable with so many eyes on her. A tendril of hair came

up to play with her welding mask, and she fought the urge to pull it down over her face.

The three were still staring at her, she needed to say something, *anything*. "Uh…" Screw it. The tendril slammed her mask down and she bowed once again, ensuring they couldn't see her face. "Lord Hordak! It's so nice to finally meet you. Sorry about the whole trapping you in my dungeon thing, but I can't promise it won't happen again." She straightened up and lifted the mask from her face again, feeling better now that the introductions were over. "Welcome to Dryl!"

Thigh-Guy glared down at her with his red eyes and let out a grunt, turned around, and made his way towards the exit. She grew more certain that this one was the big kahuna, but she'd need to confirm with Octavia.

"Grizzlor," Octavia spoke to the furry beast-man, "why don't you take Lord Hordak upstairs? We'll meet you up there in a minute." Octavia gestured to Thigh-Guy as she spoke Lord Hordak's name, finally confirming his identity to a relieved Entrapta.

Well, well, well. Tall, dark and grumpy with the legs that refused to quit was her estranged husband after all. What a lovely surprise!

Entrapta flashed Octavia a bright smile. "I think that went about as well as could be expected!"

"Agree to disagree, Princess," Octavia muttered in a tired voice. But Entrapta was looking past her now, her eyes roving over the warlord as he ascended the stairs. It wasn't lost to the two commanders remaining in the dungeon, and they shared a bewildered look.

"Uh…" Octavia began, trying not to think too deeply about what Entrapta's expression meant. "Cobalt, I've sent you a map of the castle and all the traps… All the ones Princess Entrapta remembered to document, anyway." She sighed. "Let's head

upstairs before they get too far, we need to make sure you three get to your rooms without any more surprises. Tomorrow His Lordship is expecting a tour of the mines and the robotics laboratory."

Entrapta headed up the stairs first, and once he was sure she was out of earshot, Cobalt mumbled to Octavia, "Am I losing it, or was she just checking out Lord Hordak's ass?"

Hordak eased his aching body onto the massive four-poster bed of the room he'd been assigned for the trip. His plans to have the upper hand over the princess upon his arrival had crumbled the moment his body had hit the ground beneath the main floor. Imp chittered with worry as Hordak examined the wiring of his right shoulder. He would have to make repairs sooner than anticipated.

Entrapta had not read the itinerary; she'd wanted to take him to her laboratory as soon as they ascended from the dungeon, but his force commanders had been wise enough to deter her. Hordak had not removed his armor during the journey and he needed to give his body a rest. Imp chittered sympathetically as Hordak began painstakingly removing the armor with the tools he'd brought with him.

"[Careful]," the boy said in a recording of Hordak's own voice.

"Yes, I will be," Hordak murmured.

While he worked, Hordak reflected back on his short time with the princess so far. On their way back through the castle, Hordak had dismissed the punishment he'd threatened to bestow on Entrapta and Octavia for trapping him. He had doubted Entrapta's initial claim that it was an accident, but as he observed the lively little woman dodge and weave around various pitfalls and flying knives, he was willing to accept that his predicament had been an honest mistake. Nevertheless, it was necessary to keep an air of authority, and he had warned her of the dire consequences should

it happen again. “I told you, no promises!” she’d replied with a wink.

Hordak recalled having drawn himself up to his full height, ready to lay into her for her flippant tone, but no words came out when he opened his mouth. An insignificant princess had told the greatest threat to the planet that she may or may not lock him in a dungeon, *twice* ! How was he even meant to respond? And she’d *winked* at him! Never had he been subjected to such nonchalance in all his years as a ruler.

Once they’d made it to the hallway of living quarters and Octavia had told Entrapta for the third time that they would NOT be going to the labs today, the peculiar creature shuffled into faded blue coveralls that had been slung across her shoulders, swung herself into a vent with her hair, and hadn’t been seen since.

Wincing as he removed the last piece of his armor, Hordak settled deeper into the excessive cushions of the bed. His chambers back in the Fright Zone were quite spartan, and he had to admit to himself that this bed was remarkably more comfortable than his own. Not that he *needed* such luxuries. Luxuries make you soft and weak.

He stared up at the elaborate vaulted ceiling as Imp settled onto a cushion beside him. The image of Entrapta hoisting herself into the vent played in his mind once again. His immediate reaction to seeing her prehensile hair had been to get hit by a wave of nausea; it had reminded him of Shadow Weaver and her long, greasy locks that floated above her. But the brief moments spent in her presence was enough to tell him Entrapta was nothing like Shadow Weaver, and the way she utilized her hair as though she were some sort of fluffy, purple spider was even mildly amusing in retrospect.

A yawn forced its way out of his mouth and he curled up on his side. He’d have a short rest and mend the shoulder of his armor before the long day of traversing Dryl tomorrow. He still hadn't determined the best way to probe for portal knowledge, but

perhaps he'd be struck by some ingenuity after a few hours of sleep. Maybe he'd even get the chance to threaten Entrapta again. She really hadn't seemed afraid of him, and he ought to remedy that. With the pleasant thought of striking unbridled fear into the heart of his wife, Hordak closed his eyes and let the exhaustion take him.

After a few hours that felt like only a few minutes, Hordak's body forced him awake, his muscles screaming with pain. He groaned and reached out to the bedside table for the medicine he'd placed there. Succumbing to the use of painkillers was one of the many reasons Hordak hated himself. Back when he was in the Galactic Horde, if a soldier needed additional alleviation of pain outside of what was in their rationed amniotic fluid, they were simply decommissioned. Hordak avoided using them as best he could, but some days the muscle spasms and creaking of his joints was too much. He was uncertain of how he'd cope when he returned to the light of God. That is, *if* he ever managed to return. It wasn't looking good.

Hordak eyed the syringe in his hand with dread. Direct injection of the drugs into his body via his spinal port provided the fastest relief, and he wanted ample time before everyone else awoke to repair and redress in his armor. He lifted his good arm (rather, his slightly less shitty arm) to place the syringe at the port at the nape of his neck to inject the medicine, but he couldn't bring himself to close the distance. His trembling hand wouldn't allow him to reach his destination, although it was not due to the pain. He knew with the relief from his physical discomfort, the onslaught of mental agony would take its place as murky flashbacks invaded his mind: probing cables in his neck accompanied by a calm voice informing him that he was unloved and unworthy. The cold sting of rejection as he was cast out of the light.

Hordak grit his teeth so hard his jaw ached and he willed the memories away, forcing himself to plunge the contents of the syringe when it came in contact with his spinal port. Imp stirred from slumber and crawled over to him, eyes large with concern as

he tentatively nuzzled Hordak's thigh. Hordak blinked away the tears, placing the emptied syringe on the table and stroking Imp's tuft of hair with his free hand. He certainly wasn't crying, the dry mountain air of Dryl was just irritating his eyes.

The alleviating effects of the medicine worked quickly, and it wasn't long before Hordak was out of bed and examining his armor. The rough fall into the dungeon had damaged the cables more than he'd realized, and his tools would not be enough to fix it; he'd need to access one of the Dryl labs to get additional equipment. Cobalt had sent the layout of the castle and its many traps to his datapad, and given that it was the middle of the night, Hordak determined there was no better time for him to lurk about the castle.

After slowly redressing in his armor and outer layers, he gave one last pet to Imp, who had fallen asleep again, before heading out the door. There were two guards outside his door who he instructed to stay where they were, but he expected the rest of the inhabitants of the castle to be asleep. Still, he moved as quietly as he could, although there was little he could do about his metal sabatons clinking on the marble floors.

With his datapad in hand, he found the main lab quickly, but narrowed his eyes when he spotted the keypad barring his entrance. The map of the castle had not come with a set of passwords for the many doors; no matter, it was only a minor inconvenience. He could run a wire from his datapad to the keypad and bypass the code. No one would ever know that he'd entered and all would be left as he'd found it. Then again, the owner of the lab *had* locked him in a dungeon... He sank his long claws into the device and pulled it from the door, tragically ending the life of the poor keypad. He dropped the lifeless mechanism on the ground as the locks unlatched and he went inside.

Instinct first told him the group on his left were enemies; and they turned their heads to look at him with purple, glowing eyes. Hordak inhaled sharply, ready to attack. He let the breath escape immediately as he realized what they truly were: robots, vaguely

humanoid in appearance. Apparently they had been activated by some sort of trigger, perhaps the door opening or his own movement inside the room. He stepped further inside and the lights in the robotic eyes dimmed, their heads dropping once more as they returned to sleep mode.

Looking around, he noted the room was smaller than his own lab, but he knew it was only one of several in the castle; it should still have the tools he sought. The space had a blue-hued glow from the light of several large screens displaying various formulas and diagrams. Beyond the monitors was a thick bunch of cabling that reminded Hordak of a strange tree with the way the cords branched out towards the ceiling from the base. Along with the robots, the walls were lined with workbenches, tools and an array of materials. A collection of colorful objects atop one of the tables caught his eye, and he approached it to inspect them.

He gingerly picked up a thin blue diamond etched with strange markings from the pile. He held it up, tilting his head as it seemed to glow in the dim lighting of the lab. How odd. He placed it back down and stooped to begin rifling through a container of welding equipment he could use for his damaged shoulder cabling. He paused his search as his ears twitched at a noise; there was a soft thump as something hit the ground behind him. Setting the box on the tabletop, he stood and turned, expecting one of the robots had fallen over, but his eyes widened as he saw just how spectacularly wrong he was.

Before him stood Entrapta, wearing mechanic coveralls undone to her navel, with nothing but purple striped undergarments and a pair of gloves obscuring her upper half. She blinked at him and cocked her head in surprise at finding him here. Hordak felt his ears droop down as he tried to gather his wits, which were rapidly vanishing. Luckily, she saved him from having to speak.

“Oh, hello! Are you lost?” she asked brightly, not making any move to pull up the rest of her coveralls, which were hanging limply from her waist. “How’d you get in here, anyway?” She arched an eyebrow at the open door.

“I—I… I was...” Hordak stammered gracelessly. Why was it suddenly so hard to swallow? He should tell her he could go wherever he pleased. He should tell her he doesn't have to explain himself to the likes of her. He should stop staring at her breasts. He forced himself to turn back towards the workbench to peel his eyes off of her.

Entrapta, however, came ever closer and stood next to him at the workbench, seemingly unbothered by her state of undress. "No one's ever broken into my lab before! Well, other than myself, anyway." She didn't sound mad, but rather amused. She suddenly produced a small device from her prehensile hair, clicked a button and held it to her mouth before speaking into it. "Hordak Visitation, log seven: Lord Hordak performed an unscheduled pen test on my primary lab and discovered a lapse in security. Upgrades to keypads will be needed. End of log."

Hordak could only stare at her, dumbfounded.

She turned her attention back to him as the recorder disappeared somewhere in the lavender depths of her hair. “Are you looking for something in particular?” she asked casually.

“That is none of your concern,” Hordak managed to croak in a hoarse voice.

“*None of my concern*?” He heard her tone shift to something a bit less polite. “I mean, this is *my* lab…”

Hordak turned his body towards her again, but kept his head tilted away. “Dryl is under the Fright Zone’s command, I am free to take whatever I wish.” He tried to sound imposing, but it was hard when he couldn’t even look at her. So much for striking fear into her heart.

He felt her staring at him, and not wanting to back down, he forced himself to return her gaze, trying very hard to look at her face instead of other places.

“Hmmm… Nope!” Entrapta said simply.

“I… What do you mean *no*?” Hordak’s gaze hadn’t flickered downwards for a fleeting moment. Definitely not.

Entrapta shrugged. “My lab. My stuff. And I haven’t read our agreement in awhile, but I’m preeeetty sure we’re equals in terms of hierarchy." Hordak opened his mouth to protest, but she didn't give him the opportunity. "However," she continued, hands and hair moving animatedly, "I’m more than happy to let you borrow whatever you need to fix up that shoulder! I can even give you a hand, if you’d like.” She smiled up at him.

He searched her face for ill intent but couldn’t find any. Nevertheless, he turned to the side with a huff, self-consciously tucking his injured arm inside his cape. “I do not need nor desire your help. Also, your current... *appearance*,” he waved a hand, gesturing at her, “is highly unprofessional.”

Entrapta looked down at her mostly exposed chest, but her expression didn't change. Instead of reacting with shame, she candidly replied, “They’re just boobs, Hordak. The organic body is nothing to be embarrassed about.” Hordak's jaw dropped, he was completely scandalized. “It was hot in here, and it's not like I was expecting company," Entrapta continued. "But I guess you do have a point, gotta zip up for lab safety!”

Once the rustling of clothing had ended, Hordak, who had definitely not blushed ever so lightly, cautiously turned back to her. “You will refer to me as *Lord* Hordak,” he snapped, though he could tell his voice was lacking its usual bite. He grabbed the box of welding supplies that he'd abandoned on the table. “And I am taking this.” The whole interaction had made his head spin, he needed to get out of there. Entrapta had somehow held the power in both of their encounters so far, and he did not like the trend one bit.

“That’s fine, I don’t need those tonight,” she replied, as though he had asked for her permission.

He stepped closer and glowered down at her small form. She stared right back up at him, although he noted she avoided eye contact; her gaze seemed to lie somewhere just above him. “That was not a request,” he growled.

She put a fist on her hip, unfazed and unafraid. “Well, there’s no need to be so grumpy about it.”

Hordak’s glare faltered. Never had he encountered such boldness in his presence! His supply of wits for the evening was completely depleted, and he turned and stomped back out the door. At least she’d have to deal with the broken lock. Not really a win, but he’d take what he could get at this point.

“Byeeeee!” she called after him. “I’ll see you tomorrow!”

For reasons he didn’t know, he paused in the doorway. He turned his head just enough to glare at her once more. She was waving at him with a strand of hair. With a low hum of acknowledgement, Hordak turned and left.

How in the world was he supposed to navigate this woman?

Chapter End Notes

Chapter 3 seemed as good a time as any to make Hordak cry.

Welcome to Dryl, Try Not to Die

Chapter Summary

> Hordak contemplates upgrading his anti-virus software and explores the mountains of Dryl (the real ones this time, I swear)

Chapter Notes

> I guess I should explain that I call Grizzlor, Cobalt and Octavia Force Commanders instead of Force Captains because I think they deserve a higher position than Catra, Scorpia and Adora. Is a commander even higher than a captain?? Too late now, I've committed.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hordak didn't go back to sleep after the encounter in Entrapta's lab during the night. He made the repairs to his armor and now sat fully dressed, propped up in bed with his datapad going over the ways he could test Entrapta's awareness of portal information. He was coming up empty when something strange happened to his datapad.

An odd pink symbol suddenly flashed upon the screen. Hordak tried to switch applications to determine what was causing the interruption, but the device was no longer responding to him. Hordak narrowed his eyes at the symbol. It was a circle with what appeared to be some sort of caricature of Entrapta inside of it. *What in the world?*

The image disappeared as a program began to launch unprompted. *'Opening notewriter: New document'*

Hordak tilted his head and let out a low hum, more curious than angry at the moment. He set the device in his lap, and when the application opened, words began typing on the screen.

‘*Hi Hordak!* ’ Hordak stared flabbergasted as he watched more words populate in the document. ‘*I was a teensy bit disappointed when I found this outside my lab after you left.* ’ A picture of the keypad he’d mutilated was pasted in the document, with the word “Boo!” and a little cartoon that appeared to be frowning drawn in the corner.

‘*I assumed you’d managed to bypass my access code, so the physical damage was a surprise. Don’t get me wrong, it was bolted and welded in place, so I was still impressed! It just wasn’t what I expected from the guy who designed all the bots I’ve been tinkering with, y’know?’*

A growl escaped Hordak’s throat. How dare she question his technical prowess!

‘*Anyways, I thought it was a great opportunity to demonstrate how to properly hack into someone’s device! But don’t worry, I didn’t snoop around - much ;)’*

“What does that mean?!” Hordak shouted into the room in frustration while Imp gave him a confused look. Hordak picked up the datapad quickly and keyed in his password to open the administrator settings, but nothing happened.

‘*Sorry, that’s not going to work!’* Entrapta typed into the note.

With an angry snarl, he shook the device before tossing it roughly back down in his lap.

‘*Here, I’ll open it for you. As you know, you need a passcode to turn on your device, and a second one to open up the admin settings. I’m going to change both of these now.’* The note disappeared as the administrator screen opened up, and Hordak gasped as a cursor appeared in the passcode field.

“Don’t you *dare* do that!” Hordak yelled at the datapad, although he knew she couldn’t hear him. The symbol from before appeared again on the screen, obscuring his view of the system settings. When it disappeared, the notewriter app was in view again.

‘*Couldn’t let you see those character lengths! I’ve also snuck in some extra surprises in case this is too easy for you. I’m going to let you back in for a sec. Do you have any questions before I sign off?’*

Hordak slid a finger over the screen and the cursor moved with his touch. ‘*I will ensure you are punished for this flagrant breach of conduct.’* He typed, his finger hitting the keys far too aggressively.

He watched the cursor move as he read her response.

‘*How fun! I’ll be looking forward to it. See you in a bit!*

-Entrapta’

The datapad went dark as the screen went into sleep mode. Hordak tapped the screen and keyed in his credentials, but true to Entrapta’s words, he was unable to login. Another growl ripped from his throat and he stalked across the room before hurling the device at the bed, where it landed safely among the cushions. His need to have a working datapad won out over his need for violence, otherwise he would’ve thrown the device against the wall.

He knew his flaring temper wouldn’t allow him the patience required to navigate Entrapta’s impairment of the device right now, and feeling restless, he exited his room with Imp flying closely behind him.

He didn’t get far before he remembered the castle was littered with traps, and without his datapad, he couldn’t navigate around them. It was still early, but not caring at all about waking the others at this point, he stomped louder than necessary back down the hallway and pounded on the door of Commander Cobalt.

Cobalt opened the door and bowed quickly before speaking. “Lord Hordak, is something wrong?”

“You will provide a debriefing on Princess Entrapta and then we will move on with the day’s proceedings,” Hordak replied flatly. They weren’t supposed to meet for another hour or so, but Hordak was still in charge and he could change the itinerary as he saw fit.

Cobalt rubbed the back of his head, confused. “Debriefing?” He repeated.

Hordak narrowed his eyes. “Do I need to repeat myself, or do you require a definition? You failed to provide me with a personnel file so you will give me the information now.”

“Of course, sir, right away.” Cobalt picked up the datapad hanging off his hip, pulled up a file and started reading. “Princess Entrapta ascended the throne of Dryl at age four, Dryl is the eighth largest kingdom on Etheria but is largely uninhabited, Dryl is the leading exporter of numerous metals and minerals found in the mountains __”

Hordak held up a hand, cutting him off. “Irrelevant. What…” he trailed off, trying to phrase his question. “What is she *like?*”

Cobalt blinked. “Can you clarify?”

“What do we know about her persona? She is...” Hordak was about to say ‘interesting’, but stopped himself. “Different. What do I need to be aware of?”

Cobalt looked uneasy. “Well unfortunately sir, we don’t have enough information on her to build that kind of stuff into the file. She’s a bit of a mystery.”

Hordak looked unsatisfied by this answer, so Cobalt continued quickly. “However, I can tell you what Octavia has mentioned to Grizzlor and I. She’s picked up on a few things while she’s been stationed here.”

Hordak didn’t say anything, so Cobalt took it as his cue to go on. “Princess Entrapta only eats small foods, she navigates the castle

through the ventilation system, she has at least six paintings of the same creepy cat, she may or may not sleep—”

“She steals," came a voice behind them.

Cobalt and Hordak turned to see Octavia approach, and she bowed briefly to the latter.

“She *steals?*” Hordak asked, raising a prominent brow ridge.

“Yes sir, Entrapta steals. It’s just a thing she does,” Octavia continued with a shrug.

Hordak thought for a moment. “What are our repercussions if we dispose of her?” He wouldn’t *really* do anything to harm her... *probably.* That being said, he’d still like to know his options.

Octavia stared at him in surprise. “I— Well, uh, there are a lot, my Lord. She’s responsible for upgrading the bots and building the new weapons, so there’d be no more of those. The trade agreements in place might fall apart as well. Plus, even though she’s with us, she’s still a princess; if we did anything to her, the other kingdoms may suspect she was forced into your arrangement and retaliate.”

“Very well,” Hordak grumbled with a sigh. “Let’s get on with it then.”

“Of course, my Lord,” Octavia replied. “I just need to track down Princess Entrapta.” She turned to the other commander. “Cobalt, go get Grizzlor and take Lord Hordak to the robotics lab. I’ll meet you there as soon as I can.”

As Octavia walked down the hallway, Grizzlor joined the other two men and they, along with Imp, headed to the lab where the robots were stored. They were met with yet another keypad, and not about to be outdone by a princess, Hordak wired Cobalt’s datapad to the device and quickly overrode the code.

“Sir, shouldn’t we wait for Princess Entrapta?” Grizzlor asked, but Hordak had already made his way inside as soon as the door opened. This lab was much larger than the one he’d visited last night; rows of weaponized bots were lined up, either waiting for upgrades, or completed ones ready to be transported back to the Fright Zone.

Hordak ventured nearer to inspect the craftsmanship of the closest one. As he reached out a hand to open a panel to check the wiring, the robot suddenly sprang to life. Imp screeched and flew from his perch on Hordak’s shoulder. The laser cannon in the bot’s upper center lit up and pointed directly at Hordak as Cobalt and Grizzlor rushed forward.

“Emily!” Entrapta’s squeaky voice cut through the air. “Bad girl! We don’t point our guns at our guests.”

The light in the bot immediately dimmed and it beeped in a strange minor key that definitely was *not* part of its standard programming. With a slightly glitchy left leg, it walked over to Entrapta.

“Sorry about that!” Entrapta said once she focused on Hordak. “I told Emily to wait here for you, in case you guys arrived before me. And I see that you did!” She beamed up at Hordak, seemingly pleased that he’d successfully infiltrated another of her labs. “You didn’t even break anything this time, great job!” She clapped her hands and her hair curled up in enthusiasm.

“You named the bot?” Grizzlor asked slowly.

Entrapta looped a strand of hair around Emily in a gesture of affection. “Of course! I name all of the bots. Although, Emily is the only one I reprogrammed to be more of a companion. She’s smart, loyal, affectionate, and absolutely deadly!” She let out a wild cackle. “Emily, say hello to Lord Hordak and all of his friends!”

Hordak's subordinates were certainly *not* his friends, and he was about to say as much when the robot stepped forward and *bowed* to him. Nothing should surprise him at this point, but he found himself speechless yet again.

"So!" Entrapta continued. "I'm sure you've seen these guys in battle already, so what do you wanna know?"

Hordak hesitated. He didn't *want* to see the bots at all, but he should at least feign interest. He strode over to another bot and flipped down the primary panel.

Entrapta all but bounced over to him. "Why don't you take a closer look?" She asked. With a few flicks of her hair, the outer shell of the bot popped open and he stooped to inspect the upgrades.

At first glance, the work was flawless, and he would be lying if he said he was not impressed. "Do you do all of this yourself?" He asked, glancing at her.

She beamed at him. "Sure do!"

Hordak grunted and turned back to the bot, spying a word engraved into the interior of the shell. "What is the purpose of this etching? What is a 'Steve'?"

"That's his name! Like I said, I name all the bots."

Hordak looked at her and narrowed his eyes. "*Why?* "

Entrapta shrugged. "Feels right! I do all the upgrades by hand, so even though it's the same process, they're never gonna be *exactly* the same. I figured each one deserves their own name before I send them home!"

Hordak's eyes widened and there was a painful stab in his chest. *All beings are an interchangeable part of the whole,* a voice somewhere inside him said. He forced the feelings away and cleared his throat. "I see. The work is sound."

Hordak rose from his position as Entrapta put the bot back together. “Ah, wait!” Entrapta called when she saw him heading towards the door. “I wanna show you something else I’ve been working on. Just a little side project.”

Hordak and the others watched as she darted away behind one of the rows of bots.

“I call this little beauty Model EKS! That’s short for Emily’s Kid Sister,” she said cheerily as she emerged with a bot of a different style, a tendril of hair gesturing to it dramatically. While it sported three legs like its spherical older sister, this bot was comprised of a half-circle, with a smaller dome on top. “It’s faster, stronger, smarter, and more powerful than ever! Allow me to demonstrate the best part!”

Entrapta produced a Horde-issued stun baton that she certainly should not have possession of from her hair. The three commanders in the room immediately reached down to their holsters. “When did she…?” Cobalt muttered, looking down at his empty sheath when his hand failed to find his weapon.

“Told you so,” Octavia replied dryly.

Without further ado, Entrapta pointed the baton at the bot’s front leg, blasting a hole right through it. The commanders gasped and Hordak stepped closer, watching in fascination as the hole began to mend itself. “Ta-daaa!” Entrapta sang.

“Impressive indeed,” Hordak murmured. “How does it work?”

Entrapta let out an odd squeak and she pressed her fingertips to her face. “Oh, I am SO glad you asked! It has First Ones Tech in its core processor! I believe this will give it the capability to withstand an extensive amount of magical attacks.”

Hordak’s eyes slipped from the remarkable creation to the small woman next to him. “And by magical attacks, does that mean...”

Entrapta met his gaze and he glimpsed something mischievous in her expression. “That means it should be able to rival a princess,” she replied.

And for the first time in a long time, Hordak smiled without feeling like he was doing permanent damage to his face. It appeared she was far more clever than he’d given her credit for. “And you can make more of these?”

Entrapta deflated for a moment. “Oh, I would *love* to make you a whole army of these babies,” she said regretfully. “But unfortunately, I only have enough First Ones Tech to make four. I’ve only been getting fragments from the mines lately, and while those are enough to power my own bots, I need intact crystals to be able to power the bigger gals.”

Hordak replied with an impassive hum. “Tell me more about this First Ones Tech." Perhaps with more information, he could send some troops to track down more of this strange technology.

At that, Entrapta’s face lit up faster than Emily’s laser when the bot had tried to kill Hordak. “Yes! Of course! I’ll tell you anything you wanna know!”

Entrapta led the way out the door, talking to Hordak at such a fast pace he wondered how she found the time to breathe; although he had little trouble following what she was saying. The Force Commanders followed dutifully behind, whispering questionable commentary to one another with waggling eyebrows that thankfully went unnoticed by their two rulers, who were deep in the midst of scientific discussion.

There were additional labs in the castle, but they breezed through quickly while Entrapta continued to blather away at the surprisingly attentive Hordak. After the interior was covered, they took a brief recess for mid-day rations (“You mean snacks?” Entrapta had asked) and agreed to meet directly outside the East entrance, which Entrapta swore would not lead them to the dungeon, in a half hour to travel to the mines.

Hordak arrived early to find Entrapta outside with Imp cradled in one arm, feeding him tiny pastries from her hair. "Hi again! I just adore your son," she cooed, stroking Imp's tuft of hair while the little creature let out small purrs.

Hordak had opened his mouth to tell her to stop spoiling Imp when he had perfectly good grey ration bars, but instead "My *what?* " came out of him.

"I think it's great that you're making time among all that conquering to be a dad. This little guy is sooooo cute!" Entrapta squealed. Imp chirped happily, snuggling against her. He'd certainly taken to the princess quickly.

Hordak huffed. "I'm not a… and *he's* not…" Hordak struggled to reply. He was not about to reveal to her that Imp was an attempt at cloning a new body for himself gone wrong.

She seemed unbothered by his stammering, and instead of pressing him, she continued gushing over Imp. The boy was playing recordings for her which she apparently found amusing, and as her body shook with laughter, Hordak's gaze shifted away from the coddled clone.

He hadn't really looked at her since last night; his attention today had been on the many creations in her labs and on locating any attempts at a portal, the latter of which he failed to find. Now however, he was inexplicably drawn to the strip of brown skin on display above her oil-stained white top. *Strange*, he thought as he slipped into a daze, Entrapta's voice droning on in the background with theories about how Imp's recording features worked.

Why he suddenly found jiggling contours of flesh so captivating, he was certain he'd never know. Maybe the mountain air really was toxic to him; it had made his eyes quite watery yesterday, after all. Somewhere in the distance, Entrapta kept repeating something, or maybe it was Imp. He couldn't tell. Maybe he ought to bring some equipment to test the air quality during a future

visit. *If* there was a future visit, that is. For business purposes, obviously.

The waving of Entrapta's gloved hand in front of his face brought him out of his trance. “Hordak? Are you listening?”

A small, startled sound escaped him as he suddenly found himself no longer looking at the soft curves of Entrapta’s upper body, but into her magenta eyes. She’d stooped down to where his gaze was focused and was giving him an odd look. He realized with horror she’d been addressing him for the last several minutes while he’d been blatantly staring at her. He realized with additional horror that Entrapta had *also* noticed he’d been blatantly staring at her.

She raised a brow. “Are you waiting for me to strip down again or something?”

His ears pinned against his head and he inhaled sharply. “I— Why would you say something so completely ridiculous?” He turned up his nose and folded his hands stoically behind his back as he stepped away from her.

Luckily, at that moment, his Force Commanders stepped outside, and Entrapta quickly led the way forward.

As they journeyed through the mountainside towards the closest mine, Entrapta fell into step beside Hordak, who was quiet and broody once more. “Sooo…" she began, glancing up at him. "How’s the shoulder? You get it fixed up?”

Hordak, meanwhile, was racking his brain trying to figure out what to say to bring up her portal research, and the small talk she was trying to make was distracting him. He grunted in response. He very well couldn’t mention that he’d read that stupid article Shadow Weaver had sent to him; Entrapta might think he was interested in her. And he certainly wasn’t interested in *her* , he was only interested in her technological capabilities.

Entrapta, determined to engage him, tried again. "Well if you're done with it, I'd like my welding equipment back."

"And I would like to have access to my datapad," Hordak replied, looking down at her and feeling a smirk play at the corner of his mouth as he spoke. However, well schooled in remaining impassive, he quickly willed his face to remain cold and composed.

She raised herself up on her hair to match his tall frame, looking at him in a way he couldn't parse. "And *I'm* still waiting for that punishment."

Hordak's cold composure quickly cracked into bewilderment. *What did she even mean by that?* He could only cough in response as he turned his eyes back to the road in front of them, and was grateful to see the mine just up ahead.

Entrapta dropped back down to her regular level of shortness and her pigtails flew behind her as she ran to the entrance. She was about to enter the mouth of the mine when Octavia protested. "Hold on! Is it safe to go in there? Aren't all of these mines super old? I mean, we passed like fifty warning signs on the way up here..."

"One of them even said *'Imminent death: straight ahead'*," Grizzlor chimed in.

Entrapta shrugged. "I mean yeah, they're pretty old! Been here for decades. It's safe though!" She paused. "Maybe. For a little ways down, I'm sure. Probably."

"Wait, what do you mean *maybe?*" Cobalt scowled at her. "Does that mean you've never gone inside one of these?"

Entrapta frowned. "Well, you're the one who said Hordak wanted to see the mines! But no, I've never been inside one— Yet!" She added with a cackle as she walked further, pausing just inside the entrance. With a strand of hair, she fished a headlamp from one of her overall pockets before turning to look at the others.

“In fact,” she continued, pulling the headlamp over her welding mask to rest on her forehead, “no organic being has been down here in *years*!” She’d turned back towards the mine, her voice bouncing against the walls as she moved deeper inside. “And it is suuuuper dangerous when you get too far down, so I built bots specifically to handle all the mining. They completely eliminated all the fatalities!”

The others gaped at her last comment, but she didn’t give them a chance to respond.

“However...” Entrapta rubbed the back of her neck with a tendril of hair. “For the last week or so, several of the mining bots haven’t emerged, and I can’t track their signals anymore. It’s like they totally disappeared!”

As the words echoed in the blackness in front of the princess, the group behind her exchanged wary glances.

“I even built scavenger bots to go locate the mining bots, and those didn’t come back either! It’s really slowing down my progress. I haven’t gotten nearly as many First Ones crystals lately,” Entrapta went on with a huff. She stared into the darkness for another moment before turning back to the group excitedly. “So it’s really great that you guys wanted to do this! I’ve been meaning to get down here to find out what happened to the bots anyway. There are a few risks, of course.” Entrapta’s hair began counting off as she spoke, “Toxic gases, heat strain, rock falls... but in the name of science, I’m more than willing—”

“No,” Hordak interrupted. His Force Commanders looked at him with relief.

Entrapta tilted her head. “No? ‘No’ what?”

“Traversing the mine will not be necessary,” Hordak replied, turning around to head back to the castle. Was the little fool always so careless with her own safety?

“But… Without recovering the bots, I’m not sure how long it will take to build additional EKS’s to send to you!” Entrapta protested. “I really don’t mind.”

Hordak waved a hand dismissively as he continued walking away. “Four will be sufficient for now. We will find another way to get the tech that you require for additional construction. I’ve seen enough, we’re done here,” he stated.

“What do you mean you’ve seen enough?” Entrapta asked in disbelief. She ran the short distance after him and he paused his long strides. “You came all this way just to see a couple of robots and one mining entrance?”

Hordak glanced down at her. His eyes inadvertently landed on the exposed skin of her chest again, and he quickly turned his gaze back to the road in front of him. “I am,” Hordak began, willing his ears not to twitch, “quite satisfied with what I’ve seen.”

“Well,” Entrapta eyed him doubtfully, “I still want to get my bots back, so *I’m* going in.”

Hordak returned his focus to her quickly as she spoke. “Entrapta, I *forbid you* from stepping foot inside that mine,” he snapped loudly enough for his voice to echo into the cavern, causing Entrapta and the others to flinch.

Entrapta scowled once the surprise at his outburst had worn off. “You *forbid* me?” she asked in an unimpressed tone, cocking a hip to the side and folding her arms. Hordak, however, determining the matter to be closed, had already begun walking down the pathway again with Imp in tow.

He continued alone in silence for a while before he detected multiple sets of footsteps in the distance behind him. The princess was finally following orders. Good. When he was about halfway back to the castle, he began to find it odd that he could not hear Entrapta’s incessant chatter. She was terribly loud for such a tiny thing, and her voice would surely carry in the open air. He paused

and glanced at the figures trailing behind him. Seeing only Grizzlor and Cobalt, he turned to face them fully.

“Where are the others?” Hordak asked with annoyance when the two Force Commanders caught up to him.

“Um, they went into the mine, sir,” Grizzlor answered.

Hordak’s eyes widened and his nasal ridge flared as anger seeped in. That insubordinate, troublemaking, petite pain in the—! Had he not just given her a direct and explicit order? It was no wonder why he was at war with princesses.

Seeing the tantrum building up, Grizzlor decided to speak before Hordak could detonate. “Would you like for us to go back and retrieve them, my Lord?”

“No!” Hordak barked loudly. “If she desires so fervently to die in that cave, let us not prevent her from fulfilling that wish.” In a rage at having his demands ignored but having nothing to break, Hordak grabbed the edge of his cloak and swished it dramatically as he turned and began stomping towards the castle once more.

Grizzlor and Cobalt exchanged a concerned look while Imp pouted angrily at Hordak, but the warlord carried on ahead with his head held high.

Chapter End Notes

> I'm not thrilled about this chapter or the next one but I can't look at it anymore, so here you go! I'm going to try to pick up the pace because these two days really are dragging on and on.
>
> Please let me know your thoughts (if you want)!

Alaskan Bull Worm

Chapter Summary

> (Please sing the below to the tune of "Rudolph the red-nosed reindeer")
> Hordak the red-eyed, pained dear
> Has to weigh his cons and pros
> And when Entrapta saw him
> She said "holy shit, he glows!"
>
> Alternatively, Octavia and Entrapta go on a girl's trip, Hordak takes up extreme hiking.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Octavia hadn’t thought much of it when she followed Entrapta into the mine. She was stationed here to oversee Horde operations in Dryl, and as far as she was concerned, making sure the kingdom’s monarch didn’t die on her watch most likely fell into her job description.

She wasn’t certain how deep within they’d gone, but she knew it wasn’t far, maybe a quarter mile or so. When they were no longer able to see the daylight spilling in from the entrance, she determined it was more than far enough. Entrapta disagreed and ran off ahead, Octavia cursing under her breath as she followed reluctantly.

She came to a halt as the narrow mine shaft spilled into a larger, open space with three tunnels splitting in different directions ahead of her. Because of *fucking* course they did. “Princess Entrapta?” Octavia called cautiously, her voice reverberating off the stone walls. “Are you there?”

“Over here!” Entrapta yelled back, her high-pitched voice seeming to echo in all three entrances at once.

“Which tunnel?” Octavia called.

“The left!”

Octavia muttered more obscenities and moved forward into the leftmost entryway. The lighting system along the walls appeared to no longer work, and it was getting harder to see with every step she took. After several minutes of not encountering Entrapta, she called out again. “Where are you??”

There was a brief delay. “WHAT??” Entrapta’s voice shouted, further away than before.

“WHERE ARE YOU?” Octavia yelled back.

“DID YOU GO TO THE LEFT?” Came the squeaky reply.

“YEAH!” Octavia was not getting paid enough for this.

A longer pause. “MY LEFT OR YOUR LEFT?”

For fuck’s sake! “*MY* LEFT,” Octavia bellowed.

“OH, MY BAD,” Entrapta screamed. “I MEANT *MY* LEFT, SO THAT WOULD’VE BEEN YOUR RIGHT!”

Octavia let out a loud groan as the remnants of their screaming match echoed around her. Before her lungs found the strength to screech into the darkness again, she paused at a new sound: the clacking of rock striking rock. She looked around, but all seemed stable.

“We probably should stop yelling,” Entrapta called in a more subdued tone. “I think that the sound waves are-”

The gentle plinking of rocks was no longer quiet. Octavia ducked and covered her head as the tunnel in front of her began to collapse.

They were nearly back to the castle when Hordak finally accepted that Entrapta's intelligence might be too impressive for him to knowingly allow her to wither away in the depths of the mountainside. She'd proven herself to be a pain in the ass, yet an ass*et* as well, and most likely a highly valuable one. He didn't like to jump to such conclusions so hastily, but with the dangers present in the aged mining systems, he supposed he shouldn't ponder for too long on whether to let her perish.

Octavia's warnings on the risks of an Entrapta-less Dryl had been repeating in his mind, accompanied by the memory of the self-regenerating robot. He could try to recreate one himself, but he'd never even heard of the technology she'd used until today. Entrapta's earlier explanation of the build process proved how extensive her knowledge of First Ones Tech was and he doubted anything he could make without her would compare to what he'd witnessed in her lab.

Besides, he still hadn't confirmed that she had no concept of portal creation outside of that meager research article. He didn't come all this way to leave his suspicions of her ignorance unanswered.

He heaved a great and dramatic sigh as he abruptly came to a stop. Such a shame. He was really looking forward to life as a widowed man. "Imp, return to the castle. If we do not return by nightfall, you are to alert my guards that we are in the East mine nearest the castle." The little creature gave a salute before flying off. Without another word, Hordak turned to stomp his way back down to the mine grumbling loudly the entire time, his commanders following without question.

Once back at the mine, they had barely stepped inside when they heard the rumbling from deep within. "That can't be good…" Grizzlor murmured (to which Hordak replied there was no reason to state the obvious), and they moved inside slowly once the shaking had subsided. They came to a pause as they arrived at the three splitting tunnels, the two commanders looking to Hordak for further instructions.

Hordak exhaled through his nose in irritation—even her damn mines were constructed like a maze! "We will each take a path," Hordak grunted. Cobalt started to protest, but Hordak held up a hand. "I will plan to reconvene with you at this location within the hour. At any signs of danger, you are to remove yourselves from the situation at once. Move cautiously." The commanders nodded stiffly as they headed down the first two paths while Hordak stalked down the one furthest to the right.

Hordak's red eyes lit up the path in front of him, but it remained dim and there was still the occasional rock shifting, so he moved slowly and carefully. The crudely carved walls grew more volatile from fallen beams and rubble the deeper he went, and he barely caught himself before he stepped forward into thin air. He squinted into the darkness below as his eyes adjusted. It appeared he had come to the culmination of the rockfall, and the tunnel had collapsed into a sharp decline that led to a wider space below. There was a pileup of stone that would allow him to get further down, but it would be a steep climb and he was already fatigued from maneuvering around the debris on top of the hours spent roaming Crypto Castle.

He was about to turn back the way he came when he glimpsed a flash of glowing fuschia light in the distance. Whatever he'd seen saw him as well, and the two tiny spheres of light turned fully towards his own red ones. "...Entrapta?" He called out as loudly as he dared, hearing his deep voice echo through the open space in front of him.

" *Shhhh!*" The purple orbs hissed. Suddenly, four more lights appeared—one pair was a mere foot or so to the left of the purple glow that he suspected was Entrapta, and the other pair was some ten feet above.

Hordak couldn't discern any shapes from his current distance, so he braced himself and began to climb to the space below. Testing the stability gently at first, he grabbed hold of a broken support beam jutting out to his left and began descending the steep and

rocky path. He grimaced as he heard his armor creak; he was putting his quick repairs to the test.

Once safely at the lower level, he pushed forward in the dark, stepping over collapsed mining joists and slabs of stone where the rockfall had the biggest impact, moving toward the lightsource of the alleged Entrapta and the four unidentified globes.

As he drew nearer, the light from the six orbs allowed him to make out the forms several yards in front of him and he came to an abrupt halt, his ears pinning back at the sight. Entrapta was lying on the stone ground, her face shielded by her welding mask, and her body pinned beneath a massive myriapod.

The creature was several feet wide and over three times as long as Hordak was tall, its body segmented with hundreds of legs. He observed that two of the amber lights he'd seen from the distance were the creature's eyes, and now that he looked closer, the seams between the dark brown sections of its body appeared to glow in the same orange hue.

Hordak didn't move, but shifted his gaze upwards, where a second, identical myriapod was slowly crawling up the wall of the cave. Entrapta slowly propped herself up on her elbows beneath the creature's legs, and while he could not be certain from his distance, she appeared alert and uninjured. Once he had assessed the situation, he acted quickly, coming within range and stooping to pick up a large boulder. He steeled himself to hurl it at one of the myriapod's body segments that were not hovering over Entrapta's small frame.

Entrapta, now focused on him, shook her head rapidly. He remembered her shushing him when he'd called out to her, and understanding the need for silence, he dropped the boulder as delicately as could. However, it was a boulder, so dropping it delicately still made a resounding thud that echoed around them.

The two creatures paused their movements and turned their large heads towards the sound. Hordak backed up as slowly and quietly

as he could, but they followed his movements quickly, their multitude of legs tapping against the stone room as they scurried in his direction, their antennae probing the air for him.

As he retreated, looking for something to use to protect himself, he spotted Entrapta, still on the ground but reaching for something that had been blocked from his view by the creature's body - a small box. Just as Hordak was about to make a run for her to get them both to safety, he heard a loud beep, followed by a motorized whirring sound. The creatures heard the noise as well, and their attention shifted from Hordak.

A small drone, no bigger than the palm of his hand, made its way up into the air from somewhere near Entrapta, beeping frequently and loudly as it rose high above them. It appeared Entrapta was piloting the drone with the box she'd picked up from the ground; a remote control, Hordak realized.

The myriapods followed the drone as she navigated it deeper within the mine, and before Hordak could truly register what had happened, both creatures disappeared into the blackness beyond. He waited until he could no longer hear the whirring of the drone or the tapping of the legs before he allowed himself to breathe.

"Wow!" Entrapta finally broke the silence, voice tinny from behind her mask. "That was exciting! And… *terrifying*." She did not get up from her place on the ground as she spoke. "So, what brings you down here?" she asked in a surprisingly casual tone.

Does this woman have no fear? Hordak thought as he caught his breath. He hesitated to respond, not wanting her to know how he valued her intelligence, lest she use it against him somehow. "Commanders Grizzlor and Cobalt wanted to ensure Commander Octavia's safety," he answered. It was technically the truth.

"Oh, well that was nice of them," she responded in the same bright tone.

Well, the little nuisance was alive, his job here was done. "I am leaving now," he said coolly. "I *would* suggest that you do the same before those beasts return...but you have proven yourself to be excessively disobedient, so I will leave you to do as you please."

She did not attempt to rise, and his eyes narrowed. "...I can't," she said, remaining where she was. Perplexed by the response, Hordak approached her slowly. Only her upper body and head were animated as she watched him; even her lively hair seemed to have gone static.

When he was close enough for his eyes to light up the space around her, she lifted the welding mask from her face. He suspected it must have some night-vision capabilities once he spotted the smashed headlamp hanging from her neck.

"When those things showed up," Entrapta explained, "I think they jabbed me with some sort of paralyzing agent. It certainly packs a hard punch, it even affected my hair!" She sounded far too excited for a person who had narrowly dodged death. "However, it already appears to be wearing off, as I can now move my upper body. Right before you showed up, I couldn't move at all! I hope I can get back to my lab before it has completely left my system so that I can analyze it!" She grinned broadly.

Hordak let out a puff of air that definitely was not almost a laugh. Vulnerable and alone in the depths of a dilapidated mine that served as a home to venomous monsters, yet she still was thinking only of the scientific discoveries within. Never had he encountered such a strange creature.

His face grew somber again as he circled her, realizing he would have to transport her out of here. Now that the adrenaline rush from the encounter with the beasts was subsiding, he became acutely aware of the excruciating pain in his body. Entrapta was tiny, but the journey back was taxing as is. He could return alone and have one of his commanders come back for her, but there

was the possibility that the myriapods would return in his absence as well. He really had no other option...

Entrapta's smile faltered as Hordak hovered over her, gazing down at her with his unreadable red eyes. Her breath caught in her throat as she saw his head turn from her towards the way out, the relief she'd felt when she saw him dissolving into uncertainty. She considered for the first time that he hadn't been just blowing hot air with his previous threats, and that he could easily leave her here to fend for herself.

Maybe Octavia was right to scold her for hacking into Hordak's datapad. Entrapta mentioned it to the other woman as they descended into the mine, and Octavia had berated her quite savagely. She'd tried to soothe Octavia by telling her that she'd also hacked into *Octavia's* datapad when she first arrived, but this only seemed to make the commander more frustrated.

Despite the multiple warnings from Octavia to leave him well enough alone, after Hordak had broken into her lab, Entrapta considered it an open invitation to break into something of his in return. Now she was wondering if she'd gone a smidge too far. She was about to lower her mask and tell him she could just wait for the serum to wear off when he finally spoke.

"I will need to lift you," he said gruffly, stooping beside her.

Relief flooded her mind as Entrapta nodded quickly, grateful that she wouldn't have to lie alone in the dark for hours. Plus, despite regretting her boldness just a moment ago, Hordak was an absolutely *divine* specimen and she couldn't help the slight thrill at the thought of being held in his arms. She held her breath as he stooped down to collect her in his embrace.

Hordak slipped his large hands under her upper arms and lifted her up with her front facing his, holding her at arm's length like a bag of trash as he turned to head toward the entrance of the mine.

Hm. Not what she was hoping for, but beggars can't be choosers and all that. He was carrying her at eye level and she couldn't *not* make conversation in this position, it was too weird. "Soooo… The mystery of the disappearing mining bots was solved!" Entrapta began.

Hordak grunted.

Entrapta continued, undeterred. "I was operating a drone to see further down in the mines, and Octavia and I got separated. She was yelling to me and I was yelling to her, and all of a sudden, the ground started shaking!"

Hordak grunted.

Entrapta did not believe in comfortable silences, much less uncomfortable ones. "At first, I thought the sounds of our voices triggered some sort of rock slide, but it was so much more amazing than that! Those two giiiiant creatures just smashed right through the wall, and one of them had part of a mining bot hanging out of its mouth!"

Hordak grunted.

Entrapta's ability to talk anyone into submission would not be defeated. "They must be agitated by loud sounds, because I said '*Wooooow!*' when I saw them, and one came right up to me and that's when they got me with the venom!"

Hordak finally broke. "...This position is...not ideal," he said, face remaining impassive.

He placed her back on the ground to reposition her. Could she be getting closer to his expansive chest this time? Apparently not— Hordak grabbed her from beneath her biceps at arms length again, but with her back to his front this time.

"Much better," she heard him mutter. Entrapta scowled at the comment, but for once she said nothing.

When they made it back to where the main passageway had dropped off, it was clear Hordak would need a free hand for leverage to climb back up. Maybe he would have to cradle her against his side , Entrapta thought, his long arm curled around her leg and—"Oh!" she let out a squeak of surprise as he effortlessly hurled her over his shoulder like a ragdoll, putting them back-to-back with her knees bent over his shoulder. His left arm curled around her ankles to keep her in place. She turned her head to the side so she was looking at his backside instead of the path behind them, but the darkness paired with his dramatic cape allowed her to see nothing. This had to be the most awkward way to carry someone she could think of, and she didn't even get a nice view!

Once he had climbed up into the mostly in-tact tunnel, Hordak maneuvered her back to the previous back-to-front position. His breathing had grown increasingly labored, but each time she asked if he was alright, he replied with a growl or a grunt. When they were nearly to the space where the three tunnels met, they spotted Commander Cobalt in the distance, the other two commanders close behind him.

"Hi!" Entrapta called, but was ignored.

"Lord Hordak! We were just coming to find you," Grizzlor shouted from behind Cobalt.

"Well," Hordak panted out in a gravelly voice, "I am found." The commanders turned back down the path and the five of them continued into the room where the mine shafts joined.

"Are you alright, sir?" Cobalt asked Hordak, worriedly looking the warlord over.

"Never better," Hordak hissed irritably, moving past the trio to continue on his way to the exit.

Octavia fell into step beside them. "Uh, Lord Hordak? If I may be so bold, sir… Why are you carrying Princess Entrapta like that?"

“She sustained an injury,” Hordak replied flatly.

“No, I mean… Why are you carrying her like THAT? Like a wet cat?” Octavia pressed, raising a brow.

Hordak paused then, and while Entrapta couldn’t see his expression, she did hear him start stammering something about appropriate and professional physical contact. No marriage perks were to be found, it seemed.

Octavia frowned and she held out her arms. “I see. Lord Hordak… I’m just gonna...” and before she knew it, Entrapta was scooped into a bridal-carry in the burly arms of Commander Octavia. At least this would give Entrapta the chance to recount the tale of the centipedes to the larger woman, which she began doing immediately at rapid speeds while the group moved forward.

As they emerged in the golden glow of dusk, Hordak staggered suddenly, leaning against the edge of the mine entrance for support. Grizzlor and Cobalt were at his side in a moment, but he swatted at them with a snarl.

Entrapta frowned. “You’re hurt! When we get back to the castle, I have medical equipment and I can-”

“You have done *more* than enough, you reckless little fool!” he barked, eyes glowing. With visible effort, he stood up straight and smoothed his hair as he strode towards her, and subsequently Octavia. “The next time you would like to go on a suicide mission, you are not to drag *my* force commanders along with you.” Hordak jabbed a finger at Entrapta, making her flinch against Octavia.

Entrapta swallowed. “I’m s-”

Hordak cut her off, speaking sharply through gritted teeth. “You will *not* wittingly put any of my troops at risk again. Do you understand?”

The spark in Entrapta's eyes had dissipated, and she averted her gaze, feeling guilty and small. “Yes, I understand. I apologize.”

Hordak moved towards the castle without another word, the others following dutifully behind. Entrapta stared ahead at Hordak. Not her fastest record for ruining a new potential friendship, but disappointing nonetheless.

She looked up at Octavia, hoping she wasn’t two for two in failed relationships for the day. “Octavia? Are you okay?” Entrapta murmured, desperately wishing she could walk on her own.

She felt Octavia inhale before sighing. “No harm done, Princess Entrapta. You didn’t ask me to come with you, I volunteered.”

Entrapta let out a small hum and they moved on quietly, Entrapta not even feeling up for logging the day’s findings in her recorder just yet. Octavia ended up being the one to break the silence, clearing her throat before speaking. “Y’know, being in the dark down there gave me an idea…” Octavia began. “I thought it might be a neat feature if my prosthetic eye could light up or something.”

Entrapta perked up at that. “You’re still gonna let me make one for you??”

Octavia smiled at her. “We made a deal, didn’t we?”

Entrapta let out a squeal, her hair giving a half-hearted frizz of delight as the paralytic serum dissipated further. “Oh, you are not gonna regret this! *Lights* would be just the beginning! We can include night vision, zoom lens capabilities, *a laser* …I already have a few models spun up, I can’t wait to show you when we get back!”

She let out a cackle as she continued to delve into the details she was well aware the other woman wouldn’t understand, but she was grateful to have her at least feigning interest. She may have blown things with Hordak for today, but at least her potential friendship with Octavia hadn’t been completely derailed.

Once they were back in the castle and Octavia had taken Entrapta to her lab, Hordak held out a hand to no one in particular. “Give me a datapad,” he demanded, and without hesitation, Grizzlor handed his over. While trying to ignore his throbbing muscles on the walk back, Hordak had ruminated on the princess and how to wrap up the loose ends so he could return to the Fright Zone. After replaying the day in his mind for the umpteenth time, he’d finally been hit by a stroke of genius on how to make *Entrapta* be the one to bring up the true reason he'd come here.

As Imp flew into his arms and the two of them made their way back to his quarters, Octavia’s comment from this morning remained in Hordak’s mind: *Entrapta steals* . He’d simply have to lay a trap of his own and let her come to him.

Chapter End Notes

> I 100% wrote these last two chapters just for the awkward Hordak carrying Entrapta scenes.
>
> Thank you Cas and Alex for your help on this one, whether you are aware of it or not!!
>
> Here is a picture I made that really captures the mood of this chapter.

I Love Thinking About the Crushing Void of Space

Chapter Summary

> Hordak hacks into the mainframe, Entrapta heads out for an on-site job interview.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Once Hordak was back in his room and had taken some time to rest from the long day, he wired Grizzlor's datapad to his own and got to work. True to Entrapta's words, getting back into the device wasn't as simple as overriding the passcodes. He'd cracked that easily, but the remaining steps to get full control of his datapad were laid out like traps, much like everything else in her kingdom. Most of them were simple hindrances, such as all of the text reversing, or the passcodes resetting every few minutes. However, several were tougher and involved solving formulas to get a picture of Emily off the screen. She was admittedly putting his coding knowledge to the test, and he didn't realize he was enjoying the challenge until a low chuckle rumbled from his chest.

After a myriad of puzzles, the device finally seemed clear of any additional obstacles. With this level of effort, he had no doubts that she had set some sort of trigger to alert her when he'd gotten full access back. Data theft was still theft, and with that in mind, he quickly pulled up one of the key formulas used for his portal, sat back, and waited.

'Opening notewriter: New document'

Ah, the little thief was watching, indeed.

The cursor blinked for quite a while and Hordak was starting to grow impatient when she finally started typing.

'*I know that formula'*

Hordak let out a pleased hum, although he was aware her knowledge would most likely be useless.

'Come to my lab'

Hordak would go, but he sat there a while longer; his pride wouldn't allow him to let her think he took orders from her. Plus he wanted to let her panic a little after the yelling he'd directed at her after the mine fiasco earlier.

'Are you there?????'

He grinned widely. He was in control at last. Or at least, that's what he thought before Entrapta fell from somewhere above and landed on top of him.

Their shouts of surprise intermingled and the sounds carried out into the hallway, where the Force Commanders were passing by. Hordak barely registered the exclamation of "I knew it!" coming from Commander Cobalt.

In his room, Hordak gaped at the tiny woman sprawled on top of him, completely frozen. Even Imp was speechless, hovering over the bed and gawking at the intruder. Entrapta reacted quickly, scrambling off of Hordak to stand a good distance away from the bed, looking slightly flustered. After a moment's recovery, Hordak stood as well, and quickly straightened his tabard and ran his claws through his messy hair. The amusement now gone, Hordak glared across the room at her, and she seemed to cower, just a bit.

"What is the meaning of this intrusion?" He hissed.

She put up her palms, backing away. "I'm so sorry! It's been awhile since I've been in this room, I forgot how steep the vent

was.” She peered at him apologetically. “Plus, the paralytic agent may still be lingering. I didn’t mean to drop in like this, I was just seeing if you got my message and I slipped.”

He opened his mouth to yell at her to get out, but paused. These weren’t the circumstances in which he wanted to discuss this topic, yet it still needed to be discussed. He had to find out what she knew for certain before he left the following morning. With this in mind, he circled her slowly, staring at her silently to make her feel intimidated. Imp flew to his shoulder, and assisted in the glowering.

“Uh, I…” her eyes followed him and she seemed uncomfortable, perhaps caught off guard by the lack of yelling. This is where he wanted her. “I just wanted to talk to you about what I saw on your datapad...”

Hordak stopped circling to look at her thoughtfully. “Is that so?”

“Well yes it is so, I *just* said that.” Entrapta repeated, looking at him with less nervosity.

Hordak leaned in towards her, though made sure to keep a professional distance. “So you’ve been spying on me, have you?” He asked in a low, whispery tone.

Entrapta’s brow furrowed. “Yes, absolutely I have been. Did you forget?” Hordak sensed with exasperation that he was losing control of the situation. “I told you earlier this morning I was spying on you. But only a little bit! A respectful amount, I’d say.”

Hordak sighed, deflating slightly from his imposing facade.

Entrapta shook her head, trying to refocus. “That formula...Are you experimenting with portals?”

Hordak stared down his nose at her, trying to keep his air of authority. “Perhaps.”

Any traces of fear completely gone, Entrapta lifted herself up on her hair, making them nearly the same height. "Oooohh, how exciting!" she chirped. "Although, there were a few errors in the numbers."

Hordak scoffed, folding his arms over his chest. "There are most certainly no errors."

"Mmmm there are," Entrapta replied, fishing her datapad out of her pocket. She quickly brought up the formula from earlier, proving that she had indeed swiped data from his own device. "This number should be a negative, this one should be a zero, annnnd this one you can remove entirely." She had moved behind him on her legs of hair and was pointing at the screen as she spoke.

Hordak studied the screen, eyes narrowed. There was no possible way that she was correct. He would disprove her calculations when he returned to the Fright Zone. With a grunt, he turned his nose up at the device.

"Even with a few miscalculations," Entrapta continued as Hordak harrumphed loudly, "I've never met anyone else familiar enough with portal theory to know the proper formulas!"

"*Theory* ?" Hordak turned about to face her. "Portals are not theoretical, they're real."

Entrapta lowered herself to the ground and raised an eyebrow. "What makes you so certain?"

"I have opened one before," Hordak replied smoothly, "and I am going to open another."

Entrapta's hair frizzed out at his words as her eyes widened. "You have?? And you *are?* " she asked breathlessly. "Oh, can I help you??" She flapped her gloved hands with excess energy.

Hordak let out a thoughtful hum as he observed her. She hadn't waited for a response and was still chattering away about the

unlimited possibilities that an operational portal would bring, her hair spasming along with her excitement. Would it really be so terrible to have another set of eyes for a day or so? Afterall, he could not discount the obvious magnitude of her intelligence, and he was interested in learning more about the strange, ancient tech that she had been explaining to him earlier. If she proved herself useless, he would simply send her away and all would return to normal.

Once she finally took a pause from her endless stream of talking to breathe, Hordak got a chance to reply to her earlier question. "I will review your proposed changes to the formula when I return to the Fright Zone," Hordak answered. "If I find that they are valid, I will consider allowing you to assist me."

She looked up at him with sparkling eyes and pressed her fingertips together with a tiny squeak of delight, bouncing on the balls of her feet. Hordak, who was certainly not charmed by the sight, averted his gaze. "However," he continued, "I have no doubt that someone from such a primitive planet will be useless to me in such an endeavor."

Her face fell, and Hordak should've been pleased, but instead a pang of something he couldn't recognize stabbed at him. However, the feeling faded quickly at her next words. "Wait, if Etheria is a primitive planet…" she said slowly, "does that mean that there are others?"

Hordak scoffed. "Of course there are other planets. There are countless other worlds and countless other galaxies. Etheria is the only planet I've encountered that does not seem to understand this."

If Hordak thought Entrapta's eyes had been sparkling before, that was nothing compared to the light show that danced through her awe-struck gaze as he spoke. "There are other *worlds?* " she whispered. "And you've *been there??* "

The corners of Hordak's mouth quirked up into a small grin. "Ah…" *Finally* , he held the power.

The next morning, Hordak had gone back to Entrapta's primary lab to return her welding equipment, but the curious woman was nowhere in sight. Right before she'd left his room, she'd told him she would be making a list of additional questions she wanted to ask, so he'd expected her to be waiting for him. Not that he cared. He didn't want to answer her questions anyway.

Still, last night she had let him do most of the talking for once, aside from interjecting with excited questions. She'd sat in a nest of hair, looking completely enraptured as she listened for hours to Hordak's tales about other galaxies and the wider universe. She'd been most enthralled by the concept of stars and the vast space between planets. He had to admit to himself the conversation had been...not terrible, and he was not opposed to participating in further discussion.

By the time his belongings were carted out of the castle, it was mid-afternoon and there had still been no trace of the princess. Hordak was the last one to leave, and he traveled down the rocky pathway to where his crew was just finishing loading the ship as they prepared to head back to the Fright Zone.

"We are set to head out whenever my Lord is ready," called Grizzlor from the deck once he spotted Hordak.

Hordak gave a stiff nod as he cast one last glance towards the castle. Although she meant nothing to him, it was still disrespectful for the Lord of the realm's so-called wife to not see him off as he left. Another item to add to the pile of misconduct she'd demonstrated.

As he stepped aboard the vessel and gave the command to set sail, his ear flicked in the direction of some familiar chatter coming from the cabins below the deck. Ducking his head under the too-

short companionway, he descended the stairs and followed the sound.

"Hordak Visitation log one-hundred and fifty-three: the vessel that Hordak has traveled upon is relatively small, but he and his friends brought very little belongings and have only been here for… forty-three hours; therefore a larger ship would be unnecessary."

Once in the hallway of cabins below the deck, Hordak turned and saw Entrapta blathering away into her recorder, sitting cross-legged on top of an emergency supply crate with Imp snuggled in her lap. She was stroking his tuft of hair with her free hand while the spoiled thing let out tiny purrs.

She dropped the recorder into a pocket when she spotted him. "Hi, Hordak!"

Hordak folded his arms and gave Imp a disapproving look, and the boy stuck out his tongue as he burrowed further into Entrapta's lap. "What do you think you're doing on my vessel?" Hordak demanded, attention turning to Entrapta.

"Well, I know you said you wanted to test out my formula corrections-" she began, but Hordak cut her off.

"Your *suggestions*," he clarified. He was not convinced her figures were right.

She waved a strand of hair dismissively. "Yeah sure, whatever," she replied, unaffected. "Anyways, I thought it would make a lot more sense if I went with you *now* instead of waiting. It'll save us a ton of time when you try out my formula and see that I'm right!"

Hordak tightened his crossed arms. "So you thought you could just stowaway on my ship, did you?"

Entrapta shook her head. "Oh no, not at all! To be a stowaway would imply that I was hiding; I've just been sitting here in plain sight," Entrapta explained, as if it were the most natural thing in

the world. “Grizzlor was a dear and already brought my stuff on board for me!”

Hordak let out a low growl. He’d have to remind Commander Grizzlor whom exactly he worked for later.

“Besides,” Entrapta continued, “I’m small, I don’t take up much space! You won’t even know I’m here.”

Hordak nearly laughed at that. As if the princess were anything close to quiet. He shifted his weight as he considered his options, not really having a reasonable excuse to get rid of her. And now that she was here, did he even want to? On the slim chance she was not completely wrong in her numbers, it really would be more practical to have her on site from the beginning. “Well, I… I do not have any spare cabins,” he muttered half-heartedly.

Entrapta’s casual expression changed slightly, and he saw her eyes flash. “Oh, well couldn’t I just share with you?” she asked innocently.

Hordak’s folded arms suddenly felt very heavy and they dropped to his sides, while blood rushed to his ears. He opened and closed his mouth several times before he was able to speak. “I…” he licked his suddenly dry lips in order to continue. “I beg your pardon?” he said hoarsely.

She hopped up from the crate and Imp, not interested in the conversation, glided up the stairs to the upper deck. “I mean, we *are* married,” Entrapta continued in a matter-of-fact voice, stepping closer to Hordak. “Plus, technically, we spent half the night together last night, *and* you already saw me in my underwear.”

Hordak stammered stupidly, retreating from her until the back of his legs connected with another crate, throwing him off balance and forcing him to sit on top of it. Why was it suddenly so hot down here? “W-What are you even implying…”

She was nearly standing between his knees which were splayed on either side of the crate, and she leaned the tiniest bit closer to him. Suddenly, her nonchalant expression cracked and she let out a bright giggle. “Aw Hordak, I’m sorry. I’m just messing with you!” She said with an apologetic tone. She turned to the stairs and headed towards the deck. “I’ll just find a nice small corner to curl up in, I’ll be just fine!” She called out.

Hordak took a moment to regain his sanity before easing himself off the crate. He had expected she would lose some of her boldness after the mining incident, but it seemed she was still in full force. He followed after her, towards the stairway. “What about the weapons upgrades? We cannot afford to-mmhp!” Hordak was silenced as a strand of soft lilac hair flew back and whacked him in the mouth.

“Don’t you worry about a thing! I’m ahead of schedule for once and Octavia is arranging the shipments while I’m away,” Entrapta replied, bounding up the stairs while Hordak followed slowly behind.

“My Lord,” Cobalt called to him as he reached the deck. “Is everything accounted for?”

Hordak shifted his gaze to Entrapta for a moment, who had found Imp again and she appeared to be discussing with him whether they ought to climb up the mast. He sighed deeply and looked back to the commander. “Yes. Set course for the Fright Zone.”

Hordak watched as the mountains of Dryl faded from view and breathed a sigh of relief. It would be good to get back. He’d been tense in the new environment and he would feel more in control when they returned to his domicile. Plus, he had been far too on edge to remove his armor aside from the one night which he’d had to make repairs, and the excessive wear was not good for his deteriorating body.

Deciding to use the journey to rest, Hordak neared the mast and held an arm out to Imp, but the boy screeched in protest.

“[Stay],” Imp began in the recording of an unknown soldier.
“[With Princess Entrapta],” he finished in Octavia’s voice.

Traitor , thought Hordak as he glared at the two small creatures before turning to go to his cabin.

“Have a nice nap!” Entrapta called. “Maybe when you’re back, you can tell me how he works! His recording capabilities are-”

“[Faaaascinating]!” Imp answered for her in her own voice, which caused the princess to erupt in a gleeful cackle.

This was going to be a long trip, Hordak thought as he descended the stairs.

Chapter End Notes

It only took me five chapters to describe two days.

A Tale of Two Goths

Chapter Summary

> Shadow Weaver promotes from within, Hordak bonds with his wife.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The tall being sitting upon the throne gazed with annoyance at the intruder. There really was no escape into the realm of peace and quiet, was there?

"What the hell are you doing on Lord Hordak's throne?" The sound of Catra's voice was always closely followed by a migraine.

Shadow Weaver propped her chin in her hand from where she was sprawled lazily on Hordak's metal throne. An empty bottle rested at her feet; it was a vintage year, in celebration of her hard work at completing her task with time to spare before Hordak returned. "I could have sworn I taught you to mind your own business," she drawled.

Catra stood at the base of the stairs, arms folded across her chest. "Whatever. I've been looking all over this dump for you…I wanted to talk to you. About the battle of Thaymor."

The little vermin had figured it out, it seemed. It certainly took her long enough. "What about it? Would you like to discuss how you failed to bring Adora back?"

Catra flinched. Whether it was in anger or emotional hurt, Shadow Weaver did not know. The girls had been close, and it is why Catra had been spared. She could be of use. "Shadow Weaver…" Catra continued, a look of uncertainty on her face. "No one remembers that we even *went* to Thaymor."

When Shadow Weaver didn't reply, Catra went on. "I received an order that we're going to strike Thaymor again in a couple of days but...I asked the force captain appointed for the mission how things were going to be different this time, how we were going to defeat Adora and...He had no idea what I was talking about." Catra's voice shook a little. "*No one* knew what I was talking about. They said that Adora defected, that no one has seen her since, and that *this will be our first attack on Thaymor*."

Shadow Weaver rose from the throne and picked up the bottle. "That's because I erased their memories," she said simply. She hadn't been keeping it from Catra, but she certainly wasn't going to complain if the little fool never discovered the truth. She'd allowed Catra to keep her memories because Shadow Weaver needed an accomplice to work the field while she remained in the Fright Zone.

Catra gaped at her. "*Why?"*

Shadow Weaver descended the stairs as she spoke. "So that no one will remember that Adora is She-Ra. This is information known only to you and I now. Unless you've been *gossiping?*" Catra shook her head. "I only needed to take away their memories of seeing Adora's transformation, but the spell doesn't work that way. I had to take away everything from the mission."

Catra's brows furrowed. "But... I don't understand why. Won't Lord Hordak still-"

"Lord Hordak knows what I wish for him to know." Catra looked at her doubtingly. "We cannot allow him to discover Adora's *gift*. He will not understand," Shadow Weaver put on her best sincere voice. "If he knew that a former force captain was an *enemy princess,* that she could be sharing our secrets with others...He would order her to be hunted down."

Catra scoffed, turning up her nose. "*Good.* Maybe then the rest of us will actually get some recognition."

Shadow Weaver glowered over her. "I know you had your differences, but I must admit, I'm surprised you wish to see her suffer." Catra tried to keep her expression neutral, but Shadow Weaver saw the worry there. "Hordak would have *our* Adora sent to Beast Island, or even killed on the spot. Do you want that?" It was a blatant lie, but Catra seemed to buy it, her eyes widening.

"No…" Catra shook her head.

Shadow Weaver reached out and stroked Catra's hair. She flinched for a moment, before leaning into the touch with a purr. "Now Catra, I know you and Adora did not see eye to eye in the end, but won't you help me bring her back home?"

Catra let out an uneasy breath. "What are you gonna to do with her once you have her?" She still looked unconvinced.

Shadow Weaver gripped the strands of hair in her fist tightly in a moment of anger before releasing her quickly. Why must her existence be an eternal chore? "You needn't concern yourself over that. But she will take her place in the Horde again, where I can protect her from Hordak."

Shadow Weaver let out a breath, steeling herself. She hadn't wanted to do this, but she could tell Catra needed that final shove in the right direction. She took Catra's hand in her own and turned it over. "I need you, Catra. I cannot do this without you." She dropped the Force Captain's badge into Catra's upturned palm. The look on the girl's face told Shadow Weaver that she had won.

While she'd had many reasons to be glad Hordak was going to Dryl, Shadow Weaver had to admit that the knowledge of how much Princess Entrapta would irritate the warlord was higher on the list than it should've been. It had not been a factor she'd taken into consideration when she'd orchestrated their alliance many months ago, but it had truly worked out for her. While she couldn't imagine *any* match for Hordak, she was certain there

couldn't be a worse one than the fidgety, loud and socially unaware princess of Dryl.

With that in mind, she was taken by surprise when she saw the long trail of purple traipsing behind Hordak the following afternoon. There was a constant stream of high-pitched and nasally speech spilling from her mouth; she appeared to be asking Hordak endless questions about every dusty corner of the Fright Zone that they passed, and he was *answering her*, without a trace of anger in his low voice.

"Lord Hordak," Shadow Weaver greeted as he neared the sanctum door. She'd gone back inside to make sure she hadn't left any traces of last evening's wine tasting around his throne room. "I trust you had a pleasant trip?"

His face fell when he saw her and she could practically *feel* his mood sour. It really lifted her spirits. He grunted in response and moved past her to enter the sanctum.

Entrapta popped her head out from behind Hordak's large frame to wave at her. "Hiii!"

Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed. "Princess Entrapta. So lovely to see you again," she lied.

Entrapta cocked her head. "We've met?"

Hordak spoke before Shadow Weaver got the opportunity to do so. "Did you arrange the second attack on Thaymor as I ordered?" He asked before opening the sanctum door.

Shadow Weaver bowed her head. "Of course, my Lord. The squadron will make their move tomorrow morning."

He opened his mouth to reply, but grimaced suddenly and leaned against the doorframe. Shadow Weaver smiled beneath her mask. She did so love it when he was hit by those waves of pain. She knew it wasn't possible, not without a spell, but she liked to think that she caused it.

“Take Princess Entrapta and go find her a room,” Hordak muttered, stepping through the open door. Shadow Weaver let out an inaudible sigh. She was second-in-command, not a tour guide.

Entrapta made a move to follow him. “Wait, weren’t you gonna show me the por-”

“Tomorrow,” Hordak interrupted her in a surprisingly gentle voice, and Shadow Weaver arched a brow at the tone shift as the door closed behind him.

The princess’s lively hair drooped and she frowned at the closed door, but when Shadow Weaver gestured to her, she followed the tall woman back down the hallway. There were several unoccupied commander-level quarters, but only one open force captain’s room, and it should technically go to Catra. That thought settled the matter, and Shadow Weaver led the princess to the last force captain’s room for her stay.

The princess got over being shut out by Hordak very quickly and was blabbing on and on about his visit to Dryl and how excited she was to get her hands on his portal machine. Dull as the topic was, Shadow Weaver did her best to pay attention anyway. When Shadow Weaver first met Entrapta, the princess had shown a clear lack of interest in any sort of power, and Shadow Weaver needed to make sure this didn’t change.

Entrapta was telling her all the ways she could improve the Fright Zone’s electricity grid and about how she hoped to help him with his portal machine, when they finally arrived outside the room. “Here you are,” Shadow Weaver said, interrupting the neverending droning at last. This unplanned visit would give her some excellent cover while she sent Catra to locate Adora.

Shadow Weaver turned to go as Entrapta entered the room, yet hesitated. “*Princess* Entrapta…” if Entrapta heard the mocking inflection of the title, she showed no signs of it when she looked up. “Might I ask what you’re getting out of assisting Lord Hordak with all of the *improvements* you mentioned? Such efforts exceed

the agreement between Dryl and the Fright Zone.” Shadow Weaver didn’t particularly care what the princess did, but she needed to know the motive. Entrapta seemed politically clueless enough to show her hand when asked directly.

Entrapta smiled brightly. “Why, I’m getting the joy of scientific progress of course!” Shadow Weaver raised a brow. *So simple?* “And…” Entrapta thought for a moment. “I think it would make Hordak happy.”

Shadow Weaver smirked. “Oh. I see.” *Well I’ll be damned.*

Entrapta was already in his sanctum the next morning. Although he had not yet given her a keycard to enter any of the rooms, he was unsurprised. In fact, he’d almost been *expecting* her there, and he found himself unbothered by her sudden appearance. It was a strange realization. She was sitting on her knees in front of the portal machine, examining the wiring within. He came up behind her, casting a long shadow over her body.

“You’re blocking my light,” she said, not turning around.

He huffed, but stepped to the side. “I can see you are feeling quite at home,” he replied wryly.

She stood and dusted off her knees before turning to him with a warm smile. “Yes, I am, thank you! I have some notes.”

Her straightforwardness was refreshing. “So soon?”

“So soon! Now, I’ve already replaced the cables, but I figured you’d want to be here before I recalibrated the-”

Hordak interrupted her, more surprised than angry. “You replaced the cables?” *How long had she been here??*

She nodded. “Yes, I noticed that it wouldn’t hold a charge, so I took a look and replaced them for you. You were using

uninsulated cables.”

Wide eyed, he moved past her to pull the lever. He’d expected they were past due for an upgrade, but surely that couldn’t have been his only issue, could it? He let out a long breath as the portal sprang to life, the otherworldly green glow lighting up the room. “It’s beautiful,” Entrapta murmured from beside him. He glanced down at her awe-struck expression for just a fleeting moment. Beautiful indeed.

“It’s probable that when it worked for you before, the uninsulated cables were compatible with the rest of the power grid at the time,” Entrapta mused. “However, it looks like you’ve made upgrades to some portions, but not others; there are a *lot* of outdated parts in that thing.” She glanced at him. “Plus, the Fright Zone as a whole has undoubtedly required more power over the years, so a machine that worked, say, twenty, ten, or even *five* years ago probably wouldn't be sustainable utilizing the original source."

Hordak could only nod in agreement. He'd come to many of the same conclusions, but he had been reluctant to start over from scratch, choosing instead to replace different components over time. Maybe with an assistant, a complete overhaul would be a bit less daunting. They stared at the green, swirling light in silence for a long time, before it finally flickered away.

Hordak sighed. This was the longest it had remained operational in years, but something was still missing. “It is still failing.”

She shrugged. “Well, duh! That’s because it’s not finished yet!” She grinned up at him. “Ready to get started?”

Her positive attitude managed to restore a sliver of hope, so he gave a nod and they got to work.

Getting Entrapta up to speed on the portal had taken significantly less time than he expected it would. She truly did have a much firmer grasp on the concepts than he ever could have imagined,

despite her initial belief that portals were theoretical. She had claimed one of the workbenches, and for the past several hours, she had been brainstorming how to increase the power without leaving the Fright Zone in a total blackout.

After begrudgingly admitting her calculations were a corrected version of his own, Hordak had been focused on his own task of updating his codes with Entrapta's formula. So lost was he in the monotony of endless numeric strings and symbols, he startled when the princess suddenly hopped up on his workstation. He turned to her, her small body perched casually upon the surface, completely at ease. It was odd to have someone continuously barge into his personal space, but he minded less than he thought he would. It was a nice change to have someone intelligent to converse with, and he found her pleasant to look at, although he wasn't certain why. He decided not to think too much about it and just enjoy it while it lasted.

"So," she began, "I've been thinking about how you can pay me back."

Hordak quirked a brow. "Pay you back for what?"

"For the bots I showed you back in my lab, of course! Since those are a little above and beyond what I agreed to do for you, I'll need you to trade me something for them."

Hordak frowned. She had *offered* the additional robots! He hadn't requested them, so he'd expected it was a given that she was just handing them over out of respect to the Horde.

"I *was* just gonna do all of this on the house, because they need a good fight to properly test them anyway. But then that spooky lady made a really excellent point. I can't just make a habit of giving away perfectly lethal robots for nothing!" Shadow Weaver was ruining his life, yet again, Hordak thought as his frown deepened.

"And so! Here's what you can do for me." She pulled what looked like a smaller version of the standard datapad from the depths of her endless hair, pointing at a map of blinking dots with a tendril. "This is a map of allll the assumed First Ones tech in the area. This device detects the energy of First Ones crystals, and from this distance, it's accurate up to two quadrants. The closer you get to the signal, the more precise the readings will be."

Hordak placed a hand on his hip. “And what exactly do you expect me to do with this information?”

“Well, I need someone to go track it, obviously,” Entapta replied, a pigtail flicking up in the air to illustrate the apparent obviousness of her statement. “I can’t go, I’ll be helping you here. With those monsters back in the Dryl mines, I’m gonna need to source some First Ones tech from *somewhere*.”

Hordak let out a low hum while he thought. It was a reasonable request, and he did tell her back in Dryl that he would assist in finding additional tech. Why *had* he said that again? Oh, to stop her from attempting a suicide mission that she’d gone on anyway. Right. “I trust you have more of these tracker pads? I will send someone after it.” He thought for a moment. “And what of the portal work?”

She cocked her head. “What about it?”

“Do you expect additional compensation for these efforts as well?”

She shook her head rapidly. “Oh, no, no! That bit is all free! Because it’s fun, and I like you!” Hordak’s ear twitched. “If anything, you’re doing *me* a favor by letting me help! I’ve already learned so much.”

Hordak turned back to his work. “Very well.” The idea of being *liked* was preposterous.

“Oh! Also!” She clapped her hands together, and her pigtails mirrored the movements. “I was thinking we could also try integrating some of the tech we find into the portal machine!

That’ll really boost your voltage. I already have a *ton* of ideas! Oh.” She pouted as a new thought seemed to strike her. “But I guess it’s getting late, I should probably let you-”

“I have time now.” She blinked at him in surprise, and he regretted the words. They had spent the entire day together, she most certainly wanted to rest, or-

“Great! Let me just pull up the notes I made on the way over from Dryl. Of course, they’ll need some revisions now that I’ve actually seen it for myself, but…”

As he listened to her overly animated voice in the hours that followed, Hordak decided that he liked her too.

Chapter End Notes

> Don't look at my plotholes and don't look at my made-up portal jargin.
>
> It came to me that I don't remember when SW found out that Adora is She-Ra. None of that matters now, she knows and Catra knows. Anything that happens from here on out will be a surprise to both you and I.
>
> I LOVE ALL OF YOUR COMMENTS!! I'm sorry for being bad about replies, but I reread your comments over and over again, they truly give me life.

Between Addresses

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta ponders her new relationship and plans to take a road trip.

Chapter Notes

> Wee bit of a time skip, expect more in the future or these two are never gonna bang it out.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Entrapta had planned to remain in the Fright Zone for a few days, maybe a week tops. Before she knew it, it had been a month. She only realized this when Octavia messaged her to ask when she was returning; she had received the newest batch of Horde battle bots and they were awaiting upgrades. She supposed she should've told the transit department that she could just do the upgrades here. Whoops.

As much as she appreciated her regular routine back in Dryl, she was reluctant to return home. The portal project was the most fascinating work she had ever gotten to be a part of, and to have someone to work alongside and bounce ideas off of was a dream come true.

Which brought up the second reason she didn't want to go home: *Hordak.* She had been attracted to him immediately, and aesthetically speaking, he was absolutely her type. In fact, he'd most likely set a new standard for her. A fascinating hybrid of man and machine…

She had taken notice of the ports where the tubes on his ribcage connected to his body right away, and she suspected he must have more concealed somewhere beneath that massive cloak. She would *love* to get her hands on him, in more ways than one, and examine the details of that extensive armor. She doubted she'd

ever get the chance to. He was extremely private and while he tolerated her presence, even seemed to enjoy it, she wouldn't say they had become particularly close, although she hoped that would change. Physicality aside, she'd admittedly developed a bit of a crush on him in their brief time together.

She knew flirting was not her strong suit, but often when she told someone she wanted to *experiment* with them in explicit terms, she was told she was coming on too strong. She didn't understand why that was a bad thing. Besides, flirting was just so *complicated*, and she had never comprehended the need for all the mind games that were impossible for her to play. If you wanted to fuck someone, why couldn't you just come out and say so directly? It would really save a lot of time. Oh well, it didn't matter anyway, Hordak had seemed to recoil from what she considered to be bolder statements, and now that they had a working relationship that she really enjoyed, she didn't want to scare him off.

As she pondered how to reply to Octavia, she scurried into the vents to begin making her way to the sanctum. She could hear Emily on the ground below following her movements. They hadn't made as much progress as she'd hoped they would with the portal yet, the tech that had been brought to them thus far wasn't powerful enough. Hordak had given the task of tracking it to a very sweet young scorpion woman, and while she was enthusiastic, she also seemed a bit clumsy, and often she would accidentally break the smaller crystals in her large pincers.

Entrapta had gotten a new reading on her tracker today, and it was all the way in the Northern Reach according to the signal. To get a signal from that far of a distance meant the tech had to be *massive* and Entrapta was determined to find it before it disappeared. Often large storms or earthquakes could dislodge the ancient tech from its resting place, but it was always anyone's guess as to when nature would reconceal the crystals once more.

Entrapta dropped into the sanctum from the vent closest to the portal, but failed to locate Hordak. She quickly heard his deep

baritone floating through the metal room and followed the sound of his voice into the throne room. The spooky woman and a cat girl stood before him at the base of the stairs as the former spoke.

"Lord Hordak, I understand your concerns, but I believe it is wisest if we continue to use Force Captain Catra for reconnaissance so she can report back to our squadrons about what the princesses are planning."

Hordak appeared annoyed, his arms folded over his chest, but he seemed to perk up when he spotted Entrapta in the shadows. She saw his gaze shift towards her, although when he spoke, he addressed the spooky woman. "Force Captain Catra has held her title for a full month and provided no useful intel from your so-called "reconnaissance missions". You will return her to the field immediately. Dismissed."

Spooky Woman and Catra exchanged a glance before turning their focus back to Hordak. "But, my Lord, a month was hardly enough time to-"

"I said you are *dismissed.*" Hordak barked.

The two bowed, although they seemed to do so hesitantly, before they turned to exit the throne room. Entrapta approached the stairs as the two walked past her, and she swore they narrowed their eyes at her, although she had no clue why that would be. She bounded up the stairs, pulling her trackerpad from her largest overall pocket.

"Hi Hordak!" She chirped brightly as she came to stand next to the throne. She didn't spend much time in his throne room, as they were usually working together in the sanctum. She thought it was a bit excessive with its many stairs, and the metal chair couldn't be very comfortable. She'd repurposed her own throne room *years* ago, it seemed like a massive waste of space.

“Entrapta. I had some thoughts about the portal I wish to discuss with you in the lab.” He started to rise, but she lightly pushed him back down with a strand of hair.

“Hold on a sec, I wanna show you something.” Without giving it much thought, she used her hair to hop up on the left armrest of his throne to get a better angle so they could look at her trackerpad together. The armrest was large enough that she could dangle her legs over the edge while facing him on the chair. She was about to speak, but noticed how his eyes had widened to huge spheres, looking her up and down, and she paused. “Is something wrong?”

He blinked and his ears twitched. “Ah...No. Please, continue.” He still had a peculiar expression on his face that she couldn’t interpret, but his voice was otherwise impassive, so she gave a small nod and held up the trackerpad in a strand of hair for him to see.

“Just look at this reading I got earlier. It’s *huge!*” Her hair frizzed out to illustrate her point and she jabbed her finger at the screen, inadvertently obscuring his view, and he moved the device away from her hand with one of his long talons. He leaned a little closer to get a better look, and she briefly darted her eyes from the screen to admire his close proximity. Something for her to replay in her mind later. “We need someone to go get it right away, before it disappears. There are a lot of unpredictable snow storms in the Northern Reach, so there’s no telling how soon it will be before we lose the signal.”

He huffed. “None of the tech that has been brought back to us so far has been enough to power the portal. How will this be any different? I cannot keep wasting res-" she bopped him in the mouth with a strand of hair to silence him. It was a reflex, but she was always surprised when he didn’t protest.

“True, but we have utilized every piece of in-tact tech for additional weapons, even though it hasn’t necessarily assisted us with the portal. It hasn’t been a waste at all.” He didn’t respond, a

sign he was listening. “This is the largest reading I have *ever* seen. I’m confident this will be groundbreaking for the next step of our portal work.”

Hordak sighed and leaned back, and she had to stop herself from scooting closer. “Very well, I will send a message to Force Captain Scorpia to rally a team.” Entrapta’s face must have done something, she couldn’t always control it, because Hordak arched a brow. “Are you opposed?”

She held up her hands and shook her head. “No no! Scorpia is *great!* It’s just… She’s broken 35% of the First Ones tech she’s brought back to us. I can still use the fragments, and even piece them back together sometimes, but they’re not as powerful as they would be if they hadn't gotten totally smashed.”

Hordak let out a low, growly hum as he thought and the sound made Entrapta shudder. It was often hard to tell where his pupiless orbs were focused, but he must have shifted his gaze from her, because she felt it when he locked his eyes on her again. Her face apparently betrayed her again, because his ear twitched once more as he looked at her. Oh, she really *was* trying to do a better job at keeping herself in check, but he made it so difficult. Honestly, he really expected to walk around here looking and sounding like he did and *not* have someone try to jump his bones??

“I will have Force Captain Catra accompany her. She appears to be in desperate need of an actual task. If there is nothing else…?” He gestured with a hand towards the lab and rose from the throne. Entrapta allowed herself to watch him for a moment before following him down the stairs.

Entrapta had planned to go back to Dryl after the conversation with Hordak yesterday. She really had. But Hordak hadn’t mentioned the robotics upgrades since she’d arrived here, so was it really that time sensitive? Octavia had sent her increasingly aggressive messages about her absence, saying members of the

advisory council kept harassing Octavia about Dryl politics she knew nothing about. She asked Octavia to handle things early on, but the woman had left her a very angry voice message about how she did *not* agree to be the backup Princess of Dryl.

There had certainly been an uptick in *allegedly* necessary political decisions ever since she married Hordak and let his people move into the mountains. And it wasn't like she was going to ignore them, she accepted the calls from her advisors more often than not.

However, the possibility of incredible tech in the Northern Reach was much more interesting than governing her kingdom, so she wanted to at least wait until they had it on site before returning to Dryl. And she would definitely be returning to Dryl. Most likely.

Entrapta was on her way to the huge room where she'd been stashing all her of things. Octavia had panicked those weeks ago when Entrapta had some of her tools and machinery transported to the Fright Zone, but it hadn't been *that much* stuff, had it? Before she could reflect on this further, Entrapta paused as she heard voices echoing up into the vents.

"I don't even know what we'll be looking for. The Northern Reach has no signal and no resources. This is gonna be a huge waste of time." It was the voice of the cat. She was not happy about her new assignment, although Scopia had seemed beyond pleased that the other girl was joining her on this mission. While Entrapta spent most of her time with Hordak, she had also been spending some time with Scorpia to debrief her on what she should be looking for on the searches for First Ones tech.

"I mean, I know what we're looking for! Generally speaking, all this tech looks a little different. And besides, we'll have resources. Entrapta is gonna loan us that giant drill!" Scorpia responded. Entrapta peeked out of the slats in the vent overhead to see Scorpia pointing enthusiastically to the massive vehicular drill she'd had sent over, just in case they needed it. It was one of many that were retired from the Dryl mines.

Catra hopped into the machine and scowled at all of the knobs and buttons. “I’ll never be able to figure out how to use this thing!” She folded her arms before jumping down, kicking one of the large treads of the machine. “I think that weird princess should have to come with us.”

Scorpia clacked her claws together and her eyebrows furrowed. “Catra, should you really be talking about Lord Hordak’s *wife* that way?”

Catra laughed loudly, throwing her head back as if it were the funniest thing in the world. “Oh come on,” Catra scoffed between laughs. “Everyone knows their whole *marriage* is a total joke. They were both in it for the benefits. She doesn’t mean anything more to Lord Hordak than the weapons she’s been supplying. Shadow Weaver made sure the whole Fright Zone knows she has no power here.”

Entrapta winced. *Ouch.* She couldn’t care less about having a position of power, but it hurt to hear how little she meant to Hordak. She considered him her friend and thought he felt the same, but he must have told Shadow Weaver otherwise. It was probably for the best that she left the Fright Zone soon, before she got even more attached.

Before they could say anything else, Entrapta dropped down to the ground and the younger women let out shouts of surprise. Catra did have a point: she was sending them to the middle of nowhere with a *lot* of tools they probably wouldn’t be able to figure out how to use. And she wanted Hordak to have that tech. He needed it.

“Hi there! Do you have room for one more on your expedition?” She received slack-jawed nods in response. It seemed only Hordak had gotten used to her popping out of vents. “Great! I’m just gonna let Hordak know, and I’ll meet you guys on the ship!”

It took her mere minutes to travel back to Hordak’s sanctum and she dropped gracelessly to the floor. “Where have you been?” He

asked dryly without turning around from his workstation.

"Oh, here and there. Listen, I think I'm gonna go with Scorpia to the Northern Reach."

He set down his tools immediately and turned to face her with a deep frown. "*What?? Why?*"

She shrugged. "This isn't going to be quick and easy like the other tech trips Scorpia has gone on. They don't know how to operate my giant drill or any of the tracking tools. And we need that tech."

He approached her slowly and gazed down at her with an unreadable expression. Maybe he would be glad to get rid of her. "What about the portal machine?"

"There isn't much more I can do for you until I get a big enough piece of tech to add to it," she replied plainly.

His gaze somehow grew more intense and it was a long moment before he responded. "You have no combat experience. You have no magical capabilities. You are," he eyed her up and down, "*very small*. You will not go." He turned sharply back to his desk and she raised her eyebrows. Was he *worried* about her?

"I'll be with Scorpia and Catra, it'll be fine! Besides, who knows when we'll see a reading this powerful again? We can't waste anymore time."

She heard him sigh deeply as he thought. "There is no need for you to go."

Entrapta frowned. "Yes, there is. I just explained it to you, were you listening? Without my tools operating properly on site, they probably won't succeed in procuring the tech."

After a moment of silence, he pulled out his datapad and began typing something into it. "So be it. However, I am sending Commander Grizzlor with you. You are to remain with him at all times."

Her heart fluttered at his apparent concern, even if it was only because he needed her for her skills. “You got it! I’ll stay in touch if I can, but comms signals are gonna be dodgy.” She shifted when he didn’t respond. “Well, bye!”

She turned to go, but heard him rise, and when she looked back he was approaching her in fast strides. “Entrapta.” He paused in front of her, gazing down at her intently, his ears slightly tilted downwards. He raised his hand and for a moment, it looked like he was going to pat her on the head like a dog, but instead he clenched his fist and lowered it back to his side. “Endeavor to stay alive.”

She broke into a grin, her confidence in their friendship soaring once again. “I’ll miss you, too.”

Chapter End Notes

> omg I feel like I am writing forever and getting NOWHERE!! when are they gonna kiss??

Have you ever had a dream that that you um you had you'd you would you could you'd do you wi you wants you you could do so you you'd do you could you you want you want him to do you so much you could do anything?

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta is away on a mission to procure more tech. Hordak gets a lot of things accomplished in her absence and does not miss her at all. In fact, he's never been more focused! Anyone who says otherwise is a filthy liar and they will be sent to Beast Island.

Chapter Notes

> SMUUUUUT WARNING!! THERE WILL BE SMUT AHEAD. If you don't want to read smut, just stop reading when you get to the double bars!! You won't miss anything, I swear, but I'll summarize in the end notes.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hordak found it hard to focus since Entrapta left for the Northern Reach. He should've been relieved to be rid of her, with her constant chattering, invasion of his personal space and disregard for quiet hours. He should be grateful for the peace and solitude that he had so sorely missed. And he *had* missed it, undoubtedly. There was no question.

However...Were he made to confess, he'd have to say he'd grown to *not hate* having her bouncing all around his sanctum. She was the most intelligent being he'd encountered on this mudball planet, and it was clear she outsmarted him by at least a league or two. Not that he would ever admit it to her. Of course, he probably didn't have to, she seemed to know everything already.

Her little squad was meant to be gone a week tops, but after a day and a half, he had ceased receiving updates from Commander Grizzlor. Entrapta had said communication signals may not be possible once they were at the site where the tech was located, but he was still irritated that he was completely in the dark on her safety. And by her safety, he meant the progress of the mission, of course.

Yes, if she were to perish in the snowy mountains, it would be a great loss of the only bright mind Etheria seemed to possess. He didn't know why that thought hit him so roughly, but it made his palms grow sweaty and his stomach churn, and he quickly shook it aside. She was safe with Commander Grizzlor, and they would be back in another couple of days. Perhaps he would even receive a backlog of messages from them soon.

No matter. He had work to do and more important things to think about. He sat down at his workstation and pulled out some busy work to tide him over until he had the tech for the portal in his possession. He'd been struck by what he thought was a brilliant idea of his own when he had examined the newest batch of First Ones tech yesterday and drafted the schematics right away. He would integrate First Ones tech with the Horde standard stun baton so that they could be used as long range weapons.

However...Truth be told, he wasn't sure how exactly to go about it yet, as Entrapta had done all of the weapons upgrades while he skulked around the portal. His "schematics" were really more of a drawing of a stun baton with a crystal on it. It depicted a powerful beam pointing at Bright Moon castle. It may not be the most technical drawing, but she would understand what he meant, surely.

He should really have her show him the details of how these strange crystals functioned when she returned. Maybe she would sit on the edge of his throne again and tell him how to accomplish this. ...Maybe *what??* Why would he think such a ridiculous thing? Bah! He pushed the drawing and the baton to the side and stood up. Maybe a walk around the Fright Zone would clear his head

enough to get some work done. It was late, but maybe he could find someone to cast a menacing stare to. The responding look of fear always cheered him up.

He exited the sanctum with plans to head outside, but as he passed the Black Garnet Chamber, sounds of activity within made him pause. He halted in the shadows where he could survey the door but not be seen by anyone who exited. After a moment, Shadow Weaver all but limped out, moaning and groaning, looking as though she were about to keel over. He held his breath hoping she would, but alas, she steadied herself with a hand on the wall and stumbled in the opposite direction. He had no doubt she was drunk. She seemed to think he didn't notice when she attended meetings while intoxicated, but in truth, he found that the drinking made her more tolerable so he simply turned a blind eye.

Once she had disappeared down the hallway, Hordak opened the door and slid into the dark room. The Black Garnet shone brilliantly as always, although it was little more than a symbol of status these days. Shadow Weaver informed him long ago that Scorpia was unable to connect with it, and the power she had leached from it herself had done very little in progressing their position in the war.

He walked deeper inside and peered into the strange basin she kept within. It shimmered ominously, and as he leaned closer, he took note of a vague image within, though it was quickly dissipating. It appeared to be a girl with a sword. He squinted and recognition hit him just before the image faded to nothing. *Adora* . Shadow Weaver was still spying on her former ward despite explicit orders. He exhaled deeply and clenched his fists. He would need to replace her soon. How inconvenient.

He turned to go, casting one last look at the Garnet as he passed it. Dryl had no runestone. Perhaps when she was back, Entrapta would like to see the one he possessed. He stopped cold in the doorway. *Perhaps Entrapta would what??* By Prime, what was the

matter with him? Forget the damn walk, he obviously needed to rest, he was not thinking clearly.

He strode quickly back to the sanctum and darted into his quarters, which were well hidden behind the throne room and had a lock different from the others in the Fright Zone, one that only he knew how to operate. Maybe he ought to add the same mechanism to the outer doors of the sanctum as well. He'd get around to it eventually.

His room was spartan, but he had no need for anything more elaborate. The bed was just large enough for his tall frame, and he had a few cabinets for his small amount of clothes, rations, and extra tools for when he was too ill to leave his room. His bathroom was barely any larger than an alcove.

He had made the space so small because he believed he wouldn't be here very long. That had been *decades* ago, but he'd never had the energy to upgrade to anything larger. Besides, brothers of Prime were not meant to experience worldly luxury. It made them soft. It made them *sin.* In addition, he was closer than he had been in years to opening the portal, and he still held onto the hope he would be going home soon.

The machinery that assembled and disassembled his armor took up the remaining space. This one was mounted in place, but he had a similar, mobile device just outside the door, as sometimes he was in too poor shape to make it back to his room. He stood in front of the device now and with a sharp intake of breath, the robotic limbs began removing the many components of his armor. He hadn't done much work today, so his body was thankfully not in too much pain, and though the process was still uncomfortable, his mind was able to wander.

He noted Imp was missing tonight, but he wasn't concerned. The boy often fell asleep in the vents, or occasionally he would raid the kitchens and curl up in front of the furnace. Hordak cast a glance at his datapad, which he'd placed on the cabinet nearest his bed. He would try to check in with Commander Grizzlor again

in the morning. He'd sent Entrapta several messages as well, but she rarely answered him when she was here, so he highly doubted she would find time to reply while she was in the field.

He winced as the robotic arms removed the last of his armor and organized it on the specialized shelf for wear again tomorrow. He'd had the foresight years ago to cover the bathroom mirror when not applying his makeup; he couldn't bear to see his emaciated body.

He lay down on the bed and stared at the ceiling. His brows furrowed as the image of Entrapta perched upon his throne returned to his head. She looked very nice there, illuminated by the overhead lighting, her pupils oddly blown as she spoke to him. For the most part, she had stopped making inappropriate comments towards him like she'd done in Dryl. He tried to convince himself he was relieved, but as they had grown closer over the last month, he found himself wishing she'd pay him that sort of attention again. He didn't know why, nothing good could possibly come of it.

He didn't understand why he acutely felt Entrapta's absence today, but other memories soon invaded his tired mind. The feeling of her small form on top of him when she'd fallen in his room in Dryl...The curve of her figure when he'd found her in her lab...Ashamed and disgusted with himself, he closed his eyes to dispel the vivid images. He had no business recalling such things. It was wrong and unprofessional. Still, he hoped she would return soon. For the portal, obviously. He slipped beneath the covers and let sleep claim him.

Bleary-eyed and groggy, Hordak blinked in the dim light of his bedroom, listening to the distant humming of the machines in the sanctum. At what point he had passed the threshold of sleep to wakefulness, he was uncertain, but he felt hot, anxious and unable to lie still. It was an odd sensation, and when he placed his hand on his brow, he found a thin sheen of sweat.

He wiped his damp hair out of his eyes, sitting up in the bed. The movement made him aware of a tingling in his lower half. Perhaps his spinal port was acting up? However, he didn't find it painful or unpleasant. When he placed his palms on the mattress, he noticed a dip in the space beside him.

He turned, expecting to see Imp. His mouth went dry. He did not see Imp. There sat Entrapta on the edge of his bed, her knees curled up underneath her while she leaned towards him on her hands. She had that strange dilation to her pupils he'd seen on his throne and a time or two before. More notably, she was missing her white top.

“Hi there!” she greeted. Even now, she was so casual. Panicking over his own undress, Hordak immediately pulled his sheet up to his neck to hide his wasted body from her view.

She had apparently returned early from the Northern Reach, but the fact that she chose to seek him out in his room left him bewildered. How did she even find it? Hordak opened his mouth to speak, but to his continued mortification, nothing but a pitiful whimper came out as he stared at her soft curves.

He remembered very well how there was barely enough room for himself on his bed, yet she somehow found space to crawl towards him on her hands and knees, giving him an excellent view of her breasts, barely concealed by her striped undergarments. The unfamiliar sensation in his groin seemed to pulse with each move that she made, and he averted his eyes from her, only to stare in horror at the thin sheet covering him; something beneath the fabric was making it twitch and move.

What was...Oh. *Oh, no.*

Another sign of his defect. He was unable to keep control of his body and it was rising up against him - figuratively and literally at the moment. He stared at Entrapta with wide eyes as she sat back on her knees beside him, smiling innocently. Self-conscious at her proximity, the need to conceal his lower half won out over his

desire to hide his upper body. He hunched over, trying to hide his shame with his arms and hands, but he realized far too late that touching that area was a mistake. As a wave of pleasure rushed through him, his eyes shut and a low moan escaped him before he could stop it. When he dared look at her again, Entrapta was giving him a sly smile, seemingly pleased.

The burgundy half-top that covered her arms framed her exposed chest in a very pleasing way, and he licked his dry lips, still failing to speak. Strands of her hair reached out and took hold of his wrists, moving his arms away from his abdomen. She seemed disinterested in examining his withered body, as though she hadn’t even noticed it, and a small part of him was relieved. However, the relief immediately dissolved as his lower half responded eagerly as her soft hair caressed him. His face burned with shame as his stiff member grew into a full-blown erection at her touch, lifting the sheet like a tent.

Hordak swallowed and forced the trapped words out of his throat. "You should not be here," he rasped.

She tilted her head. "But you wanted me here," she said with confusion, brows furrowing.

W-what? While he had desired her return, he hadn't sent any such message. Had he?? "I...I cannot…I believe I am unwell," he stammered, uncertain of what he even wanted to say.

"Unwell? You mean *this?*" She came dangerously close to his covered member with a pointing finger.

She did not look offended by the state of him, and Hordak struggled with how to proceed. All her forward comments came back to him. Surely, she'd just been teasing him. Surely, she didn't want *this*. Not with *him*. "I am not supposed to… Have *this.*" Hordak referred not only to his blasphemous arousal, but to the presence of Entrapta herself. Pleasures of the flesh and companionship had no place in the Galactic Horde. Such things absolutely were not meant for him. "This is wrong."

Hordak's breath caught as she climbed on top of him, straddling his knees, and he burned with a desire he'd never known he could possess. "I told you before. The organic body is nothing to be ashamed of." He gasped as she scooted herself closer to the crux of him. "And besides, we *are* married. So, how could this be wrong?" She leaned closer and her hair crept beneath the sheet, curling over his legs.

He was breathing rapidly, and he felt like his mind was going to project itself out of his body as she pressed herself forward just enough to brush against the base of his shaft. The sensation was overwhelming, even through the multiple layers of fabric between them, and he moaned loudly at the contact. From either the gates of hell, or from Entrapta's body pressed against his own, he swore he was going to catch fire one way or another.

She backed off of him, her hair retreating and a look of concern on her face. "Sorry...Do you want me to stop?"

"*No!* " He hated the desperation in his voice. Despite her words, he knew it was wrong, but he couldn't hold back when she was offering so willingly. He nodded at her in approval as she moved closer once more. She eased back down and began rubbing herself fully against his throbbing cock, and he couldn't contain the groan of relief spilling from his parted lips.

His claws gripped the sheets, and he knew he was tearing them but he didn't care. The friction was unlike anything he had ever felt, and unworthy as he was, he hoped it never ended. Grunting as she moved against him, his hips began thrusting upwards of their own accord, matching the rhythm she'd set. While he had no experience in this activity, it appeared something primal inside him knew how to increase the pleasure.

The pressure in his loins increased with every roll of their hips, and with shaky movements, he lifted his arms, hit by the sudden urge to touch her. She looked so soft. "Go ahead," she said gently, and he tentatively placed his hands on the bare skin of her waist. She let out a soft hum and began grinding down harder against

him and he grit his teeth, feeling he was nearing *something*, though he wasn't sure what.

Not faltering in her movements, she leaned her upper body closer to him. She took his wrists in tendrils of hair, arched her back and began repositioning his hands, moving them further towards her ample chest.

When he began moving his hands on his own, she removed one of her gloves with her teeth and slipped her naked hand beneath the sheet and under his tabard, wrapping her fingers around his bare shaft. Hordak cried out and his head flew back, nearly slamming it against the wall, but her ever-present hair cushioned the back of his head. "Time to wake up, *Lord Hordak*," Entrapta whispered, stroking his length with a firm grip. Right before his hands made contact with her breasts, Hordak let go.

Chapter End Notes

> Hordak has a spicy dream about his wife, but it's okay because they're married (I have to keep reminding myself about this, so I assume the readers also need reminders). Thank you Mazen and Cas for proof reading!!
>
> I will continue to keep future smut as isolated as possible!

In Sickness, And Hopefully Occasionally In Health

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta gets a cold welcome back from the Northern Reach, but it's about to get warmer.

Chapter Notes

> After a two month block, I've returned to these idiots with a needlessly long chapter. Thank you Mazen, Alex and Cas for your help with this chapter~
>
> Nothing explicit in this one, but references to Hordak being a naughty lad and Entrapta being horny all over main.

“Hooordak!” Entrapta called as she wandered into the sanctum, rolling a massive disc of First Ones Tech with her. “I’m back!” She was excited to return earlier than expected; the trip was fun, but she’d missed Hordak. Science was more fun with a partner who understood more than a fraction of what you were saying. She would’ve returned even sooner had it not been for Scorpia. Entrapta had found the tech the day after they arrived, but Scorpia asked Entrapta not to tell Catra right away, so that Scorpia could spend more time with Catra. Entrapta hadn’t really understood, but she’d shrugged and agreed, as there was a lot of fun stuff in the Northern Reach for her to mess with. However, Grizzlor called an immediate end to the excursion after they’d gotten in a fight with some angry teenagers that showed up.

At the sound of her voice, Imp immediately flew over to her, landing on her shoulder and rubbing his head against her cheek. “[Entrapta,]” he greeted in the voice of Octavia, and Entrapta brought up a hand to scratch the top of his head.

“Aw, I missed you too, little guy! Is Hordak around? I can’t *wait* for him to see this new tech!” Imp simply gave a tiny shrug and

flew off. She frowned as she looked around while walking towards the portal, but her grumpy husband was nowhere in sight. As she came to a stop with her haul, she finally heard metallic footsteps rapidly approaching.

He apparently didn't hear her enter the sanctum, and he walked right past her without looking in her direction. His ears were drooped low and he was carrying a pile of fabric in his arms. He appeared to be moving with great purpose, but Entrapta called out to him anyway. "Hordak!"

He froze immediately and inhaled sharply, but he still did not turn towards her. After a pause so long Entrapta nearly spoke again, Hordak finally tilted his head just enough that she could see his face, though it was clear he wasn't looking at her. "Entrapta." His voice sounded raspier than usual, yet somehow lacked his usual sternness. "I see you have returned in one piece." He clutched the bundle in his arms tighter, his talons digging into the fabric.

Entrapta started to step closer, but he cringed so heavily even she couldn't help but notice his discomfort, and she halted in her tracks. Had she done something wrong already? That had to be a new record. She pressed anyway; hopefully he'd cheer up when he saw what she'd brought for them. "Yep, I sure have! And I got the most *amazing* tech!" Before he could respond, her gaze shifted to the bundle in his arms. Were those bedsheets? "What've you got there?"

He turned away instantly as she took another step towards him to inspect his cargo. "It is none of your concern," he snapped. "Just leave the tech here and get out."

Entrapta frowned. "I don't understand. Don't you need me to-"

"I do *not* need you!"

Entrapta felt her face fall at the harsh words. Such a drastic change from the concern he'd shown her before she left. Perhaps she'd misread him, or perhaps he'd just wanted the tech. Or

perhaps he had realized how annoying she was when she was gone. He wouldn't be the first one. He finally looked at her directly, but she averted her eyes when he opened his mouth to speak again. Entrapta understood. She would get out. With a sigh of defeat, she scurried up the nearest vent on tendrils of hair and disappeared.

In no time at all, she gracelessly fell out of the ventilation shaft into her given room, landing roughly on the floor. "Emily!" she shouted, springing up and throwing herself at the tamed battle bot that chirped upon her arrival. "I've missed you!" She nuzzled against Emily before sliding down to rest her back against the cool, metal frame. It was comforting to have a friend to literally and metaphorically lean upon when she was feeling down, even if most people would claim the bot wasn't "real". Once in a comfortable position, she grabbed her datapad to try and distract herself from the negative encounter with Hordak.

In her downtime on the mission, she'd been brainstorming some ideas for how she could better rule Dryl from a distance, and she couldn't wait to share them with Octavia. Hordak may have a piss poor attitude, but that wasn't going to deter her from continuing work on the portal. It was the most fascinating project she'd ever gotten the chance to work on, and she wasn't going home just yet unless he had her physically dragged away.

She let out a surprised hum as she opened her message application to call Octavia. She had…*a lot* of notifications. 115 unread messages. What in the world? There were a lot of technical interferences in the Northern Reach and she hadn't bothered to try to set up a signal for the datapads. She'd expected a small backlog of messages, but this was ridiculous. Her brows knit in confusion as she started reading them.

[Message 1/115, from Hordak: Entrapta, this is a formal reminder to remain in sight of Commander Grizzlor at all times. - Lord Hordak]

[Message 2/115, from Hordak: Entrapta, you are forbidden from entering any mines, caves, caverns or the like. Commander Grizzlor has been informed of this as well. Failure to adhere to these guidelines will incur strict punishment. - Lord Hordak]

Surely all of these weren't from Hordak? Maybe some of them were sent multiple times due to the poor signal? She scrolled through them, but each one seemed to have been sent intentionally. He'd also signed his name at the end of each message. Entrapta grinned. What a dork.

[Message 112/115, from Hordak: Entrapta, I have drafted schematics for a new weapon. I will send the file to you in the subsequent message. - Lord Hordak]

[File received from Hordak]

Entrapta tilted her head. It was a picture of Imp that the boy had appeared to have taken himself. His nose was pressed against the screen and his tongue was sticking out.

[Message 113/115, from Hordak: Disregard the previous file. It was sent in error. The correct file will be sent momentarily.]

[File received from Hordak]

A drawing of a First One's crystal on a stun baton??

[Message 114/115, from Hordak: I will work on the prototype in your absence. When you return, perhaps you could assist me with this in addition to the portal. - Lord Hordak]

Entrapta's grin widened so much her cheeks hurt.

[Message 115/115, from Hordak: Let this message serve as a reminder to practice strict watercraft safety on the return trip. Regards, Lord Hordak]

Entrapta giggled like a fool as she reread the plethora of messages, half of which were barely work-related. Still, as giddy

as she was, it made his reaction to her return all the more confusing. Maybe she'd just caught him at a bad time.

Hordak was having a bad time. As he watched his tainted sheets burn to ash in the incinerator, he stewed in his newfound crippling anxiety. He bit the inside of his cheek as he shifted uncomfortably, waiting for the proof of his shame to disappear, as though it would take the deed with it. Never before had this happened! Why now?? He'd awoken early this morning to find himself…committing a vile act upon his body. While imagining *Entrapta* was the one doing it! Even worse…Hordak bit down harder, until he tasted his own blood. He had *liked it*.

It had felt so good, been such a relief, that he had allowed himself to lie there reveling in the feeling, basking in the afterglow of pleasure while picturing Entrapta's golden brown skin against his own withered flesh. Of course after thirty seconds of this blissful, willful ignorance, the horror and humiliation crashed down upon him, as God intended.

Not only had he defiled himself, but in doing so he had committed a sin that God would no doubt punish him for, and he had also disrespected Entrapta's honor. For whatever reason, the latter hit him hardest and he had risen from the bed in a wave of nausea. It…It hadn't been his fault! He was unconscious, his hips and hand moving of their own accord! Surely, God would forgive him for this mistake. And not that he would ever tell her, but Entrapta would understand as well. Right?

He'd taken shaky steps to his mirror and began hastily applying his makeup. The brief euphoria of the release was no match for the stress he'd accumulated, and he knew right away it was going to be a bad day. With plans to redo the sloppy makeup and fix his hair later, he'd donned his armor, gotten dressed, and quickly left his room with only one goal in mind: destroy all evidence.

These thoughts continued to plague him as he rushed out of his room, but all coherence left him the moment Entrapta's squeaky

voice unexpectedly pierced through the silence of the sanctum. He didn't know whether he wanted to drop to his knees and repent to Lord Prime, drop to his knees and apologize to Entrapta for using her memory for his own gratification, or drop to his knees and bury his face into Entrapta's ample chest. Either way, his knees and other parts of him were filling his head with some alarming thoughts so he responded to her chipper greeting in the one way he knew best: Anger.

A deep sigh left him as the last of his soiled sheets disappeared in the flames, and he found himself thinking of Entrapta's sad face when he'd snapped at her. Guilt was a new emotion for him, and he had to say he didn't care for it in the least. He wiped the blood from his lips from his very-chewed inner cheeks. A bad habit to pick up when one had razor-sharp fangs, but Hordak probably deserved the pain. Feeling a bit light-headed, he leaned against the edge of the incinerator to steady himself. Intense emotions always made his illness flare up, and despite years of trying, he could just never seem to stop *feeling*. It was terribly inconvenient and he really ought to find a way to be done with it for good.

After a moment, he closed the door to the incinerator and headed laboriously back into his sanctum. He was feeling quite sick, but he wanted to inspect the tech from the Northern Reach before calling for a mission debriefing session with Grizzlor and the others in one of the meeting rooms. He also felt the need to apologize to Entrapta for his earlier outburst, but he'd never done such a thing before. How did one even begin to apologize without getting angry all over again? Besides, he was fearful of his wretched body's reactions when he saw her again. It would probably be for the best if she didn't show up to the debriefing at all.

Entrapta decided to show up early for the debriefing. She wanted to discuss the next steps for the portal before Grizzlor showed up and started talking about boring stuff like girls with swords. And if Hordak was still going to be cranky, then he could sit there pouting while she did all the talking. So, not much different than

usual, really. She'd hoped to find him in the sanctum prior to the meeting, but he was yet again nowhere in sight. Glancing toward the portal, the tech appeared to be untouched from where she'd left it this morning. Strange.

She approached the throne room, looking around. "Hordak?" She wasn't *that* early, was she? Or maybe she'd messed up and she was actually super late. Oh well. As the excessive, metal throne came into view, her eyes widened. Hordak was seated upon it, but was laid over the right armrest, practically curled up as much as his large frame would allow. Something was clearly wrong. She rushed quickly up the stairs and heard him breathing raggedly as she drew nearer. "Hordak?" she whispered again. One of his arms was covering his face and she tried to lift it gently with a tendril of hair, but he swatted at it half-heartedly with a low grunt.

"Gid owd," he mumbled, his voice muffled from where his face was buried in his arms.

Entrapta huffed. "I'm not gonna get out, you're sick. Let me help you." When he didn't respond or move, she sighed and hopped up on the left armrest, poking him in the shoulder with a tendril. "Why are you so stubborn?" She rolled her eyes when she heard him harrumph from beneath his cape. She saw him stir and glance at her when she slid off again, but she didn't say anything. She was gone only for a moment to the large industrial sink in the sanctum to get him a glass of water and a cool rag, and when she returned to the throne he had managed to sit up a bit straighter and his breathing appeared less labored.

He took the glass from her and didn't even protest when she pressed the rag against his forehead with a strand of hair. She had reclaimed her seat on the armrest and watched him contemplatively while he drained the glass. "Feeling better?"

He let out a shaky sigh. "I do not wish to discuss this."

She stared at him, dying to know the details; he reacted as if this were not an uncommon occurrence. However, Octavia had

stressed the importance of personal space and private matters when Entrapta had accidentally gushed about how much she liked him on their call earlier, so she bit back her questions. “Do you wanna cancel the meeting?” she asked, scooping out her datapad to call Grizzlor, but Hordak held up an unsteady hand.

“No… We will have the meeting as planned.” However, Hordak’s body didn’t appear to want to follow his orders, and he had barely risen before he collapsed in the throne once more with an irritated growl. He seemed to think for a moment before looking at her with slightly lowered ears. “Would you…Tell Grizzlor we will meet here in the throne room, instead.”

Entrapta grinned, thrilled that he would let her assist him. “Of course!” She typed the message quickly before taking in the sight of her lab partner fully. “Say uh, you care about appearances, right?” Entrapta found it hard to worry about how she looked most days, but Hordak definitely kept up a certain facade, and she thought he may want to know that his makeup was smeared everywhere as though he’d fallen face-first into engine oil. Entrapta should know, she’d done it herself many times.

He snorted in disgust as she held up the datapad camera so he could see himself. His hair was also wet from the rag and it fell messily in front of his eyes. Entrapta thought it looked cute, but before she could say so, he batted at his blue strands in annoyance. He held the datapad in one hand and tried to correct the smudgy lines on his eyes with his free hand, but his trembling fingers were only making matters worse. Entrapta slowly lowered the datapad away from him with a strand of hair. “Can I please help you?” she asked again.

His eyes met hers and he gave a small, hesitant nod. “Do not… Do not speak of this to anyone.”

Entrapta agreed sincerely as she set the datapad aside. She didn't give it much thought as she climbed directly onto the seat between Hordak's widespread legs to get better stability. Hordak made an odd whimpering noise of what she guessed was surprise

as she rose up on her knees to better reach him, their torsos inches apart. She peeled off her gloves and held them in a tendril of hair, as they were far too bulky and would only hinder her. Additionally, she really wanted to feel his skin with her bare hands. Perhaps this was a selfish thought when he seemed so exposed, but she thought it nevertheless.

He inhaled sharply and shut his eyes as her palms connected lightly with his cheeks. He'd started breathing heavily again; she hummed in concern, hoping he wasn't going to have another dizzy spell. He moved his arms to either of the armrests, and a strand of her hair nudged his head a bit closer to her. His exhale was deep and she could feel the vibrations from his chest as her thumbs and forefingers wiped the thick eyeliner back into place in the batwing style he favored. His skin was smoother and cooler than she'd expected, and the white of his face felt thinner than the slate blue of his cheeks and jaw.

She noticed he was clutching the rag tightly in one hand, but she took it from him to wipe the excess eyeliner from the areas of his face it didn't belong on. Once satisfied with her handiwork, she stretched her right arm up to comb back his bedraggled blue hair. Her fingers sank into the tuft and she bit back a squeak of delight when she felt how silky it was. He shuddered lightly as she ran her fingers through it, which she found to be a very interesting reaction. She admittedly spent longer brushing it back than was necessary, but who knew if she would ever get the opportunity again? Besides, Hordak certainly wasn't complaining about it now.

His eyes had remained closed throughout her ministrations and she sat back on her knees once she'd finished, taking in the sight of him. He was a remarkable creature, and his tense face had melted into relaxation as she'd fixed his hair. He was even more beautiful when his face wasn't screwed up into an angry frown. She was struck by the urge to kiss him, or at the very least stroke his long ears with her bare hands, but it would be a massive breach of the trust he'd just shown her. "Okay, all done!" she chirped, showing him on the datapad once more.

He opened his eyes and hummed solemnly in approval as she placed her gloves back on her hands. She shifted to move to the ground, but a massive hand wrapped around her wrist, keeping her in place on the throne between his legs. She blinked in confusion at where they were connected before looking up at him. They locked eyes, something she usually didn't care for, but he looked oddly vulnerable and so she held his gaze. "Entrapta," he licked his lips and seemed to struggle for words. "I… regret my tone with you this morning. You were not… I was… *distracted* ." She was sure she grinned like an idiot before she opened her mouth to reply, but he held up his free hand to stop her. "Furthermore," he cleared his throat, shifting his eyes away from her, "I am… I appreciate… I am relieved that…"

"You're welcome," she replied softly. "And I'm glad to be back." She squeezed his shoulder with a strand of hair and he smiled at her in a way she was certain he hadn't before. It lasted but a moment, because they heard the sanctum door hiss open and they released one another.

Entrapta quickly hopped off the throne, meaning to move down to the base of the diais where the others would gather, but Hordak spoke again. "You may remain, if you wish." She spun around in surprise to see he had straightened up, and gestured to the left armrest of the throne. While she was uncertain as to what the implication of this gesture meant, she felt her face flush, but nodded enthusiastically and quickly hopped up beside him, stretching her legs along the length of the armrest so she could face the others.

Grizzlor, Scorpia and Catra assembled at the bottom of the stairs, bowing before Hordak. He didn't usually have such formal meetings after tech excursions, but Entrapta figured the appearance of that tall princess with the First One's sword had something to do with it. "Commander Grizzlor," Hordak began, his voice turning into the authoritative drawl he used around others. "I reviewed your correspondence this morning about the appearance of the princess known as She-Ra. Do we know why she would surface somewhere so desolate?"

"She and her companions also appeared to be tracking First One's signals, sir," Grizzlor replied. "We aren't certain why. There wasn't a lot of time for discussion, what with them trying to kill us." Entrapta frowned. Technically, Catra had started the fight, and the feline had been the only one attempting to kill someone. Oh well, probably not important. "Additionally, sir. I wanted to discuss this in person, but She-Ra…" Catra gave Grizzlor a look, but Entrapta didn't know what it meant. "She-Ra is former Force Captain Adora."

Hordak's relaxed posture tensed immediately, the talons of his right hand digging into the metal armrest. "I see." He shifted, and it looked like he wanted to stand, but thought better of it. "Force Captain Catra, come here." The feline's ears drooped, but she did as she was told and ascended the stairs, kneeling before him. "Look at me." She slowly lifted her head, and Entrapta could swear she glared at her before Catra shifted her gaze to Hordak.

Hordak bent down to lock eyes with Catra. "Force Captain, you have been running *reconnaissance* for Shadow Weaver. Did this entail searching for Adora?"

Catra bit her lip before replying. "Yes, sir."

Hordak's eyes narrowed. "And were you aware I explicitly told her to cease her search for your former colleague?" Catra hesitated before nodding slowly. "And were you aware that Adora was She-Ra?" Hordak's level voice was rising in anger.

"No, sir," Catra replied immediately.

Hordak positively glowered. "Are you lying to me, Force Captain?"

"No! I swear, I had no idea," Catra insisted.

Hordak sat back, but his piercing gaze remained on the girl. "Good. Because if I find out that you were knowingly aiding Shadow Weaver in bringing the most powerful princess we've encountered, one who has inner knowledge of our operations, back into the Fright Zone against explicit orders, the punishment

will be severe." His voice had melted into a dangerous whisper, and as tense as the situation was, Entrapta found something about his tone positively thrilling. "You will *not* go against my direct orders again."

Catra nodded. "Yes, sir."

She began to rise, but Hordak stopped her. "Force Captain, remain where you are." To Entrapta's surprise, Hordak turned and addressed her. "Entrapta, Commander Grizzlor tells me that during the mission, your drilling bots went offline." Entrapta confirmed this, uncertain where the topic was going. "Now, tell me. Is it true that Catra told you if you did not get them back online, she would…what was it?" He glanced at Catra for a moment. "Ah, yes. She would 'throw you into the rift to dig them out yourself'?"

Catra's eyes widened and Entrapta shifted uncomfortably. She didn't want to get the girl in more trouble, but she wasn't one to lie, either. "Well, uh, yes she did! But, I'm sure it was just some friendly workplace hazing!" Hordak did rise at this, towering over Catra.

"Force Captain." His voice was a threatening growl. "If you ever threaten Princess Entrapta again, you will find yourself stripped of rank and imprisoned before you have time to even blink." Catra stammered something about it being a joke, but Hordak ignored her. "No matter what inane filth you hear wafting about these halls, Princess Entrapta is my- Princess Entrapta and Dryl are our greatest allies. You *will* treat her with the same respect that you show to me." Entrapta wasn't sure she had ever been more turned on in her entire life. "And it would benefit you to ensure that you spread the word."

Catra swallowed. "Y-yes sir…"

"You are dismissed." He looked past Catra, down the stairs. "Force Captain Scorpia, you are dismissed as well. Commander Grizzlor, call Commander Cobalt. We must discuss what to do about Shadow Weaver."

As the younger girls left, Hordak returned to his throne, where Entrapta had to restrain herself from climbing in his lap again with much more ulterior motives. He turned to her fully and she swung her legs over the armrest to lean closer to him, her hair curling up in self-restraint from coiling itself around him. No one had *ever* stood up for her in such a way. "Entrapta," Hordak began, his red orbs seeming to burn into her, "you are to tell me if anyone disrespects you in such a way again. I will take care of it." She nodded breathlessly, wanting to tell him how much it meant to her, and wanting to *show* him her gratitude in any way he'd let her, but Cobalt and Grizzlor ascended the stairs, ruining the moment.

Hordak rose, seeming much more stable. "Commanders, let us gather in the East meeting room. I have some thoughts on how to proceed." She wasn't good at expressions, but she swore his face softened when he looked at her. "Entrapta, I will meet you in the sanctum first thing tomorrow to review your plans for integrating the new tech. I, ah…" he inclined his head ever so slightly. "Have a pleasant evening," he mumbled before quickly walking away.

Cobalt hesitated beside Entrapta once she hopped off the throne. He held up a glass of water. Entrapta cocked an eyebrow, but took it. "Hm? What's this for?"

Cobalt smiled at her in a weird way. "My Lady suddenly looked quite thirsty."

Entrapta frowned in confusion. My *what?* And what did he mean she looked thirsty? Grizzlor erupted into laughter and Cobalt joined in as the two commanders followed Hordak out of the room. Were they making fun of her?? It was always so hard to tell. Whatever, she had more important things to think about this evening, like the way Hordak's skin felt and his protective tone when he'd defended her. She was in for a long, sleepless night and she couldn't be more thrilled.

Oh No, She's Cute

Chapter Summary

> Shadow Weaver gets a portion of what's coming to her, Entrapta gets explosive results, Hordak gets a new perspective.

Chapter Notes

> Nothing dirty here to see today, folks! Just some good ole fashioned Hordak-bullying. Proceed with zero caution.
>
> I'm sorry it's so long, but I don't have an excuse as to why. It is what it is, just eat your food.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In the end, as much as it made him groan and growl and want to break everything in sight, Hordak could not get rid of Shadow Weaver so soon. He first planned on sending her to Beast Island immediately, but Cobalt pointed out to him that there was no backup in place. All of the day-to-day operations that kept things running were managed by Shadow Weaver, and she had never trained any assistants - most likely to render herself irreplaceable. *For now* at least.

Hordak had half a mind to replace her anyway, specifically with Catra, as he knew nothing would enrage the wretched witch more. But Catra was only recently promoted to Force Captain, and no reasonable person would take the young girl seriously as a leader. Besides, such a petty move would have the Horde questioning Hordak’s sanity as well. The entire kingdom would surely fall apart were he to implement such a ludicrous plan.

So Hordak had done the only thing he could do: he’d yelled at her, good and loud, in front of an assembly. She’d remained impassive, until Hordak informed her with a smirk that she would no longer be granted constant access to the Black Garnet. She would be

under 24-hour surveillance until she had shown a team of others how to complete her duties, and then Hordak would decide her fate. Should she fail to comply, or otherwise mislead them, she would be imprisoned with *no* access to the runestone at all.

Her composure cracked, to say the least, as she launched into a string of obscenities directed at Hordak that he suspected had been long withheld just on the tip of her tongue. He basked in the sight of her becoming unhinged for a moment, unable to withhold a low chortle as she was finally dragged away by a pair of soldiers. While he didn't get what he *truly* wanted, this little event was a fine consolation prize indeed!

It was rare for him to be in a good mood, but it continued as he exited the throne room and entered the sanctum, where Entrapta was just arriving. "Hordak!" she cheered, flitting about him on her long hair with sparkling eyes. "Today's the day!" She clapped her hands together. "Aren't you excited?"

As usual, something inside him fluttered insistently at seeing her exuberance. He ought to investigate that strange sensation at some point to see if he was finally dying. She grinned up at him and against his will, the corner of his own mouth quirked up the slightest bit as he followed her to the portal machine. Thankfully she didn't see that slip of composure. Assuming a stoic position with his hands folded behind his back, he told a small lie. "I have never once been excited."

They'd finished integrating all of the new tech into the portal machine and completed the necessary power source upgrades, meaning the device was finally ready to be tested. The process had taken them several months, as there had been some unexpected delays. For one thing, the machine required so much power, Entrapta spent two weeks designing and building a new power grid for the Fright Zone alongside the Horde's electricians. In addition to this setback, she had gone back to Dryl a few times on "princess business" as well, slowing them down even more, much to Hordak's very vocal annoyance. They did what they could

via video calls, but there was only so much they could accomplish apart.

Now, she flounced back and forth past him preparing the machine for the trial run. In one of these fly-by's, as she zipped past with some tools, a strand of her lilac hair reached up and tousled Hordak's own blue locks, causing him to harrumph indignantly. He left it as it was however, and did not blush. A warlord was incapable of blushing, actually. It was physically impossible.

He allowed himself to gaze at her lively body as she knelt before the frame, pretending he was looking over her work. While she'd not really flirted with him since their very early encounters, she had begun incorporating sporadic, casual touches after she'd cleaned him up on his throne all those weeks ago. Furthermore, there were several late nights spent working together when the space between them felt tense, heavy with something he couldn't quite comprehend…

Bah! It probably didn't mean anything. Etherians seemed far too open with their touches; maybe this is just how she was, once comfortable with another. He narrowed his eyes and withheld the low growl that wanted to escape him. The idea of her being so open with others made his blood boil.

His fists clenched as he recalled one particular video chat with Entrapta when she'd been in Dryl. She'd appeared on screen with Force Commander Octavia's *head* in her *lap*! Like it was the most casual thing in the universe! Entrapta said something about tweaking a prosthetic, but in shock, Hordak loudly sputtered some nonsense over her and promptly hung up. When he threw his datapad at a vitrine afterwards, it certainly wasn't out of jealousy. It was just that the scene was inappropriate, and the vitrine was looking at him the wrong way.

When he'd called Commander Octavia later that evening on his cracked datapad, his anger was merely over her unprofessional behavior. That's all. Ridiculous as the title of a *wife* was, Entrapta was still tied to him in such a way, and his underlings ought to act

accordingly. Despite him yelling all of this at her, the commander couldn't seem to keep a weird, half-smile off her face, her eyes frequently darting to something off-screen. Fools, all of them!

Entrapta pulled him back to the present, hopping up from the floor. "Okay, she's all ready! Let's fire this thing up!" She looked at him expectantly, but he gestured for her to turn the device on. This was all because of her, after all. She smiled at him brilliantly with a delighted squeak. Hordak looked away, determinedly undelighted. "Okay! First portal test underway: startinnnng *now!*" She spun about and pressed the button on the activator more aggressively than she needed to, clearly unable to contain her excitement.

A green glow filled the sanctum, their clothes and hair swaying from the energy as the machine powered up. Entrapta clasped her hands in front of her, her mouth ajar in wonderment. While Entrapta was fixated on their creation, admiring its power, Hordak was fixated on Entrapta, admiring her brilliance that made this moment possible. Confident she wasn't going to notice, he didn't try to fight the smile forming on his face as he drank in her awestruck expression. She was so happy. Because of *this*. *Their* project.

His brow tensed as her face melted into a frown, and he followed her line of sight. The space where the portal should be opening was warping ominously, debris and scraps of metal lazily moving into its gravitational pull ."Something's wrong," Entrapta stated. "I'm turning it off." Hordak saw the warning signs, but he was too late; Entrapta was already dashing ahead.

"No, you fool!" He yelled at her over the growing force of the machine. "It's going to blow!" He lunged for her, grabbing her wrist to pull her back. She turned to look at him with wide, questioning eyes, still not realizing the danger she was in. He pulled her against him right as the machine exploded, shielding her with his body as they hit the ground.

The talons of his left hand dug into the steel floor to keep his weight from crushing her. “Stay down,” he growled as shards of metal rained down above them. He felt the cabling of his extensive armor tightening in a way it shouldn’t, but his adrenaline wasn’t allowing him to feel the pain he knew would come just yet. He tugged Entrapta closer to him with his free arm, waiting for the remnants from the portal machine to stop pelting the floor.

After a moment of calm, Entrapta stirred. “I-is it safe?” she asked from beneath him, turning her face, which had been buried in her arms, just enough to look at him.

Sinner as he was, now that they were out of harm’s way, Hordak was reveling in the feeling of having Entrapta so near, wrapped in his arm. “Er, not yet.” Just a moment more… He pressed her head against his chest as though he were shielding her, although he knew it was so that she couldn’t look at him. From this close proximity, he could smell the fresh lavender of her hair, relish in her soft body melded against his torso, feel the stabbing pain in his side as the tubing connected to his ports snapped - *shit*.

Hordak snarled and released Entrapta immediately, turning away from her as she rose to her feet. She appeared fine, which was unsurprising, as he’d clearly taken the full onslaught of shrapnel to his already shoddy armor. “I don’t understand…” she mused, already inspecting the remains of the portal machine, going over their last steps out loud. Hordak found it hard to focus on her words, as he was busy trying not to scream out in agony. He needed to get her out of here.

“I did get some new readings for potential tech, maybe if we send Catra-”

“We’re done wasting resources on fruitless excursions,” Hordak snapped, more aggressively than he’d meant to be. He shielded his side with his large cape, still not looking at her fully. “The machine is a failure. We’re done here, get out.”

Entrapta frowned. “But that was only the first test. If we-”

He turned to face her, forcing himself to rise to his full height with his remaining strength. “I said, get *out!*” The acidity he managed to conjure up would’ve made him proud, had it not been directed at her. However, it was effective. She flinched slightly and her face fell, and Hordak hated himself more than ever. Still, she hesitated, until Imp and Emily approached and gently prodded her out the door.

Staggering to his workstation and with a frustrated roar, he terminated the surface’s contents with a single swipe of his arm. Curse his defective, wretched body! Not only was he literally falling apart, but now he would have to apologize to Entrapta *again* . He wasn't sure which was worse. With a shaky sigh, he pressed the button to begin the painful process of disassembling his armor. The robotic limbs got to work while he cast a withering stare at the smoldering remains of their creation. Hordak was disappointed and angry that the portal machine had not worked, and yet…He was relieved that he would be granted more time spent with Entrapta. Surely, it was not wrong to wish for more time with her if in the end, they were creating something that brought glory to Horde Prime.

By the time the last piece of his armor was removed, Hordak was barely able to prop himself up on the desk and was breathing raggedly. He looked in disgust at his emaciated forearms and the thin, mismatched skin that danced along them. *Abomination.* Bracing himself to drag his sorry bag of bones into his quarters, he paused upon hearing a commotion somewhere among the vitrines. He turned sharply with a gasp and spotted - *no.*

Entrapta gave a tiny wave. “Hi,” she whispered.

No! She might have seen him dilapidated upon the throne, but that was *nothing* compared to having her witness him fully exposed. “Get *out* !” he roared. “Get out, right-” and then Hordak died.

He was uncertain how he got there, but suddenly he was standing next to his throne. Occupying the seat was Entrapta, sitting cross-legged and typing on a datapad. “Why are you on the throne?” he asked her, although he wasn’t angry. She looked like she belonged there.

She glanced up at him. “You put me here,” she replied with a shrug, before going back to her work.

The air grew colder when he opened his mouth to speak again. He sensed something behind him, and when he turned, he was facing the cool and composed face of God. “Little brother, why did you replace me?” Talons that made his own look like a kitten’s claws reached forward to tear him open, but just as Hordak was preparing to die a second time, he awoke with a gasp.

Before he could contemplate this strange dream, Hordak became aware of another intruder: a blanket wrapped around his body. He snarled at it for daring to touch him when he hadn’t wished to be touched and threw it on the ground, glaring at it menacingly. As his hatred for the soft fabric dissipated, he noticed he was seated on his “secret chair” - An old vitrine base with various scrap parts welded to it, finished off with insulation stuffed beneath some tarps for added cushion. He’d longed for a soft chair for these weak moments in the sanctum (plus, Imp liked for them to sit in it together while the boy received head scratches), but hadn’t wanted anyone to *know* he wanted a soft chair. The Secret Chair clearly served no technological function, but to the naked and foolish eye, it blended in enough with the rest of the room.

“Ta-da!” Entrapta had unsurprisingly seen it for what it was. He sneered at her as she approached him with a tray of petite cups, placing it upon his lap. “I made you soup! Soup always makes me feel better.” And then the tiny princess tried to spoon feed the Lord of the Horde. He hissed at her, and at her dozen tiny blasphemous spoons, and quickly set the tray on the ground for Imp to continue scowling at on Hordak’s behalf.

“I am not discussing this,” he stated cooly when she gathered herself into her hair and leaned toward him, smiling expectantly. He rose from the chair to show her that he was still powerful and didn’t need her soups, only to stumble toward the ground the moment he tried to take a step. Soft hair wrapped around him, saving his knees from the solid floor. If only it could save his dignity as well.

“Your armor.” She spoke in an oddly soft voice, holding him there as though he weighed nothing. “It’s holding you together.” She *pitied* him.

Shame and humiliation churned in his stomach. “It is none of your concern.” Breaking away from her, he managed to stand on his own, but the frustratingly determined creature wouldn’t let him go that easily.

“This is just like that time in the throne room, isn’t it?” Entrapta grabbed his biceps to make him listen, looking up at him fiercely. ”You’re from another planet. That thing in the vitrine looks like you-” The shriveled bat fetus? Great. “-and you’ve got tech compensating for your body." Ever unable to remain in one place, she pushed him backwards as she continued wearing him down. “As a scientist, I’m not going to stop until I figure this out.” His back hit the vitrine, and although he was looking down at her, she made him feel small. “Now, *tell me everything!”*

And then Hordak said something that he’d never expected to escape his lips: “You wanna know what I am?” *An informal contraction.* He truly must be losing it. That slip up aside, Hordak was apparently powerless to deny Entrapta what she asked for, and so as requested, he told her everything. How he was a clone, cast out of God’s sight because of his defective body. About why he needed to open the portal, and how he and his big brother would crush the rebellions for good once he was reunited and welcomed back into the light. “And Horde Prime will see that he was *wrong.* ” A sin to even think it, but he spoke it all the same. “I am not a defect. I am *worth something.*” He told himself this lie often, though he never believed it.

He turned and leaned against his forearm on the vitrine. "But my portal machine does not work. I haven't conquered the planet." He pounded the glass in anger. "I cannot even clone a new body for myself! Perhaps… Perhaps Prime was right. I am a failure." When Entrapta didn't reply, he turned to see she was completely engrossed at her workbench, throwing things about. He had just laid his soul bare, for the first time *ever* to anyone, and she was *preoccupied??*

"Nonono! I'm listening, I heard you!" She insisted. "I have an idea, but I need the rest of my tools. Be right back!" She darted up into the vents, leaving him alone as he deserved.

He was convinced that she was returning to Dryl to laugh with Commander Octavia over Lord Hordak's hideous body, but it was only minutes later when she tumbled back into the sanctum through the same vent. "So!" she began, not wasting a moment to drag him back to the Secret Chair with a tendril of hair, while the other pigtail began tinkering with tools. "I have a secret too!" Hordak stared at her in surprise like a fool, and noted that he was apparently growing quite gifted in the act of idiocy when in her presence. "I have been *dying* to upgrade your armor since I noticed it wigging out in Dryl. I've actually already made a prototype I've been tinkering with in my spare time!"

How she had *spare time* when she generally spent every waking moment in his sanctum, he was uncertain. He grew more suspicious with each passing day that she didn't sleep at all, like some sort of little cryptid; and he couldn't even *begin* to process the fact that she had spent this alleged "spare time" building something with him in mind. "I do not need your help in this!" he barked in response, folding his arms over his chest with what was definitely not a pout. Of *course* it hadn't escaped her that his armor failed constantly.

"Everyone needs help sometimes!" she replied, continuing the work he did not want her to do. "And you shouldn't be upset that you're not perfect. I mean, take Emily for example!" she continued, gesturing to the bot who had settled next to Hordak.

“Her programming is glitchy, the left leg sticks, and she’s loud.” Hordak and Imp shared a look before shifting their gazes to Emily, who began a series of whirs and spins to help her creator illustrate her points. “Emily’s got quirks, but that’s why I *like* her.” She turned to look at Hordak as she spoke, and for some reason, he sensed she was not referring only to the bot with this last sentence.

“Imperfection is what makes scientific experimentation possible!” Entrapta continued, and Hordak’s eyes widened as her speech grew more impassioned. Her eyes were alight as her hair and hands moved; she truly believed what she was saying. “Imperfection is *beautiful.*” She turned to her welding, but glanced back at him over her shoulder. “At least to me,” she added thoughtfully in a soft voice. Flashes of light bounced behind her as they locked eyes, her face glowing among the backdrop of sparks. It was… *ethereal*. Hordak’s mouth dropped open in bewilderment as his stomach did that fluttery thing again that he hated. Oh *fuck*, he was in trouble.

Without warning, he was yanked out of his trance both physically and mentally by a pigtail and brought to stand in the middle of the floor. “Stand here.” She instructed him like he had a choice in the matter. Too stunned to protest, he let her move his arms into the position she wanted them. “This brother of yours sounds like a piece of work! If someone was waiting around for me to die, I wouldn't die, just to spite them.” If Hordak had possessed a fully developed sense of humor, he would have laughed out loud, but all that came out was a strangled snort. “And you’re really too obsessed with this whole failure thing. I mean, *I’m* a failure.” Outraged, Hordak opened his mouth to refute this, but she shushed him with a soft strand of hair.

Her mask lowered over face, although it seemed unnecessary for her current task. “I don’t fit in,” she continued. “I’ve tried to be friends with the other princesses, but they ignored me. And then I became friends with Scorpia, but she’s only really interested in Catra.” Hordak grit his teeth. *How dare they??* The mask lifted. “But! That doesn’t mean I give up.”

She pressed the button on his assembly device and the arms descended with the pieces she'd been strategically placing. "I found a few pieces of leftover First One's Tech, and I can't think of a better use for it than this!"

Hordak groaned preemptively as the pieces of armor were put into place, but was quickly surprised at how little it hurt. Instead of hard metal touching his bare skin as it had for years, these components were lined with something soft and breathable. The robotic limbs retreated after only a minute or so, and he had to wonder if they were complete so soon. And then he noticed it. He felt so… *comfortable.* Had he ever been comfortable? He couldn't recall. Gone were the aches of his ruptured cables and tilted ports, and the dull throbbing in his muscles from the oversized plates and heavy-cowled cape were already ebbing away. For the first time that he could remember, Hordak felt *good*.

"Ta-da!" Entrapta chirped again as Hordak basked in the glory of what felt like a new body. All in the matter of a few minutes. All because of *her*. "Your armor is more of an exoskeleton now, the tech compensating for your organic body." She sat on her hair and leaned closer to him as she had before, something almost resembling admiration playing on her features. "What does it feel like?" she whispered.

Hordak flexed his fingers and grinned. "*Powerful*," he replied with a small chuckle. She was staring at him, eyes heavy-lidded, pupils blown, completely focused on him. Was she trying to kill him with those looks?? Because it might just work. That thick, familiar tension he didn't have a name for hung between them once again, although he had no idea if she felt it as well. "I…" he swallowed, feeling his face heat up. He was relieved it was impossible for him to blush, otherwise, he might be doing so currently. "I…Acknowledge the work you put into this. It is very... Technologically sound." Imp, unsatisfied with this sad attempt at a compliment, gave Hordak a needed kick to the shin and screeched. "Uh, no matter what you say, you are not a failure!" He managed to look at her directly, gesturing broadly with an arm,

reveling in how effortless the movement felt. “Any who discount you are *utter fools!*”

Strands of her hair lifted above him, coming to rest on his shoulder. “Thanks, I…” Her eyes flickered away from him, for just a moment, but her smile didn’t falter. “I like being friends with you, too.” Her hair traveled down his shoulder, and her gaze followed it, both landing on the vibrant purple crystal now embedded in the collar of the pristine armor. She hummed as she brushed the strands over the engravings.

Hordak wanted to return the seemingly affectionate gesture, but had no idea how to do so, and no idea if it would be wanted. “Ah, I can repay you for this. Whatever you deem as fair compensation.”

The smile *did* falter then, and she quickly removed both her hair and eyes from him. She climbed out of her nest of hair and began collecting her tools. “Don’t even worry about it! Consider it a late wedding gift.”

“A *what?*”

She seemed suddenly nervous, the quick change in behavior throwing Hordak off guard. After a moment, she tipped her mask over her face again. “Oh, it’s just an Etherian tradition. To exchange an article of clothing, or some other physical token with your betrothed during nuptials.” Hordak's head tilted. *Why would she…?* With all her tools tucked away into the confines of her hair, Entrapta hovered above the ground, a tendril ready to haul her into the vents above. The mask lifted. “I know it’s silly, and that we’re just…this isn’t… Like *that* kind of marriage…” Her eyes avoided him and her gloved hands fiddled together. “But I still wanted you to have it! So I’m gonna go now, byeeee!”

Uncertain what to make of her behavior, but not wanting her to leave, Hordak took a hesitant step forward. *Be subtle,* Hordak told himself *.* “Will you return later?” *Idiot*, Hordak told himself *.* “We need to work on repairs to the portal machine.”

She’d already pulled herself into the vents, but her voice echoed down to him. “You couldn’t keep me away!”

With a sigh, Hordak went to his quarters, the one place with a mirror, so he could examine himself in the new armor. For once, he didn’t completely hate what he saw. His hand traced the carefully placed crystal at his throat, recalling Entrapta’s words about imperfections. Perhaps there was some modicum of truth there, if such a woman saw something in him.

His brow furrowed as he mulled over her comment about *tokens of betrothal* and his ears twitched stupidly, causing him to stomp away from his reflection with a growl. Ridiculous Etherians with their ridiculous, overly-sentimental ceremonial practices! Now not only did he have to learn how to say thank you and to apologize, now he had to learn how to give a gift as well! What could he even offer her that would begin to match the life-altering armor?? He may have survived crash landing a ship, being yanked through a portal and years of warfare, but this princess just might be what finally did him in.

Chapter End Notes

> I don't remember what the portal machine looks like and I couldn't find the clip I was looking for. Just point and laugh at Hordak and pretend it all makes sense.

Every Bride Wants A Huge Rock

Chapter Summary

Entrapta has some girl time, Hordak makes some strategic moves.

Chapter Notes

No NSFW in this one either! Carry on.

Entrapta hadn't actually *needed* to leave the sanctum. In fact, keeping her tools there probably would've been more convenient than storing them in the large "second lab" she'd commandeered. But she wanted to be on her own for a bit, to decompress. Hordak opening up to her about his insecurities, his past, and his illness had been amazing progress towards the close relationship she wanted to have with him. But when she'd presented him with the armor and the First One's crystal… Entrapta heaved a sigh and flopped down on the couch in Lab Two. His response hadn't been exactly what she was hoping for.

She'd carved her feelings for him into the crystal on a whim one day while giddily daydreaming about a real relationship with him, but she'd never intended to actually give it to him. Aloof as he was, this was still the closest she'd ever felt to another person, and she couldn't bear the idea of ruining it were she to press for more. She'd expected the crystal to fuel a weapon or a machine like the rest of the tech, her affection for him riding off into battle where it would serve a greater purpose. All of this changed when she'd watched in horror as his body fell to the floor.

Incorporating First One's Tech in the armor had not been part of her original plans, but when she realized his old set was essentially keeping him going, she quickly tweaked it to serve as a mobility aid as well. It would need further adjustments as he adapted to it, but it was a good start. As for the diamond-shaped slot in the collar, she truthfully could have cut the metal to fit any

of her remaining crystals, but in a moment of apparent insanity, she'd selected the one that held her secret.

When he'd thanked her in his own awkward way, for just a fleeting moment, the idea of confessing *did* cross her mind. They'd grown closer since the encounter on the throne, more comfortable together, and she could've sworn she saw him staring at her occasionally. Plus, the sexual tension was *insane* - of course, she suspected that part was only on her side. But then he'd offered to *pay her* for the armor she'd spent countless hours on. It was the catalyst needed to finally convince her how he saw their relationship - professional and transactional. She had no one to blame but herself for becoming so very attached.

Still, in spite of her rational mind's best efforts, it didn't make the unrequited feelings suck any less. She hoped he considered her a friend, at the very least. He had become so gentle with her and 45% less grumpy than when they'd first met. Plus, he'd risked his life to save her earlier, that had to mean *something* didn't it? Entrapta rolled over and groaned in defeat into one of the decorative cushions, her fair flopping uselessly beside her. Why did other people have to be so confusing??

"Uh sorry," a voice from the door pulled Entrapta out of her mini wallow-fest. "Am I interrupting something?"

Entrapta immediately launched up from the couch, her hair yanking the large woman inside. "Not at all! Come on in!" She could use a distraction. "What's up, Scorpia?"

At the insistence of Entrapta's pigtails, Scorpia settled beside her on the couch. "I'm glad I finally found you! I've been wanting to talk to you about *this!*" Scorpia held up a large scroll in her pincers and immediately dropped it after fumbling to get it open. "Oops…"

Leaning forward as it unfurled, Entapta tilted her head to read the elaborately written words. "You're invited to Princess Prom…" she murmured. Ugh, this again??

“Are you gonna go?” Scorpia asked. “I haven’t decided yet, myself. I always get invited to these things, just as a courtesy, y’know, but…” she sighed. “The other princesses don’t really want me there. I’m not…” she opened and closed her pincers, looking at them with a frown. “I’m not like them. They treat me differently. And *sure*, part of that may be because we’re technically enemies trying to kill each other, but still.”

Entrapta’s heart wrenched at the younger woman’s words. For once, Entrapta knew *exactly* how another felt, as Entrapta was also only included because it was expected. She could keep up the occasional fling and talk shop with folks from the makers guild, but no one until Hordak ever seemed to truly understand her. No one seemed to even want to try. They would appear intrigued at first, by the allegedly mysterious princess of Dryl, only to inevitably get *that look* when she started talking, or excuse themselves when she couldn’t “read the vibe”, whatever that meant.

“Anyway, I don't mean to be a downer,” Scorpia continued. “I just thought maybe if you were going, we could go together. I’m, uh, thinking of asking Catra to go as my plus one.” Scorpia turned pink with a small smile and rubbed the back of her neck.

“Ohhh, I don’t know, Scorpia.” Entrapta stared at the mile-long invitation, arching an eyebrow skeptically. “I only have about one big event in me per year, and I kinda need to save it in case I get around to my coronation.” Even as she spoke, she knew she should go. There were dozens of royal events per year that Entrapta never attended, but Princess Prom was *the big one*, and it came only once every ten years. Making an appearance was important for her kingdom, and it would get her advisory board to stop nagging her about her reclusive nature for a while. Besides, it would be good for her to try to spend less time with Hordak so she could get her ever-growing feelings under control. Or at least *try* to, anyway.

“Coronation?” Scorpia tapped her chin. “What for?”

Entrapta huffed. “Dryl’s advisors won’t stop bugging me about becoming a queen. And I can’t be a queen unless I’m crowned, and I can’t be crowned until I’m married, and even *then* I can *only* be crowned if I have a coronation and my spouse shows up to the event.” Entrapta’s hair counted off the various rules as she explained. “It’s boring, primitive, and I have way more important stuff to do!” Entrapta couldn’t care less about being a queen, and the thought of having a huge event where she was the center of attention made her stomach churn. She supposed she’d get to it eventually though, to change some of these wildly outdated rules if nothing else.

Emily had scurried over to them and Scorpia was absent-mindedly scratching the top of her shell. “Wow, being a princess with a kingdom sounds *terrible*. I’m sure glad I’ve never had to deal with any of that stuff. So, when’s the big day?”

Entrapta shrugged. “No idea! I haven’t mentioned it to Hordak yet, he doesn’t seem like a big event guy.” Dryl’s advisors had included his willful participation as part of their marriage contract, so he really couldn’t say no to it, but the thought of forcing him into an elaborate ceremony didn’t sit right with her.

“You’ve got a point there.” Scorpia didn’t look like she really understood, but she nodded anyway. “When I got this invitation, I thought for sure you’d be going with Lord Hordak, since you’re married and all. But now that I’m thinking about it…” Suddenly, Scorpia burst into laughter and Entrapta blinked at her in confusion. “I’m sorry, I’m just picturing big bad Lord Hordak, skulking around in dark corners at this fancy event, growling at everyone to-” Scorpia lowered her voice, “*get out!”* She was laughing so hard she wiped tears from her eyes. “I can’t believe I thought for a second you two would go together! I mean, can you *imagine* taking that guy with you to Princess Prom?”

Scorpia kept laughing, but it simply brought back the stinging hurt of Hordak’s clearly unromantic interest in her. “Not anymore...” Entrapta murmured in a small voice, unable to stop her face from falling.

Scorpia apparently took notice, and immediately stopped laughing. "Ooh shoot, Entrapta, I'm sorry. I didn't mean…Do you wanna hug??" Without waiting for an answer, Scorpia crushed Entrapta against her torso in a nearly bone-shattering hug. Entrapta typically preferred to be the instigator when it came to physical touch, but feeling vulnerable, she let herself be slowly suffocated in Scorpia's warm embrace, wrapping her hair around the other girl.

The spontaneous hug did add fire to one of her theories, however… She'd never discussed her and Hordak's relationship, or lack thereof, with Scorpia, and was beginning to grow suspicious that half the Fright Zone somehow knew her feelings anyway. She would often hear troops talking in low voices or giggling as she passed by, and Cobalt had asked her more than once if she was going to help him "win big" in the sanctum that day. She had no clue what that meant, but wondered if it was related to all of the whisperings in the hallways.

Scorpia pulled away a bit to look down at her. "I don't want to pry, but I've been *dying* to know. Do you really *like* Lord Hordak, y'know, romantically? Because if so, uh, weird choice, but this is a safe space."

With a sigh, Entrapta pried herself fully out of Scorpia's arms. "Yes. I do. Does *everyone* know??" She had talked about it with Octavia, in more detail than she was certain the woman ever wanted to know, but surely Octavia wouldn't be talking behind her back, would she? They were friends, and friends didn't do that. The only others she had admitted it to out loud were Emily and her recorder.

Scorpia shook her head. "No, not at all! I've just heard a lot of rumors lately. Uh, and some *risqué* notebooks have started circulating that Lonnie thinks are about you two, but don't worry! I didn't read them. There's also a betting pool going on after dark about whether you're a thing. We don't have a lot of entertainment here, people take what they can get."

Entrapta's bad mood lifted just enough to allow her to let out a cackle. The Fright Zoner's were writing *erotic fiction* about her and Hordak? She'd have to get a hold of those later. Besides, as long as they were just rumors, Hordak would surely ignore them.

"And I didn't mean to pressure you, you totally don't have to come with me to the Princess Prom thing!" Scorpia waved her claws about.

Entrapta thought about how she'd longed to have someone to talk to at royal affairs years prior, and how much more it would hurt to show up alone again, when she was technically married. She'd brought a robot as her plus one to an event when she was a teenager, but the staff considered it a weapon, and she'd had to check it at the door. She didn't want Scorpia to have to go through the pain of being all alone either, should the angry feline girl turn her down… Plus, the prom was still a week away, giving her plenty of time to mentally prepare. Entrapta gave a determined nod. "Let's do it!"

Scorpia grinned broadly. "So you'll go?? We can take my ship! And get ready together! This will be so much fun! I gotta go ask Catra!"

Before Scorpia could hurry out the door, Entrapta called out to her. "Uh, Scorpia…" Entrapta was typically an open book, but the last thing she needed was for Hordak to find out her feelings for him from someone else. "Don't tell anyone about Hordak, okay?" She wanted to pry for more details about the ship too, but she kept it inside - that could wait until later when she could be hands on.

Scorpia smiled at her. "Friend's don't give each other's secrets away. I won't tell anyone."

Entrapta breathed a sigh of relief, waving at the departing Scorpia with a tendril of hair.

Although her spirits had lifted a bit, she still wasn't feeling like facing another strictly professional evening with Hordak just yet,

and continued working in Lab Two for a long time. She didn't look up when she heard the vents rattling; Imp was the only one other than her who traversed them, and he was a frequent visitor. As expected, the boy flew down into her lab, chittering loudly. Unexpectedly, he bellyflopped and slid across her desk, knocking all of her things to the floor. Entrapta raised a brow, unimpressed. "Feral hours already? It must be later than I thought."

"[Tell Entrapta to come to the sanctum]," Imp replied in Hordak's passive voice. Oh, he must be getting snippy that she hadn't returned yet. She *did* promise to help piece the portal machine back together, she supposed. It was a bit odd that Hordak sent Imp instead of messaging her directly, but then again, she knew she wasn't the best at checking her inbox. The boy apparently wasn't planning on joining her, and she smiled fondly as she watched him curl up on top of the charging Emily. She was really going to miss him when this was all over. Tears sprang to her eyes at the sudden intrusive thought, and she shook her head rapidly to dispel it before disappearing into the vents above.

She'd pulled herself together by the time she dropped down on the armrest of Hordak's throne. It had become the routine that when her presence was requested, it usually involved talking before they got to work, and she enjoyed every moment of it. On an ordinary throne room visit, she'd be trying to miss her trajectory by *juuuust* enough so that she ended up in his lap with it looking like an accident, but she didn't have the heart for it tonight.

He jumped a little when she appeared, which was unusual. His ears were tilted downward, his eyes wide, and he'd left his hair tousled from where she'd manhandled him that afternoon. The peculiar expression aside, he already appeared rejuvenated from the improved armor, and she could appreciate his form so much more without the bulky cabling and the cape in her way. But admiring your lab partner's cute butt was apparently inappropriate, so she straightened up, and put on a well-practiced smile. "Hello! Sorry I'm so late, I got distracted. Whatcha wanna talk about?"

Were this any other evening, Hordak would have propped his chin in his hand, his elbow resting on the armrest just to the outside of her right thigh as he leaned in attentively. However, Hordak was the one who missed his trajectory, and instead of next to her thigh, his elbow landed directly on top of it. His ears flicked before they assumed their normal position, and Entrapta was surprised he didn't jerk his elbow away faster than if he'd accidentally touched a battle bot shell fresh out of the foundry.

To her even greater surprise, he leaned in to her as he always did, possibly- no, *definitely* even closer- and began speaking as if nothing were out of the ordinary. Entrapta was *stunned.* Was he going to just *leave* his elbow there? How could she be expected to focus on what he was saying? This development was far too important! What did this mean? Was the armor malfunctioning? Maybe he didn't realize it was there. As a test, Entrapta shifted her legs, but Hordak's eyes flickered downward for only a second and he kept the misplaced body part where it was, never breaking his smooth flow of words.

"Entrapta?" Ah, shit. He'd stopped talking moments ago.

"Sorry, can you repeat that?" she finally looked up at him, just now realizing she'd been staring at the rogue elbow. Thankfully, Hordak didn't bring this up, nor detach from her.

He did, however, look more than a little uncomfortable at having been asked to repeat whatever he'd just asked, or said, or yelled. Could've been anything. The elbow did move away then, but before she could be disappointed, yet another bizarre move was made. He appeared to brace himself for something, and then he very nearly put his palm on her knee, balling his hand into a fist at the last moment. The fist, however, *did* come to rest on her knee, and she tried to "play it cool", as Octavia had suggested, but she was pretty sure she was staring up at him dreamily, her hair almost certainly frizzing up from excitement.

The tips of his quickly drooping ears turned a bright pink as he stammered out his words. "Uh, I…I said I thought about your

comment earlier. About the exchange of gifts between spouses." Entrapta tilted her head. *No way* … "I'm- You have been…A great asset." The fist melted back into a palm, roving up her leg to rest on her thigh. *Holy shit!!* Even through her thick overalls, she felt the light prick of his claws when he squeezed her the tiniest bit, sending a shiver down her spine. His free hand caressed the crystal at his throat. "And this is…" He huffed. "My point is, I would like to return the gesture."

Entrapta grinned like an absolute fool, but Hordak simply turned more pink in response. "You got me a present??" She was gripping the armrest with her own hands in an effort to remain still, but a tendril of her hair wrapped around his hand on her thigh, encouraging him to keep it there.

"Yes." His voice cracked a bit in an adorable way, and his eyes seemed transfixed on the hair that she'd wrapped around his fingers. He cleared his throat, removing his hand slowly, and as much as she missed it, her brain was working at warp speeds trying to determine what these sudden developments meant. "Come, it is in another room." He rose from the throne and gestured for her to join him.

Unable to force herself to release him, a few strands of her hair remained coiled around his hand as she quickly scrambled after him, following closely behind as he led her out of the sanctum.

Once in the hallway, she remembered Scorpia's words about all the circulating rumors, and she willed her hair to free his hand in case they ran into anyone else; she was still worried he wouldn't want anyone to assume they were more than lab partners. He was looking straight ahead, but to her continued shock, his thumb and forefinger caressed the strands as they slipped away, as though he had enjoyed her touch. Withholding the squeal her overly active vocal chords wanted to make was excruciating. They didn't walk long at all before a gruff "we're here" came from him.

A light gasp escaped her as she walked into the small room when he gestured for her to do so. Her eyes tracked the massive crystal

up and down. “That’s…”

“The Black Garnet,” Hordak finished for her. She felt him move to stand behind her, but her gaze was transfixed on the runestone in the center of the room. She’d never seen a runestone up close before; it was more beautiful than she’d ever imagined.

Wait, he said he got her a present, but there was *no fucking way-* She turned to him, practically vibrating with energy. “You’re gonna let me mess with a runestone?? No one has *ever* let me near their runestone before! Can I *touch* it??”

He chuckled softly, and she was certain she had only heard him laugh in a snarky manner before this moment. “You may do with it whatever you wish. It is yours.”

Holy fucking shit!! “What?? Are you *serious??*” she knew she was practically yelling, but whatever, he had to be used to it by now. He’d barely uttered his confirmation before she fully launched herself at him. Professionalism be damned, he gave her a *runestone*!!

Her arms squeezed his midsection tightly and since she'd made it this far, she might as well go for the gold - she stood on her tiptoes and buried her face against as much of his large chest as she could reach. She’d gotten a good feel of his torso when he’d saved her earlier, but she hadn’t been able to savor it; now she could, taking the opportunity to nuzzle the side of her face against his surprisingly firm body. He grunted at the impact and she felt a shudder run through him.

Silently, his arms remained by his sides as she’d assumed they would, but it was okay; this was more than she ever could’ve hoped for. Besides, she was desperate to examine the runestone anyway. She began to pull away, only to be stopped by his arm, which hesitantly encircled her shoulders. *Holy fucking shit with a cherry on top!!* Still hardly believing this was real, she settled back into the hug with a blissful sigh, letting her hair join in as it slid up his back and rested on his shoulders. “Thank you, Hordak.”

He said nothing, but squeezed her a little tighter, his thumb brushing the bare skin of her right shoulder. Absolutely nothing could ruin this moment.

“My, my,” a smooth voice interrupted from the entryway. “What a pretty picture the two of you make.”

Just Shower Thoughts

Chapter Summary

> Hordak and Shadow Weaver find themselves in exciting new positions.

Chapter Notes

> SMUT POLICE HERE, THERE IS SOME SMUT BELOW!! For my non-smutty reading pals, you can stop at the double line break as the scene changes to keep yourselves worthy of basking in Prime's light. I'll do a family friendly summary in the end notes for those who want to skip ahead!
>
> Big thank you to our smut queen, Mazen, for beta reading, and to LadyKadilion who suggested this theme!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hordak released the princess immediately upon Shadow Weaver's entrance, stepping in front of the miniscule thing in what appeared to be an act of protectiveness. Why he thought she would waste her depleting energy on the purple little trollop was a mystery.

"Where are your guards?" Hordak demanded.

"They're taking a brief rest in the hallway." At the aid of one of her sleeping spells.

Hordak surely expected her to still be upset over the very public demotion, but she wasn't going to let her long-term plans to kill him be overthrown that easily. In fact, she'd been considering assassinating him this very evening and letting the Fright Zone fall with him. Unfortunately, she needed to gain more strength from the Black Garnet to be able to do it, so finding him and his apparent plaything with *her* runestone put a damper on her

murderous intent. “To what do I owe the pleasure of My Lord’s presence in my inner sanctum?”

Then the bastard *smirked* at her. “You no longer have any possessions here, Shadow Weaver. I have given the Black Garnet to Princess Entrapta.” Shadow Weaver’s breath caught in her throat. “I will leave the decision to her on whether she allows you to use its abilities.”

Ignoring the princess’s attempt to speak, Shadow Weaver moved towards them. “You cannot do that! The garnet is *mine!*” Her gaze locked on the princess, and the girl stared back with wide eyes. Had she misjudged her all this time, this loud, clumsy, clueless *princess??* Was this girl truly trying to live out as Hordak’s equal, to take a share of the Horde for herself? What other use could a princess have for a runestone if not to gain power?

She didn’t realize how close she’d gotten to the small woman until Hordak’s hand clamped down on her wrist. Panic began setting in; she could not allow him to separate her from the garnet! “Lord Hordak! Can’t you see what is happening? You are allowing yourself to be seduced by that flippant little miscreant!” she grabbed onto his arm, willing him to listen. “She has been distracting you since the moment she stepped foot on our grounds!”

“*Our* grounds?” Shadow Weaver had more to say, but Hordak interrupted, jerking his arm away from her. “No speck of dirt that the Fright Zone rests upon has *ever* belonged to you, nor will it!” The deep baritone of his migraine-inducing voice echoed in the room as he glowered over her.

Shadow Weaver felt energy pooling in her hands, preparing to strike; she was still powerful, but was it enough to get rid of the two of them right now? Rapidly approaching footsteps made her hesitate. No, not yet - she needed to come up with a better plan, or she’d fall with them. Several guards entered, though Shadow Weaver was uncertain if they heard their rising voices or if Hordak had somehow called for them. A bittersweet interruption.

After they saluted Hordak, the *strangest* thing happened - The guards bowed to Entrapta. Shadow Weaver's eyes widened, realizing the magnitude of this gesture: The Horde *liked the princess*. They *respected her*. Hordak would certainly never trust her again, but *this one*, perhaps…

Sucking up every shriveling speck of self-respect she had left, Shadow Weaver turned to the princess and kneeled before her. "Forgive me for my insolence, My Lady." She stared up at Entrapta's bewildered face. "You see, I'm not myself when I'm unable to draw upon the Black Garnet. If you would be so generous as to grant me a few moments with the runestone, it would do a world of good to these old bones."

She heard Hordak huff beside them, not buying the act for a moment, but the princess was soft. "Yes, uh, of course!"

"Oh thank you, My Lady." Rising, Shadow Weaver ran her fingers through the princess's long hair as she glided past and received the desired response: an angry growl from Hordak warning her to not dare touch his treasured throne ornament.

Shadow Weaver had only barely placed her hands upon the runestone before "That's enough" came from Hordak, and she was flanked by guards once again. Glancing to her left, she released a disappointed sigh as she saw that Catra had wormed her way into the mix. She would never even be in this position if Catra had a shred of capability.

"Take Shadow Weaver to a prison cell," Hordak growled. "She will only exit in handcuffs and under the watch of at least four guards. She will not enter the Black Garnet chamber without explicit permission from Princess Entrapta. Now *get. Out*."

Shadow Weaver gave one last disdainful look at the odd pair on her way out: Hordak was bending over the princess worriedly as though the mere brush of Shadow Weaver's hand would cause the pigtail to shrivel up and fall off, while the girl was already blathering away in her obnoxiously peppy voice.

Had she imagined they would actually grow to care for one another, she never would've told Hordak the marriage was a good idea. The tabloids had squawked for *years* of the princess's bizarre fondness for unconventional romantic partners, so it was no surprise on that front, but Hordak had *never* shown any indication he was capable of feeling such frivolous emotions.

In her first few years with the Horde, Shadow Weaver had propositioned him exactly one time, after one too many bottles of wine. Hordak was terribly ugly, after all, but so was she, so she'd thought it made sense at the time. Of course, she'd still hated him, even back then, but upon learning exactly how alone he truly was, she'd wondered if she could gain a swift rise to power were she to entice him in that manner. Hordak did not accept the offer, to say the least. Decades later, she still had yet to see him with as horrified an expression as he'd been sporting at that moment.

Now it appeared that not even Hordak was immune to the irritatingly natural charms of a princess. Exhausting as she was, beneath the oil grease and the oversized clothes, Princess Entrapta possessed the same physical beauty that all princesses were born into. Shadow Weaver would just have to use this infatuation to her own benefit.

It wasn't long before they placed Shadow Weaver in the prison cell, and she went in willingly to continue formulating her plan. Catra lingered outside once the others had gone. "Scorpia invited me to some dumb princess party next week."

Shadow Weaver eased to the ground and rolled her eyes. "Would you like for me to pin a flower in your hair before you dance the night away?"

Catra's tail flicked and she scowled. "I'm telling you this because if Adora is as obsessed with her new princess friends as I think she is, she'll be there."

Sighing, Shadow Weaver said nothing. She doubted entirely that Catra would ever succeed in this mission or any other. Even if she

had Adora here, without the Black Garnet and her freedom, she wouldn't be able to sway the girl back to their side. She needed to follow her new angle.

"Well?" Catra demanded. "Say something!"

"Do whatever you wish, Catra."

To her relief, Catra turned sharply to leave. "Okay, I will!" Unfortunately, she was apparently not done being abhorrent yet and wheeled back around. "And what was with all that 'My Lady' shit? You'll kiss anyone's ass, huh? Even a princess's."

“Don’t be a complete fool, Catra," Shadow Weaver drawled, although she knew Catra couldn't help it. "Sometimes we must play the game in order to win, no matter how tedious. However, let me assure you of one thing." She rose, approaching the partition and gazing into the girl's eyes. "That princess may hold the title on a legality, but there is only one Lady of the Fright Zone.” She'd be back on top. Even if she had to break Hordak's shiny new toy to make it happen.

They'd left the Black Garnet chamber quickly after the encounter with Shadow Weaver. Hordak's mood was completely soured, the moment ruined in his mind, but Entrapta had bounced right back, chattering away about all the tests she was going to run on the runestone. As they parted in the hallway, Entrapta seemed flustered, and Hordak was willing to admit he hoped she would embrace him again, but she'd said she had some work to do in her lab and quickly darted off.

Left alone with his thoughts, instead of focusing on the plans to repair the portal machine, Hordak quickly succumbed to the one thing that plagued his mind: Entrapta. He sat lazily at a workbench for some time, recalling the way she'd looked at him with sparkling eyes when he'd presented her with the runestone, how her fascinating hair frizzed up with joy. It was - *she* was…

cute. Had he ever used that word before? He buried his burning face into his arms on top of the workbench.

So far had he fallen, he didn’t even try to resist when his thoughts strayed to the way she'd melted against him in the embrace, how perfectly they seemed to fit together despite their extreme size differences. He flexed his right hand, remembering how the supple flesh of her well-rounded thigh felt beneath his fingers… How much softer would her body feel in his hands without the baggy overalls?

He growled at his lack of ability to control his own thoughts; how had he allowed himself to become so corrupt? He needed to do something productive to take his mind off of Entrapta. However, speaking of Entrapta, maybe he ought to go check on her? Perhaps she had been more shaken by the situation than she let on, and that's why she left so quickly. If they were truly friends as she'd led him to believe, he needed to ensure she was alright, and he quickly strode out of the sanctum.

He assumed she'd still be in her secondary lab working, or even sleeping. She'd told him once she typically slept in her lab so that she could get to work faster, although he still wasn't convinced she participated in the activity at all.

Narrowing his eyes as he arrived, he noticed the door was ajar. Odd. What if someone intruded inside, uninvited? She ought to be more careful.

Although the entire Fight Zone was his domain and he could enter wherever he pleased, he still knocked anyway. There was no response, and the door *was* ajar… Hordak intruded inside, uninvited.

The room was alive with the pleasant hum of machines and her large computer with its many screens, but no sign of Entrapta. He ventured further within, reflexively shutting the door behind him. He spotted Imp sleeping deeply on top of Entrapta's pet robot in the corner and tousled the boy's hair fondly as he walked by.

At the far end of the room, there was an opening to the left, and Hordak marched over to it. He was certain it led to a small storage closet; there were many rooms of this architecture in the Fright Zone, all designed the same. Perhaps she was sleeping inside of it for some reason? She did seem to enjoy small spaces.

Hordak entered the alcove and quietly opened the door just enough that he could see inside, so as not to disturb her if she were sleeping. Peering within, he quickly discovered he had gravely misremembered this room's function.

Every ounce of air left his lungs and had his body not frozen completely, he would have collapsed to the floor. There, within what he now knew was a bathroom, stood Entrapta, fully awake and fully naked in a glass-enclosed shower. She was in the midst of washing her hair, every glistening, glorious curve on display.

Hordak needed to leave *now*, this sight was not meant for his impure eyes. He would turn right around and forget what he'd seen, no damage done. He would go back to his sanctum and work on the portal machine. Instead, Hordak opened the door a sliver more for a better view.

She was facing away from him, and her fleshy backside had him completely mesmerized. His mouth watered, and he wanted more than anything to grab it and squeeze every curve, crushing her body against his own. She was magnificent, a flawless wisp of golden softness crowned with endless, shimmering purple - the most stunning sight he had ever looked upon, apostasy or not.

He knew it was beyond wrong to watch her, yet he allowed himself to consume her completely with his unworthy gaze, biting back the groan that had settled in his throat. He was certain she hadn't heard him open the door, otherwise she would've said something, or covered herself.

His eyes roamed upwards, over her back and her strong arms, noting numerous scars splashed across her skin, and even those were beautiful - a map of her chaotic brilliance when hard at

work. He would have to stress the importance of lab safety to her more than ever; many of these looked as though they would have been very painful, and it hurt him to know she'd most likely been all alone when they were formed.

She shifted to the side, eyes closed, and his breath hitched as he caught a glimpse of the part of her he'd always found most tantalizing: her breasts. Oh, the memory of seeing that well-rounded flesh spilling over her undergarments all those months ago in Dryl replayed in his mind nightly. He'd long since given in to enjoying his lustful dreams, even the ones that happened when he was awake. But now the side of her left breast was fully exposed to him, so very close, and he wanted nothing more than to barge in and have his way with her - although he wouldn't begin to know what that entailed.

He was distracted from her chest as Entrapta's petite hands ceased combing through her hair, his eyes chasing them as they moved lower. They stroked slowly and meticulously down her neck, over her clavicle, and with a gasp that Hordak quietly echoed, she cupped her breasts, water running off of the small peak at its center.

As she began to massage them with a fluttery sigh, Hordak's cock informed him just how private this moment was as it pressed insistently against his undergarments. *This had perhaps gone too far.* Entrapta deserved better than to be ogled from the shadows, and he shut his eyes to will his body to listen to him. His conscience weighed heavy with guilt over what he'd done as he silently turned to leave.

"There's no need to rush off." Hordak stopped in his tracks at the sound of Entrapta's voice calling out to him. He couldn't move, couldn't *breathe*. *Had she known he was there this entire time??* He opened and closed his mouth several times, trying to explain himself, but only pitiful sputtering sounds came out.

Although his back was to the shower, he could feel her eyes burning into him. "I apologize," he croaked. "I…" he had no

excuse. "I was just…"

"Would you like to join me?" she asked without a hint of hesitation in her voice.

Hordak could've died on the spot. He wasn't sure how much time passed before he slowly turned back to face her. "I'm - *ah-!*" what he had planned to say died in his throat. She was facing him fully with a mischievous smile, leaving absolutely nothing to his poor imagination. He cleared his throat, but it turned into a hunger-filled rumbling as his eyes darted all over her naked body, memorizing the newly revealed areas. "I do not believe that it is wise." His voice was raspier than ever.

She giggled a little. "It'll be fine, your armor is water-resistant up to 30 meters!"

Something between a cough and a nervous laugh escaped him, much to his continued mortification. "Th-that's not what I- I just- I do not think that I should."

Still smiling, she gave a shrug. "Suit yourself." Her tone was nonchalant. "You can keep watching if you want." She filled her hand with soap from a bottle, her eyes not leaving him.

"I will do no such thing." Despite his words, he failed to remove his body or his eyes. "I do not wish to disrespect you." An embarrassing sound left him as she arched a brow, running her now soap-covered hands over her breasts, squeezing them a little. His eyes tracked her fingers as they skated further down her body, over her soft stomach and to her fleshy thighs. When his gaze shamefully retraced its path upwards, they locked eyes and both knew that he had lost.

At their silent agreement, the tension between them increased tenfold, and Entrapta let out a shaky sigh, continuing to run her hands across her skin. His vision was growing obscured, however, as the steam from the warm water had been steadily fogging up the glass enclosure. He huffed in frustration and wanted to

venture closer, but his current position from several yards away kept his lower half concealed behind the door. If he were to stand fully before her, she would see the proof of his vile lust for her - although being that he was watching her shower, she probably knew already.

“I don't find this disrespectful,” Entrapta answered in an oddly husky tone. “In fact, I feel *quite* respected.” She whimpered as she moved a hand too low for Hordak to see, and he strained his neck in vain to get a better view. “You know…” she continued, her breathing growing heavier, “there’s actually a clause in our agreement about how we have to consummate our union for it to be legitimate.”

Even from this distance, she must have seen the panic on his face, and she let out a breathy giggle. “Don't worry, it’s one of those ancient rules that no one takes seriously anymore.” He stuttered his acknowledgement, and she smiled brightly at him. “You can come closer, you know. I won’t bite. Unless you’d like me to.”

Oh, how he'd like her to. Another low whine escaped him, and he glanced down with a grimace at his straining erection, which appeared to be trying to battle its way out of his tabard. Well… She *had* invited him to watch her. Besides, she'd already seen how emaciated his body was, was this really any worse? Swallowing his continuously evaporating pride and shame, he stepped fully inside the small room, shutting the door behind him.

He stopped about two feet away from the glass enclosure, but to his enragement, the fogged glass now covered most of her body. She stared up at him with hooded eyes, and without a word, she dragged her palm against the glass to wipe the fogginess away, allowing him to see her naked torso once again.

Her brows shot up when she spotted his member lifting up his skirt, but she didn't look disgusted - on the contrary, her eyes lit up and her teeth sank into her bottom lip, as though she were pleased. “Hordak,” she murmured. Her left palm returned to her

breast, both of them gasping as she rolled her nipple between her fingers.

Breathing raggedly, Hordak wanted so badly to touch her that he ached, not caring at this point that it was against Prime's laws. Surely Prime would abolish these rules had they ever been exposed to such beauty; what brother would be able to resist? Her invitation for him to *join her* and the implications the offer entailed still ghosted in his mind. The only thing holding him back was the embarrassing truth that he wouldn't know what to do with her.

Her left hand was still hidden beneath the steam somewhere below her navel, but whatever she was doing with it caused her to moan loudly, her voice reverberating deliciously in the small room. The sound and sight resonated through him; he was unable to restrain himself, and he lunged forward, his claws gripping either side of the glass enclosure, surely leaving marks. “What are you doing?” he asked desperately.

She opened her eyes and met his gaze. “Touching myself.”

Hordak swallowed. She was masturbating. In front of him. Knowingly. “Why?” This is how he would die.

“I touch myself all the time.”

Oh.

She blushed. “I often think about you touching me while I do it.”

Oh no.

“Show me.” The words were out of him before he knew what he was saying. Her face reddened further, but she obliged instantly, her visible hand releasing her breast to wipe the glass down as much as she could. Things were still blurry, but it was enough that he could see the crux of her; a small mound dusted with purple hair, the fingers of her right hand stroking up and down the slit he knew lay somewhere just out of sight.

Hordak sucked in a breath, the air hissing between his gritted teeth and he rolled his hips forcefully against the glass keeping him from her.

"Hah-! Hordak!" Entrapta mewled, her eyes watching his abdomen press against the glass repeatedly while two of her fingers focused their efforts at the upper part of her slit.

Hordak studied her face as he assaulted the innocent door of her shower with erratic thrusts. Her eyes had slipped closed, brows knit together while her hair curled up every which way in pleasure. The lust consuming him was joined closely with the elation he experienced whenever he was with her, the intense emotions overcoming him as he fumbled to name what it was he felt for her.

Her voice pulled him back into the moment; the cry of his name from her lips in the midst of ecstasy was unfathomable to him, yet it echoed from her over and over again while he continued grinding his throbbing shaft against her shower, making it shake.

When she slipped two fingers inside of herself, she groaned and braced against the door. Desperate for any contact with her, Hordak mirrored it, placing his palm over hers, separated only by the thin pane. Her eyes shot open and she stared in surprise at their hands before seeming to redouble her efforts, her fingers pumping rapidly into her depths, fervid sounds spilling from her mouth while her thumb sporadically stroked the top of her entrance.

Utterly captivated, Hordak halted his movents to focus solely on her, and he couldn't help but moan along with her as she brought herself over the edge, her legs shaking before she dropped to her knees, panting heavily. Once again, Hordak's body followed her movements of its own accord and he sank down next to her on the tiled floor, feeling just as overwhelmed at the experience despite his still painfully hard cock. It didn't matter; he could take care of himself later.

Entrapta, however, had other plans. Hordak rose quickly as she suddenly exited the shower, grinning up at him. Wordlessly, she took his shoulders in tendrils of hair and urged him to stand with his back against the glass. "What are y-" he interrupted himself by crying out loudly as Entrapta's tiny hand connected with his shaft, rubbing him enthusiastically over his clothes.

"Entr- *Haah…* I…" Too overcome to be embarrassed at his nonsensical fragments, he succumbed to her ministrations. Even through his clothes, the pleasure was beyond anything his dreams could have ever granted him, although he was certain having the real Entrapta here had everything to do with it.

"Hordak," she murmured, "you're so *cute.*"

"I- I am *not* - ah, *Entrap-ta!*" she sped up, rubbing up and down the length of him mercilessly, swirling her thumb around the head, and wound up as he already was, he came violently, his gravelly voice bouncing against the walls. As his head swam through the bright bursts of euphoria, he slumped to the ground, relieved she'd had the foresight to prop him against the glass.

Before he could fully catch his breath, it was stolen from him again as Entrapta sank into his lap, her naked backside pressing directly against his bare thigh, drawing more pathetic sounds of desire from his lips. "That was fun!" she chirped brightly, laying her face against his chest and staring up at him.

Unable to respond, he gazed down at her, stunned at having her so near and eternally grateful for her boldness. Although the temptation was nearly overwhelming, and although she *had* said she fantasized about him doing so, he didn't dare touch her for fear that she would come to her senses and flee.

The pleasure slowly gave way to newfound clarity as he fell into the endless depths of her magenta eyes, always full of sincerity and a sparkling glint of unmatched brilliance. The feelings he had been grasping to name still eluded him, but one thing became perfectly clear in this moment: *He wanted her.* Every last little bit.

How had it taken him this long to realize this? More importantly, what the hell was he going to do about it?

Far too soon, Entrapta rose from her place in his lap and he longed to pull her back, but resisted the urge. She wrapped a towel around herself and her hair hauled him up from the floor. “I guess you’ll wanna get cleaned up. Although you’re welcome to do that here.” Her eyes darted up and down his frame.

“Ah, y-yes, I…” He looked down at himself - he was a mess, drenched in water from Entrapta’s body paired with his own fluids. However, he didn’t want her to see him completely naked; his boney frame was far more hideous beneath his clothes. “I, uh, should take my leave.”

“Oh…” she followed him with a slight frown as he headed to leave.

When he opened the door, he hesitated, uncertain how to end the encounter while also letting her know he was interested in exploring more of whatever this was. “But, ah, I agree.” He looked everywhere but at her, feeling his face heat up. “This was… *fun.*” He’d nearly forgotten - he’d told himself he would practice his manners in front of her. “Thank you.”

The frown disappeared as she cackled. “Oh, you’re more than welcome. Next time, you can even touch me if you want to.”

He’d already headed out the door to die of embarrassment, but turned back so fast he nearly got whiplash. “There can be a next time?”

Chapter End Notes

> Hordak and Entrapta spent some quality time getting to know one another outside of working hours by participating in a fun, recreational team-building activity. Neither is quite sure what this means for their relationship, but they suspect that they're probably a bit more than professional colleagues now.

Slumber Party

Chapter Summary

> Shadow Weaver gets a new member in the "I Hate Shadow Weaver" club, Hordak consults with Entrapta about some remodeling.

Chapter Notes

> 95% safe for work, I promise.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The screens tethered to the Back Garnet lit up with energy readings for a few moments before fading away to nothing. Entrapta let out a sigh. When the runestone began responding to her experimental prodding, she'd been so surprised and excited. But now after only a brief moment of elated success, the signals she'd read had disappeared. She just didn't understand what she'd done wrong.

It had been nearly a week since the unexpected encounter with Hordak in her bathroom, and she hadn't so much as heard an angry "get out!" from him since. She'd arrived in the sanctum the next day with no one but Imp around, who informed her in Hordak's passive voice that he regretfully needed to attend to some urgent and classified matters and he would return when he was able. He'd also requested she not touch the portal machine, which she found odd, but Entrapta didn't mind; she had the Black Garnet to play with.

Still, even a runestone could only do so much to distract her from his sudden change. Sprawling on top of Emily, she huffed out a defeated groan. She'd been overjoyed at the sudden progression, one that technically *he* had instigated when he'd spied on her. Sure, she'd invited him to escalate things, but he'd seemed so into it! A man couldn't fake that kind of enthusiasm, could he? Or at

the very least, he couldn’t fake an erection three quarters the size of her forearm.

She thought for *sure* this was going to change things between them, but clearly he must be regretting things.

"May I come in, My Lady?" Entrapta’s gaze snapped to the sound, but she didn’t get up. It was the spooky lady that Hordak disliked. The woman floated into the room when Entrapta raised a thumbs up, four soldiers following closely behind her. She stared at Entrapta's modifications to the runestone for a moment before sighing and placing her shackled hands on its surface.

Entrapta was so lost in thought, she didn't notice that the woman had been approaching her until she was looking down at Entrapta's face. Sitting up quickly, she tried to shake off her bad mood. "Can I help you with something else?" Entrapta asked.

"If I may, I was just curious as to why you are here all alone. It appeared you and Hordak had been joined at the hip lately."

Entrapta frowned. “We’re *what?* I assure you, we are completely different entities.”

“I simply meant that the two of you have seemed quite inseparable, so I am surprised to see you are not with him now.” Entrapta thought that her face remained impassive, but clearly not, as the tall woman tsked and moved closer. “Oh, you poor thing. I wish I’d had the foresight to warn you.”

A guard told the woman - Shadow Weaver, that’s right - to keep her distance. “Warn me about what?” Entrapta asked.

“Hordak doesn’t care about anyone.”

What? No, Hordak was her friend. He’d given her a runestone! He-

“I don’t mean to be callous, my dear," Shadow Weaver continued, "but you’re nothing more to Hordak than a way to win the war. I

wouldn’t put it past him to tell you anything you want to hear if he thinks it will get him closer to victory.”

In just a few sentences, every barely-soothed doubt Entrapta had about Hordak’s feelings for her came flooding back. Shadow Weaver hadn't stopped speaking before Entrapta flicked her mask over her face and shuffled the other way on top of Emily. Shadow Weaver was wrong. Right? Hordak wasn’t deceitful, he had no reason to be…Did he? Had he caught onto her feelings after all, and thought she would stop assisting him with the portal machine if he didn’t humor her? But if that were the case, why had he told her *not* to work on it in his absence? Plus, Hordak didn’t trust Shadow Weaver, and that should mean that Entrapta shouldn’t either. But…what if she was right?

“My Lady?” Shadow Weaver’s voice pulled Entrapta back to the present, and she was beginning to see why Hordak hated the sound of it so much. “Are you quite alright?”

“Yep.” Entrapta urged Emily towards the runestone. “Now if you’ll excuse me, I have some work to do. Bye!”

Entrapta slowly lifted the mask once she was sure she was alone and rubbed at her wet eyes. “C’mon, Entrapta, get it together! He’s just a guy. You have a *whole runestone* and endless scientific discoveries in front of you!” Emily beeped encouragingly, and it made Entrapta feel a little better, even if her own self-pep talk didn’t. She whipped out her recorder and moved from Emily into her rolling desk chair. “Black Garnet log, day four! I’m slowly unlocking the mysteries of how to combine magic and tech. I don’t have a lot of information yet, but one thing’s for certain: things are gonna get *weird!*”

Some time later, Entrapta nearly dropped her tools when a message appeared from Hordak inviting her to join him in the sanctum. Her teeth sank into her bottom lip in anxiety; she was excited to see him, yet overflowing with insecurity after Shadow Weaver stoked every fear that she had. She waited for a bit while

she tried to calm her nerves, which mainly consisted of repeating "he's just a guy" over and over again like a mantra.

Pressing her hands against her cheeks, she puffed out a determined breath, scurried into the vents, and headed to the sanctum. Unfortunately, she was still so flustered, she finally missed her landing like she'd always dreamt of, and instead of her place on his armrest, she landed in Hordak's lap.

A sound of surprise came from him, his face flushing, and by how warm she felt, she imagined her own face was doing the same thing. "I'm so sorry!" Before she could scramble to the furthest corner of the armrest in shame, his large hand wrapped around her forearm, keeping her in place.

"Stay." His white face turned rosier and his ears twitched, his body tensing as he waited for her response. Was he serious?? Oh, she wanted nothing more, but what if he was only offering because he thought he had to? While she couldn't always pinpoint his red gaze, she suspected he wasn't looking directly at her. "That is, if you wish to."

Fuck it, she'd waited ages for this! Swallowing down her doubt and Shadow Weaver's words, she chose instead to trust the connection she thought they'd established.

Repositioning herself, she settled comfortably on his large thigh with her legs between his splayed knees. To her continued shock, she felt Hordak relax against her, although he seemed uncertain what to do with his arms. Taking it upon herself to help him out, her hair wrapped his right arm around her waist and placed his left hand on her knee. She was still hurt and anxious over his silence the past several days, but longing to be close to him, she fully snuggled herself against his torso, looking up at him with uncertainty.

In response, Hordak curled his fingers around her where she'd maneuvered his hands, making her sigh. He was staring at the crown of her head as opposed to her face, but she found it easier

to speak when he wasn’t looking her in the eyes. “Where’ve you been?”

"Ah, I had a…personal project to attend to.”

“Oh.” Entrapta was not satisfied with the vague answer. "I thought maybe you were avoiding me."

"No!" He responded nearly before she'd finished speaking, and finally looked directly at her face. He tightened the arm around her waist, causing a swarm of butterflies to flutter in her belly. "I apologize, I did not mean for you to-" he paused as he mulled over his words. "I did not wish to be parted from you."

Entrapta felt her cheeks heat up; he sounded so sincere. "You didn't?"

"Of course not, Entrapta." His thumb stroked her leg as he gazed at her intently. "But I…" his ears twitched and the tips turned pink. It was too adorable for words. "There was some urgent research I needed to conduct." Entrapta was about to ask him what research, but he answered her before she could do so. "It is a very private matter." His eyes shifted from her, and he suddenly turned significantly more pink. "However…There is another project that I, uh, would appreciate your input on."

Entrapta grinned. "Ooohh, what is it? Something with the portal?"

Hordak inhaled sharply, and a strange, almost sad look flashed over his face, but it disappeared so quickly that she figured she'd imagined it. "We will leave the portal machine for a while longer. I am still assessing the damage. The project I have in mind is admittedly more, ah… *personal*." He blushed again.

Oh. "Oh?"

To her disappointment, he nudged her off of his lap, and he rose from the throne to stand beside her. "Come, I will show you." Before he could walk too far ahead, Entrapta grabbed his hand

with her own gloved one, smiling at him hesitantly when he turned to look at her in confusion.

Hordak stared at their connected hands for what felt like a long time, his pink ears drooping. "Lead the way!" Entrapta tried to sound more confident than she felt, but it seemed to work. Hordak's fingers curled slowly over her hand, and with a stiff nod, he led her behind the throne into the darkness.

They walked a few yards before he stopped, and she heard him typing on a keypad. A door opened in front of them, and she followed him inside a dimly lit room. "Is this your room?" Hordak nodded his confirmation as she released his hand and looked around. It was pretty sad, even by her standards. The bed was far too small for his large body to stretch out comfortably, and the tiny bathroom had no shower, only a spray attachment on the sink. There was a machine to assemble his armor, a small cabinet, and not much else at all.

"I have been considering upgrading my living quarters." Entrapta turned her attention to Hordak as he spoke. "I am uncertain how long it will take us to open a portal, and the armor may work more efficiently if I rest in a more accommodating space."

Her brows furrowed. This was not going as she'd expected. Did he not think she was smart enough to get the machine working? "Don't say that. I'm sure we'll figure it out in no time! We were so close before it blew up"

Hordak’s impassive face gave way and he frowned, a crease appearing on his forehead. "Perhaps. But back to the matter I wished to discuss."

Now there was a discussion?? Surely this isn't why he wanted her in his private room. Maybe he needed another push. Entrapta moved further inside and sat on the bed. "Okay! Whatcha wanna discuss?"

He shut the door before following her, but remained standing. His red gaze felt intense as he peered down at her, his discomfort replaced with something she couldn't decipher, and his tongue moistened his bottom lip before he spoke. "I wished to see if you had recommendations for improvements to this space." For whatever reason, his voice was a bit rougher than when he'd last spoken, and it was extremely attractive.

Entrapta leaned back on her hands, knowing that it would provide a nice view of her chest. "Well, I'd get a bigger bed, for one thing." She was pleased when his gaze flickered downwards from her face. "Oohh, and a bathtub might help relieve muscle aches." She hummed thoughtfully and looked around the small room. "But you're gonna need to tear down some walls." Hordak finally sat beside her on the bed, although it was with incredibly slow movements, as though he expected her to run away at any moment. She sat up straighter and smiled up at him. "What do you think?"

He inhaled deeply before taking hold of her hand again, and even with her thick gloves on, it made her heart beat wildly in her chest. "That sounds logical," he replied. They sat in silence, Hordak staring at the floor while Entrapta stared at Hordak, the tension seeming to grow heavier with each passing second - at least to her. His breathing was deep, and the rise and fall of his firm chest called her to him. Right as she was about to do them both a favor and throw herself at him, he turned to lean towards her, his hands encircling her waist.

He moved quickly and seemed nervous, and apparently miscalculated their size difference as he ended up pushing her onto the bed. Losing his balance as she slipped out of his hands, he fell on top of her, landing on his elbows to keep most of his weight off of her. He stared at her for a moment in surprise before he started to rise, but Entrapta was not letting him go so easily.

She wrapped her arms around his neck to keep him close to her and met his confused eyes with her own, where she was positive he had to see her desire for him plainly on her face. She pulled

her gloves off, tossing them on the bed beside them, and cupped his face. To her delight, he pressed further into her hands and his eyes slipped closed, his deep voice whispering her name against her palm.

This was it! Their faces were mere inches apart; she had him right where she'd always wanted him. She'd waited for so long, thinking this would never happen, but finally, *finally*, she was about to do the one thing she'd dreamt of doing with him every night since she'd laid eyes upon his gorgeous form. Entrapta took a breath, leaned in close, and at long last, she ran her naked fingers over Hordak's pointy ears.

They flicked a little as she made contact, the tips turning pink. "So cute…" she whispered, stroking the edges between her thumbs and forefingers. They were warm and soft, and felt surprisingly human, although a bit firmer. Her head tilted as a low, unusual sound filled the room, seemingly emanating from Hordak. "Are you *purring*?"

Hordak's eyes shot open and he rolled onto his side next to her, propping himself up on an elbow. "Of course not! Don't be ridiculous. I do not *purr*."

"Well, okay." She ran her fingers through his hair and he quickly relaxed under her touch. "It would be pretty adorable if you did though. Just putting that out there." Hordak tried to scowl at her, but she simply giggled at him and booped his nasal ridge. Despite how much he appeared to be fighting it, his face melted into a small smile; she didn't know he was capable of looking so sweet. Her hair removed her mask and set it on the floor as Hordak draped an arm over her stomach, tugging her to him.

Their bodies were fully pressed together as they lay side-by-side on the mattress that was too small, but she scooted even closer. The strain of unrealized want still lingered between them as her eyes darted down to his mouth. He would probably let her kiss him, she realized. He would probably let her do a lot more than that. It was something she would've done without hesitation a few

months ago, but now that the opportunity was literally staring her in the face, doubt began clouding her mind once again.

In spite of how close they'd become, and although she was currently in his arms, she still didn't know how he felt about her; she was well aware it was possible he was only interested in her physically. She'd enjoyed unattached encounters before she met him, but she knew she couldn't handle casual sex with Hordak; it would break her heart.

Much to her frustration, this also meant she probably shouldn't kiss him. She supposed it made her all the more strange for it, but she'd always found kissing more intimate than sex, and had shared only a handful of kisses with past partners. Whether it stemmed from her aversion to certain textures in her mouth or something else, she wasn't certain. As eager as she was to explore more of Hordak's body, maybe she should avoid physical contact altogether until she figured out what they were to one another. Probably something she should've considered before she climbed into his bed, but-

"Is something the matter?"

Shoot, she got a bit too lost in thought. "Yes! I mean, no!" She knew she should just tell him how she felt about him and get it over with, but she was too afraid of his response. "I'm just, uh…" his unwavering stare suddenly felt like too much, and she averted her gaze from him.

Was he expecting something to happen between them now? What was she saying, of course he was! She *had* told him there would be a next time, he'd asked her to come into his room and then she'd practically flung herself into his bed; she might as well have been wearing a sign that said "Please fuck me". But then again, what if he was only being so cuddly right now because he thought he had to? No, that didn't make sense! In that case, what if he truly wanted to have sex, but was still only interested in her as a lab partner? Fuck! This was all that spooky witch's fault! If that

lady hadn’t verbalized Entrapta’s fears, she could be getting railed right now!

“Entrapta?”

Crap, she still forgot to answer him. “Everything is normal!”

"What?" The heavy tension between them seemed to have ebbed away, replaced by stark awkwardness that only she was responsible for. When she didn’t look at him or respond, he removed his arm and began to pull away. “You may go if-”

Shit! “Shit! I mean, no!” Her hair hauled him back down, and she grabbed one of his large hands in both of hers. “I don’t want to go. Being here like this, together, it’s…” Her face felt unbelievably hot, and she couldn’t tell if it was caused by her own embarrassment, or from Hordak’s red eyes burning into her. “I’m so happy to be here with you,” she managed to say. She wondered if he knew she meant more than just in his room; she felt beyond lucky for all the time they’d spent together.

His eyes were wide, and his next question surprised her. "Do you mean that?" He sounded bewildered.

Half the Fright Zone suspected she was obsessed with him, and he didn't believe her? "Of course, Hordak."

A squeak escaped her as she was suddenly engulfed in his arms and yanked against him. “I am, as well,” he murmured against the crown of her head. “I am...*happy* with you.”

Something about the soft timbre of his voice paired with his talons stroking through her hair made her eyes feel watery, and she believed him. She buried her face against his chest to dispel the moisture, her hands clinging to him. They laid in a comfortable silence, and the steady beating of his heart lulled her into a daze. As her eyes grew tired and her breathing slowed, Entrapta was certain she’d never been happier in her entire life.

It was the middle of the night when Hordak slowly awoke. His body and mind felt strangely relaxed, which was possibly a first for him. There was a comforting weight on top of him, and softness wrapped over his limbs as he breathed in the scent of lavender. He forced his heavy eyes open, hardly believing the sight that greeted him.

His theories that Entrapta was perpetually awake were finally disproved. She was asleep on her stomach on top of him, her head resting on his chest with one of his long legs between hers. She'd apparently kicked off her oversized boots at some point and removed her coveralls and long-sleeved shirt, leaving her in a pair of thin, black shorts and her usual white tank top. Looking further down the bed, his own shoes were missing as well. Normally he was an incredibly light sleeper, but now that he thought about it, he *had* scarcely rested since the encounter in her bathroom. He'd been too busy with his studies.

This was not the intended crescendo he'd expected when he'd excused himself for days to rapidly research humanoid biology and romantic relationships, but it was more than he ever could've hoped for. Strands of Entrapta's silky tresses had coiled around him, and looking to the remaining strip of the mattress beside them, he found Imp sleeping soundly, curled in another pile of Entrapta's hair. His heart brimmed with emotions he had finally accepted weren't going to go away.

His eyes darted back to Entrapta's face, and he tightened his hold on her. When she didn't move, he shifted his eyes nervously, although he knew it was only the three of them in the room. She was a much quieter sleeper than he would've guessed. Perhaps she simply made so much sound when she was awake, there was no noise left within her when her body was resting. His hand stroked down her back and when she still did not stir, he slowly bent down and kissed the top of her head. While her body gave no indication she'd felt it, her hair tightened around him.

As it ended up, researching the frivolous topics of "*Unlocking The Female Orgasm*" and "*How To Tell If They Like You Or If They*

Like-Like You" warranted him more answers than he'd expected. As he gazed at the beautiful human in his embrace, he finally understood what these infuriating, wonderful feelings were: He loved her.

He loved her, and he did not want to open a portal.

He loved her, and he wanted to stay with her always.

He loved her, and he was beyond horrified that he would have to find a way to tell her so.

Chapter End Notes

So much fluff! Let's see how long before I (or Shadow Weaver) ruin it.

Private Lessons

Chapter Summary

> Hordak and Entrapta participate in some newlywed bonding activities.

Chapter Notes

> Yep there's about to be some DIRTIES. If you aren't interested in reading about Hordak's education with the female sex/smut, please skip down to the double bars to keep your eyes pure and safe!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The sound of rattling metal from somewhere above stirred Hordak unwillingly from the realms of slumber. He cracked one eye open just enough to see Imp disappearing into the vent above his bed, no doubt on his way to harass the kitchen crew. While the Horde consumed primarily ration bars, there was a commissary where they could purchase more frivolous foods, but Hordak believed half of the supply made it into Imp's grubby little claws.

It was still quite early, and he was still so tired from his lack of rest the past week, so he allowed himself to close his eyes for a while longer. As he began drifting back to sleep, he mused about what new projects he could entice Entrapta with to keep her distracted from the portal machine.

Hordak's eyes shot open. *Entrapta.* Entrapta was in his room! In his *bed!* He'd known it in the middle of the night, but it hit him like a tank this morning. As he gazed at the woman in his arms, he noted they'd shifted to their sides at some point and her back was to his front, his body curled around hers. Their legs were intertwined and her long hair cascaded over the two of them. His face was buried in her neck, and when he inhaled deeply, her scent made his head spin.

By instinct, he gripped her tighter to him, gasping as his fingers swept over the smooth, warm skin of her stomach; apparently his hand had found its way under her shirt of its own accord. A soft hum came from Entrapta at the contact, and Hordak froze. Was she awake? Was she offended? Should he leave? She'd told him before that she fantasized about him touching her, but doing so when she was unconscious surely wasn't what she meant. Wait-

She'd told him she fantasized about him touching her. Hordak's lower half was suddenly wide awake, seemingly very pleased with this memory. Ashamed and afraid she would notice, he quickly began uncoiling himself from her, but when he tried to extract his hand from her shirt, a strand of hair looped around his wrist. His eyes widened as he met her magenta gaze over her shoulder.

Wordlessly, she removed her hair from them and turned her body to face him on the bed, his hand moving to the bare skin of her back. One of her legs found its way between his again and quickly slid upwards until her thigh firmly rubbed against his hardening length. Unable to stop himself, Hordak moaned and crushed her against his torso, thrusting himself further on her thigh.

Smiling up at him from her place against his chest, her tiny fingers found his flanks, stroking over his bare skin as he slowly ground himself against her. Hordak cupped her face with his free hand, a thumb stroking over her cheek and to his surprise, she blushed. It stunned him that she could be so bold in her actions, yet such a small act of affection rendered her a bit flustered. It was unfairly charming and his chest ached with love for her.

"You said I could touch you." His voice was low and raspy with want, and the flush on her cheeks darkened. He needed to feel her, to show her how deeply he loved her when he couldn't yet bring himself to say the words out loud.

Entrapta nodded. "You can touch anything you want."

Hordak slipped both his hands under her biceps and hauled her upward to his level, placing her on her back. Her eyes were

sparkling with anticipation as he hovered over her, and he wanted to kiss her more than anything. He'd always found the concept disgusting in theory, his face grimacing the few times he'd spotted cadets engaged in the act in the midst of the night. But now as Entrapta was smiling up at him with full lips and inviting eyes, he wanted nothing more than to claim her mouth and taste the sweetness he knew must accompany her kind words and endless intelligent chatter.

But he was too afraid. He'd been certain she was going to kiss him last night, and when she didn't, he wondered if maybe she wasn't interested in that particular activity. So instead of the kiss he longed for, he lowered his forehead to hers, and her eyes closed. His hands moved beneath her shirt again, stroking up and down her curvy sides while he rubbed his temple against her cheek. He heard her sigh before she copied his movements, nuzzling her face against his, and her hands came up to stroke his ears. As embarrassing as he found it, Entrapta seemed to enjoy the sound and so he didn't attempt to hide the low purrs stemming from his chest.

Tentatively, he grazed his fingertips over her back and across her stomach, staying below the line of her bra and above the waistband of her shorts. He felt her sporadic scars beneath his touch, tracing their outlines, but she didn't seem to mind, and he admired her for her comfort in her own skin. When his thumbs glided to her solar plexus from her navel, she moved her mouth next to his ear. "You can move higher, if you want to," she murmured. "Or lower."

Hordak indeed wanted to move both higher and lower. "Very well." He slipped his fingers beneath the band of her bra, tracing small circles into the skin of her back. Full of nervous energy and afraid he was already messing up, more unprompted words escaped him. "I'd read that it was best to move slowly."

Suddenly, Entrapta pulled back to look him in the eyes, seeming very intrigued. "You read *what* exactly?"

Dammit! Of all the times for his lips to decide they ought to utter more than a three word sentence! "I, um…I was simply looking into the most effective methods to achieve-" Hordak's face suddenly felt as though it were on fire. This wasn't how he wanted things to go at all! "I-I…I was uncertain how to proceed with…" he gestured up and down her body with a hand, "all of this." Entrapta looked confused, but all Hordak could manage to do was stammer out some incoherent fragments about anatomy as he sat up on the edge of the bed with his feet on the floor. He was certain he'd ruined the moment, and was preparing to take his leave.

Entrapta kept him in place with tendrils of hair on his shoulder. "Is *that* the personal research you were talking about?" She looked at him incredulously. "You were reading about sex for a week?"

Mortified and suspecting his face was the same color as his eyes, Hordak gave a single, stiff nod. "I have never participated in these activities before," he admitted, embarrassed even though he was certain she knew this already.

"That is…" Entrapta began, and Hordak braced himself to hear her laughing at him. "So *sweet*!" He gaped as she crawled into his lap, her hands finding his ears again and petting them soothingly. "No one has ever gone through that much trouble for me before. However, you could've just asked me about it." Her eyes darkened and she shifted so that she was straddling him, making him gasp as his confused shaft twitched at the contact. His eyes grew wider as she reached down and pulled her white top over her head, discarding it on the floor. "I'll be more than glad to teach you. Some things are easier to learn with some hands-on experience."

Strands of hair undid the clasps of her bra, and before he knew it, he was face-to-chest with Entrapta's ample bosom. She rocked her hips against him, the cruxes of them meeting beneath thin fabric, and he barely heard her whimper over the sound of his own deep groan. "Entrapta," he muttered, feeling silky tresses take hold of his wrists. He was stunned as she encouraged his palms toward her breasts and arched her back; a silent invitation.

His teeth sank into his bottom lip as he let his hands connect with her voluptuous flesh. She shuddered beneath his touch and rolled her hips again, and Hordak's body responded in kind. Entranced, he kneaded the flesh that seemed to fit perfectly in his large hands. Encouraged by the sounds leaving her mouth, he brushed his thumbs over her nipples, making her breath hitch. How such a magnificent creature would allow him to touch her intimately, he would never understand.

As he lightly pinched the peaks between his fingers, she moaned loudly and pressed her head against his chest. "Hordak, you're doing so well." The lustful whine of her voice set him on fire and before he could second-guess himself, he tilted her back with an arm wrapped around her for support and lowered his mouth to her right nipple. He was beyond pleased when a stuttering gasp came from her lips and her fingers tangled in his hair, keeping him in place. She was enjoying this, enjoying *him!* Hardly able to believe it, he hummed around the sensitive bud as her legs laced around his waist while she ground herself on him the best that she could.

His mouth swapped sides, and his free hand came up to toy with the nipple now drenched with his saliva while he sucked ardently on the other. His tongue swirled around the hardened peak mercilessly while she mewled, her short nails digging into his scalp. When her hair tethered her to him, he let the hand on her back travel lower, dipping beneath the waistband of her shorts and gripping her fleshy backside.

She groaned into his hair, her legs tightening around him while she stimulated them both, continuing to rub against his cock. It felt so good, so right to have her in his arms as he tasted her skin. She pulled him up from her chest and wrapped her arms around his neck, and he buried his face in her hair. When she straightened up on top of his lap, she unlaced her legs from him and lifted her hips, tugging his tabard to the side.

Hordak cried out when her bare fingers snuck into his undergarments and tentatively stroked his hard length. Her

fingers couldn't wrap all the way around him, and he heard her mumble a breathy "wow" against his neck. Moaning as her hand found a rhythm of rubbing up and down his cock with a firm grip, his own hands returned to mindlessly kneading her breasts.

Humming against his neck, Entrapta's lips ghosted over his skin, so close to kisses but not nearly enough. He heard himself whine embarrassingly, desperate for more contact, but the sound seemed to spur Entrapta on. "If you take these off, Hordak, I'll give you something better."

His mind was a jumbled mess of pleasure fueled by the sight and scent of Entrapta, and he couldn't make sense of her words until she stopped fondling his cock and tugged at the waistband of his undergarments instead. She slid off of his lap, sitting on her knees next to him on the bed as he rose hastily and peeled the scrap of fabric down his legs with speed he hadn't used in years. He'd barely sat back down before she flung the tabard aside again and leaned down to ogle his length with sparkling eyes.

She licked her bottom lip as she ran a single finger from the tip to the base, giggling when it twitched and Hordak groaned her name. His shaft was the same greyish blue as the skin not marred by his illness, with ridges tapering down in size from the base to the tip and a flared head. Precum was already pooling at the tip, and in the back of his mind he hoped his endurance would improve with experience. "This is a *remarkable* specimen, Hordak," Entrapta marveled. She laid down on her stomach, propping up on her elbows as she inspected him.

It was embarrassing to be examined like he was one of her experiments, but at the same time he craved any sort of attention from her, and was eagerly anticipating whatever the "something better" was that she mentioned. He got his answer quickly. Entrapta bent her head and lapped up his seed from the head of his shaft. "*Entrapta!"* Her name ripped from his clenched teeth as a low growl.

His complete lapse of control gave her all the encouragement she needed, and she covered the tapered head of him with her mouth, grabbing the remaining length in her small hand. "*By the shadows, Entrapta…* " His vision grew spotty and he knew he should be mortified by the sounds he was making, but for once he couldn't focus on his shame. Her hot tongue swirled around the head of his cock as her hand pumped him, occasionally gently scraping her teeth along his flesh, something he would've thought would be unpleasant but it merely stoked the fire that was burning him alive.

A taloned hand found her backside, and he dug his claws lightly into her flesh over her remaining clothes, careful not to injure her. Not even in his most erotic fantasies had he allowed himself to imagine she would touch him in this manner, but it felt so right. She'd always been right when she told him this was how things should be. Why hadn't he listened to her sooner? Nothing that felt so good could be wrong, how could it be? They were married; it meant that they belonged together and he belonged inside of her.

"Entrapta, I- I'm…" he panted into the room, uncertain what he planned on saying. His words died out into a drawn-out moan as she started sucking the thin, sensitive ridge of skin right where the base of his shaft flared out, sending overwhelming sparks through his entire body. He forced his eyes open, wanting to see her before he came apart. "*Fuck.* " Her free hand was tucked into the front of her thin shorts, her hips thrusting against it as she pleasured herself. "Let me touch you," he rasped.

"Mmmhmm," Entrapta affirmed around him. Hordak lifted his hand from her ass to place it lower, but hesitated, needing direction. Entrapta thankfully seemed to understand, and she removed her hand from her body, taking hold of his. She started to lead his hand beneath the garments, but he wanted to see her bared completely.

"These are… in the way," he huffed between shallow breaths. Her garments were already shredded from where he'd been stroking

her, and he easily ripped both the shorts and the panties the rest of the way off. He probably should've asked permission, but he couldn't think straight.

At the sound of ripping fabric, Entrapta's eyes opened wide. She released him for a brief moment, staring up at him with an oddly thrilled gaze before redoubling her attempts to get more of his length in her mouth. Cradling the back of her head with his free hand, he groaned. Had the use of his claws enticed her further?? Something to keep in mind for next time. In the meanwhile, he slid his hand towards the crux of her and she immediately lifted her hips, moaning loudly around him when he cupped her.

Unprepared for the softness of the most private part of her, he sighed deeply. "You are so soft, Entrapta." She hummed in response and guided two of his fingers along her slit, whimpering when he brushed against what he suspected was her clit. After a moment, Hordak picked up on the rhythm she was showing him and she removed her hand, letting him have control.

The feeling of her warmth and wetness was beyond arousing, and he began thrusting his cock further into her mouth, closing his eyes once again. The sounds from her mouth grew louder when he focused on the small bud that crowned her sex, and he circled it slowly with a fingerpad. Continuing to pump him with a hand, she pulled him from her mouth. "Hordak," she whined. "I want you inside, please."

He growled, overwhelmed with both desire and immense adoration for her. The knowledge that the most brilliant being in the universe wanted this connection with him made him feel more powerful than any battle he'd won. He moved his hand lower, gently prodding at her folds to find the right spot. "W-watch the claws," she murmured.

Slowly, at her direction, he let his index finger slide inside her core, hissing her name as her inner walls fluttered around it. He glanced down at her face for any signs of discomfort before gently moving the finger in and out of her. She gave a shuddery sigh

before reaching down and pushing his thumb against her clit. When he moved the finger inside her and swept his thumb across her clit at the same time, she groaned and her eyes rolled back into her head.

Her hips began to move, riding his hand while she once again lowered her mouth to suck hard on his length. Gripping his armored forearm with her free hand, her fingers clenched in time with the motions of his finger inside her. Hordak added a second finger and he heard Entrapta inhale sharply around him. The juices of her arousal soaked his hand and the muffled sounds stemming from her were music to his ears, and he was in awe that he could give another such pleasure.

Entrapta began grinding into his hand, her cunt clenching his fingers while she took in more of his cock than ever and swallowed around the tip, and he swore he could see the nebulas and galaxies beyond despondos dancing in his eyes. It was too much, too perfect, and with a shout of her name, Hordak released himself into her mouth, his hips pushing even deeper inside her.

His head swimming through purple waves of rapture, Hordak continued fucking Entrapta with his thick fingers as she lapped up his seed. When there was nothing left, her upper body collapsed in his lap. “Yes, Hordak!” she gasped against his thigh. Between her rapid breathing and a few more enthused thrusts of his fingers, she was pushed over the edge, crying out his name as her core pulsated violently around his fingers.

Entrapta’s hips lowered when he slowly removed his hand, both of them panting heavily. Hordak stared at his sticky fingers quizzically before raising them to his mouth and tasting the essence that was Entrapta. A pleased rumble rose from his chest and without another thought, he put his fingers into his mouth to suck the sweetness from his skin. When he was finished, he looked down to see Entrapta grinning up at him, seeming yet again pleased by his instinctual action. Perhaps some of this couldn’t be learned from a book, after all.

Tired and beyond happy, Hordak scooped her into his arms and laid down, molding his body against hers. He nuzzled into her neck and she sighed, a hand coming up to stroke through his hair, and he let his eyes fall closed. He hoped more than anything that she loved him too.

Hordak had no idea how long it was before he awoke again, but he had no interest in leaving his quarters. He'd never "slept in" before, but he was comfortable, sated, and he had Entrapta. He allowed himself to pretend for a moment that there was no war, no portal to open, and no Prime. Unfortunately, a constant electronic pinging kept beckoning him back to reality. "Entrapta," he murmured against her neck. "Your datapad."

She stirred from her place in his arms and as reluctant as he was to release her, he did appreciate the view as she strode naked from the bed. Stooping to her discarded overalls, she fished the device from one of the many pockets. "Ah, shit…" she muttered under her breath as she scrolled through her messages.

Hordak sat up as she began hurriedly collecting her clothes from the floor. "Is something wrong?"

"Oh, no no! Nothing really." Despite her words, she glanced at her shredded panties beside the bed before quickly shuffling into her coveralls. "I just forgot I had plans today."

A frown marred his face as Hordak sat up fully. "What plans? With *whom?*" Who could she possibly have time to make plans with when she was with him in the sanctum for days on end? Had she connected with someone in the past several days when he'd been absent? Was he going to have to have someone "taken care of"?

Her purple hair had Entrapta fully dressed in a matter of seconds. "I told Scorpia I'd go with her to Princess Prom tonight. She wants me to watch her try on a bunch of outfits before we leave."

Hordak's frown deepened. "You are going to watch someone get undressed? And go to an event full of our enemies?"

Entrapta did not seem to comprehend how perturbed he was. "Yep."

"Why?"

A tendril of hair rubbed the back of her neck. "Because I'm a princess? Plus I didn't want Scorpia to have to go alone." Her usual happy expression faltered, and she somehow looked far away, gazing somewhere beyond him. "They look at you differently when you show up alone." Her voice was matter-of-fact, yet sad.

"Entrapta-"

"But that won't happen this time!" She smiled brightly at him. "Because we'll be there together."

Hordak's brow furrowed. "We…?"

"Oh, sorry! Not we as in you and me, I mean 'we' as in me and Scorpia."

This was somehow worse, and Entrapta must have seen the annoyance on his face. "Well, she also invited Catra!" Entrapta sat back beside him on the bed and fiddled with her hair, looking at the ground. "And ideally, I'd go with you, but I figured you wouldn't want… And I get it! Even with the "we promise no one will die" rules…"

"Ah, right. Yes, I would be murdered on sight." Hordak nodded solemnly. Certainty of death aside, he was quite flattered that she'd want to be seen with him at such an event, his heart speeding up at the very thought. He placed his hand palm side up on the bed between them, and to his delight, Entrapta took it. Their fingers laced together, although he wasn't certain who initiated it, and she laid her head on his bicep. "You need to be on high alert if you must attend this event. I will debrief Force

Captains Scorpia and Catra on proper safety protocol to ensure your protection."

Entrapta laughed. "Protect *me?* From what?"

He looked at her seriously, concerned over her nonchalance. "From those who wish to harm *me.* You chose to tie yourself to the biggest threat that this planet has ever faced, and I would not put it past the rebellion to use you as a way to get to me." He didn't understand the need for her to travel into enemy territory for something so pointless as a party. The princesses had their little rules about not attacking other royalty unprovoked, but he didn't trust them to uphold their own values.

A pigtail came up and patted him on the head. "That's very sweet, but I'm not sure anyone outside of the Horde knows that we're married."

"... *What?*" For some reason, he didn't like the thought of her keeping their union a secret. It was irrational to be hurt over this, as the concept of a marriage meant so little to both of them at the time, but that felt like a lifetime ago and things were different now. He wanted them to belong to one another and he wanted everyone to know it. Entrapta should probably know it as well, but he'd worry about that later.

She looked up at him with a shrug. "I mean, I didn't have anyone to tell. Word doesn't travel fast in Dryl, and I didn't really have any friends until I came here, soooo…" She trailed off, her hair once again fidgeting in what he assumed was discomfort.

It didn't escape his notice how she grew a bit unsettled whenever her previous isolation came up, and he squeezed her hand, hoping to relieve some of the tension. If he got his way, she would never be alone again. "I apologize that I cannot join you at this function. Let me know if I can make it up to you in another way."

He meant what he said, but was surprised when Entrapta perked up immediately, something clearly already on her mind. "Oh! I'm so glad you offered! There is something, actually." Releasing his hand, she sat up on her knees beside him. "I need you to come to my kingdom and swear your loyalty and submission to me in front of my board of advisors and the citizens of Dryl. So, y'know, nothing too major."

Hordak's jaw dropped open. *Swear his loyalty and submission to her?* Had she gone completely mad? More alarmingly, had *he* gone completely mad, since he found himself considering saying yes? Perhaps his sanity was stored in his shaft, as he certainly found himself willing to do whatever she asked after she'd pleasured him. No wonder Lord Prime had forbidden his clones from partaking in sins of the flesh, assuming they grew stupider with every release. Pulling together his thoughts, Hordak eloquently asked her to clarify her request. "*What?*"

Entrapta nodded sympathetically. "I know what you're thinking, and you're right, it's all so boring! But the council of Dryl has been bugging me for years to go through with a coronation, and I couldn't do it without a spouse. So now that I have you, I figured I'd just go ahead and get it over with. Plus!" She clapped her hands together. "There will be snacks!"

Gazing into her magenta eyes, he knew he could deny her nothing. He had a reputation to uphold, but if this was simply a formality, surely there was no harm in humoring her. Besides, as her husband, he needed to support her rising in rank in her home kingdom. Additionally, the idea of Entrapta being crowned a queen certainly piqued his interest. She deserved nothing more, and the thought of ruling the planet with her by his side as his queen enticed him greatly. Perhaps after the ceremony, he could see how she looked seated upon the throne of Dryl, if there was one. He would kneel before her and her alone, place his hands on her smooth thighs, lower his head and-

"Hordak?"

“Yes. I’ll do it.”

“Really? Oh, that’s great!” She flung herself at him, wrapping her arms around his neck and snuggling her face against his. She pulled back before he had the chance to fully return her hug. “Thank you, Hordak! I’ll let the council know so they can pick a date and I can *finally* be done with all this bureaucracy stuff.”

She was so happy, and Hordak didn’t have the heart to break it to her that being a queen most likely meant she’d have exponentially more “bureaucracy stuff” on her plate. She’d find out in time, but they could figure things out together. She glanced down at his power crystal before meeting his eyes, and looked as though she were about to say more, but another ping on her datapad had her pulling out of his arms entirely.

“I gotta go! I’ll see you tonight!” She waved at him as her hair hauled her into the vent that Imp had disappeared in earlier that morning.

“Yes, tonight…” Hordak replied, though she was already gone.

Tonight. Yes, he should tell her tonight. He would tell her tonight.

Chapter End Notes

I know you all wanted Hordak to go to Princess Prom, but he's not invited!! I'm sorry :(Also I really struggle with writing smut, so I hope it was okay!! I try to add in feelings but I don't know what I'm doing.

Also I'm sorry for not replying to all comments, but I treasure them more than you know and I reread them all the time!!

3x3

Chapter Summary

Hordak removes some beams, Entrapta alters some seams, Shadow Weaver follows her dreams.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Entrapta hadn't been gone more than ten minutes before Hordak started demolishing his quarters. He doubted he could have it expanded before she returned that evening, but after experiencing how wonderful it was to share his space with her and wake up with her in his arms, he didn't want to waste a moment. It was perhaps premature, he didn't even know if she'd care to continue sharing a bed, but he'd already given her the excuse it was for the ease of his own body, so what could it hurt? It wasn't as though he had anything else to do in any case.

"Lord Hordak?" A voice from the sanctum reminded Hordak that, in any case, he had something else to do.

Hordak emerged from behind the throne to see Force Commander Grizzlor at the base of the stairs. So wrapped up was he in the afterglow of his night with Entrapta, he'd completely forgotten they had a meeting. Ordinarily, he would be annoyed, but it would be a welcome distraction from his growing nerves at the prospect of confessing his feelings to her tonight. When he recalled the nature of the meeting, the corner of his mouth quirked up for the briefest of seconds. He hoped the commander didn't notice. He was so very close to being rid of the witch for good.

"I trust the changeover is nearly concluded?" Hordak asked smoothly as he approached the commander, not bothering the formality of sitting on the throne.

Hordak had ultimately selected Grizzlor as his second-in-command, with Shadow Weaver's administrative duties being spread out among members of the Horde not suited for combat. The latter had been Commander Cobalt's idea; as the head of cadet training, he had a good eye for when someone wasn't cut out for the field, and suggested the day-to-day operations previously handled solely by Shadow Weaver be picked up by a larger group to avoid dependency on a single individual. Meanwhile, Grizzlor would focus on progressing the war - Something Hordak was trying very hard to care more about now that he was no longer interested in returning to Prime.

"As concluded as they're going to be. Operations have been transitioned to the new department, and all seems to be running smoothly. We haven't needed to consult Shadow Weaver for the past week." Despite his words, Grizzlor looked uneasy and Hordak knew why. While she'd been under constant surveillance, there was no way of knowing for certain whether Shadow Weaver had somehow sabotaged them, be it by placing a curse or simply withholding vital information. Even if she hadn't managed to cause damage yet, he had no doubt she would seek revenge if they let her go freely.

Hordak gave a stiff nod. "We will keep her imprisoned for a while longer in case anything goes awry. Once we have confirmed she no longer serves a purpose, I am sending her to Beast Island."

Truth be told, Hordak had sent very few to Beast Island, but he was very much looking forward to this. As was Grizzlor, apparently, as the large man smiled at Hordak's words. It was no secret Shadow Weaver was not well liked, but at least she had been efficient at keeping trivial matters off of Hordak's back all these years. However, now that she would soon be gone, and he no longer hated being alive, Hordak was finding he didn't mind the idea of being more involved with the war efforts. And when he thought about how Entrapta told him her fellow princesses had never accepted her, he was beginning to feel he might actually enjoy it.

“Entrapta! Where have you been?” Scorpia ran over to her when she arrived through a vent in Scorpia’s room, claws piled high with flashy clothes. “We’ve only got four hours to go until Princess Prom! There’s so much to do!”

Entrapta raised a brow. “Four hours? That means we don’t have to get ready for another three hours and forty-five minutes!” Entrapta never actually read the invitation, but now that she knew how much time they had to kill, she was a little miffed at being taken away from Hordak so soon. She couldn’t stop thinking about how gentle he was with her, how he’d looked at her when he told her she made him happy, how his fingers felt when they-

“Could you hold these, please? Thanks!” Entrapta was pulled out of her thoughts as Scorpia thrust the clothes into her own arms, which were significantly smaller than Scorpia’s, meaning most of the pile ended up on the floor. Before Entrapta could respond, Scorpia ran into the closet.

“She’s been like that all day.” Entrapta turned to see Catra, who was seated backwards on a chair, her chin resting in her folded arms over the backrest. “She’s already tried on like fifty outfits, it’ll be a shock if we make it to this dumb party at all.” Entrapta wouldn’t mind not making it to the party, but once again, Scorpia sprang into action before Entrapta got the chance to speak.

She emerged from the closet, dressed in a fitted black dress with a large slit up the thigh, and one sleeve that appeared to have been torn from her spiked, natural pauldrons. Entrapta liked the rip, she thought it gave the dress character. “You look great!”

Scorpia smiled shyly before turning to Catra. “Catra? Do you like it?”

She did a little spin, and Catra smiled back. “Yeah, that’s *definitely* the one.”

Scorpia’s face turned a bright pink and she giggled. “Oh Wildcat, you always say the sweetest things.”

“That is statistically untrue,” Entrapta informed her, but Scorpia didn’t seem to notice.

“What about you, brainiac?” Catra turned her focus to Entrapta. “You have a pair of diamond-encrusted overalls or something?”

Entrapta waved a strand of hair dismissively. “I was just gonna wear what I've got on.” She’d already showered and put on her cleanest clothes, so she was as ready as she was going to be. Besides, if she was lucky, she wouldn’t be wearing clothes very long once she got back to the Fright Zone anyway.

Catra merely laughed, but Scorpia’s jaw dropped for a moment before she shook her head rapidly. “No way! This is a swanky affair! Oh Entrapta, won’t you let me dress you up?” She dashed over to Entrapta and clacked her claws together, her eyes wide and shimmery. “Pretty please? It’ll be fun, I promise.”

Entrapta frowned. She liked her clothes, they were practical, comfy, and had lots of pockets to take snacks home. But Scorpia’s eyes were so big and so shiny, and she did want to make her friend happy… “I don’t have any other kinda clothes here, they’re all in Dryl.”

“It’s no problem!” Scorpia chirped. “We’re only given Horde-y clothes here too. I found all of this stuff tucked away in Horror Hall, my family’s old castle! We’ll find you something too!”

While not thrilled about the idea of new clothes, the prospect of an area in the Fright Zone she hadn’t explored yet was thrilling, and so once Scorpia changed back into her regular uniform, she happily followed the two girls to Horror Hall.

Scorpia dug through piles of clothes while Entrapta wandered around, although unfortunately, the castle had no accessible vents that she could see. She paused as she heard footsteps behind her, and turned to see Catra falling into step beside her. “What’s your deal?”

“What do you mean?”

“What are you doing here?”

Entrapta tilted her head. What kind of a question was that? “Scorpia wanted to look for clothes.”

Catra shook her head. “No, what are you doing in the Fright Zone? Don’t you have a whole castle full of tech stuff you could be in right now?” She kicked at some debris, sending it skittering down the path in front of them. "It's gotta be better than this dump."

Entrapta frowned, still not understanding the need for a question that everyone knew the answer to. “I’m helping Hordak build a portal machine. And doing weapons upgrades, plus some infrastructure maintenance when I’m in the mood.”

Catra stared at her in an indecipherable way as they continued down the dusty hallway. “Why? What do you get out of it?”

Entrapta shrugged. “It’s fun!”

“That’s it? But you could have it all!” Catra had stopped and threw up her hands.

“I could?” Entrapta blinked. “All of what, exactly?” What a confusing young woman.

Catra gestured broadly. “All of *this!* The Fright Zone, the power, everything. Hordak is a total sucker for you. Shadow Weaver knows it. Everyone knows it. Why not take it? I would.”

Entrapa pursed her lips. She didn’t know what “being a sucker for her” meant, but she didn’t like that people were suggesting she wanted to gain anything from her personal relationship with Hordak. “I don’t want it.”

“Then what do you want?”

Entrapta paused, and turned to look at Catra fully. Should she continue trying to keep her feelings a secret if she was going to

tell Hordak herself soon anyway? She opened her mouth to respond, but Scorpia continued her new habit of interrupting. Entrapta didn't mind, focusing her attention on the excited Scorpia who was running towards them with a smile. "Did you find something?"

"Well, sorta. We Scorpioni were built big, so it may not fit, but I think we can make it work. It's your color!" Scorpia held up a plum dress that sparkled as she shook it. Entrapta looked at the garment skeptically. "It has pockets!" Well, maybe it wouldn't be so bad. It was just for a little while.

Scorpia and Entrapta went back to Scorpia's room, but Catra said she would meet up with them when it was time to go. It was a bit of a struggle, and Emily had to help hold it in place, but eventually Entrapta was sufficiently safety pinned into the glittery dress without risk of it falling down - Which Entrapta didn't think was a huge deal, but Scorpia thought otherwise and seemed to know more about these things. It was sleeveless, which she appreciated for the mobility of her arms, and it hugged her chest and waist before flowing at a slope from her knees to the floor behind her. She had no other shoes, but she liked the contrast of her boots with the otherwise froofy dress anyway.

Entrapta was not a fashionable person by any means, but she had some softer, thinner gloves for the rare times she wasn't working that she decided to wear in place of her usual bulky ones, and Scorpia seemed delighted. They'd gone back to Entrapta's lab to get them, and when she peeled them off, Entrapta mentioned wanting to redo the paint on her nails as well. No one else would see them, but she liked to know they were painted, just for her.

"Oh, that is so cute!" Scorpia murmured as she watched, although her expression looked somehow sad.

"Thanks!" Entrapta beamed. "I make these colors myself, they're almost unchippable!"

“I wish I could do something like that.” Scorpia frowned at her large pincers.

Entrapta quickly set aside her paint and grinned as she began shuffling around her workstation. She held up her airbrush kit and waggled her brows at Scorpia. “Who says you can’t?”

Shadow Weaver needed to separate Hordak from the princess. She’d mulled over multiple scenarios involving killing one or both of them in the time since her dismissal, but unfortunately it all came back to splitting them apart. It was disappointingly dull, and she’d hoped slowly and painfully killing Hordak was the more reasonable option, but it simply wasn’t meant to be. Yet, anyway. Hordak was grossly fragile with no support system, and it would be easy to crush whatever confidence the princess had managed to instill in him. At least she would still have a good time with it, even if Hordak wasn’t in physical pain.

She’d had very little opportunity to do so, but she’d done what she could in planting whisperings here and there about this unique princess’s ability to break the cycle of tyrannical monarchs, and could only pray they caught wind. It was all completely ludicrous, of course, but the fools in the Fright Zone would latch on to any shred of gossip if it had to do with the oppression brought upon them by the royals.

Once Hordak had been emotionally destroyed beyond repair, Shadow Weaver would fall into the good graces of *Lady* Entrapta and with some luck, at least part of the Fright Zone would follow. The hardest part would be getting the princess to fall in line and play the role Shadow Weaver had been orchestrating for her. Ah well, it didn't matter, once she was free and had access to the garnet, she could use her magic to help steer the girl in the right direction.

A princess leading the Horde could perhaps open up opportunities for Shadow Weaver with the rebellion as well, and at this point, she didn’t care which side was victorious, so long as she had a

seat at the winner's circle. She wished she'd had the foresight to mold Scorpia into this role when she'd had her mothers sent away, but at the time her focus had been on getting the girl away from the Black Garnet by any means necessary. Hindsight is always-

"Your days are numbered, Shadow Weaver."

Oh for *fuck's sake*. "What do you want, Hordak?" She'd dropped the formalities awhile back; respect for Hordak was a facade she no longer saw a point in upholding.

His grotesque face swam into the dim light outside her cell, the oversized bones in his forehead awash with green light. He was smiling, and just as with any facial expression he attempted to make, it increased his unpleasantness exponentially. She couldn't believe this buffoon was getting laid.

"I was quite pleased when my second-in-command informed me that all of your duties have been successfully taken on by other staff." His arms were folded behind his back as he continued smiling serenely at her. Not even a smirk. A *smile.* Never in her darkest nightmares had she imagined he'd force her to look at something so hideous. She'd simply have to get rid of it herself.

"Perhaps you can celebrate with your pet princess when she returns from frollicking with her fellow royalty. That is, if she decides to come back to you." The smile faltered. Oh, this was far too easy.

"Consider this your eviction notice. In two weeks, I am putting you on a transport to Beast Island." He tried and failed to put the smile back in place, sneering at her instead. Delightful.

When she did not react as she knew he wanted her to, his nasal ridge flared in anger and he turned to leave. "I'm surprised you let her go," Shadow Weaver called out in a calm voice.

He did not move when he replied. "Entrapta is free to go wherever she wishes. She chooses to be here."

“Are you trying to convince me, or yourself?” She heard him inhale. The fool was practically setting himself up. “It’s no secret Entrapta was an outcast among her peers, but princesses are still cut from the same luxurious, overpriced cloth. Perhaps if she connects with them, she will see that she has other options. They managed to convert your top Force Captain to their side, after all. Who is to say they cannot take your wife as well?”

“This conversation is ridiculous. We’re done here.” Shadow Weaver held it in as long as she could, but once his long strides carried him quickly out of sight, she laughed freely into the tiny cell. She would never see the inside of that Beast Island transport.

Chapter End Notes

Y'all still with me?

Not sure about the Catra & Entrapta interaction, I'm not used to writing Ms. Meow Meow and tbh idk what her motives are in this since we're so far gone from canon. But I felt like including her, so there she is.

People I Don't Like

Chapter Summary

> Super Pal Trio is going to prom! The politics are made up, and the marriage rules don't matter!

Chapter Notes

> Thank you to Mazen, Grot, and Alex for all your help with this chapter a million years ago. I don't remember who suggested what, but I know that I used a lot of your ideas here. Love you all 5evr

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Super Pal Trio's ready for prom!" The cheer from Scorpia echoed throughout the fascinating arachnid-shaped ship as she eased it into the dock just below the castle in the Kingdom of Snows.

Entrapta wasn't nearly as interested in going to Princess Prom as she was in exploring Scorpia's ship. It wasn't very large so there weren't any air vents for her to crawl in, but there were lots of intriguing panels that Catra wouldn't let her pry open, and lots of buttons in the navigation console that Scorpia wouldn't let her press. They'd both said something about not wanting her to cause the ship to fall out of the sky, but she didn't see the cause for concern, she was a professional!

"Uh, you guys go ahead!" She waved a strand of hair at them as they moved toward the ship's open door. "I'll be riiiight behind you. In just a few minutes. Or ten. An hour, tops." She nearly had her gloved hands on the navigation panel, but was stopped by a painted black, glittery claw tip lowering in front of her, separating her from the sacred buttons.

"Sorry little buddy, this gal is an antique. She has a lot of quirks!" Scorpia smiled kindly, but it didn't deter Entrapta's instant pout of defeat.

"Seriously Entrapta, *please* don't break our only way out of here. I don't want Adora and all these snotty royals to see us hitchhiking our way back to the Fright Zone." Catra continued out of the ship with a huff, and Entrapta scowled after her. She'd been upgrading the Fright Zone's weapons and fixing all of their technological problems for a long time now, why did they think she was unqualified to press a few buttons? She was more than capable of playing with someone else's toy without breaking it. In fact, if it was as old as Scorpia said, Entrapta had no doubt she could make several improvements before they even left for home.

"When we get back to the Fright Zone, I'll let you push all the buttons you want," Scorpia reasoned. "Promise."

While still annoyed at their doubt in her abilities, Entrapta was at least placated with the promise of future tinkering, and with a tiny harrumph she may or may not have picked up from Hordak, she followed her companions towards the castle.

Entrapta's hair curled up in mild anxiety as they neared the entrance hall, an unconscious tick that followed her to any social gathering. At Scorpia's suggestion, she'd left most of her hair loose and flowing down her back, but with two buns on top of her head to keep it from dragging the floor. She'd not agreed at first, preferring the practicality of her regular pigtails, but Scorpia enticed her by speculating over what Hordak might think of the new hairstyle, and Entrapta had folded faster than Emily's wonky left leg.

Against her better judgment, she'd left her welding mask on the ship as well, choosing instead to crown her head with the new purple goggles she'd finished making for herself earlier that week. By the time they approached the weapons check at the entrance where the crowds were growing thick, she was feeling rather exposed. Entrapta was just about to go back to the ship to grab her mask when she spotted something across the room that immediately made her forget everything else. " *Octavia!"*

Within moments, she'd rapidly bobbed and weaved herself across the busy floor and into the muscular arms of Octavia, who caught her with a grunt of surprise. "Woah, hey there!" The larger woman gave her a good squeeze and grinned down at her. "I can't believe you showed up to this stupid thing." Octavia took a step back and her eyes widened as they darted up and down Entrapta's body. "And who bribed you with what to get you looking like *that?* "

Entrapta waved a strand of hair dismissively. "It's ridiculous, I know. But Scorpia-"

"Octavia!" Speaking of, a blur of black and red rushed past her, and where Entrapta failed to knock the wind out of Octavia with the gusto of her hug, Scorpia succeeded. "It's so great to see you! And look at your dress! You look amazing! Gosh, it's just so good to see another familiar face here."

Octavia pulled herself out of Scorpia's back-breaking embrace, gasping for air. "Good to see you too." Her eyes narrowed at the remaining girl. "Catra."

Catra's tail flicked. "Hey, Octavia. I see your eye grew back."

The bionic eye that Entrapta made for Octavia lit up. "It sure did," Octavia muttered. "Try taking it again and see what happens."

Before Catra could reply, a strand of Entrapta's hair coiled around Octavia's arm and began dragging her to the buffet. "I'm so glad you're here!" Entrapta gushed before turning her eyes back on the food ahead. The one, consistent thing she liked about parties was there was always a ton of tiny, adorable food. As they got closer, she became aware that multiple eyes seemed to follow her group as they moved throughout the room. Someone nudged their partner, gesturing towards her. Entrapta frowned. Maybe they were looking at someone else. Yes, that had to be it. She rarely received attention at these types of events, and she preferred it that way.

"So uh, why *are* you here?" Scorpia was asking Octavia as she followed closely behind them. "Oooh, are you dating a princess now? You sly dog."

Octavia rolled her eyes. "It's definitely not that. The council of Dryl didn't think Entrapta was going to show up, and they insisted the kingdom needed a representative to make an appearance as a gesture of goodwill. And with the absence of their princess, I got to be that lucky person." Octavia pointed unenthusiastically to a small brooch pinned at her chest - the sigil of Dryl. Weird, Entrapta didn't even know they made pins. "Given Dryl's close partnership with the Fright Zone, the other allies and trade partners would apparently take Dryl's absence as a slight against them. It's all so political and so stupid."

"Stupid and boring!" Entrapta chirped in agreement, filling the pockets of her sparkly dress with mini quiche from the buffet table. She was dying to tell Octavia about what happened with Hordak that morning, but Hordak was a private person, and he probably wouldn't appreciate her describing his dick in detail in such a public space. It was a shame; he should be really proud of possessing such a magnificent appendage. She'd drawn some schematics of what she thought it might look like after she'd felt him up in her bathroom, but she'd definitely underestimated the-

"Speaking of stupid and boring," Catra interrupted Entrapta's less than pure thoughts. The feline was walking back over the group holding a tray of tiny glasses. "Let's get in line to greet the pipsqueak princess hosting this thing so I can give her a withering stare. I ran into Adora on the balcony and she thinks we're up to something evil and dastardly. It'll be a blast to make her keep thinking that."

"Be careful with these," Entrapta suggested, picking up a brightly colored drink from the tray and inspecting it. "They're super cute, but what they don't tell you is they've got alcohol in them! I wish I'd known that during my first princess prom before I drank five in a row." She'd awoken in the vents of Brightmoon the morning

after with a hundred umbrella toothpicks in her hair, a marker drawing of a robot on her lower back, and a missing boot.

Catra cackled. “That’s the point, genius. Drink up!”

And they did; the four ladies clinked their tiny glasses together before downing the contents. Entrapta wasn’t generally a fan of alcohol; she didn’t like not being able to think clearly and how sluggish it made her feel. But in the bustling crowds, as the small drink warmed her insides and made her tongue tingle, she looked at her small group that was laughing with her and not *at* her for once, and was beginning to see the occasional appeal.

They bowed to the small snowy princess before moving about the room, just talking and laughing, and to her surprise and relief, Entrapta was actually having fun. She was vaguely aware they were still getting odd looks, and she swore she heard an occasional whisper of her and Hordak’s names as they passed by, but she did her best to ignore it. None of her group seemed to notice, so perhaps she was just being paranoid after one too many bad experiences. Besides, she was no stranger to receiving weird looks, although generally it was after she’d spent time conversing with someone. Whatever, she was having fun. She finally had friends. She had a brilliant, hot alien with the thighs of an angel she’d be returning to that evening. This last thought made her heart swell and her already flushed face feel warmer. A few odd looks weren't going to sour her good mood, dammit!

Catra stuck with them for a while as they roamed about and chatted, and appeared to be having a good time, but her eyes kept darting to a young blonde woman who was never far behind them. She looked vaguely familiar, although Entrapta couldn’t quite place her. Eventually, Catra left them entirely, but Entrapta was glad to see her having fun. “I’m gonna go put on a good show for Adora." Catra laughed with a grin before she darted off. "Man, I *love* ruining parties!” Teenagers had some odd hobbies.

Down to three, at Entrapta’s suggestion, they moved to the balcony where it was less crowded to people watch. Aside from

the tiny food, Entrapta had always found these events a great way to observe humanoid behavior, although her observations never seemed to help her interact with others. Watching the ever-changing faces and body language she could never identify in the crowd below was still fascinating.

“Hey, Entrapta,” Scorpia began, “can I ask you something?” Scorpia was helping Entrapta's hair hold her in place where she was perched on the balcony railing. Entrapta's goggles were over eyes, the lenses zoomed in so she could see everyone more closely. Spying and climbing all over the architecture probably wasn't the most lady-like thing to do, but Entrapta had never been a proper lady and never would be. Where was the fun in it?

“Shoot,” Entrapta replied, still scanning the crowd and muttering periodically into her recorder.

“You’re an experienced older woman.” Rude, she wasn’t *that* old. “How do you know when you’re in love?” The abrupt question took her by surprise, and Entrapta’s hair inadvertently uncoiled from the banister. Had Scorpia’s claw not held onto the skirt of her dress, Entrapta would’ve fallen over the balcony and into the chocolate fountain below. While death by chocolate wasn’t the worst way to go, she hopped onto the balcony floor so as not to risk it.

She shoved the goggles onto the top of her head and looked at Scorpia with wide eyes. Entrapta hadn’t told anyone other than Emily and the crystal powering his armor how she truly felt about Hordak, although she wasn’t certain why. Sure, Octavia and Scorpia knew she had a crush on him metaphorically larger than the mass of Etheria’s weightiest moon, and she’d told Octavia most of the dirty details (despite Octavia telling Entrapta she *really* didn’t need to know), but for some reason, she’d been scared to verbalize how deep her feelings ran.

Perhaps it was because she’d never been in love before now, and it took her a long time to sort out the confusing emotions herself. Perhaps it was because she was ultimately afraid of rejection, and

it would hurt that much more if her friends pitied her afterwards. Hordak had glossed over the finer details of his past and seemed uncomfortable with the subject, but she suspected if they opened a portal, he would be expected to return to Horde Prime. She'd asked him explicitly once about what would happen after the signal was sent into the wider universe, but he gave a vague non-answer and stomped off in an absolute tizzy. She knew he cared for her to some degree, but did he care enough to stay? She was afraid of the answer, so she hadn't broached the subject again.

Scorpia was still staring at her expectantly, and Entrapta twisted a strand of her hair nervously as the rest curled up around her. The lights dimmed and the chatter throughout the castle was slowly replaced with music, throwing her train of thought even further off track. "Um, well…" Was she really going to say it out loud? Luckily, Octavia saved her.

"I'll tell you how you know," Octavia muttered from where she was seated on the floor beside them, drink in hand. "Every time you look at them, everything feels warm, and safe. You know no matter how bad things get, you'll be okay, because they're around." Scorpia and Entrapta stared at her as she continued. "You notice all their tiny quirks and habits, and even stuff they do that may have pissed you off when you first met becomes irresistible. You want to spend every moment together, no matter what you're doing. Or even if you're not doing anything. Just being together is enough."

Entrapta wondered if Scorpia's heart was beating as hard as hers. Octavia continued. "So you finally get up the symbolic balls, and you look them dead in the eyes, and you say those three words out loud. And it's horrifying and wonderful." She smiled a bit, looking off into the middle distance. "And sometimes, that person says it back. And it's just…" She sighed. " *Wow.* "

Entrapta bit her lip. She wanted things to be just wow.

Octavia finished her drink and rolled her shoulders with a huff, gaze narrowing. "But then one day, you wake up and she's not

there. She's high-tailed it to the Crimson Waste without a word, because she's a coward and a traitor." Her eyes widened when she finally looked at the two girls who had been hanging off of her every word. "But I mean, just because that happened to me doesn't mean it will happen to you two! Sometimes, when it works out, it can be really amazing. And it'll make all of those uncertain feelings you have in the beginning worth it. I promise."

Entrapta desperately wanted it to work out. She wanted Hordak. More than anything. She turned to Scorpia, but Scorpia was no longer paying attention. Entrapta followed her gaze over the balcony, and while she wasn't an intuitive person by any means, she saw exactly what Scorpia was looking at: Catra, dancing with the blonde she'd been taunting all night. Octavia saw it too as she rose from the ground. "Scorpia," Octavia said softly, placing a hand on the younger girl's shoulder. "Don't even w-

"I'm gonna go get another drink! I'll catch up with you guys later." Before they could stop her, Scorpia was rushing off and out of sight in the sea of party-goers.

Concerned, Entrapta started to follow her, but Octavia raised a palm. "Give her a few minutes." Entrapta hummed thoughtfully, but resisted going after her. She usually liked to be alone to process her feelings too. Instead, she leaned against the balcony to watch the dancers below while she pondered whether she ought to reveal to Hordak that night what she'd engraved on his crystal.

"Hm?" She looked at Octavia's hand, which was suddenly extended next to her.

"Any way I can convince you to dance?" she asked with a small smile.

"Oh, no, no!" Entrapta waved her hands and hair. "That's okay, it's not my thing. You know I'm not the most coordinated person."

“Oh, come on. You got all dolled up, you came all this way! We can stay up here where it’s not so loud.” Entrapta still looked unconvinced, but Octavia made an offer she couldn’t refuse. “Let’s make a deal. You give me one dance, and I'll willingly listen to one gross fact about Lord Hordak’s anatomy.”

Temporarily pulled from her more serious thoughts, Entrapta grinned and placed a tendril of hair in Octavia’s outstretched hand. “Deal!” She rested her gloved hands on Octavia’s biceps while Octavia placed her free hand on Entrapta’s waist. As they began to sway, Entrapta’s hair frizzed up in enthusiasm as she prepared to fill Octavia in about the physical progress she’d made with Hordak.

“Oooh, Octavia! It’s just so wonderful.” She couldn’t help bouncing up on her toes while strands of hair gave Octavia’s cheeks a quick squish. “I have made the *most* exciting development in my interpersonal Hordak progress to date! This morning, Hordak and I-”

“Princess Entrapta.” The sound of her name in a young voice was sharp, almost sounding like an accusation.

Octavia released her and Entrapta turned around to see a fluffy pink girl frowning at her, flanked by the blonde in the red dress who’d been dancing with Catra and following them all night. “Hello! Do I know you?”

“Yes!” The pink girl huffed. “You guys attacked us in the Northern Reach, remember?” She folded her arms dramatically over her chest, making the sparkles in her hair twinkle. She was very cute, and reminded Entrapta of a cupcake from back in the Dryl kitchens, which was an amusing contrast to the girl’s deep frown.

“I didn’t attack anyone,” Entrapta replied casually. “I was just there for science!”

Octavia stepped in front of Entrapta before addressing the two teens. “Is there a problem, ladies?”

“Yes!” squeaked the sparkly girl. She poked her head around Octavia’s large body to point at Entrapta. “Is it true?”

Entrapta tilted her head. “It might be! Is what true, exactly?”

“Is it true that you’re in bed with the enemy?”

“You mean Hordak?” Entrapta appreciated the straightforward question. “Well, between us, since you asked, I was in bed with him earlier today!”

The blonde’s head made an appearance from behind Octavia as well, and her slack-jawed expression mirrored the sparkly girl’s perfectly.

The sparkly one’s cry of “Gross!” nearly drowned out Octavia’s “Finally. Cobalt owes me big time.”

The blonde stepped a little closer and smiled at Entrapta, although she somehow looked like she was in pain. “Wow! That’s really, uh… special! But what she meant to ask was is it true that you and Hordak-”

Entrapta usually didn’t catch on quickly, but she knew teenagers were hormonal and curious creatures, so she could tell exactly where this was going, and nodded in understanding. “I mean, not *yet* , but-”

“No, please stop!” the sparkly one interjected quickly. “I *mean,* is it true that you married him?”

“Oh, yes! I did.” Several passersby had stopped and were watching them now. Entrapta didn’t like it one bit.

“See, Glimmer?” The blonde asked the pink. “I don’t know why you didn’t believe me.”

The pink one ignored her and stepped past Octavia to continue speaking to Entrapta. “How could you do that?”

Entrapta shrugged. “By signing the paperwork. It was easy.”

The sparkly girl crossed her arms and spoke slowly, as though Entrapta would have a hard time understanding her. “*I know how it works*.”

“Then why did you ask?” Entrapta asked with a quirked brow.

“Because you’re a *princess!* You’re supposed to be on our side!”

“I’m on the side of science.” It wasn’t Dryl’s war, and Entrapta didn’t particularly care who won. Although, it would make Hordak happy, so she had a slight preference toward the Horde, and this conversation was strengthening that. “The other kingdoms rejected Dryl’s offers to collaborate on technological advancement for *years* . The Horde didn’t.” It was a pretty simple decision.

“Besides,” Octavia interjected, “Dryl has always been neutral in the war. We- *Princess Entrapta* doesn’t owe you anything.”

“Oh please!” the pink girl - Glimmer, apparently - insisted. “Dryl picked a side when you married the guy trying to destroy the planet!”

“He’s not trying to destroy the planet!” Both Entrapta and the teen’s voices were rising in volume, drawing more unwanted attention.

“You’re a traitor.”

“How am I a traitor?” Anger bubbled up in Entrapta’s chest. “Every kingdom has always looked out for themselves. I didn’t betray anyone.”

“My mom said Dryl is upholding alliances and trade deals with territories who are against the Horde.” Glimmer was all but pouting. “Those agreements should’ve been voided the second you affiliated yourself with the Horde.”

Octavia interrupted. “Your mother must’ve left out that Dryl and the Fright Zone are technically an empire now due to their alliance, meaning the trade agreements of Dryl are extended to the Fright Zone.”

The Fright Zone first approached Entrapta about a trade deal after facing off against one of her laser cannons in a fight with one of the only villages that seemed interested in defending itself. The council of Dryl had been appalled at the notion, and told Entrapta that a political marriage to unite their kingdoms was the only possible way she could engage in weapons dealing with the Horde without losing her other allies - which apparently mattered, according to the annoying council. Even though they gave her the idea, they were shocked when Entrapta actually moved forward with it.

Dazzled by the advanced tech described in the trading proposal, she’d simply stolen one of their already impressive robots from a neighboring battle, made some extensive upgrades, and sent it back to the Fright Zone with a bow on its head and a message asking for Hordak’s lovely claw in marriage. Shadow Weaver had contacted her right away, mostly to laugh hard at her, and told Entrapta not to hold her breath, whatever that meant. However, after some dull back-and-forth between the council and the spooky lady, Lord Hordak signed the deal not long after, Octavia moved in, and now she and Hordak were well on their way to finally consummating their marriage. Things usually had a way of working out for her.

“Plus,” Octavia continued, “those territories may not be on board with everything the Horde does, but they have access to more resources than ever now. I haven’t heard any complaints.” Octavia narrowed her eyes at the blonde. “Besides, if anyone here is a traitor, it’s *you.* I watched you grow up, Adora. The Horde was good to you.”

“They weren't good to me! The Horde lied to me for my entire life!” Adora turned to Entrapta. “Princess Entrapta, please. Octavia does have a point, I grew up in the Horde. I know what it’s like.

They’re hurting innocent people. Hordak took me away from my family when I was just a baby. Who knows what else he’s capable of, or what he’s already done?”

Entrapta backed away, beyond overwhelmed with the conversation and the endless stares and whispers. “I don’t… I can’t…”

“Princess Entrapta,” Glimmer’s voice was softer now, and she pressed her hands together. “Please, reconsider your partnership with the Fright Zone, and join the Princess Alliance. We’re the good guys. Not *them* .” She looked pointedly at Octavia who glowered in response.

Entrapta shook her head rapidly, trying to clear her thoughts. “Good guys? What does that even mean?” The way Entrapta saw it, there were no good guys or bad guys, there was just whichever side you happened to be on, and even that mattered very little to her. She didn’t want to keep arguing, she just wanted to leave, but a long history of ostracization mixed with a couple of tiny drinks pushed her further. “As for your alliance, Dryl was never even invited to join the original Princess Alliance! No one saw a use for us because we didn’t have magic. No one was interested in our technology or our weapons. No one took us seriously. The Horde does.”

“I’m sorry that happened, I really am, but things will be different now,” Glimmer insisted. “The Horde - *Hordak* is just using you for your skills!”

“Isn’t that what you’re trying to do right now?” Entrapta managed to ask, although Glimmer’s words stabbed directly into barely closed wounds.

Glimmer’s eyes widened. “I- No! I’m just-”

“I’ve gotta go.” Entrapta rushed past her, blinking the tears out of her eyes. How had they managed to instill the same exact fear in her that Shadow Weaver had? Is that what everyone whispering

about her all night thought about their marriage? If so, they were all wrong. Hordak cared about her. She would go home to him and he would tell her so himself if she asked, she knew it.

Lost in thought, Entrapta nearly collided with Catra when she got to the base of the stairs. The usual smirk was absent from her face, and she gazed at Entrapta with an unusual expression. “I’ve been looking all over for you. Can we get out of here? Like, now?”

“Yep." Entrapta gave a stiff nod. "Let’s go.”

Octavia was right behind them, and grabbed two bottles of champagne in one hand and a few glasses in the other from the drink table without breaking her stride.

Chapter End Notes

Whoops, everyone is sad now.

I'd Be The Prom Queen If Crying Was a Contest

Chapter Summary

Super Pal Trio is leaving prom! Scorpia gets dumped, Catra gets dumped, Entrapta gets [CENSORED]

Chapter Notes

sfw :o)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“I couldn’t find Scorpia,” Catra was saying as they made their way out of the castle and towards the ship.

Octavia quickly volunteered to go back and look for her, but it proved to be unnecessary, as once they entered the ship, they spotted her curled up on the floor sleeping, several empty glasses beside her.

Catra immediately grabbed a champagne bottle from Octavia and settled into one of the passenger seats while Entapta went to check on Scorpia.

“Hey,” Entrapta whispered, prodding her lightly with a strand of hair. Scorpia stirred a bit, but didn’t open her eyes, which were smudged with mascara from where she’d evidently been crying. Entrapta’s heart ached for her, and she ran a tendril of hair through Scorpia’s own white locks. “Are you okay?”

“Why doesn’t she like me?” Scorpia whispered back so quietly Entrapta barely heard her.

Entrapta settled on the floor beside her and draped her hair over the girl’s large body like a blanket, hoping it would bring her at least a smidge of comfort. “I’m sorry, Scorpia,” she whispered, listening to Scorpia’s breathing slow as she let sleep reclaim her.

Octavia sat across from her on the ground and poured Entrapta a glass from the remaining champagne bottle. "Are *you* okay?"

"Yes. I guess so. Maybe." Entrapta shrugged. "Do you think they were right?"

"Of course not." Octavia's reply was without hesitation, which was a relief. "I won't pretend to know Lord Hordak at all, but he's always seemed like a straightforward, no-nonsense guy. If he only cared about what you can do for him, I doubt he'd, uh…Well, you know." She rubbed the back of her neck, giving the same look she gave whenever Entrapta went on a Hordak-gushing spree.

Entrapta sighed and took a drink. "They aren't the first ones to tell me that Hordak is using me. Shadow Weaver said the same thing. We've gotten so close lately, but I can't help but wonder-"

"Don't listen to Shadow Weaver." Entrapta was surprised to hear Catra speak, although only her tail remained visible from her place in the chair that was made for someone much larger. "Shadow Weaver is a bitter, jealous old hag. She'll say anything if she thinks it will benefit her." A short, humorless laugh came from the chair. "And sometimes, she'll say stuff just to mess with you for shits and giggles." Liquid sloshed as Catra drank from the bottle. "Don't get me wrong; I don't get what you see in Hordak either. But there's a reason he locked *her* up. So don't let her get in your head, okay?"

"I…Okay…" Entrapta was a bit taken aback. She'd suspected on more than one occasion that Catra didn't always like her, so the words of encouragement were unexpected. Nevertheless, it did make her feel a little better.

"What Adora said about him taking her away from her home is super weird, though," Octavia pondered, earning another shrug from Entrapta. She'd honestly forgotten that part of the conversation.

“Don’t mention Adora,” Catra slurred from her chair. “She picked them. She’s dead to me.”

“Oof, okay, everyone is being a real drag tonight,” Octavia muttered, casting the teen a quick glance before turning back to Entrapta. “Anyway, I’ve been with the Horde all my life too, and never once seen anyone kidnap a kid. What would we even do with them? It’d be a waste of good resources. And I mean, even if we did go around grabbing babies, Hordak has never been hands on, so I doubt he’d have anything to do with it. The princesses are no doubt just filling Adora’s head with garbage.”

“It was probably Shadow Weaver,” Catra offered. “She’s always out here ruining lives, so she probably thinks the earlier she gets her hands on them, the better. What. A. *Biiiitch*.” Octavia rose and tried to take the bottle Catra was spilling all over the chair, but received a hiss and a threat of claws, so instead she sat down in the driver’s seat out of Catra’s reach.

Entrapta supposed she should be more concerned over Hordak’s alleged war crimes, but her own morals had always been far from cleancut, and honestly, she just couldn’t be bothered to care about what he’d done in his past. Whether he was all the things they said - an evil colonizer, a vicious baby snatcher, a boat criminal - he was still her lab partner, and it didn’t change her feelings for him. Entrapta scowled into her nearly empty cup. Wait… Boat criminal? What was a boat criminal? Yep, definitely time to stop drinking. The point was, she knew who he was to her, how well he treated her, and she knew how much she was totally and ridiculously in love with him. She just hoped she could keep the nerve up to tell him so when they got back home.

“Well, it’s getting late.” Octavia turned her chair to the control panel. “Guess I’m the designated driver tonight.” She glanced back at Entrapta. “I’ll take you guys back to the Fright Zone before Lord Hordak sends half the Horde out looking for you. Buckle up, lovebird.”

Entrapta curled her hair tighter around the sleeping Scorpia, and feeling the teensiest bit spinny from the drinks, she settled in the hollow of Scorpia's curled knees.

A nearly empty bottle was raised from the passenger seat. "Love is a lie and friendship is a sham," Catra announced.

"Whatever you say, Catra," Octavia replied, navigating the ship out of the dock and into the night sky.

As their chatter quieted and they drove home in silence, Entrapta couldn't stop her insecurities from nibbling away at her wavering confidence. She'd been so certain after their night together that she was finally going to confess to him how she felt. But now, as the moment was a short flight away, she was having significant second thoughts. Did she really dare to risk what they had?

He heard a hiss, the sound of the door opening, and Hordak's attention snapped to it immediately. The tension plaguing him all evening lifted from his chest in a drawn-out exhale as he heard the familiar sound of boots much too large for the feet that wore them slowly approaching on the metal floor. *Entrapta.*

She'd told him she would see him that night, but as the evening hours drew into the early morning, he'd very nearly sent Cobalt after her when it was apparent neither of the young force captains planned on checking their datapad messages. However, to his great relief and even greater irritation, Force Commander Octavia contacted him to let him know she had her eyes on Entrapta. Hordak did not appreciate the phrasing, nor the fact that for whatever reason, she was apparently attending this event with Entrapta. He'd demanded to know why she wasn't at her post in Dryl, but she failed to respond after her initial message. Useless, the whole lot of them!

But none of that mattered now. Entrapta had returned to him as promised, and he couldn't be more eager to see her, as embarrassing as it was. He opened his mouth to teasingly voice

his surprise that she'd chosen the door instead of popping out of an air vent, but the barely formed words died in his throat as she sauntered into view.

His eyes widened into huge, glowing spheres, as though opening them wider would allow him to consume her with his gaze, keeping her to himself forever. She wore a purple dress that accentuated the soft curves of her chest and waist, with excess material tapering into a train that dragged the floor behind her. *Oh, to be a scrap of fabric trailing the ground at Entrapta's feet*, Hordak thought, well aware of just how pathetically lovestruck he'd become. Her hair was out of its usual pigtails and hung loosely down her back, like a cascading sea of lavender waves. It nearly felt wrong for the likes of him to even be looking at her, yet he was helpless to do otherwise.

Although he was too much of a coward to say it out loud, he'd always found her stunning at all times. The confidence she radiated when she was in dirty overalls, working beside him chattering away with brilliant ideas and solving all his problems was where he found her most beautiful. However, as she crossed the floor to him now, looking regal and somewhat shy, he found himself completely enraptured by her glow.

When she was at arm's length, he noticed the flush on her cheeks and how her steps were curiously unsteady. Was she ill? He was about to ask her if she was feeling alright when her arms encircled his waist, and only a hitched breath emitted from him as sparks flew through his body at her touch. She continued forward until she was flush against him, her face burying into his chest.

Still unused to physical affection and stupefied by her breathtaking appearance, Hordak's own arms hovered frozen by his sides as his body inadvertently tensed at the sudden contact; staring down at the crown of her head, he found it impossible to move.

In response to his tightened muscles, he felt Entrapta's body go frigid as well, and she immediately began to pull away from him.

He caught her expression as her face turned from his chest, and he could see embarrassment mixed with something else in her small features. “I’m sorry…” she murmured in slightly slurred words, and he spotted unshed tears shimmering in her magenta eyes.

His heart wrenched in his chest. Never had he seen her so vulnerable, so unsure, and unable to stand the sight, his brain finally caught up with him. He pulled her back against his body, his arms wrapping firmly around her, and he threaded his talons into her silky locks of hair as he cradled the back of her head, pressing her face against his chest once more.

She gasped before exhaling shakily, and it was a relief when her arms hesitantly returned to wrap around his waist. After what felt like a long moment, she seemed to relax, and she sank fully into his arms, sliding her hands up his back, grabbing fistfuls of his tabard and easing herself impossibly closer. It felt so right to simply hold her, and he swore there was an inexplicable warm, tingling sensation wherever their bodies were touching. Although they had been physical that very morning, this embrace felt much different; there was an unspoken intimacy between them in this moment that made Hordak’s face burn and his ears droop.

He felt her chest heave against him as she inhaled a shuddery breath, sniffling a little. Was she crying? He tightened his arms around her. Entrapta’s fists on his back clung tighter to him and he heard her whisper his name, strands of lavender hair curling over his fingers. He didn’t know the first thing about comforting another, but he had to try. Very slowly, his hand on the back of her head moved to cup her face, and he gingerly tilted her head back until she was looking up at him with sad, wet eyes.

“Entrapta,” he murmured softly, wiping away a tear with his thumb. “What happened?” Premature anger nearly overtook his concern. If someone had hurt her, he would ensure they would be very sorry.

She averted her eyes. "Would you still like me if I didn’t make weapons?"

He blinked. It was a bizarre question, but one he knew the answer to without having to even think. "Of course. I will always like you." More than like, too.

He was relieved that this seemed to abate her sadness at least in part, and she finally granted him a small smile, her cheeks growing rosier. She was far too adorable, and he couldn’t help but smile softly in return, love for her and the desire to erase her sorrow burning in his chest. Abruptly, she released his robe and moved her hands to his front, sliding them slowly up his chest, making him shudder. She nuzzled her face into his palm, and her eyes darkened in a way that made his heart beat faster. “I missed you, Hordak.”

Hordak's face burned, head spinning by the sudden change in her attitude. As he struggled with his response, something in the back of his flustered mind pieced together the flush of her face and the shakiness of her steps. “You are intoxicated,” he stated gently, loosening his hold on her.

Her smile faltered for just a moment before her hair began coiling up his arms. “Not so much that I don’t know exactly what I’m doing,” Entrapta replied, her voice taking on a determined edge. She tried to lift herself up to his height on her hair, but it gave out underneath her wobbly movements. He tightened his left arm around her waist to keep her from collapsing on the floor, his free hand moving to her upper back for extra support as he held her against him.

Due to their size difference, her feet hung in the open air and she tapped them together with a soft giggle. The tears in her eyes had dried, but her usual spark was still missing. She seemed to study him for a moment before reaching her arms up and wrapping them around his neck, pulling herself closer to his face.

“What are you doing?” Hordak asked in a low voice, although he knew. They moved in tandem as Entrapta hoisted herself closer; his arm around her waist gripped her more firmly while the other rested under her backside as she swung her legs up to wrap around his midsection. His right hand moved to her thigh, his fingers brushing bare skin where the dress fell away, and she released a sigh that he echoed at the contact. They stayed this way for a moment in heavy silence, and he found himself lost in her eyes, in her soft hair curling over his body, and in her skilled fingers pressing lightly into his shoulders.

Entrapta’s face was tantalizingly close to his own, and she looked him in the eyes, although she seemed uncertain of herself in spite of her bold actions. “Hordak,” she released his name in a breath, drawing another sigh from him as he leaned even closer, his name on her tongue beckoning him to her. His gaze flickered for a moment to her lips, and she seemed to notice, her eyes darting down shyly before she hid her face between his neck and the collar of his armor. He found her sudden and uncharacteristic nervosity unfairly endearing. “Can I kiss you?” The words were whispered against him so quickly he would've missed them had he not possessed such keen hearing.

While a great weight lifted from Hordak’s shoulders at her request, it seemed to settle in his stomach instead, nerves and excitement churning together, and he struggled to verbalize the one word that was screaming loudly in his useless brain. When he swallowed forcibly and at last regained his faculty of speech, he didn’t care how eager he sounded as he responded. “Yes.”

Entrapta perked up quickly to look at him with wide, sparkling eyes. “Really??” she squeaked excitedly, her face breaking into a grin.

Hordak chuckled softly at the immediate lift in her spirits. Had he somehow given her a reason to expect he would deny her? He would find time to be ashamed of himself later. “Yes, of course,” he replied. However, when she leaned in towards him, his

inexperience made him anxious. “What… What should I do?” His mouth suddenly felt very dry.

“Oh! Just close your eyes,” she informed him sweetly, a small hand running through his hair.

Hordak leaned into the touch, shutting his eyes tightly. As he prepared himself for the moment he’d been longing for, he inadvertently screwed his entire face into an ugly grimace, his lips peeling back with his teeth clenching together. He heard Entrapta release a huff of air, as though she were restraining a laugh, before he felt her gloved hand stroking the side of his face.

“Relax,” she whispered soothingly. Her hands disappeared from him for a moment and he heard the light rustling of clothing. Bare fingers returned to either side of his face quickly, her now ungloved skin meeting his and he felt himself sigh blissfully at the contact.

She slid her thumbs slowly over his face, as though she were mapping out his features. He felt her breath against his skin and he longed to share it with her, but was grateful she was taking control. Her thumbs began softly stroking the outer edges of his prominent brow, moving in tandem until they met in the middle at his forehead. They trailed lightly down the thin bridge of his nose until they separated to brush across the grooves on either side of his face.

The movements were mesmerizing. He’d never known such gentle touches were possible, and they were certainly never meant for him. He felt the tension leave not only his face, but every muscle in his body melted as she continued caressing him. Her lips soon followed her fingers, placing barely-there kisses across his face, and he murmured her name in response, knowing it was with reverence but not caring; she deserved every ounce of his devotion. She made him feel so cared for, so valued, and he knew he couldn’t go back to a life without her. Overwhelmed by his feelings, he could bear the distance between them no longer and

just as he was about to push himself forward to find more of her, he finally felt her mouth on his own.

Everything he'd been working for, everything he thought he wanted was nothing compared to the moment their lips met. Nothing beyond this moment mattered; there was only Entrapta. She was gentle and tentative, and the first kiss was nothing but a delicate press of her lips to his. She pulled back quickly, *too* quickly, and with a whine he couldn't be bothered to feel embarrassed by, he lunged forward to feel her again.

He mimicked her movements as they kissed again, Hordak angling his lips over hers softly, melting into her, needing whatever she would give him. Whether it was confidence or desperation, Hordak couldn't say, but he found himself cradling the back of her head once more to crush her mouth harder against his, and she hummed in apparent approval, the sound piercing right to his very center.

His talons stroked through her hair while one of her petite hands cupped his jaw, the fingers of her other hand toying with one of his ears. He'd started purring, and his stomach fluttered insistently as he felt her smile against his mouth at the sound. He didn't know how long they held onto one another, but neither could stand to be apart for long, and no sooner would one kiss end then another would begin, their lips continuing to meet over and over again, unhurried and savoring. He was under her spell, he'd belonged to her since the moment they met, and he would belong to her forever more, Prime be damned.

As they broke apart once more, he exhaled her name, and this time he pulled back from her just enough to look her in the eyes. "What do you want from me?" he whispered, baffled as to what this brilliant, beautiful woman was doing anywhere near him.

Her legs unlaced from his waist and with great reluctance, he let her slip down to stand on her feet. "Hordak…" she murmured, and her eyes bore into his. One of her hands drifted over the purple crystal she'd gifted him with the life-changing armor, and her gaze

followed the path. She traced over the engravings etched onto the surface with a finger. “I really…”

She took a deep breath and seemed to brace herself, and Hordak placed his hand over her own on top of the crystal, waiting for her to continue, hoping with all his might she was going to say what he himself planned on saying.

Her breathing increased. “Um,” she stammered, “I…”

He furrowed his brow, noticing a sheen of sweat coating her skin. “Entrapta, are you al-

Hordak didn’t get to finish his question, because at that moment, Entrapta bent her head and expelled the contents of her stomach onto his polished metal sabatons.

Chapter End Notes

> My deepest apologies to Scorpia, I didn't mean to hurt you baby girl.

The Poor Groom's Bride is a Whore

Chapter Summary

Hopeful bats. Hateful rats. Hungover cats.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Entrapta generally seemed to possess no shame, something Hordak had grown to deeply admire about her. However, for the first time that he could recall, she was positively mortified and refused to look at him, keeping her face which was ablaze with a bright blush buried against him and her stream of endless apologies muffled into his chest. Hordak bit back the small laugh that wanted to escape, but couldn’t help smiling fondly at her frazzled, needless reactions.

"It is quite alright," he assured her for the twelfth time. He'd been covered in much worse, and if Imp had a say in things, this certainly wouldn’t be the last time.

He'd stepped out of his shoes, leaving them in the sanctum and was carrying Entrapta to her quarters, despite her insistence that she could walk. He'd desperately wanted to keep her with him through the night, to ensure she was feeling better and to just be close to her after the intimacy they'd just shared. Unfortunately, he'd gotten overzealous in his plans to extend his living area earlier that day, and his bedroom practically didn't exist anymore. It made no difference to him if he was sleeping on a too-small mattress on the floor among rubble, but Entrapta deserved much better.

He kissed the top of her head and it seemed to soothe her, a small sigh escaping her. "Do you remember back when we first met?" She asked after a moment, fidgeting with her fingers before tracing the red wings of the Horde emblem on his chest. "When we went into the mines in Dryl?"

Hordak chuckled. When she had faced off against giant monsters for the sake of technology and good-naturedly lost. It had been as infuriating as it was impressive. And then he'd all but dragged her out of the cave to boundless chatter he was a fool not to appreciate right away. How could he forget? "Of course I do."

"I've dreamed about you carrying me like this ever since then." She giggled. "This is nice, despite the circumstances."

Now it was Hordak's turn to be embarrassed, remembering how he'd slung her around like she was a bag of old ration bars. Now he could hold her to him, caress her soft body and treasure her as she deserved. He squeezed her tighter to him. They'd come such a long way since then.

Once in her room, he deposited her gently on the bed and fetched her some water and a wet rag as she'd done for him all those months ago when she'd found him ill on his throne. His heart swelled at the memory of her tenderness. When he turned back to the bed, she was pulling her dress over her head. His face heated up and he longed to keep watching, but it seemed inappropriate in this scenario, so he turned his eyes away respectfully.

When he heard her climb beneath the covers, he approached and sat on the edge of the bed, handing her the rag and setting the glass on her bedside table. She groaned as she covered her face with the cool cloth, burying further beneath the blanket, he assumed to hide from him. At the sound of a yawn, he took it as his queue that he should take his leave.

"Goodnight, Entrapta," he murmured. However, before he could rise, a tiny hand shot out from beneath the blankets and tightened around as much of his wrist as she could.

"Hordak, wait." Her voice was tired and small, and he could only see the crown of her head peeking from beneath her covers. "I wanna ask you something.” She paused when he settled back on the bed, but only silence followed, and for a moment he thought

she’d already fallen asleep. Her next words were spoken quickly in a single exhale of breath. “What if we didn’t rush to finish the portal machine?”

He froze, and could swear he could hear his pulse in his ears. Had she figured out what opening the portal meant for him? Did she know that's why he hadn't attempted to repair the machine since it blew up? He cleared his throat. “Ah…I am uncertain what you mean.”

She shifted towards him, only the top half of her face visible, and she stared at him with wide magenta eyes full of meaning. "What if we just kept working on it until it was perfect?" His heart stopped. Until it was perfect. But she didn’t believe in perfection. And she certainly didn’t believe in delaying progress. Was she saying what he thought she was saying?

Hordak slowly dropped to his knees beside the bed so he could lean closer to her, and he took her hand from his wrist and held it tightly. His previously stopped heart was now hammering so hard in his withered chest he was certain she'd be able to hear it. If she was asking him to stay on this primitive planet, he would do so gladly if it meant he could spend the rest of his days by her side. “I think that is an excellent idea.”

Her eyes crinkled at him, and he knew she was smiling at him beneath the covers. They stayed like this for a moment, gazing at one another in comfortable silence that was heavy with significance, until her eyes slowly closed and sleep took her. Hordak kissed her hand which he'd been gripping a bit too hard and continued watching her for a bit as she slept. She wanted him to stay with her. She wanted *him*. And he wouldn’t let anything, anything at all, keep them apart.

Shadow Weaver was going to rip them apart if it was the last thing she did. She paced impatiently along her cell as she plotted how to make her escape. She was no longer allowed access to the

Black Garnet, so she would have to get her hands on some other sort of magical conduit.

She was startled from her plotting as a tray filled with mushed up ration bars was flung into her cell, the contents splattering the walls and floor haphazardly. She smirked beneath her mask as Catra cringed at the sound, regret at her own noisy action clear in her freckled face.

"Good morning, sunshine," Shadow Weaver crooned louder than necessary, delighted as Catra winced again, her ears flicking irritably. "Feeling a bit under the weather this morning, are we?" She knew a hangover when she saw one.

Catra simply sneered at her. "Well, we can't all have your magically regenerating liver, can we?"

Shadow Weaver stooped down and began cleaning up the contents of the tray and was pleased to see that Catra still brought her a copy of *The Etherian Daily News*, despite the girl's animosity towards her. As she slowly rotted away in the prison she'd helped build, Shadow Weaver still couldn't help but enjoy her indulgence in the tabloids. Plucking the paper from the ground, she eyed the front page. "Ah, your little party made the news. Did you and Adora have a grand time?" She turned to look dramatically around Catra, eyes shifting. "Why, Catra, where is she?" Her surprised tone was dripping with mockery. "You were so very certain you would be bringing her back with you." She tsked.

Catra grit her teeth and flexed her claws, tail flicking erratically. "Whatever. I still got closer than you ever did, didn't I? Enjoy your breakfast, I added a little something special in there for you today. Maybe you'll have better luck finding the metal shavings than you will in finding a way out of that box."

Shadow Weaver settled uncomfortably on the floor as she unfolded the paper, listening with disinterest to Catra's fading footsteps. The stories were certain to be chock full of the excessive dramatics of the Princess Prom, most likely including

however Catra had managed to embarrass herself in front of Adora. Foolish girl. But as she scanned the page, she spotted something much, *much* more enticing. “Giving up so soon?” Her voice echoed into the walkway in front of her cell, and she heard Catra pause.

“What are you talking about?” Annoyed, yet intrigued. Good.

“I told you before, did I not?” Shadow Weaver did her best to use a more patient tone. “Winning can be tedious.” Slow, hesitant footprints were growing louder once again. “If you still want Adora back, I have a plan. But I need your help.”

Catra appeared before her once more, although she kept her distance. “And why should I help you?” She folded her arms defiantly. “I bet you don’t even have a plan. This is just another one of your games, and I’m not falling for it. Besides…” Catra frowned. “Adora made her choice. She doesn’t want to be here. Why should I waste anymore of my time?”

Distinct sadness marred Catra’s features, as much as she tried to hide it behind a mask of anger. Catra had always reminded her of Hordak, in that way. Perhaps it was why Shadow Weaver had always found her so irritating. “Adora is simply confused, deceived by the princesses' illusions. If you help me, I can communicate with her using magic.” Shadow Weaver had no intention of contacting Adora if this worked, not yet. But Catra didn’t need to know that. “I can reveal to her how severely she is being deceived.” She’d risen and walked closer to the partition. “I know Adora dreamed of ruling the Horde with you by her side. I can help make that a reality.”

“Oh, so that’s how I fit into your plan? As Adora’s sidekick?” Catra hissed. “And who is really pulling the strings, huh? You?”

Shadow Weaver sighed deeply. Yes, that was exactly right. “Catra, I am tired. I am old. Too old to be a ruler,” she lied. “I simply do not wish to see Hordak continue sullying the Horde with his monumental failures before he loses this war for good. I want

what is best for both you and Adora, and what is best for the Horde." And most importantly, what was best for Shadow Weaver.

Catra huffed and shuffled her feet. She wasn't so easily won over this time. Perhaps Shadow Weaver shouldn't have filled her bunk with fleas so many times. Hindsight is always twenty-twenty. Catra moved closer, but her skeptical frown remained unwavering. "*If* I decide to help you, what exactly would I have to do?"

Shadow Weaver smiled beneath her mask. "I need you to bring me my old Sorcerer's Guild badge to create the bridge to communicate with Adora. Secondly, I need you to distract Hordak." He was counting down the seconds until he sent her to Beast Island, the old bastard. "I'm uncertain how long it will take to reach Adora, and Hordak has guards reporting my activity to him every hour." Catra herself was on the rotation, so that wasn't an issue. It was the rest that would pose a problem.

A scoff left Catra and she wrinkled her nose in possible disgust. "I think Entrapta has him *plenty* distracted."

"Perhaps." Shadow Weaver held up the news article for Catra to see. "But I think it best we ensure he stays that way."

Cata scanned it quickly, shaking her head. "No way. Forget it. I'm not doing that to her."

"Oh don't get soft, Catra," Shadow Weaver insisted. "She is a princess. She has plenty of other toys to play with." Including *her* runestone, she thought bitterly. "It's her, or us. Which will it be?"

The girl's eyes narrowed, but with a sigh of defeat, she lowered the partition just long enough to snatch the paper in her claws. "Don't ever ask me for anything else. This is the last thing I'm ever going to do for you." With the closing of the prison door, Shadow Weaver's escape was finally in motion.

Entrapta normally would've been in the lab by now, but Hordak imagined she was especially tired after her late night and turned

stomach. He hadn't been able to rest after their intimate moment followed by confessions of their shared desire to prolong the portal project indefinitely, and as horrid as the word was, he felt nearly - dare he say - *giddy*. He, Lord Hordak, positively *giddy!* Disgusting! Just accepting this foreign emotion made his face screw up in annoyance, and he felt better with the scowl in place. He'd been smiling far too much lately, and it made his face ache.

For the hundredth time since yesterday, he reached up to touch his lips, somehow surprised that they were as dry and thin as they always had been; he almost expected them to feel different, given the phantom tingles that lingered upon their surface since the first kisses he'd shared with Entrapta. Shaking his head to clear the bizarre, nonsensical feelings, he continued his work. Her words had reenergized him, and he'd made significant progress on reconstruction of the sleeping quarters he desperately hoped would soon house more than just himself and occasionally Imp.

Although, perhaps he should've asked if she would prefer they reside in Dryl? She did travel there fairly often and always spoke fondly of it. Traversing the mountains for long periods of time would be rough on his body, but with the new armor, he could adapt. He'd live anywhere, so long as they were together. Of course, this was assuming she wanted to share a space with him in such a way at all. He swallowed. A large assumption at that, even after last night. As implied as he believed they'd left things, things were still just that: Implied. They hadn't confessed to any concrete feelings, after all. Entrapta wasn't good at deciphering implications, and he wasn't the best at it himself. No matter, things would be clarified as soon as Entrapta arrived for the day.

Trying to shake off the doubt, Hordak walked into the sanctum through the massive hole in his bedroom wall to grab some more materials, eyeing the remains of the portal machine as he did so. He supposed they would get back to it, eventually. He knew she still wanted to see the stars, and truth be told, he'd missed them as well. Surely, with plans to take all the time they needed, they could figure out a way to do it safely, without sending a signal to

Horde Prime. He felt he could accomplish anything so long as he had the universe's brightest being by his side.

A downright dreamy sigh left him, and he was annoyed further by the sound, despite how happy he was. Still, he indulged deeper in the fantasies he no longer considered that far out of reach about living with Entrapta as though she were truly his wife in a romantic sense, not just his political ally. He had come to see her that way already, after all, although he couldn't say when he'd first done so. The progression had felt so natural he hadn't even realized it, and Hordak couldn't imagine going back to a life without her. He frowned in his search for his welding tools. Now where did that wife of his put his equipment?

While he searched, his head turned to darker thoughts as he recounted more about last night. When Entrapta arrived, if she was willing to discuss it, he'd still need to uncover the mystery of who had caused her such tears and sorrow at the party so that he could kill them. Or at the very least send them tiny bombs baked into those little cupcakes Entrapta liked so much. Indeed, no one would dare to insult Lord Hordak's precious wife without paying severely! As her husband, he would do whatever it took to protect her honor. Because they were married! Although surely a marriage contract ought to have a vow about not moving your spouse's tools quite so much. "Ah, there you are," Hordak murmured once he finally spotted his target.

He strode across the sanctum, while possibly pretending he were strolling arm in arm with his lovely wife through the mountains of Dryl, when he eyed a peculiar stack of papers next to his welding tools on top of the workbench in the corner. Blueprints on grey paper? He cocked his head and picked it up. No, not blueprints, they were tabloids that he'd rolled his eyes at from time to time the few times he'd spotted them littered about the Fright Zone. Curious. Surely Entrapta, who was his wife, didn't read this nonsense, did she? His wife was much too busy for such rubbish! His wife was too good to soil her brain with mindless gossip! His wife was too brilliant to waste her time! His wife was…

Hordak gripped the paper so hard his knuckles turned as white as his face, his claws tearing shreds from the edges. *His wife was a conniving little minx.*

The Etherian Daily News

Vol. 0124 - No. 0218 | Morning Edition | Priced at 0.5 Buckmoons

CALLOUS CAD CAUGHT GETTING CUCKED?

We Were Unaware of Lord Hordak's Whereabouts When His Newly Wed Wife Was Witnessed Waltzing With Another!



PICTURED IS THE UNPREDICTED PAIR PARTYING AT PRINCESS PROM!

Could this present problems, and proof prenups are positive? Or perhaps the princess and the perpetator participate in polygamy!

Full story on page 1.

HAVE YOU SEEN MY BOAT?

I docked my ship in Seaworthy last week before a round of ale with the fellows. The fellows didn't show up, so I had to drink all the rounds myself, and haven't seen her since. If you spot her, please contact Princess Mermista for a reward. Attached you will find a picture of my heartache. I am usually much more handsome.



SWIFT WIND'S MAGIC APPLE CIDER

Available now in Brightmoon stables!

Disclaimer: Swift Wind's Magic Apple Cider contains no actual magic.



I'm looking for the goddess. Are you the goddess? Who's the goddess? A goddess is a woman, the woman, it's all women. Find me in the Crimson Waste.

GRAND OPENING!

Alternative fashion store
SPICY SUBJECT
Now open!!!
(Notice: Please do not flirt with staff, they are very shy. Thanks, Management)



EMBARRASSING PHOTOS OF THE QUEEN LEAKED!

Full spread from Astacey Pellasay on page 6



ENCHANTED GROVE'S FARSIGHT EXTRAVAGANZA CANCELED

Due to unforeseen circumstances, the Farsight Extravaganza is canceled indefinitely. NO REFUNDS!!!

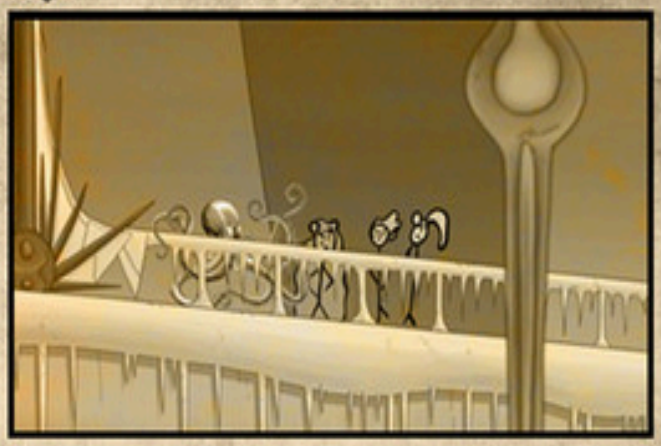
Additionally, we are seeking to hire new talent as well as a new lawyer. Call to apply.

Alt text: CALLOUS CAD CAUGHT GETTING CUCKED? We Were Unaware of Lord Hordak's Whereabouts When His Newly Wed Wife Was Witnessed Waltzing With Another! PICTURED IS THE UNPREDICTED PAIR PARTYING AT PRINCESS PROM! Could this present problems, and proof prenups are positive? Or perhaps the princess and the perpetator participate in polygamy!

Vol. 0124 - No. 0218 Morning Edition Priced at 0.5 Buckmoons

The elusive Princess Entrapta of Dryl, who was recently discovered to have wed the horribly horrendous Lord Hordak, arrived at Princess Prom without her haggard and hateful husband.

Things soon heated up for her, however, when she took to the dancefloor with who we can only assume is Dryl's ambassador. This is not the first time Princess Entrapta has been spotted entertaining bestial guests since her alliance with the Horde. Whether Lord Hordak knows or cares about her extramarital affairs remains a mystery.



It was all hair and tentacles until a conveniently loud argument broke out between Princesses Entrapta and Glimmer, bringing an evening of blooming romance to an abrupt end. When asked for comment, Princess Glimmer indicated she is not giving up on including Dryl in the rebellion.

With Lord Hordak's absence, Dryl's stance on joining the newly formed Princess Alliance and the nature of the relationship between Princess Entrapta and her newest flame is unknown. One thing is for certain, however: Lord Hordak is predicted to lose both the war and his wife very soon.

Alt text: The elusive Princess Entrapta of Dryl, who was recently discovered to have wed the horribly horrendous Lord Hordak, arrived at Princess Prom without her haggard and hateful husband. Things soon heated up for her, however, when she took to the dancefloor with who we can only assume is Dryl's ambassador. This is not the first time Princess Entrapta has been spotted entertaining bestial guests since her alliance with the Horde. Whether Lord Hordak knows or cares about her extramarital affairs remains a mystery. It was all hair and tentacles until a conveniently loud argument broke out between Princesses Entrapta and Glimmer, bringing an evening of blooming romance to an abrupt end. When asked for comment, Princess Glimmer indicated she is not giving up on including Dryl in the rebellion. With Lord Hordak's absence, Dryl's stance on joining the newly formed Princess Alliance and the nature of the relationship between Princess Entrapta and her newest flame is unknown. One thing is for certain, however: Lord Hordak is predicted to lose both the war and his wife very soon.

Chapter End Notes

After all, why not? Why shouldn't I shitpost my own story? Also I'm not fixing any typos!!! You'll take them and you'll like them!!!

She Wants The D(ivorce)

Chapter Summary

When in doubt, scream "Get out!"

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Entrapta awoke later than she would've liked, but was feeling much better. Warm feelings from the night before flooded her body, and she could barely get a hold of herself long enough to take a shower and get dressed before she was flying through the vents at record speeds towards the sanctum. *He said he'd stay*. Well, sort of. He said he wanted to take his time on the portal machine, but she was fairly certain he'd gotten her meaning. The vents practically vibrated with her energy, and she wanted nothing more than to throw herself into Hordak's arms, kiss him senseless, and tell him how much she loved him. And she intended to do just that.

She didn't even attempt a soft landing, instead letting herself drop to the floor carelessly. She'd hardly made contact with the ground, however, before she was on her feet and on the prowl for her lab partner. "Hordak?" Nerves mixed into her excitement. Why wasn't he here? She'd hoped he would be just as eager to see her as she was to see him. "Oh, Hordak!" She rounded the vitrines to see he had his hands planted firmly on a workbench, his upper body leaning over something, looking very studious.

She frowned when he didn't look up at her. "Hey, whatcha working on there? Looks serious." In a few more quick strides, she'd reached the table, and to her surprise, he visibly flinched. She lifted up on her hair to look over his shoulder, but all she saw was a newspaper. "Somebody die?" she asked, cocking her head.

Slowly, he inclined his face towards her, his red eyes fierce, brow tense. "I see you had a nice time," he spat, flinging the

newspaper at her and stomping away with a growl.

“What?” She skimmed the page, but didn’t see anything to cause his sudden outburst. “Are you mad at me?”

He didn’t answer, instead choosing to say something else cryptic. “You must think yourself quite clever, deceiving me as you have all this time.” He still had his back to her as he leaned dramatically on another workbench.

She raised a brow. “I have no idea what you’re talking about.” Cautiously, she approached him again. What in the world had happened between last night and now? He’d been prone to grumpy mood swings in the past, but weren’t things different now?

“I am talking about *this!”* Hordak snatched the paper from her hair and jabbed a finger at a picture of her and Octavia. “Does it amuse you to make me look like a fool in front of your fellow princesses?”

Entrapta’s head spun, trying to parse what was happening. Apparently they weren’t past the grumpy mood swings after all. Was he upset she’d danced for two seconds with Octavia? But what did he mean by deceiving him in front of the princesses? Before she could ask for clarification, he threw another confusing question at her.

“Tell me. Is it true?” he asked, finally looking at her. His face had an odd expression she hadn’t seen on him before - angry, sure, that was an easy-to-read Hordak classic, but there was something else she couldn't quite decipher. “Is it true you had… *partners* during our union?”

Entrapta managed to skim some of the article as he continued gripping the paper, although he was practically shaking. “‘Extramarital affairs’?” she murmured as she read. Oh, so this is why he was so crabby! She could've cleared up this whole mess had he simply talked to her before getting himself all worked up!

"Yes, I certainly did!" Entrapta confessed, relieved they could put this behind them.

Hordaks face, however, distorted into what she guessed was dismay. "*When?*"

"Hmmm, it's hard to say, exactly! There were several. They were right around the time we got married, I suppose." She didn't think it was fair to call them "extramarital affairs", seeing as the handful of flings happened *way* before she'd met him. In fact, the moment he'd fallen into her trap in Dryl, she'd lost her taste for others nearly instantaneously. Unfortunately, Hordak didn't give her the chance to tell him so.

He didn't address her explanation, instead changing the subject again. "Well, what do you call this little stunt, then? You looked quite comfortable with Force Commander Octavia last night, in front of my enemies," he snapped. "I see you've even given her the sigil of your kingdom."

Entrapta stared wide-eyed, still struggling to adapt to the harsh shift between them. She was hurt by his behavior and rash assumptions, yet she was also getting pretty annoyed that he was being so pissy. He was just jumping to random conclusions and yelling at her before he even tried to talk to her rationally. It reminded her too much of her interactions with the princesses last night, and anger of her own boiled in her chest. "Hordak, it's a stupid *pin.* I don't even know where she got it! Why are you so upset?"

"I am not *upset!* " he roared, clearly upset. Sharp talons shredded the paper above his head, and Entrapta could only gawk at him stupefied through the curtain of greyscale confetti that rained from above. "I merely wish that you would *think* for a brief second about how your flippant actions reflect upon my empire." His words were growled through clenching teeth.

Beyond exasperated, Entrapta threw her own hands up in the air and felt her hair frizzing up irritably. "What the fuck are you

talking about??" she shouted back at him.

He'd begun stomp-pacing back and forth, pausing only to glare down at her. "You engaged in alliance conversations with the *heir to Brightmoon*." Was he seriously changing the subject *again* ? It was as though he were looking for any flimsy excuse to be angry at her! "How do you think that makes me look, Entrapta?"

"I don't think it makes you look like anything, seeing as you weren't there. It had nothing to do with you! And I wasn't even-"

"You are wrong." He interrupted her, which he'd not done often. "Any scenario you place yourself in is a direct reflection of the Fright Zone given your status. Dryl is supposed to be the Horde's partner, our greatest ally." His words came out raspy, perhaps from all the yelling; he was a bit out of practice. "You entertaining a conversation with the rebellion will make them question our-" their eyes met for a moment before he quickly looked away. " *My* empire's stability." Entrapta started to protest, but he continued. "Furthermore, Force Commander Octavia had no right to appoint herself as Dryl's representative. Since she clearly believes she can undermine my authority, I will be removing her from Dryl entirely."

"Oh, no you won't." Entrapta frowned up at him. "If you want to be mad at me over nothing, that's between us. Octavia didn't do anything wrong." After all the emotional twists and turns, she wasn't sure she could get through much more of this conversation without crying, but she wasn't going to let him take out his tantrum on her friends.

"Commander Octavia is *my* subordinate, and I will reassign her as I see fit," he answered with a sneer. "She has gotten too familiar with you and I will see to it she knows her place. You will not speak to her again."

Entrapta huffed, brows raising. "Excuse me?"

"While we are on the subject, you are not to speak to the princesses either." Hordak turned up his nasal ridge as he spun

away from her, walking off seemingly towards nothing.

“You’re not my boss, Hordak,” she called after him, sounding sadder than she intended to, and he stopped in his tracks. “You’re my *partner.* At least, that’s what I thought we were.” She knew he was worse at emotions than even she was, but that was no excuse for him to be a total jerk. And what awful timing, too! They’d had such a lovely night together, and now he was spoiling it.

He turned back towards her, finally looking at her again. “I did not mean-”

“And I’m going to talk to whoever I want to talk to.” As exhausted as she was, they were settling this now. “It’s not a big deal to me, but I’m still a princess. I still have other alliances. Which means I’m probably gonna have to talk to the other princesses for some reason or another. And Octavia is my friend.” He narrowed his eyes, but she tried not to let it deter her. “And I’m going to talk to her as much as I want.”

“If that is what you wish," Hordak said in a detached voice. "But seeing as Dryl belongs to me, she will need to atone for undermining my authority and taking what is rightfully mine.”

Entrapta gaped at him, suddenly certain he was *not* talking about Dryl. “You don’t own Dryl, Hordak.” His eyes flashed at that, but she met his gaze defiantly. “And you definitely don’t own *me* .”

His eyes widened as he seemed to consider her words, and for a moment, she expected him to agree with her sound logic, and maybe even apologize for how harsh he’d been. However, his face suddenly hardened again and she was drastically unprepared for his next words. “Very well. If that is how you feel, perhaps it is best we go back to how things were.”

“What? Hold on a second.” No. No, no, no. This was just a fight! Couples had fights, she’d read all about it in her humanoid studies! She tried to fight the panic as she followed him when he

briskly walked past her, but she felt her throat constrict and eyes burn. They'd barely even gotten started, it couldn't be over this soon. Not over such a silly misunderstanding. She grabbed his wrist in a coil of hair. "I don't want that-"

He froze before jerking his hand free, the forcefulness of the maneuver causing her to flinch and take a step back in surprise. "We are done here." He didn't turn around as he spoke in an even voice. "Get out."

Moisture welled in her eyes, both from anger and disheartenment, and too tired to keep arguing, she did as he asked and clambered back into the vents. Part of her wanted to stay, to tell him how wrong he was, but he'd already shown her what he thought about her: she was apparently careless and clueless, undeserving of a calm discussion when there was a misunderstanding. She'd come to expect this of most everyone else, but she'd thought Hordak was the exception. He'd always seemed to understand her, but clearly she'd misread things, as usual.

As she neared her room, the anger ebbed away, leaving only heartbreak in its wake. She was breathing in ragged gasps by the time she landed on her feet, trying to will away the inevitable tears by pacing back and forth, running her fingers erratically through her hair. "He's just a guy," she muttered her old mantra to herself. "Just a guy. Just a guy." It was no good. Her eyes drifted to the floor where she'd discarded the dress she wore when they kissed for the first time and Entrapta promptly fell apart.

She felt the sweet caress of shadows roving over her weightless body, sending sparks of familiar power into her fingertips. The energy throughout her being felt unforgiving and raw in a way it hadn't since she was first learning the art of magic, but it was understandable given how weak she'd become. She knew her body would pay a heavy price for this spell, but as she felt her physical form stabilize, she couldn't stop the mirthful chuckle from spilling from her lips, although it was followed by a fit of coughing

and wheezing. *It worked!* She was free! Free from her cell, free from the Fright Zone and threats of Beast Island, and most importantly, free from ever having to see Hordak's hideous face and stupid, floppy ears ever again!

Her plan to deter Hordak's wrath by severing his ties to the princess worked better than she'd hoped, and it had been mere days after Catra brought her the badge that she was able to put her plan in motion. She had entertained briefly the idea of teleporting herself to Brightmoon to be with Adora, but ultimately decided to see how this whole Entrapta thing played out.

Once she was certain the incantation had concluded and she was fully in the mortal realm, Shadow Weaver rose from the ground with a groan and creaking joints to look at her surroundings. Her brows shot up in surprise when she was greeted with vast nothingness. Engulfed in darkness, she slowly, painstakingly walked forward with her arms extended, coming to a stop when she felt cool metal. Keeping one palm against the texture, she followed the path of what appeared to be steel bars. She wasn't certain how long she walked in circles before she finally came to a realization: Shadow Weaver was, once again, in a cage.

Chapter End Notes

I'm no longer proofreading, we die like men and fall like princes.

I'm Not Crying I'm Just Allergic to My New Eyeliner

Chapter Summary

> Hordak returns to an old habit, Shadow Weaver journeys to a new habitat, Entrapta tries to self-rehabilitate.

[Message sent: Force Commander, I am relieving you of your current duties effective immediately. Return to the Fright Zone for reassignment by the week's end. - Lord Hordak]

[Message received from Octavia: With all due respect, eat shit, dirtbag.]

Hordak glared at the message as he'd done periodically for the last two days, although he hadn't bothered responding. He could yell and scream and threaten severe punishment but…Well, what was the point? He'd considered dragging her back by the tentacles, but that would only further upset Entrapta. "Entrapta…" He sighed her name deeply, as he did every fifteen minutes or so. He'd fucked everything up.

"[Entrapta! Entrapta! Entrapta!]" The sound of her name in a multitude of voices filled his achingly empty sanctum, and Hordak swatted at his companion half-heartedly.

"I have told you countless times, she is gone! Now stop saying her name!" Hordak growled, although he himself couldn't keep her name off his tongue. Entrapta had returned to Dryl the day he'd confronted her, he presumed for good. Imp settled on the right armrest of the throne, gave Hordak a huge pout, and folded his little arms over his chest, deeply unhappy with Entrapta's abrupt absence. Hordak was deeply unhappy with it as well, although he knew it was for the best. Even if she'd returned his feelings, it would've been only a matter of time before she realized he had nothing to offer her except failure. He knew the heartbreak he was experiencing now would pale in comparison if she were to

leave him after they became further entwined. Surely his outburst had simply sped up the inevitable.

While he had convinced himself in the moment that his rage was justified, he was beginning to second-guess the quality of where he'd gotten his information from. It was just so very hard for him to conceive that a treasure such as Entrapta would ever truly want him when she had a world full of fellow royals and apparent suitors to choose from, so when he'd seen his fears printed out before his very eyes, he couldn't help but believe them. Still, Entrapta had never been anything but honest and genuine with him, and guilt over the encounter ate away at him. He'd been jealous and consumed by his own insecurities, so he reacted in the only way he knew how: uncontrollable and blindly misdirected rage, this time at the person who deserved it the least. After all she'd done for him! All the wonders she'd built, all the care she'd shown him, and this is how he chose to repay her. Had she even done anything wrong? He was certain she would never forgive him, and rightfully so.

He knew it was unfair to be upset that she'd had past lovers before they met, but he couldn't help but believe that if she compared him to the others, he'd come up severely lacking. Of course, this was nothing compared to how his heart stung when he thought about Entrapta in the arms of Octavia for all to see. Even if there was nothing ulterior going on, the Force Commander could be open and free with Entrapta in a way that he never could, and the knowledge filled him with unfathomable misery. Didn't Entrapta deserve to be with someone who could accompany her to pointless events and show her off, if that's what she wanted? Technically, he was supposed to do that himself at her coronation in the very near future, but he had no doubt he'd no longer be welcome. Perhaps he could find a loophole in Dryl's rules so he wouldn't have to be there to spoil things for her. Perhaps Octavia could fill in for him, he thought bitterly. Entrapta would probably prefer it.

He'd nearly contacted her many times to apologize, yet couldn't bring himself to do it. He wished so badly to talk things out with

her, to grovel for her forgiveness, but he was so ashamed of how he'd acted. He hadn't even allowed her a chance to explain before he'd blown up at her. Why had he done that? Why was he such a fucking fool? He sighed again, the pitiful noise reverberating off the walls, intensifying how very alone he was, and he sank ever further into the seat of his throne. He sniffed and wiped at his damp eyes again, paying no mind to his smeared makeup. It wasn't like he had a wife to try to look less ugly for anymore.

Trying to force thoughts of Entrapta from his mind for a bit, he decided to reflect upon his other recent shortcomings for a breath of fresh air. He'd gotten nothing done in the days since she departed, and he truly didn't care. The portal engine remained untouched, his quarters remained unfinished, and his gloom remained eternal, just as Prime intended. He should at the bare minimum be looking forward to the public sentencing of Shadow Weaver to Beast Island, but even that couldn't lift his nonexistent spirit. He groaned loudly and inelegantly, letting his body sag impossibly more so into the throne, as though the gravity of the situation were literally crushing him into the seat. His backside met open air as his horrid posture gave way, and he wondered if perhaps he'd fully fall out of the seat and down the steep stairs and die. That would be nice.

So heavily was he invested in his wallowing, he failed to hear footsteps approaching the throne room until the figure was in his peripheral. Hordak sneered, but gave a final wipe to his eyes and began heaving himself upright as Grizzlor and Cobalt quickly approached.

"Sir, we have an emergen- Uh…" Cobalt trailed off, eyeing the warlord up and down as Hordak lazily dragged his body into the throne from where he was halfway in the floor. "You doing okay, sir?" he asked.

"Yes," Hordak replied dryly, well aware he was fooling no one. "What is this so-called emergency? I'm very busy."

"We can see that," Cobalt muttered as the two arrived at the top of the stairs.

"My Lord, we're not sure how it happened, but Shadow Weaver has escaped," Grizzlor stated quickly.

That got Hordak's attention. "*What?"* He rose immediately to tower above the other men the best that he could, despite their similar heights and the knowledge that he looked, to say the very least, a tad unkempt. "For how long? How could you let this happen?" he snapped. Grizzlor had just *barely* been promoted and was already failing this extraordinarily? Hordak wasn't sure whether he was angrier at Grizzlor for letting her escape, or at himself for promoting such a blatant fool.

"Well, sir," Grizzlor looked more uncomfortable than afraid. "We're not sure when it happened. The surveillance logs for the entire week have been signed off as all clear, but we did some investigation, and there were no guards scheduled to check her cell for the past three days."

Hordak snarled, fury building deep in his chest. Disastrous as the situation was, it was admittedly refreshing to yell at someone again. The last person he'd yelled at had been Entrapta, and he desperately needed this palate cleanser. With that in mind, he didn't hold back. "What blundering, *idiotic failure* is responsible?" he roared at them, pleased when they flinched. "The consequences they will face will be like nothing the Fright Zone has ever seen. Immediate sentencing to Beast Island comes to mind."

Cobalt blinked. "Sir, I think that's a bit harsh. We don't know-"

"What we *know* is that *someone* allowed a prisoner with immense knowledge of our operations to slip out right from beneath us!" he bellowed, talons flexing and fangs flashing. "This is *unacceptable.* I want you to tell me what complete waste of space on this piece of excrement you fools call a planet is responsible for this monumental screw-up. I want a name and I want. It. *Now."*

The two men exchanged glances, and Hordak was just about to enthusiastically continue his full-blown rampage when Grizzlor finally answered him. "Uh, that would be *you*, sir."

"Autobio log, year 31, month 11: It's my sixth day back home in Dryl after the abrupt conclusion of my extended research project in the Fright Zone." Entrapta frowned into her recorder as she continued. " *Home…* Fascinating. Although I'm fully aware it's an illogical emotion, referring to Dryl as home feels wrong since I've returned. It's as though I'm missing part of the formula that changes a mere residential location to a place where one feels safe and whole."

Purple locks swooshed about as she shook her head to get back on track. "Despite the fact that the collaborative portal project was prematurely terminated with inconclusive data, my time with the Horde was extremely beneficial. I made huge leaps in expanding my knowledge of runestones, the wider universe beyond Etheria, and most importantly, my understanding of First One's Tech!" She smiled to herself. "And I'm not giving up on opening a portal. I now know enough to begin creating my own machine. The stars are out there, and I'm going to find them. In conclusion, I consider Component A of the project a huge success!"

A gloved thumb stroked over the buttons of the recorder gently, her smile fading. "Component B, however…" A soft inhale. "My continued attempts at obtaining prolonged and stable companionship remain a challenge. I…" A soft exhale. "I thought I'd finally figured it out with him. Whatever mythical, incomprehensible, intangible *thing* that needs to exist to connect two people together… I don't think I'll ever understand it like everyone else seems to, but I really thought we had it, whatever it is. I just don't understand what I did wrong."

She blinked rapidly and shook her head again. "It doesn't matter. Romantic relationships may be nonsensical, but data doesn't lie.

It’s clear from years of failed experiments that no amount of information I gather seems to have an impact on my lack of comprehension. Component B was a complete and total failure. No further analysis needed. End of log.”

Entrapta wiped at her red-rimmed eyes and tucked her recorder back into her pocket. When she felt like she could face Hordak again, verbally speaking, she would make sure that he still wanted to leave Etheria before she began work on her own portal machine. They’d been so close and she was sure she could figure it out, but she wouldn’t want to do it without him knowing. All he’d ever wanted was to go home, and if he still wanted to leave after all of this, she wouldn’t try to stop him.

She was still very heartbroken and angry at him for what he’d said to her, yet against every rationale, she feared she’d never stop loving or missing him. Nearly just as worrisome, what if she could never adapt to working alone again? Despite Hordak’s demands that she return, Octavia was staying, and as thrilled as Entrapta was to have her there as a friend and involuntary part-time lab assistant, she knew Octavia wasn’t interested in her work and it just wasn’t the same. Plus, Octavia was always so wary when Entrapta asked her to “pull the lever, then duck and cover”. Hordak would always do so without hesitation, even before he heard the potentially fatal consequences!

Entrapta began unpacking some of her still-boxed equipment as she did her best to steer her mind away from thoughts of Hordak. Perhaps she ought to hire some new scientifically-minded staff for the castle. People from the Maker’s Guild were always asking to team up, afterall. Her brow furrowed. Then again, maybe not - she’d tried to collaborate with guild members in the past, but they always went from over-the-top idealization of her to disappointed in a matter of hours once her struggles with social interactions surfaced. Probably best to not set herself up for more disappointment.

Maybe she should focus on the AI lab bots she’d been tinkering on between bigger projects. But then what if they learned to be more

human than she was and they got tired of her too? Entrapta groaned and flopped back against Emily, who was being particularly grumpy since the separation with Imp. This sucked! She just wanted Hordak back, as her partner in any way she could have him. It seemed just yesterday she'd first laid hungry eyes upon him as he roared and stomped around her dungeon, a bat in her trap. How did things get so fucked up? Why did he have to be such a jerk?

"Hm?" Entrapta bounced up as she caught sight of a strange reading on one of her monitors, quickly running over to it. Speaking of the dungeon, according to the castle's security feed, she had an unexpected visitor. "Who might you be?" she murmured, flicking a few buttons to bring up the video footage. Her eyes opened wide as the image appeared and she saw who her guest was. This week just kept getting worse and worse!

Entrapta grabbed her datapad and pinged Octavia's communicator. "Hi there!"

"Hey. You doing okay?" Octavia had taken to pitying her lately. Entrapta supposed she couldn't blame her, since she *had* sobbed all over her and all but begged Octavia to take her back to Dryl.

"Oh, sure, I'm just fine! But listen, do you remember that spooky lady from the Fright Zone?"

"Shadow Weaver? Unfortunately," came Octavia's wry reply.

"Well, she appears to be locked in the dungeon." Entrapta twirled a strand of hair absently. "What do you think I should do with her?"

"*What?!"* Octavia's voice was so loud, it made the speakers on Entrapta's datapad hiss and crackle. "Are you *sure?"*

"Mmm…" Entrapta squinted at the lanky form dressed in red. "Yep, that's definitely her."

“Fuck, why is it always something?” Octavia groaned. “Meet me in the entrance hall.”

“The east hall or the west hall?”

“The east hall.”

Entrapta tapped her chin. “I thinnnnk that’s the one with the deadly spikes. Maybe. I’ve been doing a LOT of tinkering, there’s really no way of keeping track of it all.”

There was a pause. “We’re not doing this again. Just meet me outside. We’ll go from there.”

Once they met up, after only a few near missteps away from being skewered into swiss cheese, Entrapta and Octavia descended the steps to the dungeon. “Since when is there a camera down there, anyway?” Octavia asked.

“Oh, for a *long* time now. Ever since the incident,” Entrapta answered. Octavia’s brow furrowed, but Entrapta didn’t give her the chance to elaborate on her question. With a clap of Entrapta’s hands as she entered the chamber, the lights came up, and pacing inside of the cage was Shadow Weaver. She paused and dropped into a kneeling position on the ground as soon as the two neared her.

“Oh, my Lady! Thank heavens you’re here,” Shadow Weaver wailed. “Please forgive me for intruding unannounced, but I didn’t know where else to turn. Due to all the misunderstandings between us, Hordak was going to send me to my death. But I knew you, in all your kindness, would never allow such a thing to happen.”

Entrapta nodded attentively throughout the bizarre speech, but as the woman kept droning on and on about Entrapta’s incredible leadership skills that she knew for a fact she didn’t possess and never would, she turned to Octavia. “What is she doing?” she whispered as Shadow Weaver continued her speech of unwarranted homage.

"Kissing ass," Octavia whispered back.

"Oooh, gotcha." It was slang even Entrapta was familiar with, although she couldn't recall being the target of it before now. It was fascinating, the things the spooky lady was making up. What did Entrapta even have to offer her? When Shadow Weaver began comparing Entrapta's hair to the founding winds of the planet, Entrapta finally interrupted. "Okay, I'm so sorry, but I left like seven burners on upstairs, so I'm gonna have to stop you." She ignored Octavia's look of horror. "So if you could briefly and concisely summarize the reason for your visit, that'd be super."

"Hordak is a monster and will be this planet's downfall." Entrapta let out a squeak as Shadow Weaver grabbed her forearms through the bars as she spoke. Octavia rushed forward, but Shadow Weaver continued. "He is failing the Horde. They do not trust him. But they trust *you."* Entrapta blinked. Aside from Hordak, she'd barely spoken to any of the Horde other than Octavia, Scorpia, and Catra. What the fuck was this lady talking about? "I was wrong to help Hordak all these years, and I would hate to see you make the same mistakes I did," Shadow Weaver went on. "We can change things, you and I. We can put a stop to all the fighting and chaos, we can build a better Horde! So please, let me stay here and serve you, my Lady. I can help you become the leader I know you can be."

Entrapta stared earnestly at her face - well, at her mask - as she thought about the situation. Her brow was furrowed, and her gaze fell on where Shadow Weaver was still gripping her arms through the bars when a sudden idea popped into her head. Entrapta knew what she was about to ask was a risky question, one that was probably best left a mystery, but in spite of everything she'd just heard, Entrapta asked it all the same. "Can I have a sample of this?"

Shadow Weaver released her. "I- Excuse me?"

"You appear to be leaking," Entrapta stated, pointing a strand of hair at the black, goopy shadows pooling beneath Shadow

Weaver. “And I want a sample to analyze.” She didn’t wait for an answer. Entrapta produced a vial from her pocket, scooped up some of the sludge creeping beneath the cell bars, and went on her merry way upstairs without another word.

“What do you want me to do about her?” Octavia called after her.

Entrapta shrugged. “Whatever you want, I guess!” Hordak hadn’t trusted Shadow Weaver, Catra hadn’t trusted Shadow Weaver, and Entrapta certainly didn’t trust Shadow Weaver or any of her weird lies.

Idiot. *Idiot!* He’d been so drunk on his own self-pity and sorrow, he’d mindlessly been checking the administrative boxes without making sure the work was actually complete. Fucking *failure!* Not only had he lost the woman he loved, he’d lost the woman he loathed as well. He put a task force together to interrogate damn near everyone, but no one had seen a trace of her, as though she vanished into nothing. Hordak prayed that the bowels of Etheria had opened up and swallowed her back inside whatever hell-spawn was responsible for her existence, but he knew realistically it had to be her damn black magic. However, how she managed the strength without access to the garnet, he was uncertain. Fucking *fool.*

How was he ever going to find her? Dammit all, she was running about (or in his wildest dreams, mangled and crawling about) with more knowledge of the Fright Zone than anyone else possessed. How could he have been so stupid? So mindless? So- What was that blasted ringing sound? Honestly, how was he meant to berate himself with all this unnecessary racket?

Finally piecing together that the sound was an incoming communication, he pressed the button to make the connection, expecting to see Grizzlor or Cobalt. But the last person he expected to see was-

“Hello, sir." *Force Commander Octavia*. "Misplaced anything lately?” Force Commander Octavia and *Shadow Weaver??*

Fashion Show At Lunch

Chapter Summary

> Hordak gets mountain fever, Entrapta has ceased being a griever, Octavia becomes an unwilling perceiver, author forgets about Shadow Weaver

Chapter Notes

> I'm not saying there's smut in this chapter, but if there were going to be smut, it would be after the double bars about 3/4 down, and I'd suggest those who aren't interested in smut turn away at that point, respectfully.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hordak's jaw dropped open at the sight of the rogue commander standing in Entrapta's dungeon with an oddly leaky Shadow Weaver behind her. "What are you doing with my prisoner?" he snapped. Had Entrapta captured her somehow? Was she harboring the witch to punish him for how he'd treated her? His brain informed him at once how ludicrous he was to accuse her of any such thing, but he apparently still wasn't in the realm of rational thought just yet. This sudden communication certainly wasn't helping matters.

Octavia arched a brow. "Well, she's in *our* cage, so I think that makes her *Dryl's* prisoner."

Hordak sneered, fresh pain seeping into his heart at how casual the commander was about her claims of sharing territory with Entrapta. "It appears you are once again forgetting your place, *soldier* ," he growled through gritted teeth, but Octavia seemed unfazed by the hint of demotion. "I suggest you return my prisoner immediately, lest I decide to have you join her on her trip to Beast Island."

Gone was the fear he could once instill in the commander by a simple look it seemed, and she frowned determinedly at him. “What the hell is the matter with you?”

His jaw hit the floor for a second time, and he somehow sensed it wouldn’t be the last. “How dare-”

Apparently no longer considering him her superior, Octavia had the gall to interrupt him. “You somehow luck into the sweetest, smartest girl caring about you, single-handedly upgrading your army, and you throw all that away for *what* exactly?”

“My personal affairs do not concern you,” he snapped, his already fiery temper quickly soaring at the reminder of his failure to remain in Entrapta’s favor, paired with the knowledge she’d clearly told Octavia about his shortcomings. “If you do not plan on discussing delivering the witch back to the Fright Zone, I will gladly take her back by force.”

“Oh, keep your skirt on,” Octavia replied curtly, and Hordak bared his teeth, not understanding the need to bring his attire into the conversation. “You’ll get Shadow Weaver back.”

“He will?” Shadow Weaver’s weak voice chimed in, the sound of her deep drawl souring his already foul mood faster than ever.

“But here’s what’s going to happen,” Octavia continued, ignoring the interruption. “You’re going to come to Dryl. You will apologize to Entrapta and you will go to her coronation.” The commander narrowed her eyes at him - the robotic prosthetic by Entrapta truly was remarkable, he noted with both fondness and annoyance. “Meet those conditions, and we can consider a transfer of the prisoner.”

Hordak drew himself up to his full height, ignorant of the fact Octavia couldn’t tell via the video feed, and gave her his best scathing glare. “Who do you think you are?” he growled. “Who exactly are *you* to be making demands of me?”

"The fucking ambassador of Dryl if the paper is anything to go by," she retorted. "I have it on good authority that a real stand-up article came out recently." Somewhere behind her, Shadow Weaver laughed.

"Ah, I see," Hordak replied coolly. "Was this part of an arrangement with the Princess of Brightmoon? Stealing my prisoner out from under me in some sort of deal with the rebellion?" He didn't think Entrapta would ever do such a thing, not truly, but he was apparently in a bad habit of vocalizing his worst fears, no matter how unrealistic he knew they might be.

Octavia's eyes widened. "*What* arrangement? Entrapta basically told that little cream puff where she could shove it. I swear, I don't know what she sees…" Octavia trailed off, but Hordak knew the intended ending of her sentence and shame burned throughout his core. "You know what, no. I'm not doing this. You can talk to Entrapta yourself when you get here. And actually fucking *listen*."

Hordak grimaced, more irritated that he knew she was right than he was at her flippant tone and complete disregard for the power dynamic between them. When he said nothing, Octavia sighed impatiently. "Do we have a deal, or what? If not, I'll be auctioning her off to the highest bidder." She turned to look behind her, addressing Shadow Weaver. "What do you think you'll go for? Word around the Horde is you must have more enemies than Lord Hordak himself," she muttered.

Hordak set his jaw a bit too hard as he considered her demands, feeling a tension headache coming on. He would never allow a subordinate to tell him what to do. Simply couldn't! He had his glowing reputation of evil to think of! However…this is exactly what he *wanted* to do, and if he could do it under the guise of it being part of a trade agreement, would it really appear so weak? And he did promise Entrapta he would attend her coronation. Circumstances might be different now, but if she didn't want him there, she could simply tell him to leave. He harrumphed as he focused back on the call. "Entrapta has agreed to this

arrangement?" Do not be pathetic. "Does she…" *Do not show vulnerability.* "Does she wish for me to attend?"

Octavia smirked at him. "Why don't you come find out for yourself?"

Useless, cocky little-! A loud hiss escaped him as he gripped his communicator too roughly, ignoring the sound of whatever snapped within. "I will consider your proposal." He ended the call without waiting for her to reply.

The echoes of Hordak's sabatons stomping heavier than necessary on the steel floor alerted Imp of his return to the sanctum, and the little clone barely made it out of the secret chair before Hordak collapsed into it. He'd been sleeping there since the destruction of his living quarters, and Imp couldn't be more pleased. Hordak had built them a sad little nest in the chair using the blue blanket Entrapta bundled him with all that time ago and the bedding he swiped from the room she'd stayed in that still smelled of her. So overall, he was on the upswing.

"We have been invited to Dryl," he told the boy, voice muffled into the pillow he was currently inhaling the scent of. Imp screeched excitedly in Hordak's ears at the news, nullifying any chances of staving off the impending headache. "Do not get ahead of yourself," Hordak scolded, lifting his head. "I've not yet decided whether we are going," he lied to both of them, turning up his nose with a grunt when Imp screeched again, this time in protest.

"[Entrapta?]" Imp insisted in Hordak's own needy voice, making him cringe.

"I do not even know if she wants me there," he grumbled, and did not pout even a fraction, despite his face feeling like it might be pouting. "I suppose I could call her."

Imp nodded enthusiastically.

"But perhaps I will wait for her to call me with the details. She is most likely very busy with preparations." In reality, Entrapta

probably wanted very little to do with the affair, but Hordak clung to the flimsy excuse nevertheless. Imp threw his hands up and kicked Hordak's shoe with his own tiny booted foot. Octavia already messaged him the information as soon as their call concluded, but if something changed, Entrapta might need to send him updates directly. It was entirely plausible. Definitely so! But what if… "Or what if it is a ruse!" Hordak declared, sitting up stiffly and gripping the pillow tightly - not *too* tightly however, he couldn't risk damaging it. "Another of Shadow Weaver's schemes! How dare they?"

["Idiot,"] Imp offered helpfully in Catra's voice, rolling his yellow eyes.

Hordak scowled for just a moment before sighing in defeat, deflating back against the chair and squeezing the pillow affectionately. "You are right, I am simply making needless excuses. I have awaited an opportunity, and now one has dropped itself into my lap. I would be a fool not to take it." He couldn't bring himself to admit to the boy how terrified he was that he'd be rejected.

Imp clapped his hands together, as Entrapta so often had. ["Don't be stupid!"] Cobalt's voice spilled from Imp's mouth, and while the boy could clearly be cruel, it was an effective peptalk. No matter how afraid he was, Hordak couldn't give up his last shot to be with Entrapta, while hopefully destroying Shadow Weaver in the process. He would gather up every last scrap of manners he'd stapled and glued together since meeting Entrapta and pray he could come up with a decent enough apology for her to forgive him, and maybe even give their marriage a real attempt, if she were willing.

"You are absolutely right. This could be my final chance, and I will not squander it. Thank you, little one." With the matter settled, Imp relaxed himself onto the pillow in Hordak's lap for well-earned scritches. Ordinarily, threading his talons through the boy's hair while Imp chirped appreciatively calmed Hordak's nerves like little else could, but he was now feeling monumentally high-strung.

The sharp claws of Hordak's free hand strummed anxiously on the threadbare chair while his mind drifted to the upcoming journey. Although he was determined to take full advantage of this opportunity, there was still one last thing that had been gnawing at him since Octavia mentioned his skirt. He looked down in exasperation at Imp's questioning gaze. "But what will I *wear?"*

Hordak, Cobalt, and Imp arrived in Dryl the morning of Entrapta's coronation. Grizzlor and Cobalt had made a fuss about wishing to join him to support Entrapta, but as second-in-command, Grizzlor needed to remain in the Fright Zone in Hordak's absence. Since both men were apparently three years old, Grizzlor insisted it was unfair that Cobalt got to go while he didn't, but when Cobalt mumbled something about "seeing the bet through to the end", Grizzlor rather cheerfully relented.

Prior to their departure, Hordak dug through all the old garments and adornments left behind from King Scorpio's dynasty. He flipped through more of Shadow Weaver's newspapers and magazines to see what sorts of things people were expected to wear to formal events, and even enlisted Imp to spy on any frivolous conversations around the Fright Zone about what the cadets thought to be fashionable. In the end, he had no idea what was considered appropriate attire to escort the love of your life to an extravagant event where she rightfully became a queen, and therefore Hordak arrived on Crypto Castle's doorstep with no less than ten overstuffed shipping containers of clothing and accessories.

As Hordak and Cobalt wheeled the last of the containers inside the lifeless castle, Cobalt gave him a peculiar smile. "Don't you think this is a bit forward, sir?"

Hordak frowned. "What are you implying?"

"She's going to think you're trying to move in." Cobalt gestured grandly to the large containers, which would've doubled Hordak's height had they all been stacked one on top of the other.

Hordak felt his face grow hot with both anger and embarrassment, but before he could get even one good threatening grunt out, Imp suddenly flew towards them down the hallway at record speeds shouting Entrapta's name in every voice he had a recording of. Hordak himself had looked around with zero subtlety as they'd crossed the threshold, but the entryway and the corridors leading to the guest rooms were empty, much to both Hordak's relief and disappointment.

"Octavia says to make ourselves comfortable," Cobalt said with a shrug as he looked up from his datapad. "She's in the middle of "a cupcake emergency", whatever that means."

Once dismissed with a disinterested wave of Hordak's claw, Cobalt went off to find Octavia despite her message, and Hordak found himself alone with Imp in the room they'd stayed in all those months ago, when Hordak first told Entrapta of the stars. With time to kill and nerves that were rapidly growing, Hordak shut the door and began digging through the shipping containers like a hyperactive racoon in a pile of trash.

"Stupid." A handful of clothes were thrown across the room. "Ugly!" An array of jewelry followed their path. "Out of date!" An entire container soared onto the bed, a stray kilt landing on Imp's head and knocking him out of the air mid-flight. By the time Hordak had tried on and rejected no less than 72 outfits and one tablecloth, he found himself fuming with his arms folded in a room that was no longer visible due to the amount of clothing piled on every surface. "This is ridiculous!" he barked in exasperation at the highly unimpressed Imp. "If I can't find something nice to wear, I'm not going."

Hordak *had* found a rather nice black coat. It had an elaborately high golden collar, a cascading widespread cape with a scalloped hem, and silk red lining embroidered with diamonds. It struck him as a much more luxurious version of the old cape with the steel collar he wore with his previous armor. However, he was certain no one - probably not even Entrapta - would want to see him

parading around the castle grounds flaunting nothing but a coat and a scowl.

He was just about to give up and give the curtains a try when Imp knocked a pile of accessories from the bed. They both watched as a small disc of bright cosmetic pigment rolled on the floor until it stopped at Hordak's feet. Stooping to pick it up, a wry smile creased Hordak's face as he read the label. "Ah," he murmured. "If I cannot find an ensemble, I'll make one instead."

Imp looked at Hordak like he'd grown a tail of his own, but Hordak was already hard at work with his makeup brushes.

When he finally was as presentable as he was going to be, Hordak and Imp stepped out into the hallway. Entrapta was nowhere in sight, but Hordak's eyes widened at the busy scene before them. The castle had been completely empty when they'd arrived early this morning, and aside from the assigned Horde soldiers, the castle had been widely vacant during his first visit as well. Now, however, it was bustling with an array of Dryl's civilians of varying species. While his appearance grabbed their attention for a moment, he was relieved they were ultimately uninterested in ogling the mysterious Lord Hordak, and they quickly went back to their business of pushing trays of dishes, hanging decorations, and generally getting in his way.

"That him?" he heard someone mutter as they waddled past him down the hall.

"I think so," came a disinterested reply. "I thought he'd be taller."

Hordak stared bewildered after them. Entrapta's claim that news traveled slowly in Dryl was a severe understatement if the princesses greatest enemy wasn't even recognizable to her people. Well, they'd all know him after tonight's ceremony when he stood before their newly crowned queen.

Hoping to speak with Entrapta before the main event, Hordak was just about to go hunt for her when Octavia and Cobalt emerged around the corner. Their brows shot up at the sight of him, and he felt more self conscious and exposed than ever.

"Lord Hordak." Octavia gave him a stiff nod, still looking at him in a funny way, but Hordak was too on edge to be annoyed. Somewhere far in the back of his mind, he knew he ought to demand to retrieve Shadow Weaver to save face after their heated conversation, but now that he was in her kingdom, he could think only of seeing Entrapta.

Octavia began leading them through the castle and explaining the timeline of events when they were abruptly cut off by a caravan of tiny gremlins pulling wagons laden with petite pastries. "Oh Entrapta must *love* this," Cobalt said dryly, voice dripping with sarcasm once their path was no longer blocked.

Octavia sighed. "She's been in hiding for days. Almost called the entire thing off, but I talked her into going through with it." Hordak narrowed his eyes, highly irritated that Octavia would push Entrapta into doing something she wasn't comfortable with. He hoped she was alright. "Dryl is pretty sparse in population, but the council seems to expect a high turnout and that spooked her. Seems basically no one except those old crones and codgers have ever seen Entrapta, and the townsfolk aren't convinced she exists." Cobalt snorted at this, and it earned a spark of amusement from even Hordak. Charming little cryptid. "Doesn't seem Dryllians are big party people," Octavia continued, "but proof their princess isn't a myth is apparently one bit of news they'll pay attention to." She huffed. "Nosy bastards."

"Where is she?" Hordak asked the moment she stopped speaking, and unable to stop himself, he added "Did she know that I— that *we* were coming?"

Octavia looked at him like he was a complete fool. "No. Like I just said, she's been hiding. There are areas in this place not on any of the maps that only she knows. I haven't seen her in days, and she

hasn’t replied to any of my messages.” Octavia was far too casual about this in Hordak’s opinion. “She’s done this to me before. She’ll show up when she’s good and ready. Probably about fifteen minutes after the ceremony should’ve started.”

“Or perhaps she is injured and alone somewhere,” Hordak snapped. “All because you did not think to locate her when she was missing.” Octavia made an annoyed face and started to argue, but Hordak waved her off and turned away down the hall, cape swishing behind him. While vaguely aware his sudden presence could upset her further, he needed to find her and make sure she was safe.

A series of beeps pierced through the small room crammed with computers and half finished projects, sounding as annoyed as mere beeps possibly could.

“C’mon Emily, would you give me a break?” Entrapta looked disdainfully at the bot. “I just needed a little time alone. I’m sure Octavia is handling things up there. You know she always does.”

The beeps were not having it, and Emily spun about in a clear show of disapproval.

“I still have approximately two hours before the coronation. And really, the second dungeon’s lighting system *needs* to be replaced before that happens! What if someone falls in and sees a flickering bulb? How mortifying!” Free strands of hair around intricate braids waved her tools about to illustrate Entrapta’s very reasonable points.

She’d snuck up through the vents earlier to grab snacks from the kitchen, but a so-called “stylist” had been there waiting for her to fall into their diabolical clutches. She’d put up a good fight, but in the end, and with the promise of the stylist serving one weekend as a lab assistant, Entrapta succumbed to a flamboyant half-updo with braids after ensuring it wouldn’t limit the use of her hair. So really, given the circumstances, she was being an awfully good

sport about all of this, even if she was currently hiding out in the lowest level of the castle.

Entrapta had even voluntarily put on the fancy outfit *without* the oil stains on it, although that was probably going to change before long. She wore black fitted pants with a slight shimmer and a sleeveless turtleneck in the same color. A maroon dress-thing that she couldn't name was embroidered with darker sparkly thread and went on top of the other garments. The excessive sleeves were as long as the half-skirt that revealed her pants, and they split apart at the open shoulders, falling away from her arms like a cape, and Entrapta was grateful the outfit didn't restrict her ability to work too terribly. Plus everything had pockets for all her snacks and tools. Knee-high boots replaced her normal clunky ones, but her thick work gloves and welding mask remained in place.

Turning her focus back to the minor argument with Emily, Entrapta elaborated on reasons she should remain downstairs, just a little longer. "Not to mention the cracked tiles in the sixth level basement. I'll have to design an entire new bot for that task." She tapped her chin thoughtfully. "And the cat painting could use a new frame. I'm sure I have time to whip something together before tonight."

Emily hobbled over to her mother-figure and tried to nudge her towards the door, once again urging her to leave the cavernous room nestled far beneath the Crypto Castle's main floor.

"Emily, cut it out! Don't make me ground you, young lady!" It was an empty threat, as Emily never went anywhere on her own anyway, but an attempt at discipline made Entrapta feel better about her parenting skills. She would go upstairs when she was good and ready! Wellll, maybe not *ready*, but at least a few ticks towards *willing*. Plus, she just *knew* the stylist was wandering around somewhere upstairs, and Entrapta wasn't ready to face that dark fate yet again.

Besides, beyond all the much needed repairs, she was getting some really fascinating data from the Spooky Sludge project she'd

been working on with her sample of Shadow Weaver's leaky aura. Maybe it wasn't too late to call off this whole coronation thing. Entrapta was just about to finally turn on her communicator and tell Octavia to kick everyone out when the very secret door in the underground room started to inch open.

"Woah, Emily, you were right!" Entrapta cheered as the bot ran behind her and started shaking. "The castle is haunted after all!"

Entrapta clutched a syringe excitedly, eager to explore the matter of whatever being appeared behind the door. Not one, but two red orbs floated down from blackness beyond the door frame, and Entrapta nearly dropped the syringe. "Hordak?"

Emily immediately pointed her laserbeam at him, but Entrapta held up a hand. "Walk it off, Emily." The bot beep-grumbled, but made her way out the doorway as Hordak hesitantly entered the room, closing the door behind him.

They stared at one another in silence, the cool air growing thick with tension. Entrapta had thought constantly about what she'd say to him if she saw him again, but as he stood before her, she couldn't decide whether she wanted to throw herself into his arms, or whether she wanted to throw her syringe at his head. "What are you doing here?"

Her eyes grew wider as he stepped closer and she observed his appearance. The cabling and plates of his armor were nearly completely concealed beneath a fancy coat, and shiny golden circlets adorned his wrists and neck, contrasting beautifully with the spark of his eyes. Astonishingly, small patches of skin on his torso were exposed to her for the first time, as the tight, navy fabric he wore on his upper half had small keyholes at the sternum and flanks, revealing a good deal more of his flanks than before, as well as what appeared to be a line of gold paint on his chest.

Her eyes chased that curious pattern ever downward to see a gold colored tunic on his lower half with high inviting slits exposing

more of his long legs than ever before. Furthermore, he had tantalizingly painted his body with elaborate designs in dark blue pigment across his thighs and down his legs, and she found it incredibly rude that he showed up unannounced while looking unbearably hot.

Hordak said nothing, but advanced toward her in long strides until she was backed up against her workbench, and her body tensed as she feared he was going to yell at her again. Instead, he dropped to his knees in front of her, grabbing her forearms in his huge hands and she let out a squeak of surprise. "H-Hordak? What-"

"Forgive me. Please." He looked up at her with soft, sad eyes, his brow furrowed and ears lowered. “I am so very sorry.”

It was what she’d longed to hear from him, but now that he’d said it, she found herself suddenly worried over whether he truly meant it. “Look, I know Octavia probably bullied you into coming.” Entrapta bit her lip and looked away uncomfortably. “I told her not to, but she was so riled up over things. But you really don’t have to do this, you can take the spooky lady back and just go home. I’ll tell the advisors you couldn’t make it. We’ll work it out.”

“No! I want to be here.” He retained his hold on her, eyes burning into her. “I was so wrong for all the things I said to you. It was inexcusable. You did nothing wrong-”

“I know that,” she snapped, anger over all the terrible things he’d said returning in full force.

She pulled free from his grasp, but he remained on his knees before her. “I was so foolish, so wrong for trying to tell you who you could speak to, for believing some nonsensical gossip instead of trusting you.” He spoke earnestly, but it was still hard to trust the sincerity of his pleading words.

“Yes, you should’ve,” she replied flatly. “I know words aren’t your thing, and they’re definitely not mine either, but you were so

dismissive that it made me feel like our time together didn't even matter to you." He looked horrified, but she pushed onward, difficult as it was. "You were so quick to believe anyone else over what I was telling you. Not that you even listened to me, you were too busy yelling."

"Entrapta, being with you has meant *everything* to me," he insisted, seeming almost angry that she'd accused him of otherwise. "My insecurities got the best of me, but-"

"We've all got insecurities, Hordak, but I would never take mine out on you," she interrupted in a gentler voice, studying his face. He stared back at her with such sadness painted in his features that even she could read the signs, her anger finally melting a bit as she began accepting he truly meant what he said. As hurt as she still was, she understood they were both new to relationships and to coexisting with other people in general. While it wasn't a reasonable excuse for his behavior, a spark of hope that they'd get through it began gleaming.

"I know." He hung his head. "I know I do not deserve it, but please, allow me the chance to make it up to you." He was practically bowing to her, his fists clenched at the air mere inches from the hem of her skirt as though it were difficult for him not to take hold of her. "I'll swear whatever you wish tonight, in front of whomever you wish. Your people, the princesses, anyone." He grimaced at the mention of the princesses, but she appreciated the gesture. "I'll swear my loyalty to you," he continued, "my kingdom, my love. It is all yours, if you wish it."

Her breath hitched, and his own brow raised in apparent surprise at the impassioned (if not a tad overly dramatic, but it *was* Hordak, after all) confession. "Um, could you elaborate on that last part?" she squeaked.

His slanted ears drooped further, the tips turning a bright pink, but he looked up at her most seriously. "Entrapta," he breathed, both of his hands finding one of hers. "I love you. I have loved

you for a very long time.” He looked away with a slight frown. "I understand if you do not-"

"I love you, too!" she practically squealed, giggling softly when he looked up at her with a stunned expression.

“But…” He sounded unconvinced. “I am… Are you *certain?*”

Instead of answering with words, Entrapta leaned forward to kiss him softly, a near-whimper emanating from Hordak as he returned the kiss immediately. She knew an apology, and even having his love wasn’t enough to completely erase what had happened just yet, but it was a damn good start.

She pulled away to smile at him. "I don't need all of those exorbitant promises, Hordak.” She cupped his face with her free hand, stroking his cheek with her thumb when he leaned into the touch. “I just need you to be my partner. I love you just as you are, and I always have.” She paused thoughtfully. “But I may need you to swear never to read a newspaper ever again."

She felt his slight nod against her hand before he turned his face to kiss her palm. “I promise. I will be better, I swear to you.”

“I know.” Her whispered answer died against his mouth as he claimed her lips again.

Hordak’s endless legs lifted him to his full height as she sighed into their kiss. Her hair chased after him, trying to match his towering stature, but it proved to be unnecessary as he wrapped his arms around her to hold her effortlessly against him. She was feeling lightheaded by the time she reluctantly pulled away to breathe, but whether it was from the swarm of warm feelings in her chest or from the fact she had been nearly out of oxygen, she was uncertain.

Hordak made use of his newly gained free time, and with a sweep of his arm, the contents of the table behind them were strewn

across the floor, Entrapta taking their place as Hordak placed her to sit on top of it. One hand braced himself on the table to lean over her while the other cradled her face, and he stared at her with such intensity she nearly forgot to breathe again. "Have I ever told you that you are the most beautiful creature to ever grace this universe and all those beyond?"

Grinning like the lovestruck sap that she was, Entrapta quickly shook off her gloves and ran her bare fingers over the exposed skin of his torso. "I don't believe that you have, but now seems as good a time as any to start."

Hordak matched her smile, sending her heart pounding rapidly, and she nuzzled against his chest when he embraced her. Entrapta had never heard him speak so much before as it was, but she practically melted in his arms as he began lavishing the most wonderful praises against the crown of her head in his low voice. As unexpectedly romantic as he was, her body grew impatient to demonstrate how much she loved him and how much she'd missed him. Luckily, Hordak appeared to feel similarly, and soft kisses began trailing down her face between his words.

Remorse began interlacing with the compliments, and continued apologies were released in fevered breaths against her throat until her fingers tangled into his tuft of hair to drag him upwards, silencing him by crushing her mouth against his.

He responded enthusiastically as she wrapped her arms around his neck, feeling one of his own ensnare her waist while a large hand cradled her head. Love and longing for him was burning her alive, and when he tilted her head in his large palm, she ran her tongue over his bottom lip. Hordak instinctively opened his mouth enough for her to deepen the kiss, drawing a sound of surprise from the back of his throat. His momentary stiffness confused her, until she quickly remembered she'd never gotten to kiss him this much before, their previous kisses being quite chaste. Well, it was his fault, and she wanted nothing more than to make up for lost time. He caught on quickly, moaning against her when their tongues met.

As their kisses grew deeper and more desperate, Entrapta slung her legs over his hips, wanting to be closer, their fight and the impending coronation forgotten. When she needed to breathe again and pulled away to take deep breaths, Hordak continued planting kisses all over her face. His hand at her waist had slipped beneath the overlaying dress and found the skin of her back under her turtleneck, stroking her gently and sending shivers throughout her.

Fuck, she'd missed him so badly, and she needed to show him. Her hair wrapped around his body loosely and she kissed the side of his face, affirming her love for him against his long ear. Her hands ran through his hair while she reveled in the feeling of skin-on-skin as he adored what small fragments of her flesh were bared to him.

An ardent moan slipped out of her when his tongue darted out to lick her neck, her desire magnifying when the claws of his free hand pulled the collar of her turtleneck lower for more access. When her ankles laced behind him to rock her hips against whatever of him she could reach, her name left his mouth as a sharp whisper.

He pulled back enough to look her in the eyes as both of his huge hands moved lower, pausing just before he reached unprofessional terrain, and Entrapta nodded her permission eagerly. She gasped as he skipped the buildup and quickly snaked his hands down the back of her pants, beyond her panties, and grabbed her bare backside to squeeze her sensitive flesh. His name reverberated through the small room in her voice, drowning out the sounds of several seams popping, not that she could begin to care. With another growl, he pulled her forward until she was flush against him, and using his grip on her backside to lift her, he began rubbing her sex against his hard cock.

Entrapta's cry was muffled as he kissed her passionately, and she could do nothing but take it as she gave herself over to him. It was beyond arousing, the way he'd lost all control and was

manipulating her body to stimulate them both, and she was positive she was going to come before he even got her clothes off.

"I am so sorry," he muttered as his mouth traveled lower once more, continuing to grind her roughly into his rolling hips. "I love you so much." She whimpered into his ear when his open mouth found her pulse point and sucked fervently. One of her own hands left its place from his hair to pull open the overlay sparkly overlay, sending buttons flying everywhere. The moment she had access, she slid her hand beneath her shirt to toy with her hardened nipples, which were aching for contact. Hordak noticed, and seemed to like this very much. "Fuck, Entrapta. Let me see."

She obliged immediately, rolling the shirt above her chest, and her fingers sank into her bra to allow her chest to spill from the cups. A pleased rumble left Hordak as Entrapta resumed rolling the stiff peaks of her breasts between her fingers, his red eyes wide and hungry as he watched her. After a moment, he returned his sharp fangs to graze on the other side of her neck, his tongue hot and demanding against her sensitive flesh. She was so lost in her own movements and the grinding of their clothed sexes, it was a shock when one of his hands snuck further beneath her, gliding a long finger up her drenched slit.

She inhaled a stuttering breath that crescendoed into a cry of his name when he brushed against her clit. Sharp fangs pressed against her skin as he smiled against her neck, and as he began to circle her most sensitive area, she felt herself spiraling within seconds. When he cautiously teased her opening with two of his fingers, her hands left her breasts to cling to him in a frenzy. "Yes, Hordak," she gasped against his chest. To her frustration, he didn't plunge them fully in, but thrust a little further inside her in rhythmic motions, slowly spreading her open. It was pure, delicious torture. She bucked her hips in time with his movements, trying to obtain much quicker friction, and Hordak acquiesced with a deep groan, allowing his long fingers to sink fully into her tight core.

Hordak pulled the hand still clutching her ass out of her pants to begin kneading her breasts, leaning down to kiss her. When he tentatively sucked on her tongue and his fingers swept firmly over her nipples, it was too much, and with a final thrust of his fingers, she came hard against his skilled hand.

His lips left hers, allowing her to catch her breath as he slowly removed his fingers from her core once the tremors had died down, but he moved to scatter wet kisses up and down her exposed arms. The hand that had been inside her returned to her butt while his free one stroked up and down her back under shirt, sending delightful chills throughout her body. Despite the fierce orgasm, she felt unsated and wanted much more of him, to be with him completely in the most intimate way, and her hair flung his golden tunic aside so she could access his massive length. She'd barely dipped her fingers beneath the waistband of his undergarments while he groaned encouragingly above her when they were interrupted by a voice outside the door.

"Entrapta is late for her coronation, so I am going to enter this room to check on her," Octavia's voice announced loudly, followed by some responding beeps from Emily. “I sure hope I don't see anything that will scar me for life. I think I'll wait a few minutes before opening the door very slowly."

Entrapta's sigh was drowned out by Hordak's irritated snarl, but he stopped her hand when she tried to wrap it around his still very hard cock. She pouted up at him. "She said we have at least three minutes!" Entrapta panted, still out of breath.

Hordak hummed lowly in acknowledgement, yet pulled her hand gently away from him. "I do not wish to rush this," he whispered before raising her hand to his mouth and kissing her fingers. He moved his other hand from her ass to her waist, stroking her lightly while he breathed deeply with closed eyes, trying to calm himself. Entrapta huffed with annoyance but began straightening up her clothes and pulling her shirt back in place, pausing when Hordak opened his eyes and gave her an odd look. "Ah, I seem to have…" He ran gentle fingers over her neck where he'd sucked at

her skin. Taking a step back, he looked her up and down, his ears drooping over something he saw. "Apologies, I got carried away."

Entrapta hopped off the workbench and dazedly walked to a foggy mirror in the corner. She smirked as she inspected Hordak's handiwork: huge purple marks were scattered across her neck and jaw. There would be no disguising them, even with the turtleneck. Furthermore, his body paint was smeared all over her fancy outfit which was now stretched out and torn, and the froofy hairstyle that the annoying stylist spent an hour on now resembled a rat's nest. She turned to Hordak with a giggle right as Octavia opened the door.

Octavia's jaw dropped open comically as she looked from Entrapta's ruined outfit and plentiful love bites to Hordak's disheveled hair, smudged makeup, and the paint missing from half his body. She pinched the bridge between her eyes with a deep sigh. "Really? You couldn't have waited an hour?"

Entrapta simply grinned hugely and shrugged. "Sorry," she said, not feeling sorry at all.

"Whatever, we don't have time to do anything about it now, you're already late. Let's get a move on."

Giddy and blissfully in love, Entrapta and Hordak ascended the stairs hand in hand to make the most scandalous first impression ever.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry this chapter is so long, but hey we're almost there!

Hordak's coronation clothes are heavily inspired by this wonderful art by Alex!. My Hordak's a lil shy though so unfortunately not as nakey (for now).

Entrapta's coronation clothes

Coronation? More Like Bore-o-Nation.

Chapter Summary

Entrapta gets a crown, Hordak goes to town, Shadow Weaver gets shut down.

Chapter Notes

NOT THE END. I had to split this chapter, so I have a bit more in store for these two before we're calling it quits.

If you expect smut in this chapter, you are absolutely right. Avert your gaze at the double bars if you wish to remain as pure as Scorpia's little heart.

Thank you to the lovely Mazen for beta reading this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Hey, you made it!” Octavia cheered, punching the younger girl on the shoulder.

“Yeah! I took a few dozen wrong turns, but I wouldn’t miss it!” Scorpia grinned, taking her place next to Octavia, Cobalt, Imp and Emily at the front of the audience. “I tried to get Catra to come, but she got all quiet and said she’d rather glue ration bars to her feet and use them to go ice skating.” She shrugged with a laugh. “She’s something else.”

“That’s one way to put it,” Octavia mumbled.

Suddenly, the lights dimmed, and a hush washed over the crowd. Dryl’s solitary civilians would finally see once and for all whether their alleged princess was just someone’s wayward fever dream. As waves of bedraggled purple besmirched with blues and blacks came into view, the hush over the attendees was broken by one lingering comment: “By Old King Scorpio’s leftmost tit,” Cobalt coughed out into the silence.

Taking this declaration as their queue, the murmurs of the crowd became substantial as the disheveled, blissed-out guests of honor appeared from the curtains and ascended the platform steps in Dryl's barely-used ballroom. Octavia simply sighed for about the billionth time that day. "I corralled them into a washroom on the way up, but they just came out looking even worse. Can't blame 'em, really. That one was on me."

"I don't get it?" Scorpia tilted her head. "I think they look great!"

The susurrus of scandalization barely died out as Dryl's royal advisors, a smattering of large, elderly rock golems, began the ceremony.

Hordak was not paying attention. He knew at some point, they would say his name, and he would repeat what they told him to say, but until then, he let his mind quiet while he watched his wife receive the title she deserved, even if she didn't necessarily want it. Mercifully, they were both closer to being components of the decor than they were participants in this ridiculous display of pageantry. He knew Entrapta was as relieved as he was that they were allowed to sit to the shadowy sidelines in near silence while the stone golem crone's droned on and on.

"-And just as our rocky plains and cavernous depths have persevered for centuries, we, the royal council and citizens of Dryl, give our unwavering support to Dryl's newly crowned queen to persevere in a long-lasting, prosperous reign."

Something heavy settled over him when she rose and the crown replaced the mask on her head. It was inornate and as practical as any crown ever was: a simple pewter circlet kissing her forehead. Yet the feelings of reverence it stirred within filled him with an unbearable ache, a longing to worship her mind and body. He'd do his best to fulfill her desire of having a partner, but who could ever claim equivalence next to such a blinding light?

"And yet, none can rule alone-"

“Until I change the laws,” Entrapta whispered to him, squeezing his hand as he rose beside her. Not a slight against him, but against the archaic traditions that drove her into this situation.

“And so Dryl looks to-” the dry, cracked voice sighed heavily before continuing with zero enthusiasm, “Prince Consort Hordak, Lord of the Fright Zone, to stand by our Queen and provide stewardship as she deems fit.”

His chest brimmed with pride, finally lowering himself before her. Not too long ago, willful submission to anyone but his maker would have been the highest form of blasphemy. Now he couldn’t imagine any other life than one spent ruling by her side. From here on out, she was the only one he would ever gratefully drop to his knees for.

“Will you swear to serve under Her Majesty for as long as she will have you?”

Their eyes met and his breath caught, a large thumb stroking over her hand. “Always.” He ignored the way his voice cracked and the loud, oddly familiar “awwww” in the distance when he kissed her gloved hand.

As he stared at Entrapta, all else in the universe vanished. This was always where he was meant to be, and he would sing praises to whatever bizarrely unorthodox occurrences aligned to grant him this new path in life. He would spend his days pleasing her, partnering on whatever projects she wished. If she wanted to cease the war, find a safe way to open the portal, to open that silly robot pet store she was always talking about, he would be more than happy to-

“AHEM,” came a gravely rumble. “Prince Consort, for the third time, you may *rise* and take your seat.”

Dammit, this was not the time nor place for daydreams of exaltation. With a giggle, Entrapta pulled him back to their large chairs while the endless blathering of the rock-headed golems

continued. After what felt like another eon of pedantically political poetics, Entrapta was clearly getting restless, fidgeting in the chair beside him. When he squeezed her hand encouragingly, she leaned over to him.

“Hey,” she whispered, “do you wanna get out of here?”

“What? But this is *your* party.”

“Yeah, and it blows!” Her hand began traveling further up his arm, her fingers dancing along his forearm, heedless that they were both on full display. “I have something I’ve been dying to show you.”

Looking beyond the platform, it was clear they weren’t the only ones who had lost interest. Many of the attendees were chattering to themselves, some were sleeping where they sat, while it appeared many others had broken into the reception spirits early - including his Force Commanders. It truly didn’t look like they would be missed. With a small nod, he let Entrapta’s impatient tendrils quietly and quickly lead him down the steps and back the way they came.

“It’s this way!” she laughed, tugging him along once they were in the corridor. He followed easily on his long legs as she ushered them through the maze that was her castle. Her abode truly was a marvel. If she wished for them to return to the Fright Zone, perhaps she could help him make some structural changes there as well. It certainly would be nice if no one were ever to find the sanctum again. She glanced behind her to grin at him, her smile a crescent of sunshine on a moon-filled world. “It’s just around this next corner, c’mon!”

He would follow her to the ends of Etheria.

She assumed the sound of partygoers and festivities far above had been meant as a new way of torturing her while she rotted away in the bowels of Dryl. Therefore, it had come as a great

surprise when a sloshed little hobgoblin stumbled its way down the dungeon stairs, landing in front of her with a tiny hiccup.

So inebriated had the poor bastard been that it easily succumbed to her insistence she, too, was an invitee, woefully fallen into the cage by a few wrong twists and turns. Apparently the creature was familiar with accidents caused by Entrapta's creations. It slurred something about the princess's robots destroying its petite vegetable stand, to which Shadow Weaver had to feign sympathy. The empathetic lies worked flawlessly, and two teensy, wobbly hands produced metal picks to begin toying with the lock she'd been too weak to break through. The creature explained many of Dryl's civilians were used to getting ensnared in the vicious trollop's traps (her words, not theirs) and carried lockpicking tools on them at all times.

Freed at last, Shadow Weaver took a brief, celebratory pause to down the rest of the gremlin's tiny drink. As the bottle dropped to the ground with a loud clink, she immediately felt rejuvenated. Had she time to ponder this further, perhaps she would've begun to wonder whether her diminished, oozing state was truly due to the absence of magic so much as it was due to withdrawals from certain other vices. Ah well, no use delving into such trivial matters at this late stage in life.

As she wound her way through the castle as quickly as she could - which was painfully slow - she felt a sense of finality. It was her last opportunity to bring down the bastardly bat boy and that meddling princess once and for all. She had a hunch the chaos surrounding them would be the perfect cover.

Unfortunately, Dryl was more of a barren wasteland than she ever could've imagined. The kingdom's supernatural abilities were just as severely lacking as its runestone-less, worthless monarch. With all the guests flooding the cursed castle, she'd expected surely there would be at least one sorcerer among them, or at bare minimum a poorly trained street magician that she could leech off of. Tragically, each being she purposefully stumbled into bore no

hint of supernatural talents - if her sense of perception was what it used to be, that is. At least the drinks were good.

Inelegant as it was, Shadow Weaver was just about to give up and see if the tasteless tart had an armory so she could see about slicing Hordak's throat as he slept. However, the conclusive answer to her last prayer appeared as a giant flash of apologetic, red exoskeleton.

"Oh, geeze, pardon me! Gosh, you're all just so *little*, I'm so sorry!" Scorpia was stammering as she stepped on the feet of Dryl's small statured population.

Health partially restored by a booze-fueled rampage, Shadow Weaver reached her in mere moments. "Princess Scorpia!" she rasped, gripping one large claw as the girl flinched.

"Shadow Weaver?" she squeaked. "Wow, you look *awful*. I'm sorry, that was rude! I just mean, um-"

"It's because Princess Entrapta has kept me locked away in her dungeon!" she wailed. "Hordak has corrupted her beyond all recognition. But you and I can fix things! Your mothers entrusted me with your care, but Hordak kept us apart. He wanted you out of the picture because he knew the power you were capable of!"

"Ma'am, I don't-" Scorpia looked panicked and tried to back away, knocking into a table of food in the process.

Shadow Weaver pursued her. "Listen to me," she hissed. "Don't tell anyone you've found me. Just take me back to the Fright Zone, I beg you! I can teach you how to connect with the Black Garnet, just like your mothers wanted. You and I are a lot alike, you know. Hordak has banished us both from the Garnet because he knows that together, you and I-" She felt a firm hand on her shoulder. The next thing Shadow Weaver knew, she was staring at Force Commander Octavia's raised fist before everything went black.

“What did you want to show me?” Hordak turned to face Entrapta once she’d closed the door behind them in the pitch black room. “*Oh.* I see.” The dark space lit up dimly with a flick of her hand on the wall, allowing Hordak to see that Entrapta had already stripped down to her undergarments and was smiling up at him without a trace of shyness. Dryl’s assets were very fine, indeed.

Her eyes were hooded as she sauntered towards him, and his throat suddenly seemed very dry. His knees felt unbearably weak, but she saved him from collapsing on the ground with mortification. A soft tendril of hair lightly ushered him backwards until the backs of his legs were up against something hard. With one gentle shove, he found himself sitting on a huge, plush bed. Entrapta was close behind, and within a flash, his lap was filled with gorgeous, warm skin as she settled herself on one of his bare thighs, snuggling up against his torso.

“I’m so glad you came,” she breathed, one finger tracing the keyhole at his chest. A slight tremor in her voice betrayed the confidence of her bold actions. It appeared the spell of lust that had consumed them since that afternoon had suddenly broken somehow. When he looked down into her eyes, they were glossy with unshed tears.

Horrified, he immediately enfolded her in his arms, kissing the top of her head. “What is the matter?” he asked, but it only seemed to make her more misty eyed.

She wiped at her eyes with the back of her hand, shaking her head. “I’m just so happy.” Her sentence ended with a half-sob, half-laugh. “I know it’s irrational to cry over being happy but…”

Cupping her face in one palm, he leaned down to kiss her softly. “I am so sorry that I hurt you. That I pushed you away. I had never known happiness until I found you.” She heaved a shuddery sigh as he gently ran the talons of his free hand up and down her bare back. “I love you so much.”

“I love you, too,” she whispered before he’d finished saying it to her, flooding his chest with warmth and relief.

They clung to one another in a heavy yet comfortable silence, the feeling of her skin against his own through the small cutouts in his clothing soothing him as much as it tantalized him. Before he could get too distracted, he felt her bury her face further into him and mutter something quietly. “I don’t want you to go home.”

The statement perplexed him. Did she mean she did not wish to return to the Fright Zone? She should know by now that he would gladly live wherever she wanted, so long as they were together. “I will need to make some arrangements, but we can stay in Dryl, of course. I can leave the Fright Zone under Grizzlor’s command and-”

"No." She’d grown extremely tense in his embrace, but slowly peered up at him with a serious expression. “What I mean is… I don’t want to open the portal. Not if it means you have to leave.” Her words were rushed and flustered. “I know it’s a lot to ask, and I know it’s selfish, but I don’t want you to go. I want you to stay here. With me.” She took a deep breath. “But I mean, if you still want to go home, I’ll definitely help you! I love you and I want you to be happy, even if it’s not with- even if it’s not on Etheria.”

“Of course I am staying.” He was sure his face showed his shock, if she could read it. After all this, she thought he might leave her, and he was distraught and ashamed she’d think that of him. He shifted her out of his lap and onto the foot of the bed before lowering to his knees on the floor in front of her. Even with faintly red eyes and messy hair, she was perfectly angelic. He could never, ever leave her unless she begged him to do so. “I just swore my entire life to you.” He held her small hands, staring at her intently. “I know it is not something you take seriously, but I meant it. I am yours, Entrapta. I am not going anywhere without you. Not ever. You are my home now.”

Her breath hitched and her shoulders heaved and then she threw herself at him, arms encircling his neck. “I love you. I *love you,*”

he murmured into her hair. He thought she might be crying (not that he was exactly *not* crying himself), but when she put some distance between them, she immediately closed it again by kissing him.

He dove into the kiss immediately, drawing it out. The barely satiated hunger from earlier came roaring back to life in his gut when her tongue flickered over his lower lip. Apparently, his fire wasn't the only one reignited. Entrapta dominated their kiss, her fingers tangling in his tuft of hair while her tongue claimed his own and swallowed his sounds which were quickly rising in volume.

With Entrapta seated at the foot of the bed while he knelt in front of her, he let his hands roam across her body. She whined and twitched when his palms drifted over her breasts and he started to knead them. Her back arched, pressing her torso further against his hands, and he firmly swept his thumbs across the hardened centers through the fabric. The sharp hitch in her breath was all the permission he needed. He was just about to reach for the clasp of her bra when he recalled their time together back in the Fright Zone. She'd seemed highly enticed by him ripping through her undergarments, and he *had* already ruined the remainder of her clothes… therefore, Hordak lowered his mouth to the miniscule article and effortlessly shredded it off of her with a few chomps of his sharp canines.

"Hordak," she moaned, wrapping her legs around his middle to press her center up against him.

Well, he would certainly be considering *that* a successful experiment. Conveniently at eye level with the magnificent plushness, Hordak's tongue darted out to lick one nipple, followed immediately by the other. Entrapta responded with a high-pitched whine and a mindless roll of her hips against his stomach, a response he couldn't help mirroring by thrusting his thickening cock into the wooden base of the bed frame. She muttered

praises into his hair, petting his ears as he continued lavishing her with his affections.

His lips and tongue partnered with one hand to stimulate the contours of her torso while his free hand trailed up and down her spine, into her long hair, and over her full hips. She was panting heavily, and when he opened his eyes so he could look at her, the sight turned his shaft fully hard instantly. She was staring at him with dilated eyes and flushed cheeks while her hair had wrapped itself around the posts of the bed. The crown she hadn't thought to remove still sat upon her head, shimmering dully in the dim lighting of the bedroom and Hordak was overcome with the need to worship her like the queen she was.

Her legs released him as he rose to tower above her, and the anticipatory look in her eyes as she licked lower lip burned him alive. Smiling serenely, he shrugged off his long coat to pool on the floor before placing his palms on either side of her on the bed. He lowered his head to kiss her, leaning further over her until her back hit the mattress. Her arms had locked around his neck and her hair urged him to follow her onto the bed, but Hordak had other plans. She propped up with a confused look when he removed himself from her, but the look dissolved into wide eyes, eager encouragement and adorably frizzed-up hair at his next move. Slowly, without breaking eye contact, he ripped her panties off, making a show of carefully slicing each of his talons through the flimsy fabric.

The scent of her desire nearly drove him to lose all resolve, but as she willingly lay beneath him, completely naked save for the sign of her status, he forced himself to savor the moment. He marveled at her golden skin and all the proof of her brilliance littered across her body, a cosmic sea of small scars. "You are so beautiful," he exhaled. Entrapta said nothing, but cupped his face, drawing him back down into a slow, consuming kiss. Intangible as it was, he felt her love for him in her fervent lips and in her skilled hands clutching greedily at his body. It overwhelmed him how monumental his feelings for her had become. Still, the call of undiscovered delights beckoned to him, and his mouth soon

painted a trail down her body, peppering kisses on every raised mark in his path until he settled on his knees once more.

Gentle talons lifted her legs to his shoulders, her breathy sigh and the tendrils of hair lightly caressing his body spurring him onward. It wasn't the throne room he'd imagined in his frequent fantasies about this scenario, but a plus size royal bed where he might be welcomed after was certainly a fair tradeoff. He felt a purr build up in his chest when he inhaled her intoxicating aroma deeply before tracing the channels separating her mound and inner thighs with his hot tongue. Her stuttering gasp and the anticipatory arching of her back off the bed made him want to dive in instantly, to give her what they both clearly desired, but he moved further down instead.

The inside of her abundant thighs were smooth and silky and he couldn't resist nuzzling the side of his face against the flawless heated skin, reveling in her fingers combing through his hair. When she began lightly scratching at his scalp, he turned his face to plant wet kisses on both thighs, suckling at them occasionally and leaving more red marks in his wake.

When his eyes returned to his goal and he saw the evidence of her lust glistening before him, he could hold back no longer. He flickered his tongue over her drenched slit, his taste buds bursting at the array of new flavors flooding his mouth. Helpless to do otherwise, he moaned and wasted no more time. Messy and ardent, he began devouring her shamelessly, heedless of any rhyme nor reason, driven only by the need to taste and feel more. Broken fragments of his name called to him in a high-pitched voice, the fingers in his hair tightening to hold him where she wanted him as he lapped rapturously at otherworldly velvety petals.

When he plunged his tongue inside her core as far as he could go, Entrapta cried out, confirming her gratification, and he held her thighs in place when they tried to move. Oh, the endless fantasies had done *nothing* to prepare him for this. Lush, welcoming walls massaged his tongue while pretty keening rang out in his ears,

singing praises of rapture he was responsible for. As much as they pushed him to increase his ministrations, he was becoming painfully aware of his throbbing cock, which twinged impatiently at the siren call of her voice.

"Hordak," she whimpered, her hips twitching into his movements as much as his grip allowed. "I need…" But he already knew. He withdrew his tongue and her sound of objection melted into a satisfied moan when he replaced it with his thick fingers. He thrust them in and out of her, easing his grip on her thighs so she could rock into the motions. Meanwhile, he turned his mouth's focus to her clit, assaulting it with unwavering devotion. When he felt her inner walls begin to shudder, he picked up the pace and wrapped his lips over the tiny bud, sucking on it in the same rhythm that his fingers serviced her.

With one last strangled sound, Entrapta promptly fell to pieces around his fingers and in his avid mouth. Aroused beyond measure, he quickly swapped his fingers for his tongue once again while she ground herself against his face. The feeling of her insides clenching around his tongue while he drank her down pushed him closer to the edge himself, despite his member remaining untouched.

Her spasms slowly stilled and he felt her tense body relax with a huge sigh. "Holy shit," he heard her whoosh in an exhale, and he couldn't help but laugh. "Get up here." She didn't give him a chance to respond, as her hair was already pulling him onto the mattress and scooting them both further up the bed. Breathless as she was, she still wasted no time straddling his hips and leaning down to kiss him, not seeming to mind the taste of her own essence on his tongue.

Her hair entwined between his fingers, pulling his arms up until she had practically pinned him against the headboard. He wouldn't have expected he'd enjoy feeling so dominated, but with Entrapta as his conqueror, he found he had no complaints, only a burning desire for more. He writhed in her clasp when her fingers sought out his skin, dipping beneath the cutouts in his clothing.

This, coupled with only brief brushes of her bare skin against what little of his own was exposed, led him to draw one conclusion: his clothing had to *go.*

"Entrapta," he muttered, squirming against the strong strands. "I want to-" An undignified groan overtook the end of his request as one of her hands snuck beneath the golden tunic to rub his length over his undergarments. He felt through his thin top that she was already soaked again, and knowing how aroused she was just to touch him forced a whimper from him. His hips thrust upward into her hand and they moaned in tandem.

"On or off?" she panted, a strand of hair tugging at the tunic.

"Off," he grunted, and her hair wasted no time at all stripping the skirt off and taking his undergarments with it, tossing them to the floor.

Entrapta bit her lip and let her magenta orbs linger hungrily on his straining shaft for just a moment before she released his arms and met his eyes. "What about the rest?" she asked in a softer voice, and he was filled with love for her that she was still so patient with his insecurities, even in such an impassioned moment.

"*Off,*" he reiterated without hesitation. He did his best to ignore the tremors when he used his newly freed hands to show her just how serious he was. His claws sank into the cutout at his chest and ripped the poor garment off, flinging the tatters down to the floor. He vaguely recalled that his remaining clothes were in another room, but that was a problem to solve later.

Entrapta, goddess that she was, didn't look at his exposure and instead closed her eyes, leaning down to kiss him. She lay completely flush on top of his slight frame which shivered slightly with nerves. While he'd craved flesh on flesh, he hadn't realized just how starved he was for it until she settled over him. His eyes burned and he shut them tightly, engulfing her in his embrace so hard she squeaked in surprise. The fact he had been wilfully

denying himself the unmatched sensation of being melded against flawless brown luxury was exasperating, and all he could do now was make up for lost time.

He was ravenous for every bit of her, and his hands rose to explore her body, pressing her harder against his own and losing himself in her kiss until she had to come up for air. "Can I look at you?" she asked in a husky voice, to which he could only nod dumbly. She shifted and he instinctively tightened his grip, not ready to give up the loss of contact. Entrapta giggled sweetly and kissed his nose before managing to escape his unrelenting arms. Her cheery expression hollowed out into solemnity when she sat back on his waist. He flinched under her scrutiny, but there was no disgust on her face. She looked at him like he was beautiful.

"You're *so hot!*" she squealed, and Hordak lived out her description in real time as he blushed furiously. "Would you prefer to keep the armor on?" Hordak's head had barely indicated his negative response before tendrils were hovering over him, hardly restraining themselves."Want help?"

"Yes. Please, Entrapta." He never would've guessed it would feel so good to beg.

Delicate strands got to work quickly, disposing of his armor while Entrapta's fingers stroked his ears comfortingly. His face was peppered with kisses while tender affirmations of her love were whispered until the armor was carefully set aside and he was as bare as his partner. He'd never been more exposed, yet he felt completely safe and wanted in the arms and hair of Entrapta. She didn't hesitate to lie back down on top of him, and when Hordak wrapped his thin arms around her, the closeness took what little breath he had away.

Every arch and dip of her small body fit perfectly against his own rigid form, filling in each sharp angle with indescribable suppleness. He cradled her head to steer her back to his mouth, kissing her fervidly as her palms explored his newly revealed flesh. The path her touch left seemed to set his skin on fire, and she felt

it too, breaking away to sit up on his stomach. “I need you,” he rasped.

“Then have me,” came the whispered response.

Not breaking eye contact, she scooted backwards on him, until her core was hovering over his cock, and Hordak sat up with his back against the headboard to be closer to her. One of his hands covered her lower back while the other cupped her face. Staring at one another intently, Entrapta took in a sharp breath and slowly descended on top of him.

As erotic as the sight was, it was nothing compared to the feeling of her wetness enveloping the tip of his shaft. A guttural growl emanated from his throat as she inched ever downward at an excruciatingly slow pace. The urge to grab her hips and ram himself to the hilt inside her sacred body was overwhelming, but he didn’t dare do such a thing. She was flushed and covered in a sheen of perspiration, her brows knitted together in both pleasure and concentration. Her breathing was slow and controlled, and he wondered how she managed as she did given their size difference. However, the thought was expelled from him without a trace when he watched with rapt attention as the last of him sank inside her body.

Unfathomable silkiness surrounded his throbbing cock in a way his imagination never could’ve conjured, and his eyes rolled back into his skull with a low, needy whine. “Entrapta, Entrapta…” he was vaguely aware he was whispering her name as a reverent chant, but he couldn’t stop, not when he was so completely immersed inside of her body and love.

She’d buried her face into his chest and he heard her mumble incognizable phrases between tiny kisses that she left on him, seemingly pleased as they both settled into the new sensation. Her nails dug into his shoulders, and he was unprepared for how overcome he felt when their eyes met again. Her thumbs wiped the moisture from his face and he leaned down to press his lips to hers. Entrapta hummed against him, and while none of his length

slipped from her, she rolled her hips, grinding firmly against him. Sounds of indulgence and surprise fled from both of them, their kiss forcibly broken, but neither seemed to mind.

Instinctively, he palmed her ass, squeezing the delicious flesh, and the moan that left her at the action was music to his ears. Slowly, she rose off of him until only the tip remained nestled inside her. When she lowered back down, Hordak's hips met her half way. She quickly set the pace, settling into an unhurried rhythm as they made love at long last. This was how it was always meant to be. Their marriage was no incident, no random happenstance, it was destiny; she was his and he was never letting her go. Their bond was sealed in this moment.

Primal instincts were taking over, and the need to possess her was overcoming him. He began thrusting deeper, pulling her hips down harder to grind her against him forcefully. He received no qualms from Entrapta, only continued enthusiasm which he savored as he kissed her mercilessly. Stars, he was not going to last long, he needed to pull back. Entrapta didn't give him the chance. Waves of purple surrounded them, adjusting them both until Entrapta was flat on her back and Hordak was repositioned on top of her.

The new angle sent him reeling. He thrust more aggressively inside her core while Entrapta's legs laced around his waist, seating him impossibly deeper inside her. "I love you." Hordak leaned his forehead against hers. He couldn't stop saying it now that it was out in the open.

"Show me." Her kiss-swollen smile was too endearing, her eyes too easy to drown in, and Hordak gave himself over completely. He crushed her body against his and pounded into her desperately, her own hips chasing every movement. She whispered words of adoration before licking the shell of his ear, her inner walls trembling around him, and he knew he was doomed.

He went first, ramming into her with one final moan of her name. She followed him quickly, her insides pulsing around him and

extending the euphoric bursts of ecstacy, causing a sea of stars to dance in his vision. Her insides clung to him as her limbs did, and he felt more loved and more wanted than he could have ever dreamt of. She completed him in every way.

They held one another until her body stilled and they began to catch their breaths. He reluctantly pulled out of her, but kept her in his hold as he rolled onto his back with her on top of him. Now more than ever, he needed to be as close to her as possible, any loss of her touch unimaginable. A strand of lilac flung her small crown to the floor with a small clink as Entrapta folded her arms beneath her on his chest. She leaned down to smother every inch of his face in kisses, leaving him feeling delirious with love and warmth.

"Hordak," she breathed. "This has been a dream come true! You have no idea how long I've wanted to do highly unprofessional things to you in this bed. Or wherever I could, really."

He couldn't repress a smirk as he shifted them to lie on their sides facing one another, the backs of his fingers lovingly trailing down her sides, taking delight in her shivers. "If I had to guess, I would assume ever since you shamelessly flirted with me by hacking into my datapad my first night here?" It was hard to conceive she was interested in him all that time ago, and he could kick his past self for not acting sooner.

She grinned and hid her face in the crook of her arm. "Took you a while to figure it out, huh?"

"Yes, but I am onto your tricks now, you vent-crawling vixen." Entrapta cackled and he smiled fondly at her. "I learned far more in my studies of interpersonal relationships than just how to attempt to pleasure you, you know," he chided.

"Oh, that was no attempt," she sighed. "That was executed research at its *very* finest."

“Had I known what I was missing out on, I am certain I would have allowed you to seduce me much earlier.” She giggled brightly at his words, but winced when she propped herself up. “Have I hurt you?” he asked, horrified. “I know our sizes are a bit-”

“Oh, don’t you worry ‘bout a thing!” a strand of hair booped his nose, while more tendrils began herding them beneath the covers of the bed. “That was *more* than worth a smidge of pain. Besides, I’ve been practicing for this moment since I laid eyes on you.”

“Practice?” His face fell as she tucked them both into bed. However, before he could get too jealous, she both soothed and intrigued him.

“I admittedly made a few replicas. They get more accurate throughout the time we’ve known each other.” She grinned. “I’d love to show you sometime. You might even like them, too.” She winked as she snuggled up in his arms.

“Perhaps.” He had his doubts, but then again, Entrapta hadn’t had a bad idea yet. “We have all the time in the world to figure it out.”

Beyond spent from the life changing events of the day, both emotional and physical, with one last kiss from Hordak to the top of her head, the Queen of Dryl and her husband drifted off into the well-deserved best night of sleep either one had ever had. It was only the first of many to come.

Chapter End Notes

> Honk if you're still here, and stay tuned for the exciting conclusion of The Highfalutin Frolicking Of The Firehydrant And The Fishbowl!

And They Lived Happily Ever After

Chapter Summary

> Shadow Weaver gets what's due. Author is grateful this story is through. Home is wherever I'm with you.

Chapter Notes

> Small splash of smut below, watch out! Notated by the double bars.
>
> Thank you once again to the incomparable Mazen for your help with this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Entrapta awoke early the next morning. Her body was a bit sore, but her heart was soaring and she wiggled about in Hordak's firm embrace until she was able to look at him. The still-sleeping man responded with a grunt of protest and reaffirmed his hold on her, squishing her still naked skin against his own. She didn't mind in the least, grinning up at him with a dreamy expression.

Thrilled to have a bit of quiet time to ogle this precious alien, Entrapta decided it was also high time she made a new entry into her recorder. Her hair lazily grabbed the device off of her bedside table, pressed record and began whispering into it. "Hordak Log seven-thousand, nine-hundred and thirty-eight: Things have progressed more than I'd ever imagined! After confessing our love to one another, Hordak and I finally banged. I can now confirm the act is exponentially more enjoyable when feelings are involved. We've been too busy to discuss what exactly this means and what we'll do next, but most importantly, Hordak expressed his willingness and even enthusiasm to stay on Etheria with me."

Entrapta repressed an excited squeal - Although apparently it wasn't as repressed as she thought, as Hordak's long ear twitched. She never did have a good gauge of her own decibels.

She winced and bit her lip, but thankfully his eyes remained closed and his breathing even. He looked so peaceful when he slept; an expression of relaxation she'd only gotten to glimpse once before when they shared a night together back in the Fright Zone. Hopefully, this would be a regular occurrence from now on. "I'll spare the log the graphic details," she continued, "but I'm hoping to experiment with some other positions very soon. I can only imagine that- Hey!"

The recorder was plucked from her hair and the stop button clicked by swift blue talons before being tossed gently aside. Hordak smirked down at her, and Entrapta's annoyance at the interruption was immediately forgotten. "Why would you *imagine* such a thing?" he asked, his tone making her shiver. "After all, did you not once tell me that some things are easier to learn with hands-on experience?"

His lips gave her no chance to answer.

Hours later, Entrapta could ignore the messages flooding her datapad no longer. Shadow Weaver had apparently escaped the dungeon last night, harassed poor Scorpia, drank half the open bar, and made endless threats on Hordak's life and ears before Octavia apprehended her. As much as she'd rather ignore it, as Dryl's slightly unwilling ruler, Entrapta figured she had to do something. What a drag. Thankfully, Hordak was there to help her and he had plenty of ideas - though some were a bit too gruesome, even by Entrapta's standards.

Hordak said if they were in the Fright Zone, he would sentence the spooky lady from his throne with a small audience to make an example of this particular case. However, Entrapta was more than audience'd out and had no throne, so the most she would agree to was addressing the situation in her lab's comfiest rolly chair. They debated back and forth before coming to what she thought was a reasonable compromise and journeyed back to the Fright Zone to get things over with.

This was how she once again found herself in clean, dressy clothes and the silly tiara as they waited for the hour of the assembly where Hordak would decree their joint decision. He'd suggested they dress the royal part because he knew it would enrage Shadow Weaver, and Entrapta figured she was willing to give up comfort for half an hour in the name of being facetious.

Hordak was sporting the sexy coat he'd worn to her coronation and a tabard emblazoned with a new emblem. He'd put together a design that combined the wings of the Horde with the cogs of Dryl, and he'd done it so fast there was no possible way it hadn't already been on his mind. Once finalized, he'd practically paraded it to Octavia, whose disinterest was rivaled only by Entrapta's.

Entrapta's indifference to sigils and boundless flags on every corner were a tiny point of contention, but she had to admit that Hordak's excitement to present the two of them as a united front was very endearing and highly attractive. She'd even happily let him embroider the sigil onto her current outfit, which she'd jokingly dubbed her "punishment playsuit" for the occasion. It didn't escape her notice that Hordak had blushed madly at the term, and she'd made a mental note to dig into this in the near future.

Both dressed and ready to ruin a woman's life, Hordak was using the downtime to mess around on his datapad while Entrapta lounged comfortably in his lap. She should be productive as well, but found herself more than a bit distracted by his suave appearance. Figuring they had time to kill, she squirmed with intent against his lap. She smiled in satisfaction when something squirmed back.

The datapad was immediately set aside so he could grip her hips firmly, holding her still. "Careful, troublemaker. We will have visitors any moment now," he growled into her ear. Despite the reprimand, his lips traveled lower. He nipped at her jaw, pulling her more firmly into his lap to rub himself against her.

The first attempted syllable of his name dissolved as he suddenly kissed her, one of his hands reaching down between her legs while the other palmed her breasts. She hadn't expected him to react so quickly to her light teasing, but his response magnified her lust in record time. Her nipples grew stiff and sensitive under his fevered touch and Entrapta cursed her clothing that separated her from feeling his cool skin. Unfortunately, before she could do something to remedy this, the warning signal they'd installed alerted them of someone approaching the locked sanctum doors.

The noise pulled Entrapta reluctantly back to reality, but Hordak didn't let her go. He kissed her deeper, probing wetly in her mouth with his tongue to draw a moan from her. His hands moved more insistently over her body and when she felt how hard he'd become, she was absolutely positive he wasn't going to unlock the doors. However, when she tried to move his hand beneath her waistband, he resisted and pulled back with a smirk.

"We have a meeting, love," he crooned.

Entrapta pouted up at him, but he simply laughed and shook his head, lacing his arms around her midsection with a chaste kiss to the crown of her head. "Where did you learn to be such a tease?" she grumbled, feigning a scowl.

"From the very best."

"You don't have to learn from *everything* I do, you know!" she chastised, running her fingers along his sensitive ears. She may be a bit worked up, but as she felt his pleased purring against her back, she was exactly where she wanted to be.

Giving in to responsibility, Entrapta opened her mouth to give the verbal command to unlock the sanctum doors. Before she could speak, Hordak stunned her into silence with a kiss so fierce she nearly got whiplash from the mixed signals. Had he been *doubly* teasing her? She'd be a bit annoyed if she weren't so turned on. His tongue instantly claimed her mouth and swallowed her rising moan. His hand returned to her chest to pull down her shirt and

the bra beneath, rolling her left nipple between his thumb and forefinger before switching to the right. She mewled against him, shivering when she felt his pleased smile against her lips.

The urgency he seemed to possess had an intoxicating effect on her, and she grew more fervid, trying in vain to rub her clit on his shaft through their clothing. Hordak noticed immediately and thankfully, he decided to act. She tore her mouth from his to cry out in relief and pleasure when his free hand sank beneath her waistband, trailing over her slit through her drenched panties. "Hordak," she panted. "Please-"

Growling, he released her breasts to lift her by the waist while the hand in her pants abandoned her center to yank the garment just below her ass. Keeping her elevated with a supporting arm around her midsection, he flung his tabard out of the way and released his hard length from his undergarments. Holding her in place just above him, she could barely feel the tip of him brushing tantalizingly against her aching sex through her panties. "Is this what you want?" he whispered mischievously.

"Yes!" she whined, writhing in his hold in an attempt to get closer. She wouldn't have expected someone who started out so shy to gain such a dominant thirst this quickly, but it was incredibly arousing and Entrapta was more than willing to switch things up. He acquiesced to her plea quickly, his long fingers sliding her panties to one side of her mound while his other maneuvered her body to lower her onto his cock. Entrapta positioned him quickly and his name was ripped from her throat as he immediately buried himself to the hilt inside of her. Filled and stretched in the most delicious way, her hands scrambled to his beautiful thighs, feeling if she didn't hold on to something, she'd simply float away.

She couldn't do much from her position with her pants still halfway on, but Hordak enthusiastically took the lead. He grabbed her hips, easing her up and down his hardness while his hips rolled in the same rhythm. His thrusts were shallow, but the firm ridges rubbed all the right things in all the right places and she was overwhelmed beyond measure.

The feeling swelled when one of his thumbs extended to rub the swollen bud peeking beneath her panties. He arched his large frame over her body easily, and when he lowered his mouth to let her feel his sharp fangs on her neck, Entrapta came faster than she ever had before. Her voice echoed obscenely throughout the throne room like some sort of freakishly erotic bells. Never before had she been so grateful they'd soundproofed the sanctum long ago against explosions of a less sensual kind.

Hordak came soon after, muffling his own moaning against her pulsepoint while her spasming core coaxed him to give her all he had. They were gasping for air as they came down, bodies slowly calming. Hordak appeared exhausted from the speedy rendezvous and slumped over in the throne with ragged breaths. Entrapta, however, was feeling re-energized from the encounter. The release had done wonders for her nerves over the assembly, and her hair wasted no time redressing them. She settled back against him, feeling beyond loved and happy when his tired arms returned to hold her. They'd have a bath and quiet time later, but right now, they had a job to do.

As what Entrapta called the doorbell and what Hordak called "the Ungodly Gong of Perpetual Headaches" kept blaring, Entrapta huffed a final, annoyed sigh before unlocking their sanctum doors. She shifted to move to the armrest as she had in the past, but Hordak's strong arms stayed locked around her as he sat up straight, hugging her to him. "Stay here," he murmured.

Her brows shot up. "For real?" Their romantic relationship was *beyond* officially public now, but for him to want her snuggled in his lap while sentencing a prisoner to their probable death was another move altogether.

"I like you close," he whispered among the approaching footsteps. "So stay, if you wish."

Oh *hell yeah* did she ever wish! His lips planted a soft kiss on her cheek and she knew she was the luckiest girl in the entire

universe, statistics be damned.

Adora. Catra. Entrapta. Scorpia. Ungrateful, worthless, miserable *bitches!* Every last one of them! After all she'd offered them! The power she could've shared, asking nothing in return but for a seat at the inner circle and neverending devotion! All these years spent having to see Hordak in the disgusting flesh and raise these snot-nosed ankle-biters, all wasted on absolute nothingness!

"Move it!"

They'd been waiting outside Hordak's precious, damnable sanctum for eons while he took his sniveling time to open up the doors. She was flanked by Force Commanders while an audience of Force Captains trailed behind, many of which she'd had a hand in training. *Bastards*. She may be out of magic, but she'd still curse every last one of them.

Despite her prideful fury, her stomach still turned as she was led towards the dais of Hordak's throne. The same throne she'd defiled plenty of times in his absence with bottles of vintage reds and whites and the occasional elixir of foul fetor. As he came into view, it appeared he'd taken to defiling the throne of his own accord. He sat tall and smug with an exceptionally regal looking Entrapta sprawled in his lap, not a hint of shame on either one of them. In fact, they somehow looked suspiciously like they'd just had relations. What a revolting thought to kick off these regrettable events.

All too soon, they arrived as the base of the needlessly steep stairway and she grimaced beneath her mask. The troops bowed as though nothing were amiss, as though this were perfectly normal. "Kneel," came an order, and Shadow Weaver wasn't given a choice. Her slightly oozing form was brought to her knees by arms on either side before they moved to join the sidelines.

"Welcome back to the Fright Zone, Shadow Weaver," Hordak practically purred, looking sickeningly serene as he toyed with the

damn princess's hair. Shadow Weaver had thought Hordak coddling the flying bastard boy was bad, but it was nothing in comparison to him practically fondling a pillow princess in front of an army. "Although I admit this will be a rather short stay, as the departing vessel for the Dryl mines will be leaving shortly."

Shadow Weaver set her jaw as her fate was revealed. Hordak seemed cool and collected instead of the enraged, screaming, heart-attack-waiting-to-happen she had grown accustomed to. It appeared she couldn't even trust him to die from natural causes such as uncontrollably high blood pressure these days like she'd often daydreamt about. She was devastated.

"If it were solely up to me," Hordak said passively, "you would have been on a transport to Beast Island by now. However, Entrapta has deemed we show you mercy." His lip curled in apparent disagreement.

"You're welcome!" The princess dared chirp with a little wave.

Lackadaisical miniscule monsterfucker, Shadow Weaver swore internally.

"You see," Hordak droned on, "her First One's Tech research in Dryl has been delayed far too long due to unforeseen, monstrous circumstances. We require someone to participate in rather high-risk missions inside the mines to determine how to remove the beasts so that our work may continue. My wife and I agreed that you seem the ideal candidate."

Never before had Shadow Weaver been so inspired to vomit, and it had nothing to do with a life exiled to a mineshaft.

Hordak leaned forward in his seat, keeping his hands all too casually on the princess, like she was a prize to be coveted. "You will be outfitted with a tracker and under constant surveillance. Additionally, you will remain banned from using magic. If you take one small step out of line, we will not hesitate to proceed with more extreme measures." A clawed hand waved dismissively. "And

should you happen, by chance, to perish while serving Dryl, you shall be remembered for the sacrifice you made towards scientific discovery. A fate far better than what you deserve, I would say."

Shadow Weaver said nothing. What could she say? She had no powers, no allies, no-

"If you have any final words, now would be the time," Hordak drawled in a bored tone.

She narrowed her eyes at the mismatched pair. Fuck it, maybe she *could* say something after all. With literally nothing else to lose, Shadow Weaver turned to address the Horde. "Are you all truly going to stand there and allow this monster to banish one of the founding members of the Horde? Someone who gave their entire life away to make this empire what it is today?" she pleaded with whomever would listen. "Do none of you have anything to say about your supposed leader choosing a *princess* to rule by his side?"

"Yeah, actually," Octavia interjected. "I think the title you're looking for is *queen.*"

To her horror, there were several nods of agreement. The remainder of the assembly was white noise in her head until the troops filtered out with her and her guards in the rear. She cast one final look at the man she'd wasted thirty years on to see he was once again making googoo eyes at the girl. The plans for her kingdom had fallen at the whims of one unwitting, purple fly in the ointment who didn't even appreciate the position of power she'd been handed. And there was nothing Shadow Weaver could do about it except go out calm and composed with her head held high.

"Oh! One other quick little thing!" Entrapta called out to her. "No big deal, but I thought you might wanna know the mines of Dryl are far enough away from the castle to be in dry territory. So no drinking!"

"*YOU BAT-FUCKING, DISENCHANTED SLUT! IF I EVER GET MY HANDS ON YOU-"*

Shadow Weaver was dragged out leaking and screaming every expletive she'd ever known plus a few new ones as she departed the Fright Zone for the last time. She had finally lost.

Hordak's living quarters were essentially an empty shell, but he had taken her advice of installing a bathtub before, in his words, he "got a small bit beside himself" at their brief separation. It was bittersweet, but they were together now, and nothing would change that.

The tub was remarkably huge. Hordak could easily stretch his gorgeously long legs all the way out and his cute toes did not even quite touch the other side. His head was resting against the porcelain edge of the tub and Entrapta was settled between his thighs, leaning back against him as they relaxed in the warm, bubbly water. On a whim, and just because she could, she gently took one giant blue paw from the side of the tub in her hands so she could kiss it. She thought he'd been asleep until he responded with a contented sigh.

When she leaned her head back against his bare chest to look at him, he lifted his own head to gaze down at her, cupping her face in his other hand. Entrapta had admired his red orbs from the moment she saw him. It was mostly due to her fascination with their strange ability to glow, and because she felt she didn't have to try in vain to read any hidden meaning behind them. Now, she couldn't mistake the look of love and adoration that shone in them for her alone.

She figured he must be able to see the same reflected in her own eyes, because as if reading her thoughts, he closed the distance, giving her the sweetest kiss. He absently ran his fingers through her wet hair, and she swore she felt the soothing touch throughout her entire body. She'd never known she could love a

person the way that she loved him. She thought she might love him more than she loved science.

When they parted, something else flashed in those glowing eyes. Without warning, he nibbled at the tip of her nose, so lightly it was barely there. The playfulness took her by surprise and she squealed followed by a bright giggle, ducking away while the water splashed around them. Hordak joined her with his own rich laughter, drawing her back to him. It was a rare and wonderful sound, and by the First Ones, she would do whatever she could to hear more of it.

"Well…" Entrapta took advantage of the broken silence, smiling up at her cute husband. "There's still a *lot* of data to collect before we even consider more portal experimentation. The coronation is out of the way, and Shadow Weaver is taken care of. Whatcha wanna do next?"

Hordak let out a low hum, mulling over her question. "I do have one idea. Seeing as I did not know just what a remarkably flawless decision we were making at the time, I think that we ought to do it over again."

Entrapta tilted her head. "I'm not sure I get your meaning."

Slowly, a small grin formed on his face. "Entrapta, will you marry me? Again?"

Chapter End Notes

> THE END. I have one little epilogue in store, but there you have it folks. I know this has been a longass ride, and I hope the ending satisfies.
>
> Thank you to everyone who has stuck with this story and left me so many wonderful comments. I'm sorry I'm the worst at replying, but just know all your words have fed me endlessly and I reread comments all the time. I love you all forever.

Extra special thank you to all my buddies in Dryl who have supported me with this story from the beginning! Mazen, Alex, Grot, and Shan, I would've never finished this shit without all your help and plotting!

The Wedding of the Warlord and the Wunderkind

Chapter Summary

In which everyone gets what's coming to them

Chapter Notes

Epilogue plus a tiny splash of smut between the double bars.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Neither one being big travelers, and since most of her possessions were still there, Hordak and Entrapta made the Fright Zone their primary residence. Their first project was finishing the destroyed living quarters that Hordak had been too unmotivated to complete during their time apart. The task took them significantly longer than it should have, but they both agreed the frequent visits to the mattress on the floor as well as every other corner of the Fright Zone was time well spent.

Octavia was elevated from Force Commander to hold the official title of Dryl's warden, although it still damaged Hordak's hardly existent pride. Octavia was much happier about the arrangement than she wanted anyone to believe, and she easily accepted the offer to remain in the mountains and oversee Entrapta's kingdom - while seeking more of Entrapta's input than Entrapta really wanted to give, of course.

Cobalt worked with his newly established training team to expand the cadet program and roles within the Horde, so that the single point of failure a la Shadow Weaver would not happen again in the future. He worked closely with Force Captain Catra, who was well on her way to becoming a Force Commander herself.

Grizzlor learned quickly to never use his elevated access as second-in-command to enter the sanctum unannounced and was

permanently scarred for life by the things he stumbled in on. Other than that, he fell into a great working relationship with Hordak, and even learned how to comprehend what half of Hordak's grunts and growls meant.

The victor of the Horde's will-they-won't-they bet was never agreed upon. Cobalt insisted he'd won when he bet day one that Entrapta and Hordak would fuck before they left Dryl. Grizzlor protested it didn't count, as they'd left Dryl since Cobalt's declaration and that he himself had won when he'd bet Entrapta would never fuck Hordak until he learned to act right. Octavia said this was unfair, as Entrapta clearly would've fucked Hordak well before he learned to act right if Hordak had let her, and Cobalt agreed.

Octavia's claim to victory was her initial bet that they'd go to pound town in the Fright Zone, proclaiming that Entrapta had told her about several close encounters the scientists shared against Octavia's will. Cobalt and Grizzlor said that since they didn't go all the way, it didn't count. In the end, all the bets they'd been collecting over the past year from the rest of the Horde had been divvied up and returned. There was a near uprising over the absence of a solid outcome and the Fright Zone barely survived what they deemed "The Bet-Edging of The Century".

Scorpia wasn't quite on track for Force Commander, but she had something a bit more exciting in store. While Entrapta wasn't ready to give up the first runestone she'd ever had access to, the two entered a joint-custody arrangement with the Black Garnet, working together to try and figure out how to "turn on" Scorpia's magical powers. They hadn't made much headway yet, but the pair still had a lot of fun and shared a bunch of tiny snacks while trying to crack the code.

Shadow Weaver was caught within a week of her sentencing to Dryl after escaping to a gremlin campsite several miles outside of the mines. She was apprehended while wine-wasted and doing Hordak impersonations for a captive audience - literally, as she'd bound the gremlins up and was forcing them to watch. As

punishment for the breach of parole, she was immediately sent to Beast Island. It was a close second to the greatest thing that had ever happened in Hordak's life.

Entrapta accepted Hordak's second marriage proposal, so long as there was cake, chaos, and no more than five guests. The party they had planned was so tiny it could hardly be called a party at all, yet both couldn't help the nerves bubbling up inside…

"Are you ready?" Scorpia asked, poking her head into the supply closet Entrapta was getting dressed in. "Oh gosh, you look so beautiful," she gushed between sniffling and near-sobs.

"I'm ready!" Entrapta called back. "I'll be right behind you." Seeing as Entrapta was wearing an oversized sweater, leggings, and boots, she thought that Scorpia was overstating the effect of the ensemble. Another of her wedding stipulations was, for the love of the First One's, *no more fancy clothes.* Luckily, Hordak was more than happy to agree. Besides, she thought what she was wearing *beneath* her clothes would excite him a bit more than some big fluffy dress.

Despite the casualness of the entire affair, Hordak still looked adorably flustered when she emerged in the sanctum where the others were gathered. She joined hands with him in front of the soothing backdrop of glowing vitrines and turned to smile at their guests: Octavia, Cobalt, Grizzlor, Scorpia, Imp, and Emily. A massive turnout!

Hordak cleared his throat and began their wedding ceremony. "I acknowledge that you have all prioritized this meeting," he addressed the crowd. "Your punctuality is noted." Entrapta practically swooned. He had such a way with words! He turned to her and his gaze softened. "My Entrapta… I have prepared a few words to describe my feelings for you." He held up a large piece of paper in his free hand and unfolded it. And unfolded it some more. And kept going until the paper began bunching up on the floor.

Entrapta's brows shot up. "Um, that's very sweet, but you only scheduled our wedding to be fifteen minutes long." Normally she couldn't care less about timeliness, but she was beyond ready to get to the kissing part. And the cake.

"Ah, right. I would prefer we adhere to the agenda, but I suppose we can skip ahead." There were sighs of what she assumed was relief from their audience. Entrapta still had every intention of hearing whatever adorably over-the-top praise she was certain spanned the page that was taller than she was, but she had some other priorities right now. Like eating their wedding cake off of his body. "But for now, I will just say that…" she saw how he tried to keep it still, but his ear still twitched and he lowered his voice. "I love you. I wish to remain married to you for all eternity."

"I love you too!" She bounced up to his level on her hair. "And I wanna be married and do so much science with you forever!" She didn't know if he had some sort of conclusion planned, but she'd waited long enough. She flung herself at him and kissed him deeply, not caring that her friends were watching.

Her friends apparently *did* care, however, as she heard them quickly shuffling to the workbench where Octavia had set up the tiny cakes and refreshments. Hordak and Entrapta joined them briefly, until the alarm he set went off. He informed them that the event was now concluded, and everyone could go back to their regularly scheduled duties. All in all, their wedding was everything Entrapta could've wished for.

Alone together at last, she hopped up onto the workbench, her hair dragging Hordak closer. He was eager to follow, leaning down to kiss her, but she pulled back when a very serious realization dawned upon her. "You didn't have any cake!"

"Is that an issue?" He sounded a little impatient at the subject change, but this was important.

"No, but… now that I think about it, I've never seen you eat anything sweet," she mused.

He smirked, burying his face in her neck and inhaling. “I could argue against that.”

A sigh escaped her when he darted out his tongue to lick her skin and hummed with satisfaction. The gentle claws sneaking beneath the hem of her sweater were almost enough to distract her from getting the information she sought - *almost* . She shed her gloves and swiped her index finger through the icing of the nearest mini cupcake. “Here.”

Hordak pulled back enough to blink at the offered confection. He looked skeptical, but pulled her hand to his mouth. His tongue caressed her fingers, slowly cleaning the icing off her skin in the most delightful way. When he pulled her hand from his face, his nasal ridge scrunched cutely as he pulled an unpleasant face.

“Too sweet?” she asked with a giggle.

“I do not see how you can stomach this as a regular part of your diet.”

“Well, I appreciate you trying!” a tendril of hair came up to ruffle his own. “That’s been a gap in my data for *ages* .”

His hands had returned to trailing up and down her sides. “Will you ever show me that particular data?”

She scowled. “I dunno. The Hordak log is pretty proprietary.” She laced her arms around his neck as he leaned over her, pressing her body further against the table. “You may have to sign an NDA.”

“Hm. I would have expected being the subject of those files would entitle me to review the logs.”

She opened her mouth to tell him she would consider it, but then he was kissing her.

Her hair tried to haul him onto the table with her, but when it started to creak ominously, Hordak grabbed her into his arms instead. He didn't stop kissing her even as he carried her to their quarters, but Entrapta's hair thankfully managed to steer them to the right location unscathed.

Once they were safely locked behind the confines of their freshly completed bedroom, Hordak wasted no time in tossing her onto the bed while she let out a bright giggle. He pounced on top of her playfully, though kept propped on his elbows to avoid putting too much of his weight on her.

They fell back into heated, deep kisses while skilled talons made quick work of her clothing. She kicked off her boots and he yanked her leggings down her legs. When her hair tossed her sweater over her head and onto the floor, Hordak made a sound of surprise against her mouth as his fingers brushed against lace. He pulled back just enough to look at her, but his eyes widened and he sat back on his knees to gape at her when he saw what she was wearing.

Entrapta was all about cute printed comfy undies, but for her wedding night, she'd found something just a little bit frillier that didn't bug her sensitive skin too badly. Besides, it wasn't like she planned on wearing them more than a few minutes once he saw them anyway. Until then, Hordak's flustered gaping over the black satin bra with red lace trim and matching panties made up for it.

"You're beautiful," he breathed in a low, needy voice.

Entrapta smiled at him and reclined down against the pillows, her hair encouraging him to follow. He did so immediately, but when he palmed her ass, his sharp claws pierced right through her panties.

"Ah, I'm s-"

She cut him off with a kiss. It was unbelievably hot when he ripped her clothes off of her, and she'd invested in many more

coveralls and white tops just for such occasions. As his hands roamed her nearly bare body, her own hands were shedding him of his armor and tunic. Her hair placed the pieces gently beside the bed as she exposed more of him to her wandering eyes. She vaguely took note that shreds of black and red undergarments were joining the armor on the floor. So fucking hot.

He always took great care to pleasure her with his mouth and fingers, and tonight was no exception. His own stamina had increased exponentially, so to both their delight, she was able to return the favor while still leaving him with energy for more.

As arousing as their bountiful other activities were, there was nothing quite like having him fully, and before too long, he was settling his hips between her trembling thighs. "I love you so much," he whispered, catching her mouth in a soft kiss as he pushed forward.

Her affirmation of her own feelings ended with a moan of satisfaction as he filled her completely, sending the stars she longed to see dancing in her eyes. The push and pull between their bodies was effortless and breathtaking as they made passionate (and freaky) love on their marital bed.

He hit his crescendo first and she followed quickly after, both making ample use of the sound proofing - at least Entrapta hoped so; she'd forgotten to confirm that bit on their checklist. Oh well.

Sated, sweaty, and breathing heavily, they finally collapsed in a loved-up pile on the plush bed. "I must admit," Hordak panted, "making love to a queen is perhaps the least likely scenario I would have ever expected myself in. I am extremely grateful to be shown the error of my miscalculation."

Entrapta cackled unevenly. "Well, I planned on making love to the Lord of the Fright Zone the moment I set my eyes on him." She waggled her brows at him as he blushed furiously. It was so cute how shy he could still be when she complimented him.

He nuzzled into her neck, spooning his body against hers. “And I would not have it any other way.”

“Neither would I.” She curled one arm up to pet his ear soothingly and let her eyes slip closed to the gentle vibrations of his purring against her back.

They’d need to clean up and put away his armor in a bit, but for now, the Lord and Lady of the Fright Zone (or the Queen and Prince Consort of Dryl, depending on who you asked) couldn’t be pried from one another’s arms if every princess on Etheria were outside their door.

Later that evening, after a lengthy bath, the newly re-wedded couple returned to snuggle in their bed, drowsily sharing wishes about their future together. As overjoyed as they were to have finally found the meaning of home with one another, they still longed for more than Etheria. They decided to continue researching a way to pull the planet into the wider universe, so long as they could do so without detection from wandering eyes. It was a long way off, if they ever got there at all, but they had all the time in the world.

In the meantime, the Horde was closer to victory than ever before, and the pair had been having a blast kicking princess ass together. Their casual discussion grew heavy, however, when they hit a disagreement on the schematics of the freeze ray they were attempting to create. Neither realized how long they’d been debating until a huge yawn interrupted Entrapta’s mathematically-charged monologue.

Hordak chuckled, kissing the top of her head. “Shall we return to this topic in the morning, my love?”

“Mm, yeah,” Entrapta murmured sleepily, snuggling against his chest. “It’s funny. I thought we might agree on this stuff more once we were married for real. Like I was hoping we’d start to share the same brain or something, I dunno” she giggled.

He pulled her further into his arms, threading his claws through her hair. “I do not mind disagreeing. I always learn so much from your brilliance during our scientific debates.” She blushed a little at that, giving him a tired smile when he cupped her face. He leaned down and they shared one last chaste kiss for the night. “Besides, we ought to treat our marriage like all of our other experiments. We’ll just keep working on it until it’s perfect.”

Chapter End Notes

> And that's a wrap! I'm sorry if you expected more smut or more wedding in this chapter, but this was all I had in me, pls forgive.
>
> Thank you once again for joining me on this silly little journey!!!

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